

Fate's Edge: Player's Guide

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Fate's Edge: Player's Guide

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Chapter 1

Welcome to Fate's Edge

A world where every choice carries weight, every spell risks backlash, and every legend is written in the shadow of consequence.

Welcome to **Fate's Edge**, a tabletop roleplaying game where narrative drives mechanics, and every decision shapes not only your character's path—but the world around them. This is not a game of perfect successes or clean victories. It is a game of risk, drama, and legacy.

What Is This Game?

Fate's Edge is a narrative-first RPG where:

- Every roll introduces potential for triumph *and* complication.
- Magic is powerful—but dangerous.
- Choices ripple outward, shaping character arcs and the setting.
- Growth is meaningful, earned through experience spent on skills, talents, and assets.

This guide helps you build a character, understand the setting, and step into a world where your actions matter. For the complete core rules (dice resolution, Position, Difficulty Values, Story Beats, Boons, and more), refer to the *Fate's Edge System Reference Document (SRD)*.

Core Principles

The game is built on four key ideas:

Narrative First Mechanics serve the story. Rules reward descriptive play and creative problem-solving.

Risk Creates Drama Every roll carries tension. Even success may come at a cost.

Meaningful Growth Experience is a currency of choice. Invest in yourself or in your influence on the world.

Consequences Matter No action is free. Every choice changes the fiction.

Style of Play

Expect cinematic, collaborative storytelling:

- Stories driven by character choices.
- A world that reacts to your decisions.

- Themes of legacy, sacrifice, and moral complexity.

Whether you are a lone duelist, a scheming mastermind, or a spirit-touched outlander, your path is yours to forge.

Safety Tools: Lines, Veils & X-Card

Safety Tools: Lines, Veils & X-Card

Fate's Edge explores mature themes—conflict, loss, horror, betrayal, and difficult choices. The table should always feel safe. Use these simple tools to keep the game enjoyable for everyone.

X-Card (by John Stavropoulos). Any player (including the GM) can draw an "X" on a card or simply say "X" when a moment makes them uncomfortable. When the X-Card is shown, the described content is **removed from the fiction**—no questions, no explanations, no judgments. You do not need to justify using the X-Card. The scene is retconned or redirected immediately.

Lines. A **Line** is a hard boundary: content that will not appear in the game at all. Examples: "No sexual violence," "No harm to children," "No body horror." Before the campaign or a session, players name their Lines. The GM and group honor them completely.

Veils. A **Veil** is a soft boundary: content that can happen "off screen" or fade to black. The event is acknowledged but not described in detail. Example: "A romantic scene can happen, but fade to black before it becomes explicit." Veils allow the story to acknowledge mature themes without forcing players to roleplay through them.

How to Use These Tools at Your Table.

- Establish Lines and Veils during **Session Zero** (or before your first game). Write them down where everyone can see them.
- Keep an X-Card visible on the table (a printed card, a drawn X, or a digital symbol). Remind players they can use it at any time, even mid-sentence.
- When the X-Card is used, pause, rewind if needed, and move on. Do not interrogate the player who used it.
- The GM is also a player. The GM may use the X-Card for their own comfort.
- Respect the tools. If someone calls an X-Card, trust that they had a good reason and support them.

These tools are not about censorship—they are about **consent**. They allow the group to tell darker, more intense stories together *because* everyone knows they can tap out at any time. A game that feels safe is a game that can go to the edge.

For more detail, search online for "TTRPG X-Card" or "Lines and Veils RPG". Many free resources are available.

Session Zero: The Foundation of Your Story

Before you roll your first die, gather with your GM and fellow players for a **Session Zero**. This is where you build the shared understanding that makes Fate's Edge sing – and where you make sure everyone is excited for the same kind of story.

Core Philosophy to Embrace as Players

- **Optimal play = most fun.** Spending Boons, embracing failure, and courting Patron attention leads to better stories. There is no "winning" except an unforgettable session.
- **You and the GM are co-creators, not adversaries.** The GM frames pressure; you drive the fiction. No one is trying to "beat" anyone else.
- **Boons are not XP tokens.** Spend them. Hoarding Boons for conversion starves the table of drama and leads to less engagement.
- **Patrons are allies who demand payment – embrace it.** Obligation is plot, not punishment. When a Patron calls, a story hook arrives.

Session Zero Checklist (Player's Edition)

Session Zero Checklist

Answer these together and write down the answers where everyone can see them.

1. **Lines & Veils** – What content is off-limits (Lines) or only implied (Veils)?
2. **Tone** – Cinematic action? Grim survival? Political intrigue? Dark horror? Mix of several?
3. **Campaign length** – One-shot, short arc (3–6 sessions), or long campaign (12+ sessions)?
4. **Character hooks** – Each player shares one goal and one fear for their character.
5. **Patron interest** – Which Patrons (if any) are already watching the party?
6. **Starting situation** – Where does the story begin?
7. **House rules** – Any optional subsystems (Threat Pool, Deck of Consequences, etc.) the GM plans to use?
8. **Scheduling & attendance** – How often do you meet? What happens if a player misses a session?

Taking thirty minutes for Session Zero will save hours of mid-campaign friction and give you a richer, more invested table.

Guide Structure

This Player's Guide contains:

- **Chapters 2–3: Core Mechanics** — Action resolution, Position, Difficulty Values, Story Beats, Boons, and character advancement. (For the complete SRD, see the separate document.)
- **Chapters 4–5: Attributes, Skills & Advancement** — Building your dice pools and growing your character.
- **Chapters 6–7: Talents & Character Concepts** — Special abilities and example builds.
- **Chapters 8–11: World & Cultures** — The peoples, lands, and factions of Fate's Edge.
- **Appendices** — Quick references, magic tags, and player tools.

Quick Reference: Where to Find It

Use this one-page guide to jump straight to the rules you need at the table.

What you need	Where to look
Core resolution (roll dice, DV, outcomes)	Chapter 2 (2)
Position & Effect	Chapter 2 (2.8)
Combat (initiative, actions, harm)	Chapter 2 (??)
Magic (paths, rites, backlash)	Chapter 3 (3)
Travel (legs, clocks, roles)	Chapter 8 (11.4)
Clocks & Fronts	GM Guide, Chapter 2 – ask your GM
Story Beats (SB)	Chapter 2 (2.9)
Boons (earning, spending, limits)	Chapter 2 (2.7)
Assets & Followers	Chapter 7 (10)
High-tier play (Tiers IV–V)	GM Guide, Chapter 8

How to Use This Book

Read cover to cover or jump to relevant sections. Each chapter stands alone while connecting to broader themes. The SRD provides full mechanical detail; this guide focuses on character creation, setting, and player-facing options.

Getting Started

This is a game of bold choices and lasting consequences. Your story is written in decisions—not dice rolls.

Welcome to the Edge. The world is watching.

What will you risk to reshape the world?

1.1 The Philosophy of Narrative First

In Fate's Edge, the story is not a byproduct of the rules—it is the reason the rules exist. When you sit down to play, you are not rolling dice to see what happens; you are telling a story together, with dice as your co-authors. This is the *narrative first* philosophy.

1.1.1 Why Narrative First?

Imagine this scene:

Your character, a wounded duelist, faces the baron's champion in the royal arena. Your legs ache from the earlier fight, and the crowd's roar has become a physical pressure. You know one strike will end it—but you also know you are one misstep from death.

Now consider two ways this might play out:

- **Mechanics-First Approach:** "I roll Body 3 + Melee 2 to attack. I get 3 successes. The baron's champion has 2 Harm. I win."
- **Narrative-First Approach:** "I lunge forward, my blade a silver arc against the red of the arena sand. But my injured leg buckles—I spend 1 Boon to re-roll the die that came up 1—and I twist to drive my shoulder into his chest instead. The crowd roars as we both fall to the sand, my blade at his throat." GM: "You have the advantage, but your wound has reopened."

What do you do?"

The first version tells you who won. The second tells you *how* you won and what it cost you. This is the heart of narrative first: your choices matter not because of numbers on a sheet, but because of the story they create.

1.1.2 Your Role in the Story

In Fate's Edge, you are:

- **A storyteller** — Your descriptions shape the world.
- **An active participant** — Your choices drive the narrative.
- **A co-creator** — You and the GM build the story together.

This means:

- **Flavor is free:** Describe how you fight, what your character looks like, or what the world feels like—no mechanical cost, only story enrichment. *Example:* "I parry with the grace of a dancer, my movements a memory of my mother's training, even as blood drips from my brow."
- **Describe your action before rolling:** Do not just say "I attack"—show us how. This informs the GM's response and often determines Position (Dominant, Controlled, Desperate). *Example:* "I use the crowd's noise as cover to slip behind him and strike his exposed back." (Likely *Dominant Position*.)
- **Embrace failure as opportunity:** A miss is not "you fail to hit." It is "the blade glances off his armor, and you see the baron's hand reach for the hilt of his dagger." Failures should always move the story forward.

1.1.3 The Golden Rule

When in doubt, make the choice that serves the story. If you find yourself asking "What's the optimal move?" try reframing it as "What would be most interesting for the story?"

Remember

In Fate's Edge, the dice do not determine your success or failure. *You* determine the story. The dice just help decide which path you take to get there.

1.1.4 Flavor is Free (Even for Mundane Actions)

Flavor is Free

Players: Add descriptive details, cultural elements, and atmospheric touches without spending resources or requiring rolls. **This applies to all descriptive actions, not just magic.** Want your Vhasian duelist to parry with a flourish from royal fencing schools? Go ahead. Want to describe the eerie silence of a Valewood ruin when searching for clues? Perfect. Want to narrate how you reload your crossbow with a practiced flick of the wrist? Even better. Flavor enriches the narrative without changing mechanical outcomes. Describe your character's background, customs, or scene details. The GM should encourage this and reciprocate. Mechanics determine success or failure, but flavor determines the story we tell about it.

Narrative-Heavy Gameplay Options (Optional)

For groups that prefer strong narrative focus, consider these approaches:

- **Collaborative Scene Framing:** Players may suggest scene elements (weather, NPC reactions, environmental details) that fit the fiction, with GM approval.
- **Intent-Driven Resolution:** When success is reasonably assured, the GM may ask players to describe *how* they accomplish their goal rather than rolling.
- **Flashback Declarations:** Spend 1 Boon to declare a flashback establishing past preparation, and describe the scene.
- **Descriptive Assistance:** Players can assist each other by providing vivid descriptions, granting a +1 die to the primary actor's roll.
- **Narrative Control Points:** Each player starts each session with 1 Narrative Control Point. Spend it to:
 - Introduce a minor NPC who provides useful information or assistance.
 - Establish that they have a useful item on hand (within reason).
 - Create a favorable environmental detail.

These points refresh each session and encourage proactive storytelling.

What's Next?

The next chapter covers the core mechanics that drive play. If you are eager to build a character, jump ahead to Chapter 4 (Attributes Skills). For an overview of the world, see Chapter 11 (World Regions and Cultures).

Now close the book—or keep reading. The road is waiting.

Chapter 2

Core Mechanics

A Word from the Raven Road

"The road is a ledger. Every broken wheel is a debt, every lit lamp a witness. The only question is: what are you willing to owe?" — Dusana of the Raven Road, *The Hearth Ledger*

2.1 The 90-Second Play Loop

At the heart of every scene is a simple, fast loop that keeps the story moving:

1. **GM sets the stage** – Describe the situation and ask "What do you do?"
2. **Player declares intent and approach** – State what you want to achieve and how (Attribute + Skill).
3. **GM sets Position and Difficulty Value (DV)** – Choose Dominant/Controlled/Desperate and a DV (2–5+).
4. **Player rolls dice** – Count Successes (6+) and Story Beats (1s).
5. **Apply outcome** – Compare Successes to DV (Clean Success / Success with SB / Partial / Miss).
6. **GM spends Story Beats (SB)** – Introduce complications, advance clocks, or escalate the scene.
7. **Player marks resources** – Gain Boons (1 on Partial, 2 on Miss), track Fatigue/Harm, update Obligation, etc.
8. **Pass the spotlight** – Next player acts, or GM frames a new beat.

This loop should take about 90 seconds per player action. If it drags, simplify: focus on intent, one roll, and a clear consequence.

2.2 The Core Resolution Cycle

Every meaningful action in Fate's Edge follows this cycle:

1. **Declare Action & Approach:** State what you want to achieve and how (Attribute + Skill).
2. **GM sets Difficulty Value (DV):** Based on narrative stakes (see 2.5).
3. **GM sets Position:** Dominant, Controlled, or Desperate (see 2.8).
4. **Roll dice pool:** Attribute + Skill d10s.

5. **Count Successes (6+) and Story Beats (1s).**
6. **Check against DV using the Outcome Matrix** (see 2.6).
7. **Apply outcome:** Clean Success, Success with SB, Partial, or Miss.
8. **GM spends Story Beats (SB)** for complications and twists.

Golden Rule

When in doubt, make the choice that serves the story. If you find yourself asking "What's the optimal move?" try reframing it as "What would be most interesting for the story?"

2.3 Player-Managed Modules

In Fate's Edge, you are the primary manager of your character's mechanical state. This isn't just about convenience—it is a core design principle that reduces GM overhead and keeps you engaged.

You Track Your Own Story

What You Manage:

- Obligation tracks (one per Patron or Symbol)
- Corruption clocks (Cantors, Pact-Whisperers)
- Leash clocks (summoned spirits)
- Asset states (Maintained, Neglected, Compromised)
- Follower conditions (Exposure, Harm)
- Progression clocks (Repertoire, Spirit Bond)
- Boons, Favor, Leverage

Your Responsibilities:

1. **Mark immediately** when a rule says "mark +X".
2. **Declare thresholds** ("My Obligation is full!").
3. **Keep it visible** (use trackers everyone can see).
4. **Maintain ownership** – you know your state best.

GM Support: The GM spot-checks and provides consequences, but you drive your character's mechanical narrative.

Example: Tracking Your Obligation

A character with Spirit 2 and Presence 2 has an Obligation Capacity of 4. She invokes a Rite from Patron A (+1), then later Pushes a Rite from Patron B (+1), then Cracks the Seal on a Symbol (+2). She now has:

- Patron A: 1 segment
- Patron B: 1 segment
- Symbol (Invoker): 2 segments

Total Obligation = 4 → exactly at Capacity. No Fatigue yet. If she invokes one more Rite from any Patron, she exceeds Capacity and marks ****1 Fatigue**** immediately.

2.4 Basic Dice Mechanics

When you attempt a significant action, roll a pool of ten-sided dice (d10s). The size of your pool is:

$$\text{DicePool} = \text{Attribute} + \text{Skill}$$

Attribute (1–5) Broad traits like Strength, Wit, or Charm.

Skill (0–5) Training in a specific area (e.g., Melee, Stealth, Arcana).

Lore of the Fall: The Weight of Numbers

"The Aeler count their breaths; the Aelaerem pour eight cups and stop. The ninth is not a number – it is a wound that hasn't closed." In Fate's Edge, dice are not mere randomisers. They are the echo of every oath sworn, every debt unpaid. When you roll a 1, you feed the Hollow – and the Hollow feeds the story.

Reading the Dice

Each die that rolls **6 or higher** counts as a **Success**. Each die that rolls a **1** generates a **Story Beat (SB)**.

Die Result	Effect
6–10	+1 Success
1	+1 Story Beat (SB)
2–5	Nothing

2.4.0.0.1 Example: Lyra (Agility 3 + Stealth 2 = 5 dice) rolls: 6, 4, 3, 1, 6 → 2 Successes, 1 SB. The DV is 2 – she succeeds, but the GM has 1 SB to spend (perhaps a guard stirs).

When to Roll

You roll only when:

- The outcome is uncertain, **and**
- Failure would matter to the story, **and**
- The action is significant enough to deserve a spotlight.

For routine actions with no real risk, the group can simply agree that you succeed. *Example:* Climbing a knotted rope in calm weather → no roll. Climbing the same rope while goblins shoot arrows → roll.

2.5 Difficulty Value (DV)

The Game Master sets a **Difficulty Value** – the target number of Successes needed.

Difficulty Value (DV) Ladder

DV	Situation
2	Routine, no pressure
3	Pressured, mild opposition (default)
4	Difficult, active resistance
5+	Extreme, high stakes

DV 3 is the default. If the GM calls for a roll, something is at stake. Do not inflate DVs – they already do their job.

2.6 The Outcome Matrix

Compare your Successes to the DV to determine the outcome.

Outcome Matrix	
Outcome	What It Means
Clean Success ($S \geq DV$)	You achieve your goal without complication.
Success with SB ($S \geq DV, SB > 0$)	You succeed, but the GM spends SB to add a twist.
Partial ($0 < S < DV$)	You make progress, but the situation remains unresolved. You gain
Miss ($S = 0$)	You fail, and the situation escalates. You gain 2 Boons.

2.6.0.0.1 What a Partial Means. A Partial is not failure – it moves the story forward. Examples:

- Improve your Position for the next attempt (see 2.8).
- Reduce the effective DV of the next roll.
- Succeed at reduced scale or duration.
- Reveal information or open a new path.

Fail Forward

A **Miss** is never "nothing happens." The GM must introduce a complication, advance a clock, or reveal a hidden danger. You gain 2 Boons – the story moves, and you get resources to try again.

Example: You fail to pick a lock (Miss). The GM says: "Your pick snaps, but you hear the guard's footsteps – he's about to turn the corner. You have one beat to hide." The story advances.

2.6.1 Critical Successes

A roll of **10** counts as **two Successes**. If the roll succeeds, each 10 adds narrative weight.

10s	Effect
1	Strong success – improve your Position by one step on your next action this scene, or gain a minor ad
2	Exceptional success – choose two benefits from the list above.
3	Legendary success – decisive victory; clear 1 segment from a relevant clock.
4+	Mythic success – reshape the scene; clear 1–2 segments from a relevant clock.

Example: Rolling a 10

Lyra rolls 3 dice: **10**, 8, 1. She gets: 2 successes (from the 10) + 1 success (from the 8) = 3 successes. The roll also generates 1 SB (from the 1). Because she rolled a 10, the GM grants an extra benefit: "Your arrow pierces the bandit's shoulder – he drops his sword." (*Narrative*

benefit chosen by GM.)

Important: 10s are never re-rolled by Position effects. Critical effects apply only if the roll succeeds.

2.7 Boons

Boons represent momentum and narrative leverage. You may hold up to **5 Boons**.

Lore of the Velvet Touch

"The coin that never spends is the one you don't remember taking." Boons are the thief's best friend – a second chance when the lock clicks wrong, a sudden shadow when the guard turns. In Silkstrand, they say a Boon is a debt to luck, and luck always collects.

Why You Should Spend Boons – The Math of Fun

Hoarding Boons for XP conversion leads to less engagement and lower fun scores.

Every Boon you hold is a dramatic moment waiting to happen:

- Re-rolling a critical failure turns despair into triumph.
- Improving Position before a risky roll turns a Desperate gamble into a Controlled chance.
- Activating an Asset brings your character's network into the story.

XP from Boons is a trickle (max 2 per session). The real reward is *agency*. Spend Boons freely – they are not XP tokens.

Example: You have 3 Boons. Instead of converting them later, use 1 to re-roll a missed lockpick, another to improve your Position before a fight, and save the last for an emergency. That is how legends are made.

2.7.1 Earning Boons

- **Partial Success:** Gain 1 Boon (see 2.6).
- **Miss:** Gain 2 Boons.
- **Bond-Driven Action:** Once per bond per session, gain 1 Boon when an action meaningfully engages that bond (see ??).
- **GM Award:** For creativity, sacrifice, or strong narrative play.

When not awarded: Safe rehearsal, null-risk probes, or repeated identical attempts in the same scene do not generate Boons.

2.7.2 Spending Boons

- Re-roll a single die (after seeing the result)
- Activate an on-screen Asset (1 Boon)
- Improve Position by 1 step before a roll (see 2.8)
- Power certain Rites or abilities (see 3)
- Convert to XP (2 Boons = 1 XP, once per session during downtime, max 2 XP per session)

2.7.3 Carryover Limit

At the end of each scene, reduce held Boons to a maximum of **2**. Excess are lost – spend them or lose them.

2.8 Position

Every action takes place from a **Position** that reflects the character’s advantage.

Position Effects

Position	Narrative Frame	Mechanical Effect
Dominant	You press your advantage	Re-roll one <i>failure</i> .
Controlled	Balanced norm	No re-rolls.
Desperate	You act under duress	Re-roll one <i>success</i> .
You can spend 1 Boon to improve Position by one step before rolling. The GM can spend 2 SB to worsen your Position by one step (after the roll).		

A Vhasian Duelist’s Lesson

"On the Pont-du-Tithe, Position is everything. Stand with the sun at your back – you are Dominant. Feet on a slippery plank – Desperate. The bridge does not care for your pride."
Your Position is the story’s judgement of your risk. Change the fiction, and Position follows.

2.8.0.0.1 Boon Interaction with Fatigue: When Fatigue forces a success re-roll (see 2.10.1), spending 1 Boon negates *one* such re-roll. You may spend Boons after seeing the result of a Fatigue re-roll.

Boon Economy at a Glance

Action	Boon Change	Maximum
Partial Success	Gain 1 Boon	
Miss	Gain 2 Boons	
Bond-Driven Action	Gain 1 Boon (once/bond/session)	
GM Award	+1 Boon (rare)	
Re-roll a die	Spend 1 Boon	
Activate Asset	Spend 1 Boon	
Improve Position (before roll)	Spend 1 Boon	
Convert to XP (downtime)	Spend 2 Boons → 1 XP (max 2 XP/session)	

held: 5 Boons. At end of scene, reduce to **2** (excess lost).

2.9 Story Beats (SB)

Story Beats are narrative tools the GM spends to introduce twists. They keep the story alive with complications.

2.9.1 SB Spend Examples

- **1 SB:** Minor complication – noise, trace, +1 Supply segment.
- **2 SB:** Moderate setback – alarm raised, lose cover, lesser foe appears.
- **3 SB:** Serious trouble – reinforcements, key gear breaks.
- **4+ SB:** Major turn – trap springs, authority arrives, scene shifts.

2.9.1.0.1 Player Advice: Don't fear Story Beats – they are fuel for drama, not punishment. Every time you roll a 1, you give the GM a spark. That spark can light a fire that makes the story burn brighter.

2.10 Harm and Fatigue

2.10.1 Fatigue Track

Each character has a Fatigue track equal to **Body**. Mark Fatigue for exertion, magical strain, or stress.

- Each Fatigue step worsens your Position: Dominant → Controlled → Desperate (see 2.8).
- If already Desperate, apply –1 die per Fatigue instead.
- Penalties from Fatigue and Harm **stack**. For example, a character with Harm 1 (–1 die) who is also Desperate from Fatigue suffers both penalties.
- **Overflow:** When the track fills, increase Harm by 1 step (see 2.10.3) and clear all Fatigue.
- **Recovery:** Short rest clears 1–2 Fatigue; full night's rest clears all.

Aeler Breath-Counting

"The Deep Accountants say: eight breaths is a corridor, sixteen is a chamber, thirty-two is a fool who forgot to turn back. Fatigue is your breath running out – mark it, or the mountain will mark you." Fatigue is not just tiredness; it is the weight of every hard choice you've already made.

2.10.2 The Roller-Coaster Effect (Taking Harm Clears Fatigue)

When you take Harm, the shock of the wound temporarily clears your Fatigue. This creates natural dramatic swings – a character near collapse who takes a wound and suddenly finds a second wind.

2.10.2.0.1 Example: Kael is at Fatigue 3 (Desperate, –2 dice). A goblin stabs him for Harm 1. Following the procedure in 2.10.4, the Harm clears his Fatigue (step 2), then he adds the converted Fatigue (step 3). He ends with Harm 1, Fatigue 0 – wounded but clear-headed.

2.10.3 Harm Levels

Harm Level	Effect
Harm 1	–1 die on related actions
Harm 2	–1 die on most actions until treated
Harm 3	Incapacitated or dying

2.10.4 Taking Harm and Fatigue – The Procedure

When you are hit, follow these steps **in order**:

1. **Convert** incoming Harm to Fatigue using the Armor Conversion Table below.
2. **Apply remaining Harm** – if any Harm remains after conversion, increase your Harm level by that amount, and **clear all existing Fatigue** (the shock of a wound resets your exhaustion).
3. **Add the Fatigue** from step 1 to your Fatigue track. If this fills or exceeds your track, resolve **Overflow** (see 2.10.1).

2.10.4.0.1 Armor Conversion Table

Armor Type	Incoming Harm		
	Harm 1	Harm 2	Harm 3
Light	Fatigue 1	Harm 1 + Fatigue 1	Harm 2 + Fatigue 1
Medium	Fatigue 1	Fatigue 1	Harm 2 + Fatigue 1
Heavy	Fatigue 1	Fatigue 1	Fatigue 2

2.10.4.0.2 Examples

- **Light Armor, Harm 2:** Result is Harm 1, Fatigue 1. Apply Harm (clears existing Fatigue, Harm 0→1), then add Fatigue 1. (If you had Fatigue before, it is cleared first.)
- **Heavy Armor, Harm 3:** Result is Fatigue 2. No Harm taken. Add Fatigue 2.
- **Heavy Armor, Harm 1:** Result is Fatigue 1. No Harm taken. Add Fatigue 1.
- **Overflow example:** Body 2, currently 1 Fatigue, Heavy Armor hit with Harm 3 → result Fatigue 2. Total Fatigue becomes 1+2=3, which fills the track (max 2). Overflow triggers: Harm 0→1, clear all Fatigue. Final: Harm 1, Fatigue 0.

2.10.5 Recovery

- **Fatigue:** Short rest (food/water) removes 2 Fatigue; full night removes all.
- **Harm:** Requires medical care and time – minor treatment downgrades Harm, proper care removes it.

2.11 Initiative and Turn Order

2.11.0.0.1 Default: Narrative Initiative. Fate's Edge does not use fixed initiative. Turn order follows the fiction:

- **Narrative Fiat:** The GM frames spotlight order based on circumstances.
- **Player Input:** Players may suggest acting when it makes sense.
- **Surprise:** Ambushers act first; targets respond after.
- **Flexibility:** Spotlight may shift mid-scene if fictionally appropriate.

(Optional structured initiative systems – popcorn, side-based, speed slots – are available in the GM Guide if your table prefers them.)

2.11.1 Turn Economy (Quick Rules)

Each character takes **1 Action and 1 Move** on their turn. Actions and Moves may be taken in any order; repeating the same Action is not allowed unless noted.

2.11.1.0.1 Move: Traverse up to **one range band** (Close → Near → Far, or the reverse).

- **Stand:** Use your Move to stand from prone.

2.11.1.0.2 Action Options:

Action	Effect	Notes
Attack	Make melee or ranged attack against a target.	Ranged in Close is Desperate .
Disengage	Enable safe movement.	Your Move does not provoke opportunity attacks; you cannot Attack this turn.
Charge (Full turn)	Move two bands toward an enemy + make one melee attack.	Costs 1 Fatigue, next defense Desperate, requires open ground. Leaving Close range during a Charge provokes opportunity attacks as normal.
Skirmish (Full turn)	Move two bands away from an enemy + make one ranged attack.	Costs 1 Fatigue, next defense Desperate, requires open ground.
Observe / Change Position	Gain +1 Position once.	Once per turn.
Setup (Teamwork)	Grant an ally +1 Position or step up Effect.	Requires a roll (typically Wits + relevant skill).
Assist (Teamwork)	Spend 1 Boon to give +1 die to an ally's roll.	Max +3 dice from all assists.
Defend / Protect	Adopt a guarding stance.	Your defense rolls improve Position by one step.
Channel / Weave	Runekeeper/ritual preparation.	Interruption may worsen Position.
Cast Rite / Song	Perform a magical action.	May Push (cost Fatigue/Corruption).
Interact	Manipulate an object or environment.	GM sets DV.
Free Items	Short shouts, dropping an item.	Longer actions require proper action types.

Helping Others – Assistance

You can help an ally on their roll:

- **Assist (Spend 1 Boon):** Give the ally +1 die on their roll. You must describe how you help (distract, flank, steady, etc.).
- **Setup (Take an Action):** Roll an appropriate skill (DV set by GM). On success, the ally gains +1 Position or +1 Effect on their next action.

Limits: Only one assistant per PC per exchange (by default). Max total assist dice from all sources: **+3**.

2.11.1.0.3 Opportunity Attacks Leaving an enemy's **Close** range without using *Disengage* provokes one free melee attack (Controlled Position, no action cost). Additionally, the following actions provoke an opportunity attack if performed while **engaged in Close** with an enemy:

- Making a ranged attack (bow, crossbow, thrown weapon).
- Casting a spell that does not have the [TOUCH] or [WARD] attribute.

A **Charge** that takes you out of an enemy's Close range provokes an opportunity attack as usual (unless you used *Disengage* beforehand).

2.11.1.0.4 Position and Dice Modifiers

- **Position ladder:** Desperate → Controlled → Dominant.
- **Improving Position:** Each step above Dominant grants **+1 die** instead.
- **Worsening Position:** Each step below Desperate imposes **-1 die** instead.
- **Example:** If bonuses would raise Position two steps above Dominant, you gain **+2 dice**. If penalties would drop you two steps below Desperate, you suffer **-2 dice**.

2.11.1.0.5 Caveats and Talents:

- **Charge** and **Skirmish** require open ground (no difficult terrain) unless a talent says otherwise (see ??).
- Talents such as *Effortless Charge* (4 XP) or *Effortless Skirmish* (4 XP) allow ignoring the Fatigue cost once per scene.
- The *Relentless* talent (6 XP) allows Charge or Skirmish over difficult terrain (Fatigue cost still applies).

Combat in Brief

- **Turn:** 1 Action + 1 Move.
- **Move:** Close Near Far.
- **Attack:** Roll Attribute + Skill vs. DV (enemy's defense). Ranged attack while in Close range → Desperate.
- **Harm:** When you hit, the target marks Harm (see 2.10.4). Enemies use the same Harm levels as players.
- **Fatigue:** Each point worsens your Position (or -1 die if already Desperate). Taking Harm clears Fatigue – the "roller-coaster".

- **Clocks:** GMs often use clocks for reinforcements, environmental collapse, or enemy morale.

Full combat rules are in Chapter ?? (GM Guide).

2.12 Weapons & Armor

Silkstrand Steel

"A Light blade is a courtier's promise – fast, elegant, easy to hide. A Heavy blade is a condotta captain's ultimatum – slow, brutal, and final." Choose your weight as you choose your words. Both can cut.

2.12.1 Weapons by Weight Class

- **Light (4 XP)** – fast, concealable.
- **Medium (8 XP)** – balanced, battlefield standard.
- **Heavy (12 XP)** – punishing, slow.

2.12.2 Melee Modifiers

Weight	Close	Near	Notes
Light	+2d	+1d	Quick in tight quarters
Medium	+1d	+2d	Set once/scene or –1d first attack
Heavy	–1d	+3d	Set once/scene or –2d first attack

2.12.3 Ranged & Tempo

Ranged weapons have a **Tempo** that determines how they interact with movement, aiming, and reloading.

2.12.3.0.1 Tempo Types

Fast – You may **Move and Shoot in the same turn**. *Examples:* throwing knives, light crossbow (if pre-loaded), sling.

Standard – You may either **Move** or **Shoot** on your turn, not both. As a special action, you may **Aim** (gain +1d or +1 Effect on your next shot), but Aim replaces your attack that turn. *Examples:* longbow, heavy crossbow (if pre-loaded), musket.

Slow – The weapon requires a **full round to load** (or set/brace). *Round 1:* Use your action to load (no attack). You may still move, but moving while loading is at Desperate Position unless you have a talent. *Round 2:* Shoot (and may move afterwards). Then you must reload again for another shot. *Examples:* ballista, hand-cannon, heavy arquebus.

2.12.3.0.2 Ranged Modifiers by Weight

Weight	Tempo	Close	Near	Far
Light (4 XP)	Fast	Controlled	+1d	—
Medium (8 XP)	Standard	Desperate	+2d	+1d
Heavy (12 XP)	Slow	Desperate	+1d	+3d

2.12.3.0.3 Tempo Quick Reference

Tempo	Move + Shoot?	Aim Option?	Reload Required
Fast	Yes (same turn)	No	None (or free)
Standard	No (move or shoot)	Yes (+1d/+1 Effect)	None (Aim costs action)
Slow	No (load one turn, shoot next)	No	Full round

2.12.4 Weapon Tags (Optional, +4 XP each, max 2)

Reach, Close, Accurate, Brutal, Hook, Concealable, Quickdraw, Two-Handed, Off-Hand.

2.12.5 Shields (Optional)

Shield	XP	Benefit	Tradeoff
Buckler	4	+1d Defend vs melee or +1 DV once	Off-hand occupied
Heater	8	+1d Defend; convert 1 Harm→1 Fatigue	−1d Ranged
Pavise	12	Plant: heavy cover cone	Slow to move; bulky

2.12.6 Armor

Armor	XP	Conversion (Harm → Fatigue)	Penalty
Light	4	1→1 (minimum 1 Fatigue per hit)	—
Medium	8	2→1 (minimum 1 Fatigue per hit)	−1d physical skills
Heavy	12	3→2 (minimum 1 Fatigue per hit)	−2d physical, no sprint in rough

Notes: Conversion is applied per Harm instance before marking Fatigue. See 2.10.4 for the full step-by-step procedure.

2.12.7 Condition & Upkeep

Neglected Weapons: −1d; **Armor:** conversion worsened by one step (e.g., Light behaves as no armor, Heavy as Medium).

Compromised Weapons: −1d first attack each round; **Armor:** no conversion.

Fix: Short rest with tools removes Neglected (no roll required). A scene of work or a smith removes Compromised; a successful Craft roll (DV 3) can reduce the time to a short rest.

2.13 Ranged Options

- **Aim:** +1 die or +1 Effect next shot (lost if you Move or are disrupted).
- **Volley:** Spend extra ammo for +1 die (max +2).
- **Suppress:** Zone under fire; foes there act at −1 die or Limited Effect until they shift cover.
- **Overwatch:** Ready a Controlled shot on a clear trigger crossing your line.

2.14 Followers and Assets

2.14.1 Followers

Followers are named NPCs with a personal relationship to your character. They:

- Assist during scenes via Bonds and Assists (see ??).
- Act offscreen to gather information or manage tasks.
- Have motives and vulnerabilities – the GM may place them at risk.

Followers are not disposable tools. They can grow, change, or be lost.

2.14.1.1 High-Capability Followers (Cap 4–5)

Followers with Capability 4 or 5 are trusted lieutenants, stewards, or commanders. They can be delegated the management of your Assets, freeing you from direct oversight.

- A **Cap 4** follower can be delegated **up to 2 Assets**.
- A **Cap 5** follower can be delegated **up to 4 Assets**.

When an Asset is delegated to a follower, the follower’s own upkeep (paid in XP or downtime action) **automatically covers the upkeep of those Assets** – you do not pay separate Asset upkeep. The follower handles the logistics, staff, or political maintenance as part of their role.

If the follower becomes Wary, Neglected, all delegated Assets immediately become Neglected as well until the follower is restored. If a follower is Compromised, those assets are lost.

2.14.2 Assets

Assets are durable resources or positions under your control – safehouses, networks, political offices, relics. They:

- Create advantages that persist beyond a single scene.
- Resolve problems that dice alone cannot.
- Cost Boons to activate (the GM determines the impact).

Assets can be threatened, degraded, or lost. Overuse attracts attention.

2.14.3 Followers vs. Assets

	Followers	Assets
Nature	People	Resources/Structures
Primary Role	Personal support	Strategic leverage
Activation	Assists (spend Boon) or narrative interaction	Boon expenditure
Risk	Emotional, narrative	Structural, political
Growth	Can become PCs	Can expand or collapse

2.14.3.0.1 Design Principle: Followers create *depth*. Assets create *reach*. High-tier play depends on managing both.

2.15 Game Structure

2.15.1 Time Scales

Moment A heartbeat, a single action.

Some Time A few minutes, a short activity.

Significant Time Hours, extended effort.

Days Large-scale endeavors.

2.15.2 Game Units

Scene Basic narrative unit, covers a specific conflict.

Session One game session (3–6 hours).

Campaign Entire story arc.

2.16 Action Resolution Steps

1. Describe your intent and method.
2. Build dice pool: Attribute + Skill (+ gear, assists).
3. Roll d10s; count Successes (6+) and Story Beats (1s).
4. Compare Successes to DV.
5. Apply outcome from the Outcome Matrix (see 2.6).
6. GM spends SB if applicable (see 2.9).
7. Earn Boons for Partial or Miss (see 2.7).

Quick Reference

Dice Pool: Attribute + Skill d10s

Success: 6+ on each die

Story Beat: 1 on any die gives SB to GM

DV: 2 (easy) to 5+ (extreme) – default 3

Harm: 3-level system; see 2.10.4 for the procedure

Boons: 2 on miss, 1 on partial

2.17 Narrative Suggestions

- **Collaborative Scene Framing:** Players may suggest scene elements (weather, NPC reactions) with GM approval.
- **Intent-Driven Resolution:** If success is reasonably assured, the GM may ask players to describe *how* rather than roll.
- **Flashback Declarations:** Spend 1 Boon to declare a flashback establishing past preparation, and describe the scene.
- **Descriptive Assistance:** Players can assist by providing vivid descriptions, granting a +1 die to the primary actor.
- **Proactive Storytelling:** Players may suggest minor favorable details (a helpful NPC, a useful item on hand) subject to GM approval.

Core Mechanics Quick Reference

What	How
Dice Pool	Attribute + Skill d10s
Success	Die ≥ 6
Story Beat (SB)	Die = 1
Difficulty (DV)	Default 3 (2=easy, 4=hard, 5+=extreme)
Outcomes	Clean Success ($S \geq DV$, $SB=0$) Success with SB ($S \geq DV$, $SB > 0$) Partial ($0 < S < DV \rightarrow$ gain 1 Boon) Miss ($S=0 \rightarrow$ gain 2 Boons)
Boons	Max 5; trim to 2 at scene end. Spend: re-roll, improve Position, activate Asset, convert 2 $\rightarrow$ 1
Position	Dominant (re-roll failure), Controlled (normal), Desperate (re-roll success)
Fatigue	Worsens Position (or -1 die if Desperate). Full track $\rightarrow$ Harm+1, clear Fatigue.
Harm	1 (-1 die), 2 (-2 dice), 3 (incapacitated). Taking Harm clears Fatigue first.
Armor	Converts Harm to Fatigue; minimum 1 Fatigue per hit.

Chapter 3

Magic and Special Abilities

Magic in this game is powerful but dangerous—a negotiation with reality itself that always carries risks. This chapter covers the core magical systems and the distinct paths a character may follow.

Sidebar: [TAGS] & Magic

What are [TAGS]? Effects in *Fate's Edge* are communicated via [TAGS]. Each [TAG] is a discrete effect gated behind a Talent, Rite, spell, or asset—it *cannot be invoked spontaneously* unless a rule grants access.

How they're used. [TAGS] provide a common language for describing effects, especially when players invent spells via *Free Casting*. Many prewritten spells and abilities also list their [TAGS] for clarity.

3.1 The Nature of Magic

Magic is not a safe tool but a dangerous force:

- **Powerful:** Can reshape battles, stories, or even the world.
- **Controlled:** Every use generates **Story Beats (SB)** that manifest as backlash (see 2).
- **Thematic:** Effects and consequences align with the type of magic used.
- **Volatile:** Never fully predictable or controllable.
- **Narrative:** Casting is always a significant story moment.

3.1.0.0.1 Table Vignette: “*I can hold the avalanche,*” says Mira, *fingers trembling.* “*But something will answer.*” The party nods—risk accepted, stakes clear.

3.1.1 Patron as Co-Star

Your Patron is not just a source of power—they are a **co-star** in your story. How often they appear depends on your campaign’s length. Ask your GM which style they will use:

Passive Patrons (long campaigns) – The Patron stays in the background, appearing only when Obligation thresholds are breached. Their demands feel like slow, inevitable consequences.

Active Patrons (short campaigns / one-shots) – The Patron appears often: in dreams, omens, or through intermediaries. They offer bargains, push the Obligation spiral, and make the price

of power immediate.

Player advice: Embrace Patron demands as *story hooks*, not punishments. When the GM says "Your Patron requires a task," lean into it. That task will lead to adventure, not just a tax. A Patron who intervenes is a Patron who cares – and a caring Patron is a source of power and drama.

For Full Patron Details

The complete descriptions of all Patrons—including their Rites, Obligation mechanics, and corruption tables—are found in **Chapter 15 (World Powers and Obligation)**. That chapter also covers terrestrial patrons, faction obligations, and the mechanics of clearing debt. This chapter focuses on the *paths* of magic; for the *sources* of power, see the World Powers chapter.

3.2 Paths of Magic

Magic in *Fate's Edge* is not a single system. Characters may follow one of several distinct paths, each with its own mechanics, costs, and narrative flavor. The five primary paths are:

Free Caster Improvisational magic using [TAGS]. Flexible but risky (3.2.1).

Runekeeper Structured rites granted by a Patron. Reliable but accrues Obligation (3.2.2).

Invoker Ritual magic using Patron symbols. Safe but slow (3.2.3).

Cantor Songs that mimic Low Rites. Accessible but corrupting (3.2.4).

Summoner Binding and commanding spirits. Powerful but requires control (3.2.5).

A character may dabble in multiple paths, but specialization is more effective.

3.2.1 Free Caster (Spellcraft)

Free casters shape raw magic through will and knowledge. They do not rely on Patrons or rote rites.

Requirements

- Talent: **Spellcraft** (6 XP) – see 8.
- Appropriate magical skill (Arcana, Elemental Magic, etc.).

Casting Procedure

1. **Declare Intent:** Describe the desired effect using [TAGS].
2. **Choose Approach:** Attribute + magical skill.
3. **Set Position & DV:** $DV = 1 + \text{number of [TAGS]}$. Dangerous tags add +2 each.
4. **Roll:** Resolve normally (see 2). Each 1 generates a Story Beat.

For powerful or complex effects, use the **Casting Loop** (two actions: Weave then Cast). Simple effects (one tag) may be cast as a **cantrip** (one action, no separate Weave).

Backlash

On a failure or mixed result, the GM may impose:

- Harm 2 (Arcane)
- +2 Fatigue
- Corruption +1
- A catastrophic side effect

Backlash is always flavored by the elements used.

Free Caster Talents

Ritual Mastery (6 XP) Reduce casting time for major spells by half.

Elemental Focus (4 XP) Gain +1 die when using a chosen element.

Stabilize Weave (8 XP) Once per session, cancel 1 SB from a failed cast.

3.2.2 Runekeeper (Rites)

Runekeepers bind themselves to a single Patron, learning structured Rites that produce reliable effects.

Requirements

- **Thiasos (Familiar) (2 XP)** – a token or bond with the Patron (see 8).
- **Codex (4 XP)** – a personal record of Rites.
- **Patron Choice:** Select one Patron (e.g., Traveler, Oath of Flame, Morag).

Invoking a Rite

- **Action:** 1 action.
- **Cost:** Mark +1 Obligation to your Patron.
- **Effect:** The Rite works as written.
- **Push It:** Once per scene, mark +1 Obligation to amplify the effect (+1 die or +1 Effect).

Patron's Gift (Imbuement)

Once per scene, as 1 action, imbue a held item with +1 Melee and +1 Thematic skill (e.g., Navigation for Traveler). Lasts one scene. Mark +1 Obligation.

Runekeeper Talents

Efficient Invocation (4 XP) Reduce Obligation cost of one specific Low Rite by 1 (min 0).

Patron's Favor (8 XP) Once per session, ignore Obligation cost for a Rite.

Runebound Resilience (18 XP) Convert up to 2 Harm into Obligation instead of damage.

3.2.3 Invoker (Symbols)

Invokers do not bond permanently. They use consecrated Symbols to borrow a Patron's power through ritual.

Requirements

- **Patron's Symbol (4 XP per Patron).** One Symbol per Patron.
- No Thiasos or Codex required.

Ritual Invocation

- **Time:** Significant Time (DV in rounds). +1 round per DV.
- **Cost:** Always mark +1 Obligation to that Patron.
- **Symbol Benefit:** If the Symbol is openly displayed, reduce DV by 1 (min 1) and Obligation by 1 (min 0).
- **No Symbol:** +1 DV, +1 Obligation, and on a partial/failure, GM gains +1 extra SB.

Note: *Obligation cost cannot be reduced below 1.*

Crack the Seal

Resolve a known Rite instantly as 1 action. Set the Symbol to **Compromised** and mark +2 Obligation (+3 for High Rites). Restore the Symbol during downtime (Arcana test DV 3) or spend 1 XP.

Invoker Talents

Borrowed Grace (Free) Spend 1 Boon or 1 Fatigue to gain +1 Melee or +1 Thematic for one action. Mark +1 Obligation.

Crack Specialist (6 XP) Reduce Obligation cost of Crack the Seal by 1.

Symbol Resonance (4 XP) When using a Symbol, gain +1 die to the ritual roll.

3.2.4 Cantor (Songs)

Cantors perform Low Rites as songs, using voice and performance instead of Patron bonds.

Requirements

- Talent: **Cantor's Path** (8 XP) – see 8.
- Prerequisites: Lore 1+, Performance 2+, Presence 2+.

Performing a Song

- **Action:** 1 action to begin; resolves at start of next turn.
- **Test:** Lore + Performance (DV 2–3).
- **Cost:** Materials as listed. No Obligation on success.
- **Corruption:** Track a Corruption Clock (size = Spirit). Mark segments when you Push, perform a Resonant Rite, or when the GM spends SB on your occult activities.

Push It

Resolve immediately. Mark Fatigue 1, mark toward Corruption accumulation, and the GM gains 1 SB (social/Patron fallout).

Corruption Clock

When the clock fills, gain a thematic benefit and drawback from the last Patron whose Rite you performed. Then **set your current Corruption segments to your Tier** (minimum 1). The clock's maximum size remains equal to your Spirit. This means you are never completely free of Corruption; high-Tier Cantors always carry a remnant of past blooms.

Resonant Rites (Founding a Chorus)

A **Resonant Rite** is any Cantor song performed with dramatic intent, witnessed by at least 10 people, and dedicated to a specific Patron. The GM determines if a performance qualifies.

Chorus Cults (Optional)

If you perform a Resonant Rite before 10+ witnesses, you may found a **Chorus**. This grants a minor follower benefit (see 10), but you must mark Obligation to the cult's patron (the patron whose Resonant Rite was sung to form the cult) each session you use it. **If neglected, the cult may fracture** – your followers could splinter into a rival sect, spread false rumours, or ally with a Patron's enemy. Keep an eye on your followers; a neglected Chorus can become a serious problem.

Example minor follower benefits (work with your GM):

- Once per session, gain +1 die on a Performance roll or on a social roll where the crowd's opinion matters.

- Once per session, call upon the cult to provide a single piece of information from within a community where the cult has a presence.
- Once per session, gain +1 Boon when you perform a Song in a public space.

High Cantor and Instant Songs

The **High Cantor** talent (below) allows you to learn Standard Rites as songs and resolve them instantly (no delay). When you sing a Standard Rite as a Song, you may also **Push** it for additional effect (e.g., +1 Effect) at the usual cost of 1 Fatigue and marking a Corruption segment.

Cantor Talents

Resonant Performance (3 XP) Gain +1 die when performing for an audience of 5+.

Song Weaver (4 XP) Combine two compatible Songs for +1 Effect. Two Songs are compatible if they share a thematic tag (e.g., both affect healing, positioning, spirits) or if they are from the same Patron. The GM has final say. Sing both as a single action; resolve the Performance roll once; if successful, both effects occur with +1 Effect.

High Cantor (18 XP) Learn Standard Rites as songs; resolve instantly (as described above).

Steady Voice (2 XP) Passive. When you Push a Song, you may choose to mark 1 additional Fatigue instead of marking a Corruption segment (once per scene). You cannot use this talent if your Corruption clock is already full. This talent gives low-Spirit Cantors an emergency buffer at the cost of greater exhaustion. *Requires: Cantor's Path.*

Patron's Dedication (4 XP) Prerequisite: Cantor's Path.

Effect: You bind your voice to a single Patron (choose one when you take this talent). Your Corruption clock is always keyed to that Patron – it never resets to a different Patron's table when you bloom. Whenever you would gain Corruption from any source, you mark it on this same clock.

Downside (Rivalry): Singing a Song (Low or Standard Rite) of any other Patron is treacherous. When you do so, your Position for that song is worsened by one step (Dominant → Controlled, Controlled → Desperate). This penalty applies even if the song would otherwise be instant or free.

3.2.5 Summoner (Pact-Whisperer)

Summoners call and bind Outsiders for temporary aid.

Requirements

- Talent: **Pact-Whisperer** (2 XP) – see 8.
- Lesser Pactwright (2 XP) for Cap 1 spirits; Greater Pactwright (4 XP) for Cap 3.

Core Mechanics

- **Call (1 action):** Manifest a spirit at Near range.
- **Bind:** Spend 1 Boon or mark 1 Fatigue.
- **Leash Capacity:** Cap + Spirit segments.
- **Tick Leash:** Spirit takes harm, commanded against nature, crosses a [WARD], or you split focus.
- **Departure:** When Leash fills, spirit acts once according to its nature, then departs (or turns hostile at GM discretion).

Spirit Whims Table (When the Spirit Acts on Its Own)

When the Leash fills or the spirit acts independently, the GM may choose (or roll) from this table to make the action interesting – not just damage.

d6 Spirit's Independent Action	
1	Reveal a Secret: The spirit blurts out a hidden fact about a PC or NPC – true, embarrassing, or da
2	Break Something: The spirit shatters a mundane object (a lantern, a rope bridge, a crucial tool).
3	Lead Astray: The spirit moves a short distance and creates a false trail, forcing the party to waste ti
4	Call for Help: The spirit summons a minor ally (a rat swarm, a will-o'-wisp, a lesser elemental).
5	Curse a PC: The spirit leaves a lingering mark (–1 die on one skill until the next sunrise).
6	Bargain: The spirit offers a deal: "Release me now, and I'll tell you where the treasure is hidden."

Boon Finesse

Once per round, spend 1 Boon to clear 1 Leash tick.

Summoner Talents

Spirit Synergy (4 XP) When commanding two spirits, reduce each Leash by 1.

Spirit Link (10 XP) Spirits act on your turn; commands are free actions.

True Name Keeper (15 XP) Call any previously encountered spirit by true name; reduce Leash Capacity by 2.

3.3 Universal Mechanics

3.3.1 Obligation Capacity

A character's **Obligation Capacity** equals Spirit + Presence. Track total Obligation segments across all Patrons.

- **Exceeding Capacity:** For each segment above Capacity, mark 1 Fatigue. Cannot invoke Rites until Obligation is reduced.
- **Resolution:** Reduce Obligation through downtime service, Patron tasks, or ritual cleansing.

Player guidance: You track your own Obligation (see Player-Managed Modules, 2.3). When a Patron intrudes (e.g., a demand or omen), treat it as a **plot hook, not a penalty**. The Patron is offering you a story.

Components as Devotion

Even if you already have a Patron's Symbol, Codex, or Thiasos, voluntarily acquiring rare components for a ritual shows dedication. Use this rule of thumb:

- **Ritual with no components (just Symbol/Codex):** Normal DV, normal Obligation cost.
- **Ritual with common components (herbs, salt, a candle):** Reduce Obligation by 1 (minimum 0).
- **Ritual with rare or dangerous components (a phoenix feather, a drop of troll blood, a whispered secret):** Reduce DV by 1 **and** clear 1 segment of existing Obligation to that Patron (once per session max).

- **Ritual with a truly legendary component (the crown of a dead king, a tear from a goddess):** The Patron may waive all Obligation for that ritual – and even grant a free Boon.

This turns component hunting into adventure hooks and gives you a meaningful choice: use the easy, costly path or invest legwork to earn the Patron’s favor.

3.3.2 Backlash

Any magical roll can generate backlash. The GM spends Story Beats (SB) to introduce complications tied to the element or Patron involved.

Result	Backlash Severity
Partial	Minor (e.g., Position -1, Fatigue 1, minor complication)
Miss	Major (e.g., Harm 1, condition, significant complication)
Critical failure (many 1s)	Catastrophic (e.g., Patron intervention, scene shift)

Backlash Severity by Position

Position	Backlash Severity on Partial/Miss
Dominant	Minor – one SB complication, manageable cost.
Controlled	Moderate – 1–2 SB complication, temporary setback.
Desperate	Severe – 2–3 SB complication, lasting consequences or Harm.

Elemental Backlash Examples

- **Fire:** Burns, flares, smoke.
- **Water:** Slick footing, gear corrosion, flooding.
- **Earth:** Tremors, encumbrance, binding roots.
- **Air:** Dispersal, deafening gusts, thrown debris.
- **Fate:** Opportunities close, predictions become set.
- **Life:** Uncontrolled growth, fever, exhaustion.
- **Luck:** Fortunes reverse at the worst moment.
- **Death/Dreams:** Whispers, numbness, portents.

3.3.3 DV by Spell Scope

Use this table as a quick reference when the GM asks for a DV for a new spell:

Scope	Example	DV
Cantrip	Light a candle, sense magic	2
Combat	Fire bolt, force shield	3
Ritual (small)	Find a lost object, speak with a spirit	4
Ritual (large)	Summon a storm, teleport across a region	5+
Epic	Raise a dead army, rewrite a law of reality	6+ (with quest)

When in Doubt

A spell's power is not measured by how many dice it rolls, but by **how much it changes the story**. Use this rule of thumb:

- **Minor change (1 TAG):** The effect affects only yourself or a single object. Examples: **Light**, **HEAL**, **Veil** (self only). DV 2–3.
- **Moderate change (2 TAGS):** The spell affects a whole zone, creates a significant advantage, or bypasses a notable obstacle. Examples: **Area + Force**, **Barrier** across a doorway. DV 3–4.
- **Major change (3+ TAGS):** The spell rewrites the situation, solves a major problem outright, or introduces a new faction/ally/threat. Examples: **Teleport** across a city, **Summon** a Cap 3 spirit, **Transform** a person into a beast. DV 5+ and often a ritual.

If your description would *skip over a scene* ("I teleport us past the entire fortress"), that's a major change – require components, a clock, or a steep cost. If it would only *add flavour* ("I make my eyes glow red"), that's free. Let the fiction guide the DV, not a pre-computed formula.

3.3.4 Example: Accepting a Cost – The Hard Choice

When a magical roll generates SB, the GM may offer you a choice instead of a flat consequence.

3.3.4.0.1 Example: You cast a ritual to divine an enemy's location. The roll generates 2 SB. The GM says:

"The vision comes clearly – but your Patron's symbol glows hot on your hand. **You can have the vision for free, or you can let the spell fizzle and keep your Obligation unchanged.** If you accept the vision, mark +2 Obligation and your Patron will demand a task next session. What do you choose?"

This turns a success into a *narrative fork*. Embrace it – the Patron's task will be an adventure hook.

3.4 Free Casting (TAGS System)

Some casters shape raw forces through shared arcane grammar known as **TAGS**. Construct a spell at the table using a short phrase of TAGS.

3.4.1 Spell Structure

Intent + Target + Tags = effect. Example: "*I unleash Burning • Area • Force against the marauders.*"

3.4.2 Base Difficulty Value (DV)

$$DV = 1 + \text{number of TAGS}$$

Dangerous TAGS (Teleportation, Transformation, Domination) add +2 DV instead of +1.

3.4.3 Casting Roll

Roll **Wits + Arcana** (or similar). Success = spell works. Failure or any 1 = Backlash.

3.4.4 Backlash for Free Casters

Choose one:

- Harm 2 (Arcane)
- +2 Fatigue
- Corruption +1
- Catastrophic side effect (GM describes)

If the spell includes a "Dangerous" TAG, Backlash triggers on *mixed* results as well.

3.4.5 TAG Library (Abridged)

Table 3.1: Common TAGS

TAG Category	Examples
Elemental	Burning, Freezing, Storm, Stone, Wave, Wind
Force	Force, Area, Strike, Wall, Bind, Dispel
Mind & Veil	Veil, Scry, Memory, Command, Fear
Life & Body	HEAL, Purify, Strengthen, Waken, Beast
Space & Motion (dangerous, +2 DV)	Leap, Fold, Gate, Gravity
Creation & Trans- formation (danger- ous, +2 DV)	Create, Summon, Transmute, Animate

3.4.6 Magic in Social Situations

Using magic socially carries additional risks:

- **Discretion:** Hidden casting may require a Stealth or Subterfuge test.
- **Consent:** Affecting minds without permission is often considered a crime or taboo.
- **Reputation:** Known magic users may face distrust or fear.
- **Legal Consequences:** Many cities restrict magic use without a license.

3.5 Magical Item Creation

Creating permanent magical items is a complex, campaign-level endeavor. See the full rules in the *Game Master's Guide*. In brief:

- Requires high magical and craft skills (Arcana 3+, Craft 2+).
- Costs XP (minimum 5 XP for Tier I) and rare materials.
- Takes weeks or months of downtime.
- Risk of backlash or permanent curse on failure.

For temporary enchantments, use the **Patron's Gift** (3.2.2) or **Borrowed Grace** (3.2.3).

3.6 Optional Magic Expansions

The following systems are optional and may be introduced by the GM.

Psionics (Optional)

Psionics represents mental power drawn from within — no Patron, no Symbol, no debt. It is meant to feel **alien**, even to other magic-users. Different cultures have varying opinions (see the Gray Wanderer’s Grimoire for examples), but psions are generally viewed with suspicion or fear.

Example Arts: Telekinesis, Telepathy, Clairvoyance, Biofeedback, Astral Projection, Psychic Assault, Mind Shield, Empathic Manipulation, Precognition.

Warning: Psionics generates Story Beats (SB) quickly. The GM is encouraged to spend these SB on *social complications* — suspicion, hostile glances, a Chain-Lantern investigation, or a neighbor locking their door. Mental backlash is common, but the deepest cost is always *trust*.

Each use costs Mental Strain. Overflow converts to normal Fatigue or Harm. Many societies distrust mind-readers; a psion is always *unwitnessed*, and therefore outside the ledger.

Witchcraft (Optional)

Witchcraft is magic practiced through patron-bound Orders. Witches suffer — **1 die** in consecrated spaces and must navigate the Curse of the Unanointed — the world’s refusal to witness their labor.

Ritual Magic (Weave & Cast): Two-step process, each roll generates SB.

Example Orders:

- **Mab, Queen of Courts:** Glamour, bargains, fae oaths. Risk — Glamour-Bloom (lose a memory for +1 Effect).
- **Aveh, The Rider:** Identity shedding. Risk — Unface (your features blur).
- **Morag, The Hag:** Hidden costs and prophecy. Risk — Mirecloth (sacrifice identity for truth).

Identity Cost: Every use marks who you are. The cost is memory, identity, or reputation.

3.7 Quick Reference

Magic Quick Reference**Free Caster**

- Talent: Spellcraft (6 XP)
- DV = 1 + number of [TAGS]
- Backlash on miss or mixed

Runekeeper

- Thiasos + Codex (6 XP)
- 1 action, mark +1 Obligation
- Push It: +1 Obligation

Invoker

- Patron's Symbol (4 XP each)
- Ritual: Significant time, +1 Obligation
- Crack the Seal: instant, +2 Obligation

Cantor

- Cantor's Path (8 XP)
- Song: 1 action (resolves next round)
- Corruption Clock (size = Body)

Summoner

- Pact-Whisperer (2 XP)
- Call + Bind (1 Boon or Fatigue)
- Leash = Cap + Spirit

Chapter 4

Your First Magical Character

So you want to play a magic-user. Good choice – but FATE’s EDGE offers **six different magical paths**. Jumping into all of them at once is a recipe for confusion. This guide helps you pick a path and then walks you through building a **single, focused magical character** that is powerful, fun, and manageable.

Quick Reference: Magic Paths at a Glance

Use this table to choose a path that fits your preferred complexity and play style. **New players: start with Runekeeper.**

Path	Complexity	Cost Type	Risk	Best For
Runekeeper	Low	Obligation	Patron demands	First-timers, reliable
Cantor	Medium	Corruption	Social fallout, madness	Bards, performers,
Invoker	Medium–High	Obligation + ritual time	Slow casting, Symbol breaks	Ritual specialists,
Summoner	High	Leash + Boons	Spirit breaks free	Pet-class fans, tact
Free Caster	High	Backlash (Fatigue/Harm)	Unpredictable effects	Improv players, wi
Psionics (optional)	Medium	Mental Strain	Mental strain, social distrust	Mind-power enthus

All paths are viable. The table only shows the *relative* complexity and risk. If you are still unsure, follow the recommendation below – you can always learn a second path later.

4.1 Step 0: The Recommendation

If this is your first magical character, play a **Runekeeper**. Why?

- **One Patron:** You swear to a single Patron. No juggling multiple Symbols or conflicting obligations.
- **Clear costs:** Every Rite costs Obligation. Track one number.
- **Support from your Thiasos:** Your familiar is a built-in roleplay hook and mechanical aid.

You can explore Invokers, Cantors, Witches, Psions, or Summoners later. Start simple.

Which Magic Path Fits You?

Not every player enjoys the same kind of magic. Use this table to find the path that matches how you like to play.

If you want...	Choose this path	Why it fits
Reliable, straightforward magic with clear costs	Runekeeper	One Patron, one resource (Obligation). No surprises.
To sing, perform, and risk losing yourself	Cantor	Corruption clock creates drama; great for bards and risk-takers.
Rituals, preparation, and borrowing power from multiple sources	Invoker	Slow but flexible; you collect Symbols like tools.
A summoned creature that fights for you	Summoner	Tactical pet class; manage the Leash clock.
Improvised magic on the fly, unpredictable effects	Free Caster	TAGS system lets you invent spells; high risk, high reward.
Mind powers and subtle influence (optional)	Psionics	No Patron, but mental strain and social suspicion.

Still unsure? **Let's start with Runekeeper.** You can always learn a second path later (see Chapter 3 for multi-path rules).

4.2 Step 1: Choose a Patron

Your Patron defines your Rites, your Obligation, and your role in the story. Pick one that matches your character concept.

Patron	Domain	Character Concept
The Traveler	Roads, journeys, safe passage	Guide, courier, scout
Oath of Flame & Light	Dawn, vows, protection	Paladin, healer, knight
Grimmir	Nature, seasons	Druid, ranger, hedge-witch
Ikasha	Shadow, secrets, thresholds	Spy, infiltrator, night-walker
The Witness	Truth, memory, revelation	Investigator, judge, archivist
Mykkiel	Law, covenant, judgment	Templar, inquisitor, notary
The Carrion-King	Decay, renewal, compost	Necromancer (gentle), healer

New player favourite: *The Traveler*. Low Obligation costs, useful Rites, and a forgiving Patron.

4.3 Step 2: Buy Your Core Talents

At character creation (30–34 XP), you need two talents:

- **Familiar (Thiasos) – 2 XP.** Your bond to your Patron. It might be a raven (Traveler), a candle flame (Oath of Flame), or a small fungal creature (Carrion-King).
- **Codex – 4 XP.** Your book of Rites. It could be a leather journal, a set of carved slate tablets, or a roll of bark.

Total so far: 6 XP. You have 24–28 XP remaining for Attributes, Skills, and optional talents.

4.4 Step 3: Set Your Attributes

Runekeepers rely on **Spirit** (Obligation capacity, Rite effectiveness) and **Wits** (Lore, Investigation). A simple spread:

Attribute	Rating	Cost (new rating $\times$ 3)
Spirit	3	9 XP (1 $\rightarrow$ 2 = 6, 2 $\rightarrow$ 3 = 9)
Wits	2	6 XP (1 $\rightarrow$ 2 = 6)
Body	1	0 (base)
Presence	1	0 (base)

Total: 15 XP. You have 9–13 XP remaining.

4.5 Step 4: Buy Your Skills

You need **Lore** (to understand your Rites) and at least one social or utility skill.

Skill	Rating	Cost (new level $\times$ 2)
Lore	2	6 XP (0 $\rightarrow$ 1 = 2, 1 $\rightarrow$ 2 = 4)
Insight	1	2 XP (0 $\rightarrow$ 1 = 2)
Sway	1	2 XP (0 $\rightarrow$ 1 = 2)

Total: 10 XP. You now have 0–3 XP left – perfect for one minor talent.

4.6 Step 5: Choose Your First Rites

You begin with **two Low Rites** from your Patron. Pick ones that are useful and clear.

Example: The Traveler

- **Road-Sense (Low, 4 XP):** Gain +1 die to avoid ambushes or delays on a journey. *Use this every travel leg.*
- **Traveler's Boon (Low, 5 XP):** Ignore one level of difficult terrain or bureaucracy for the scene. *Great for crossing rivers or skipping paperwork.*

Example: Oath of Flame & Light

- **Kindle Vow (Low, 4 XP):** Declare a short vow (e.g., "I will protect the villagers"). Gain +1 die to actions fulfilling it.
- **Lay on Hands (Low, 5 XP):** Cleanse an affliction or downgrade Harm by 1. *The classic healing Rite.*

4.7 Step 6: Understand Your Resources

You track three numbers:

1. **Obligation (to your Patron).** Capacity = Spirit + Presence. For Spirit 3, Presence 1, capacity is 4. Each Rite marks +1 Obligation. When you exceed capacity, mark 1 Fatigue per extra segment.
2. **Fatigue.** Each point worsens Position. When Fatigue fills your Body track (Body 1 = 1 segment), convert to Harm.
3. **Harm.** Harm 1 = -1 die, Harm 2 = -2 dice, Harm 3 = incapacitated.

Players job: Mark these yourself. Announce when Obligation fills. The GM does not track them for you.

4.8 Step 7: Play Your First Session

Before the session

- Write your two Rites on an index card.
- Set your Obligation to 0.
- Set your Fatigue to 0.

During the session

1. **Invoke a Rite:** Say "I invoke *Road-Sense*." Mark +1 Obligation. Roll Lore + Spirit (or as specified). Apply the effect.
2. **Take a Short Rest:** Clear 2 Fatigue.
3. **Accept a Patron's demand:** If the GM says "your Patron requires a task," treat it as a story hook, not a punishment.

After the session

- Clear Obligation by performing an **Act of Service** for your Patron (e.g., The Traveler: guide a lost traveller; Oath of Flame: speak a public vow). Describe the act. The GM will tell you how much Obligation clears.

- Spend XP to raise Attributes, Skills, or buy new Rites.

4.9 Optional: Add a Minor Talent

If you have 2–4 XP left, take one of these:

- **Efficient Invocation (4 XP):** Reduce Obligation cost of one specific Low Rite by 1 (minimum 0).
- **Keen Senses (2 XP):** +1 die on perception checks.
- **Silver Tongue (2 XP):** +1 die on persuasion attempts.

4.10 What to Avoid at First

- **Multiple Patrons.** Stick to one. Cross-Resonance (page XX) adds complexity you don't need yet.
- **Crack the Seal (Invoker ability).** You are a Runekeeper. Let Invokers handle emergency rituals.
- **Cantor's Corruption.** A great path, but the Corruption clock requires active management. Save it for your second character.

4.11 Sample Build: Kestra the Traveler's Runekeeper

Element	Choice
Name	Kestra
Patron	The Traveler
Attributes	Spirit 3 (9 XP), Wits 2 (6 XP), Body 1, Presence 1
Skills	Lore 2 (6 XP), Insight 1 (2 XP), Sway 1 (2 XP)
Talents	Familiar (2 XP), Codex (4 XP)
Rites	Road-Sense (4 XP), Traveler's Boon (5 XP)
Starting Boons	3
Obligation Capacity	4 (Spirit 3 + Presence 1)

Total XP spent: $9+6+2+2+2+4+4+5 = 34$ XP (using the +4 XP from Bonds/Complications).

Kestra is a former caravan guide who swore to the Traveler after being betrayed by her crew. She carries a brass compass (her Thiasos) and a leather journal of route-maps (her Codex). She invokes *Road-Sense* before every journey and *Traveler's Boon* to cross difficult terrain. She tracks her Obligation carefully and pays it off by guiding lost travellers through the mountains.

4.12 Final Advice

The One Rule for New Magical Players

Spend your Boons. Hoarding them for XP conversion starves the table of drama. A re-rolled failure, an improved Position, or an activated Asset creates a memorable moment. The XP will come from your adventures.

You are now ready to play a Runekeeper. When you feel comfortable, read about the other five

paths (Chapter 3). But for now, enjoy the clarity of one Patron, one Codex, and one set of Rites. The road is waiting. Pay your toll.

Chapter 5

Healing: Mending Flesh and Spirit

"The HEAL tag closes small wounds and eases exhaustion. To knit broken bones or purge a curse, you need greater power—and greater risk."—The Gray Wanderer

In **Fate's Edge**, injuries are not mere hit points. They are narrative weights: a fractured leg forces hard choices; a festering wound breeds desperation. Healing magic exists, but it is never cheap, never perfectly safe, and always part of the story.

This chapter explains how your character recovers from the two kinds of damage—**Fatigue** and **Harm**—using magic, medicine, rest, and willpower.

5.1 The Two Faces of Injury

Type	What It Represents	How It Heals (Fastest)
Fatigue	Exhaustion, minor cuts, bruises, winded	HEAL cantrip, short rest, a hot meal
Harm	Broken bones, deep wounds, poisoning, curses	Rest + medicine, powerful magic, time

5.1.0.0.1 Fatigue is your character's ability to keep going. It accumulates from physical exertion, missed sleep, harsh weather, and the strain of magic. Fatigue is **common and easy to remove**.

5.1.0.0.2 Harm is serious injury. Each level of Harm (1, 2, or 3) imposes a 1 die penalty on most actions. Harm is **rare and expensive to heal**. When you take Harm, the world takes notice.

5.2 Recovering Fatigue – The Easy Work

Fatigue clears quickly with rest, food, or a minor magical touch.

5.2.1 Rest and Recovery

- **Short rest (one hour):** Remove 2 Fatigue. You must be able to sit, breathe, and drink water. No roll required.
- **Full night's rest (8 hours in safety):** Remove all Fatigue. If you are in a dangerous or exposed place, the GM may reduce this to 2 Fatigue instead.
- **Warm meal and comfort:** The first rest after a hot meal removes an additional 1 Fatigue (stacks with the above).

5.2.2 The HEAL Cantrip

The [HEAL] tag (typically from the Life element or a Patron of healing) removes Fatigue quickly.

HEAL Cantrip

Tags:	[HEAL]
DV:	2
Action:	1 action
Range:	Touch
Effect:	Remove 1 Fatigue from yourself or a willing creature you touch.
Backlash:	None. The GM may still spend Story Beats (from any 1s on the roll) to add minor flavour

This cantrip works for any magical tradition that can access Life or a healing Patron (e.g., Free Caster, Runekeeper of Oath of Flame, Cantor with healing songs).

5.2.2.0.1 Example: Lyra uses HEAL on Kael after a fight. She rolls 5d10 (Spirit + Medicine), gets 3 successes vs DV 2 – a Clean Success. Kael clears 1 Fatigue. No complication.

5.3 Healing Harm – The Hard Work

Restoring a level of Harm (e.g., from Harm 2 to 1, or Harm 1 to 0) requires **significant effort** – either mundane medical care over time or powerful magic that comes with risk.

5.3.1 Mundane Healing

- **First Aid (Wits + Medicine, DV 3):** Stabilise a dying creature (prevent Harm from worsening). Does not heal existing Harm. Takes 1 action.
- **Treatment (downtime, safe haven):** Requires a healer's kit and at least one day of rest. Restores 1 Harm per full day of care. A successful Medicine roll (DV 3) can reduce required days by half (minimum 1 day).
- **Surgery or magical cleansing (serious injury):** For Harm 3 or cursed wounds, the GM may require a full scene or a quest component (rare herbs, a spirit's favor).

5.3.2 Magical Healing of Harm

To heal Harm with a spell, you must meet **two conditions**:

1. Include the [HEAL] tag.
2. Include **at least one other appropriate tag** based on the injury:
 - [PURIFY] – poison, disease, corruption
 - [STRENGTHEN] – broken bones, torn muscles
 - [CLEANSE] – curses, magical wounds, shadow-damage

The base DV for healing Harm is **1 + number of tags**. Healing Harm also adds a **+2 DV surcharge**. Examples:

Injury Tags Base DV +2 Surcharge Final DV	——— ——— ——— ——— ———
Shallow cut (Harm 1) [HEAL] 2 +2 4	Poisoned wound (Harm 1) [HEAL] [PURIFY] 3 +2 5
Broken arm (Harm 2) [HEAL] [STRENGTHEN] 3 +2 5	

The GM may increase DV further for legendary wounds (e.g., a dragon's claw tears your spirit –

[HEAL] [CLEANSE] + a ritual requiring significant time).

5.3.3 Ritual Healing

Healing Harm 2 or Harm 3 often requires a **ritual**, not a single action. Rituals take at least 10 minutes (or longer per the GM). During a ritual, interruptions (combat, loud noises, disbelief) can cause the healing to fail or backfire.

Many magical paths have specific healing rites:

- **Runekeeper (Oath of Flame & Light):** *Lay on Hands* (Low Rite) heals Fatigue; *Cleansing Light* (Standard Rite) can remove poison or downgrade Harm at the cost of Obligation.
- **Cantor:** Healing songs (e.g., *Hymn of Restoration*) require a Performance roll. On a Partial, the wound heals but the Cantor marks Corruption.
- **Witch (Hearth craft):** Hedge Gifts like *Steady Hand* (remove Fatigue) and *Knot of Mercy* (remove a Condition) are roll-free but limited per scene/session.
- **Invoker:** Ritual healing with a Patron's Symbol is slow but has reduced backlash. Crack the Seal for emergency healing – at double Obligation cost.
- **Summoner:** Can bargain with a spirit to transfer wounds (e.g., a spirit of sacrifice takes your Harm). Tick the **Leash** clock each time.

5.4 The Risk of Magic – Story Beats and Backlash

Whenever you cast a healing spell (especially to heal Harm), any 1s you roll generate Story Beats (SB) for the GM. The GM will spend those SB to introduce **complications** – the healing works, but the world pushes back.

5.4.0.0.1 What complications look like:

- **Minor (1 SB):** The wound leaves a visible scar. The patient feels an odd craving (honey, raw meat, silence). A faint magical residue lingers.
- **Moderate (2 SB):** A minor spirit or "echo" of the injury appears – it watches the patient for a scene. A Patron sends a dream: "You owe me."
- **Serious (3 SB):** The healing draws attention from a rival, a witch-hunter, or a territorial nature spirit. The patient gains a thematic Condition (e.g., *Phantom Pain*, –1 die on rolls involving that limb until they perform a small ritual).
- **Major (4+ SB):** Reality warps briefly – a corpse nearby twitches; the patient forgets something precious; the healer's own shadow moves on its own for a day.

These complications **do not cancel the healing**. They are **narrative gifts** – hooks for future scenes, reminders that power has a price.

GM's Role

Your GM uses Story Beats to make healing **dramatic**, not to punish you. Embrace the complications. A scar is a story. A Patron's demand is an adventure. A haunted shadow is a future ally (or enemy). Talk to your GM about the kinds of complications you find interesting – body horror, social fallout, ominous omens, or debts to mysterious powers.

5.5 Natural Recovery – When Magic Fails

If you have no access to magic or medicine, your body still heals – slowly.

- **Per day of complete rest (no strenuous activity):** Remove 1 Fatigue automatically. If you also have food, water, and shelter, remove 2 Fatigue.
- **Per week of rest (downtime):** Remove 1 level of Harm. A successful Medicine roll (Wits + Medicine, DV 3) at the start of the week reduces the required time to 3 days per Harm level.
- **Neglected injuries:** If you continue to adventure while at Harm 2 or Harm 3 without any healing, the GM may advance a **Worsening Condition** clock. When it fills, your injury becomes permanent (a limp, a weakened arm, etc.) or requires extraordinary magic to fix.

5.6 Healing by Magical Tradition – Quick Reference

Path	Fatigue Healing	Harm Healing
Free Caster	[HEAL] cantrip (DV 2)	[HEAL] + other tag, +2 DV, risk backlash
Runekeeper	Low Rite (e.g., <i>Lay on Hands</i>)	Standard Rite, costs Obligation, may Push
Invoker	Ritual [HEAL] (slow)	Ritual + Symbol, reduce DV with rare comp
Cantor	Healing Song (Performance roll)	Song + Push (marks Corruption), requires H
Witch (Hearth)	Hedge Gift: <i>Steady Hand</i> (no roll, 1/scene)	Hedge Gift: <i>Knot of Mercy</i> (once/session, re
Summoner	Spirit bargain (costs Leash ticks)	Transfer wound to spirit (costs Leash, may a
No magic	Short/long rest	Downtime + Medicine roll

5.7 Summary: Healing at a Glance

What You Want	How to Get It
Clear 1 Fatigue (fast)	HEAL cantrip (DV 2, 1 action) or short rest (1 hour).
Clear all Fatigue	Full night's rest in safety.
Heal 1 Harm (mundane)	A week of rest, or 1 day with Medicine roll (DV 3) and a healer's kit.
Heal 1 Harm (magic)	[HEAL] + other tag, +2 DV surcharge (minimum DV 4). Accept possible complications from SB.
Heal 2+ Harm (magic)	High DV (5+), often a ritual. Expect significant cost (Obligation, Corruption, quest).
Remove a Condition	<i>Knot of Mercy</i> (Hedge Gift), <i>Lay on Hands</i> (if Condition is curse/disease), or a Patron's Rite.

5.8 Final Advice for Players

- **Don't hoard your healer's resources.** Fatigue is cheap to heal; use HEAL often. Save big magic for when someone is at Harm 2 or unconscious.
- **Embrace the scars.** A permanent mark from a healing complication is a badge of survival. Work with your GM to make it meaningful.
- **Ambient healing is a thing.** After a fight, take a short rest. The GM will usually allow it unless you are under active pursuit.
- **Protect your healer.** If the only person with HEAL goes down, your party's recovery slows to a crawl.

- **Talk about tone.** In Session Zero, discuss how gruesome or light you want healing complications to be. Some tables love body horror; others prefer comedic side-effects.

The blade cuts. The spell mends. But the scar remains – and that scar is your story.

Chapter 6

Character Advancement and Capabilities

Philosophy of Growth

Every XP spent is a choice about who your character becomes – invest in yourself, your network, or your legacy.

Your character is not just a collection of numbers; they are a living story. When you spend XP on an Attribute, you are saying "I become stronger, smarter, more resilient." When you invest in a Follower or an Asset, you are saying "I build relationships and influence that outlast me." When you buy a Talent, you are saying "This is my signature, my unique edge."

There is no single "correct" way to grow. A lone duelist (see 7.4) might pour everything into personal skill; a merchant prince might build a trading empire. Both are valid. The question is: *what kind of story do you want to tell?*

Why This Chapter Matters

In this game, growth is not just about numbers — it is about deciding who your character becomes. Advancement through **Experience Points (XP)** lets you shape your capabilities, influence, and legacy in the world. Every XP choice is a statement about your character's priorities and the mark they leave behind.

Your capabilities are built on four core **Attributes** and a set of specialized **Skills**. This chapter explains how they work together, what advancement looks like in play, and offers player-facing tips for making satisfying choices.

6.1 Core Attributes

Attributes represent your character's fundamental capabilities. Each is rated from 1 to 5; higher numbers mean greater potential in that area.

6.1.1 Body

Physical strength, endurance, coordination, and health.

- **Used for:** melee combat, athletics, endurance tests, physical labor.
- **Typical applications:** lifting, running, climbing, fighting, resisting physical harm.

- **Associated skills:** Athletics, Brawl, Melee, Endurance (see 6.2).

Rating guide:

- 1: Average person; some physical activity.
- 2: Fit; trains or works physically on a regular basis.
- 3: Athlete or soldier; excellent condition.
- 4: Exceptional athlete; near peak human.
- 5: Peak human capability; legendary strength and stamina.

6.1.2 Wits

Mental acuity, perception, quick thinking, and problem-solving.

- **Used for:** investigation, perception, tactics, snap decisions.
- **Typical applications:** spotting details, solving puzzles, planning, reacting quickly.
- **Associated skills:** Investigation, Tactics, Lore, Survival (see 6.2).

Rating guide:

- 1: Average awareness; sometimes misses important cues.
- 2: Observant; notices most relevant details.
- 3: Sharp-minded; quick to spot patterns.
- 4: Exceptionally perceptive; rarely surprised.
- 5: Almost uncanny awareness; sees connections others miss.

6.1.3 Spirit

Willpower, intuition, mental resilience, and connection to intangible forces.

- **Used for:** resisting mental effects, intuition, magical aptitude, persistence.
- **Typical applications:** resisting fear, sensing danger, channeling magic, enduring hardship.
- **Associated skills:** Arcana, Ritual (for magic users), Endurance, Insight.

Rating guide:

- 1: Average willpower; somewhat suggestible.
- 2: Strong-minded; resists ordinary pressure.
- 3: Very determined; hard to intimidate.
- 4: Exceptional will; can inspire others.
- 5: Iron will; nearly unshakeable resolve.

6.1.4 Presence

Charisma, social influence, appearance, and force of personality.

- **Used for:** social interactions, leadership, persuasion, intimidation.
- **Typical applications:** negotiating, leading, charming, commanding attention.
- **Associated skills:** Sway, Command, Performance, Deception (see 6.2).

Rating guide:

- 1: Average presence; does not particularly stand out.
- 2: Noticeable; leaves a mild impression.

- 3: Charismatic; naturally influential.
- 4: Commanding; people listen when you speak.
- 5: Magnetic; can sway crowds and redefine the mood of a room.

6.2 Skill System

Skills represent specialized training and expertise. In play, you combine an Attribute with a relevant Skill to form your dice pool (see 2).

6.2.1 Skill Ratings

Rating	Description
0	Untrained — no formal experience
1	Novice — basic understanding
2	Competent — reliable and capable
3	Professional — expert in the field
4	Master — renowned specialist
5	Grand Master — legendary skill

6.2.2 Skill Categories

Below are the eighteen core skills, grouped by theme. Your table may rename or reskin these, but the roles remain similar.

6.2.2.0.1 Combat Skills

- **Melee:** swords, axes, close-quarters weapons.
- **Ranged:** bows, crossbows, thrown weapons, firearms (if present).
- **Brawl:** unarmed combat, grappling, improvised fighting.
- **Tactics:** battlefield strategy, unit coordination, ambush planning.

6.2.2.0.2 Physical Skills

- **Athletics:** running, climbing, jumping, swimming.
- **Stealth:** moving unseen, hiding, blending into shadows.
- **Endurance:** resisting fatigue, harsh weather, poison, disease.
- **Craft:** building, repairing, creating tools, art, or structures.
- **Survival:** tracking, foraging, predicting weather, navigating wilderness, animal handling (Nature folded into this skill).

6.2.2.0.3 Social Skills

- **Sway:** persuasion, negotiation, charm.
- **Command:** leadership, intimidation, issuing orders.
- **Deception:** lying, bluffing, misdirection.
- **Performance:** entertainment, oration, acting, musical display (used by Cantors for Songs).
- **Insight:** reading emotions, detecting lies, understanding motives (covers social observation and "reading" people).

6.2.2.0.4 Knowledge Skills

- **Lore:** history, culture, religion, customs, general knowledge (cities, civilizations, scholarly topics).

- **Investigation:** research, deduction, analysis of clues (covers finding and interpreting evidence).
- **Medicine:** healing, anatomy, first aid, treatment.

6.2.2.0.5 Magic Skills

- **Arcana:** magic theory, rituals (identification), mystical phenomena, free casting (TAGS system), counter-spelling.
- **Ritual:** performing rites, invocations, exorcisms, consecrations – used by Runekeepers, Invokers, Cantors, and Summoners for active magical workings.

Optional Module – Psionics: If your table uses the *Psionics* expansion (see *The Grey Wanderer's Grimoire*), a separate **Psionics** skill is added. It is not part of the core skill list and is used for telepathy, telekinesis, clairvoyance, etc.

6.3 Building Dice Pools

Your dice pool for any action is:

$$\text{DicePool} = \text{Attribute} + \text{Skill}.$$

You roll that many d10s and interpret the results according to the core rules (see 2).

6.3.1 Choosing the Right Combination

The same fictional action can often be approached with different Attribute + Skill pairs, depending on how your character does it. The GM has final say, but the default is to use the most obvious pairing (e.g., *Body + Melee* for a straightforward sword swing). Creative alternatives are encouraged when they fit the fiction.

- **Climbing a wall:**
 - *Body + Athletics*: sheer strength and stamina.
 - *Wits + Athletics*: clever route-finding and leverage.
 - *Spirit + Athletics*: grim determination against fear or pain.
- **Persuading a guard:**
 - *Presence + Sway*: charm and personality.
 - *Wits + Sway*: logical, well-constructed arguments.
 - *Spirit + Sway*: conviction that burns through doubt.
- **Investigating a crime scene:**
 - *Wits + Investigation*: methodical observation and deduction.
 - *Spirit + Investigation*: intuitive leaps and gut feelings.
 - *Presence + Investigation*: getting witnesses to open up.

6.3.2 Creative Combinations

With your GM's agreement, you can justify unusual combinations that fit the fiction. The table below offers common alternatives, but the GM may allow others based on the scene.

Intended Action	Standard Pair	Alternative Pairs (Example)
Recall a combat drill	Wits + Lore	Body + Lore (muscle memory)
Soothe a patient	Presence + Medicine	Spirit + Medicine (laying on hands)
Forge a masterwork	Wits + Craft	Spirit + Craft (inspired artistry)
Read weather signs	Wits + Survival	Spirit + Survival (omen-sense)
Feint in a duel	Wits + Melee	Presence + Melee (intimidation feint)
Track a spirit	Wits + Survival	Spirit + Lore (follow its legend)
Bribe a guard	Presence + Sway	Wits + Streetwise (know the right price)

6.3.3 GM Guidance for Creative Pairs

- **Ask "How?"** – The player must describe *how* they use that Attribute and Skill together.
- **Maintain Position** – A creative pair does not automatically improve Position or reduce DV. It just changes the dice pool.
- **Consistency** – If you allow *Spirit + Craft* for visionary work, allow it again in similar circumstances.
- **No Double Dipping** – The player cannot swap both Attribute *and* Skill to max out a single stat; the combination must still respect the fiction.

6.3.4 When to Roll (and When Not To)

Not every action requires a roll. The GM should call for a roll when:

1. The outcome is uncertain.
2. Failure would meaningfully change the situation.
3. The action is significant (not routine).

For routine actions with no real risk, the group can simply agree that you succeed. Example: climbing a knotted rope in calm weather – no roll. Climbing the same rope while goblins shoot arrows – roll.

6.3.5 Assistance and Teamwork

When multiple characters contribute to the same action:

- **Assistance:** One character is primary; up to three others add +1 die each by describing how they help (e.g., "I hold the ladder steady").
- **Cooperation:** Several characters each roll; the group succeeds or fails based on combined results (e.g., all must sneak past a patrol).
- **Complementary:** Different skills cover different parts of a larger task (e.g., one distracts a guard, another picks the lock).

Example: A ranger scales an ice wall using **Wits** + **Athletics** to find the safest holds, then switches to **Body** + **Athletics** to muscle over the lip. The fiction guides which combination fits each moment.

6.3.6 Selling the Action – Intricate Description

You are always welcome to state your action plainly. But when you take a moment to **sell it** – to invest in the fiction, reveal what your character cares about, or show why this moment matters – the GM may reward you with a mechanical edge. This is about *roleplay investment*, not word count.

- **Basic description:** "I attack the goblin with my sword." No bonus.
 - **Tactical description:** Use the environment, positioning, or a clever tactic. "I feint high, then drive my shoulder into the goblin's shield, shoving it aside to open its flank." The GM may or may not upgrade your Position by one step (e.g., *Controlled* → *Dominant*) for this roll.
 - **Character-driven description:** Reveal a stake, a bond, a fear, or a hard choice. *One heartfelt sentence counts more than a paragraph of adjectives.*
 - Example: "I think of my mother, who died because I wasn't brave enough to fight. I won't let that happen again. I plant my feet and dare the goblin to come through me."
- The GM may grant a larger benefit – e.g., upgrade Position *and* bank a **Boon** you can use later, or upgrade Effect by one step.

What Counts (and What Doesn't)

Counts:

- Stating a clear stake: "If I fail this lockpick, my sister doesn't eat."
- Invoking a bond mid-action: "I owe Marcus my life. I'm not letting him face this alone."
- Revealing a fear or hope tied to the roll: "I'm terrified of fire, but I grab the burning beam – because the children are behind me."
- Making a hard choice visible: "I could run, but I don't. Running is what got me exiled."

Does not count:

- Piling on adjectives ("gleaming," "mighty," "ancient") without stakes.
- Passive sensory laundry lists ("the cold wind, the wet stones, the dim light").
- Repeating the same florid description for every roll.

Guidelines for the GM

- **No penalty for plain speech.** Never punish a player who is tired, shy, or simply prefers quick resolution. The bonus is a gift, not a tax.
- **Be consistent.** Reward genuine investment, not vocabulary. A quiet player who delivers one heartfelt sentence deserves the bonus as much as an eloquent storyteller.
- **The bonus should fit the fiction.** A desperate, reckless action described with real stakes might upgrade Effect but worsen Position – let the mechanics mirror the emotion.
- **Invite quiet players.** Ask leading questions: "What's at stake for your character right now?" or "What are you afraid will happen if you fail?" Gentle prompts help shy players find their moment.
- **Group "selling."** If the whole table contributes to describing a group action (a coordinated ambush, a joint ritual), grant the bonus to the primary roller or give each participant a small benefit.

Example

Basic: "I sneak past the sentry." (No bonus, roll as normal.)

Selling it (tactical): "I wait for the wind to rattle the shutters, then pad across the wet cobblestones – heel-toe, heel-toe – keeping the stack of barrels between me and the sentry's gaze." The GM nods: "Great. Because you're using the wind and the barrels, roll at *Dominant* Position."

Selling it (character-driven): "My little brother is in that camp. I've hidden from every fight since we left home – but not this time. I creep forward, not quiet anymore, because he needs to know someone came for him." The GM: "That's the heart of it. Roll at *Dominant* Position, and I'll bank a Story Beat to make his reaction matter."

Remember: The dice still decide success or failure. But a well-told action makes the story richer – and earns you an edge when the dice fall.

6.4 Earning Experience Points

XP represents learning through action. You gain it by engaging meaningfully with the world: overcoming challenges, taking risks, making hard choices, and leaning into your character's story.

6.4.1 Session Breakdown

At the end of each session, XP is awarded based on what happened at the table. A typical breakdown might look like:

- **Base Participation:** +2 XP for attending and contributing.
- **Major Objectives:** +2–4 XP for completing significant story goals.
- **Discoveries:** +1–2 XP for uncovering important lore, locations, or secrets.
- **Hard Choices:** +1–2 XP for making difficult moral or strategic decisions.
- **Story Engagement:** +1–3 XP for embracing complications and twists.
- **Personal Goals:** +1–2 XP for pursuing your character's individual storylines.

Example: At the end of a session, the party rogue gains:

- +2 XP for participation,
- +2 XP for helping retrieve a cursed artifact,
- +1 XP for pushing a personal rivalry subplot.

Total: 5 XP.

6.4.2 Game Pace Options

You and your GM can decide how quickly characters advance, matching the tone you want:

Mode	XP / Session	Tone
Gritty	4–6	Hard choices, slow growth
Standard	6–10	Balanced progression
Epic	10–14	Heroic, rapid development

Player Tip: If you want a sweeping, mythic tale, ask for an *Epic* pace. If you want advancement to feel hard-won, lean toward *Gritty*.

6.4.3 Arc Completion Bonus

When a major story arc finishes (typically 3–6 sessions), everyone gains an additional +8–12 XP. One player may receive +2 XP more for a particularly memorable contribution. This rewards the story as a whole, not just individual rolls.

Boons vs. XP

You may convert 2 Boons → 1 XP (once per session, max 2 XP per session via conversion).

But: Spending Boons during play is almost always more fun. A re-rolled failure, an improved Position, or an activated Asset creates a memorable moment. Hoarding Boons for XP conversion starves the table of drama. Spend freely; the XP will come from your adventures.

6.5 Spending Experience Points

XP is your currency for growth. You can invest it in three broad areas:

1. **Personal Improvement** (Attributes and Skills)
2. **Special Abilities** (Talents, magic, unique tricks)
3. **Resources and Influence** (Assets, followers, organizations)

Think of these as three pillars: *what you can do*, *what makes you unique*, and *what you own or command*.

6.5.1 Personal Improvement

Attributes

Attributes are expensive but powerful. The cost to raise an Attribute is:

$$XPCost = 3 \times newrating.$$

Examples:

- Raising Body from 2 to 3 costs $3 \times 3 = 9$ XP.
- Raising Spirit from 4 to 5 costs $3 \times 5 = 15$ XP.

Attribute increases usually require downtime equal to the new rating in days, spent training, reflecting, or transforming yourself (see 6.7).

Skills

Skills are cheaper and represent focused practice. The cost is:

$$XPCost = 2 \times newlevel.$$

Examples:

- Lore $1 \rightarrow 2$ costs $2 \times 2 = 4$ XP.
- Melee $3 \rightarrow 4$ costs $2 \times 4 = 8$ XP.

Skill increases typically require downtime equal to the new level in days.

Example: Kara wants to improve her swordsmanship (Melee) from 2 to 3. She saves 6 XP and spends three in-game days training with her mentor. This training becomes part of the story, not just a line on a sheet.

6.5.2 Special Abilities

Special abilities are unique moves, talents, or tricks that define your style.

General Abilities (4–8 XP) Universal benefits, like improved recovery, bonus dice in a common situation, or a signature combat technique. *Example:* “Quick Recovery” — heal 1 extra Harm when you rest.

Cultural Abilities (variable) Abilities tied to heritage or background. They may require specific fictional positioning (see 14.3.1). *Example:* “Stone Sense” — an instinctive feel for stonework and tunnels.

Advanced Abilities (12+ XP) High-impact features available at higher tiers, often with strong narrative hooks or prerequisites (see 6.8). *Example:* “Master Diplomat” — once per session, you can reroll or soften the outcome of a failed major negotiation.

Example: A veteran bard purchases *Silver Tongue* for 6 XP, gaining the ability to sway a hostile crowd once per session. This quickly becomes their trademark in tense public scenes.

6.5.3 Resources and Influence

See §10 for full rules. As a quick reference:

Minor Resource (4 XP, 1 week) A small shop, basic workshop, discreet safe house, or minor contact network. Offers modest but reliable benefits.

Standard Resource (8 XP, 2 weeks) A decent-sized business, crew, or operation with real impact. Comes with some upkeep and obligations.

Major Resource (12 XP, 1 month) A large enterprise, elite team, or rare capability. Very potent but also demanding; often becomes a major part of your character’s story.

Player Tip: Resources pull the camera out from your character to your *sphere of influence*. A spy network means intrigue. A workshop means invention. A guild hall means politics.

When to Invest in Assets and Followers

Player Archetype	Typical Investment	Best For
Solo	0–10% XP	Reliable personal power, minimal upkeep.
Mixed (Balanced)	15–25% XP	One solid Follower or Asset (e.g., a scout or a safehouse).
Mastermind	35–55% XP	Networks, informants, multiple Assets; build a faction.

Planning for succession? A loyal Follower (Cap 3+) can become your successor – see the **Legacy Engine** (§??). Investing in a potential heir early pays off when your character retires or falls.

6.6 Character Development Paths

How you spend XP shapes your character's growth. These are broad patterns, not rigid classes.

Path	Typical XP Split	Strengths / Weaknesses
Specialist	70–90% personal, 0–10% resources, 0–20% abilities	Extremely effective in a narrow niche. Vulnerable outside it.
Leader	50–65% personal, 15–25% resources, 15–25% abilities	Well-rounded, boosts the group. Rarely the best at one thing.
Mastermind	25–40% personal, 35–55% resources, 20–40% abilities	Solves problems through assets. Personally vulnerable, many moving parts.

Example (Leader): A merchant-prince spends 60% of XP on personal skills and social abilities, 20% on a network of trade contacts, and 20% on talents that improve negotiation and command.

These patterns are *guides*, not rules. You can shift between them as your story evolves.

6.7 Training and Development Time

Most improvements take time in the fiction. Training montages, study scenes, and building projects are all opportunities for character moments.

6.7.1 Standard Time Requirements

- **Attribute increase:** new rating in days.
- **Skill improvement:** new level in days.
- **Resource acquisition:** about 1 week to 1 month depending on scope.
- **Ability learning:** typically 3–10 days.

6.7.2 Accelerated Development (Rush Rule)

You *can* attempt to learn faster, but rushing has a price.

- The group tracks a short **Risk Clock** (4 segments) for your crash training.
- If it fills, the new capability has flaws:
 - Attribute/Skill: temporary –1 die penalty until you retrain properly.
 - Resource: loyalty issues, partial effectiveness, or hidden problems.
 - Ability: unreliable effects or quirky side consequences.

Example: A wizard crams advanced spellwork into three frantic days. She gains the ability, but the Risk Clock fills: her spells spark and flicker until she takes time to train safely.

6.8 Character Progression Tiers

As you accumulate XP and capabilities, you advance through tiers that represent your growing reputation and influence.

6.8.1 Tier I: Novice (0–40 XP)

- Learning the ropes, establishing yourself.
- Local reputation, modest capabilities.
- Typical assets: basic equipment, a few contacts.
- **Position Manifestation:** The difference between life and death; a shift from Desperate to Controlled means "I live to fight another day."

6.8.2 Tier II: Seasoned (41–90 XP)

- Proven capability, reliable in your specialty.
- Regional reputation, respected in your field.
- Typical assets: skilled followers, specialized equipment.
- **Position Manifestation:** The difference between victory and defeat; a shift from Controlled to Dominant means "I've earned the right to choose how this ends."

6.8.3 Tier III: Veteran (91–150 XP)

- Master of your craft, significant influence.
- National reputation, can handle major challenges.
- Typical assets: multiple operations, elite teams.
- **Position Manifestation:** The difference between influence and control; a shift from Controlled to Dominant means "The city hangs on my decision."

6.8.4 Tier IV: Paragon (151–220 XP)

- Exceptional capability, strategic influence.
- Continental influence, shapes regional outcomes.
- Typical assets: organizations, unique capabilities.
- **Position Manifestation:** The difference between shaping events and defining eras; a shift from Controlled to Dominant means "I am the axis upon which history turns."

6.8.5 Tier V: Mythic (221+ XP)

- Legendary status, world-changing influence.
- Historical reputation, defines eras.
- Typical assets: nations, legendary artifacts.
- **Position Manifestation:** The difference between ending and remaking the world; a shift from Desperate to Controlled means "The universe waits on my choice."

6.8.6 Position Scales with Narrative Weight

The mechanical effect of Position (re-rolling one die, see [2](#)) never changes — but what it *means* evolves with your tier:

- **Tier I:** Position defines personal survival.
- **Tier III:** Position shapes regional outcomes.
- **Tier V:** Position reshapes reality.

The system does not need to scale — your story does.

GM Tip: Never add mechanical bonuses to Position. Instead, deepen the narrative weight:

- **Tier I:** "Your Position shows whether you live or die."
- **Tier V:** "Your Position shows how the world bends to your will."

The mechanics stay consistent so the narrative can grow as large as your imagination allows.

6.9 Managing Allies and Followers

Allies can extend your reach but also create obligations and risks. For full rules, see §10.

6.9.1 Acquisition Costs

A skilled helper's cost in XP is roughly their *capability rating squared*. *Example:* A capability 3 scout costs $3^2 = 9$ XP.

6.9.2 Upkeep Requirements

Each downtime period, you either:

- spend XP equal to their capability rating, **or**
- dedicate a meaningful scene to maintaining the relationship (time, favors, protection).

6.9.3 Risk Management

- When big complications arise, your allies can be targeted instead of you.
- Allies can handle one significant task off-screen per downtime, but this often creates extra story fallout (the GM gains a Story Beat).

6.10 Skill Advancement and Synergies

6.10.1 XP Costs

Improvement	XP Cost
0 → 1	2 XP
1 → 2	4 XP
2 → 3	6 XP
3 → 4	8 XP
4 → 5	10 XP

6.10.2 Training Time

- 0 → 1: 1 day of practice.
- 1 → 2: 3 days of training.
- 2 → 3: 1 week of intensive study.
- 3 → 4: 2 weeks with a master or rigorous practice.
- 4 → 5: 1 month of dedicated focus.

6.10.3 Attribute Limits

You cannot have a Skill rating higher than the relevant Attribute. To advance a Skill further, you must first raise its primary Attribute (see 6.1).

6.10.4 Skill Synergies

When the fiction supports it, well-justified combinations of skills can grant +1 die or better Position/Effect. Examples:

- **Combat:** Tactics + Command (battlefield coordination), Melee + Athletics (acrobatic strikes).
- **Social:** Sway + Lore (persuasion backed by knowledge), Deception + Performance (long

cons).

- **Exploration:** Investigation + Survival (tracking), Lore + Insight (cultural observation).

6.11 Using Skills in Play

6.11.1 When to Roll

You roll when:

- the outcome is uncertain,
- failure would matter to the story, and
- the action is significant enough to deserve the spotlight.

For routine actions with no real risk, the group can often simply agree that you succeed.

6.11.2 Difficulty and Skill Level

As your skill rises, routine tasks become trivial. A rough guideline:

Skill Level	Routine Task	Challenging Task
0	Needs a roll; modest DV	Needs a roll; higher DV
1	Often needs a roll	Challenging but fair
2	Usually automatic	Needs a roll; moderate DV
3	Automatic	Needs a roll; interesting stakes
4+	Automatic	Automatic for simple cases

Reading this as a player: by Skill 3, basic tasks in your area of expertise should rarely require rolls. You are there to be impressive, not to trip over routine jobs.

6.11.3 Group Skill Use

When multiple characters contribute:

- **Assistance:** One character is primary; up to three others add +1 die each by describing how they help (see 2).
- **Cooperation:** Several characters each roll; the group succeeds or fails based on combined results.
- **Complementary:** Different skills cover different parts of a larger task (e.g. one distracts, one picks a lock).

6.12 Skill Challenges

Some goals are too big for a single roll.

6.12.1 Extended Tests

For long, involved tasks:

- The group sets a progress clock (4–8 segments).
- Each significant success fills one or more segments.
- Complications can add segments or create new problems.

6.12.2 Complex Challenges

For multi-step or multi-skill situations:

- Different skills tackle different phases of the challenge.
- Success in one area creates opportunities; failure creates obstacles.

Example (Heist): **Stealth** to infiltrate, **Craft** to bypass locks, **Investigation** to find the vault, **Deception** to mislead guards. Each roll advances a *Heist Clock*; complications add heat, suspicion, or security changes.

6.13 Strategic Advancement Considerations

6.13.1 Early Game (Tiers I–II)

- Focus on survival and a clear niche.
- Raise a key Attribute to 3 early.
- Bring core Skills to 2–3.
- Establish one or two modest resources or safe havens.

6.13.2 Mid Game (Tier III)

- Develop signature moves or combinations.
- Expand your resource base.
- Consider your role in the group and lean into it.

6.13.3 Late Game (Tiers IV–V)

- Choose advanced abilities that reshape the story around you.
- Build organizations, movements, or legacies.
- Decide how your character will leave their mark on the world.

Common Advancement Mistakes

Avoid these pitfalls:

- **Over-specializing too early:** A Melee 5 character with Body 3 is fragile and incapable outside combat.
- **Forgetting training time:** You cannot learn a new skill in the middle of a dungeon without justification.
- **Neglecting resources:** A few well-chosen assets can solve problems no amount of personal skill can.
- **Hoarding XP:** Spend your XP! Characters who never improve become irrelevant to the escalating threats.

6.14 Practical Examples

6.14.1 Combat Example

A warrior with Body 4 and Melee 3 attacks:

- Dice pool: $4 + 3 = 7d10$.
- Opponent's defenses and the fiction help set the difficulty (see 2).

- Strong successes translate into higher Effect or better Position.

6.14.2 Social Example

A diplomat with Presence 3 and Sway 2 negotiates:

- Dice pool: $3 + 2 = 5d10$.
- Position might be *Controlled* if circumstances favor them, or worse if under suspicion.
- Consequences for failure could be mistrust, delays, or new complications.

6.14.3 Exploration Example

A scout with Wits 3 and Survival 2 searches for tracks:

- Dice pool: $3 + 2 = 5d10$.
- Easier tasks (fresh tracks) are more forgiving; older or obscured tracks are harder.
- Partial successes might reveal some information but not all, or come with side effects (e.g., you find the tracks but disturb a nest of predators).

Your Attributes and Skills determine not just *if* you succeed, but *how* you tackle problems. Lean into combinations that express your character's style.

XP Planning Guide

Early Tier Priorities:

- Raise a core Attribute to 3 (9 XP).
- Bring key Skills to 2–3 (4–6 XP each).
- Claim 1–2 minor resources (4 XP each).

Mid Tier Expansion:

- Push core Attributes toward 4 (12 XP).
- Specialize key Skills to 4 (8 XP).
- Add standard resources (8 XP each).
- Explore cultural or thematic abilities (6–10 XP).

Late Tier Mastery:

- Purchase capstone abilities (12+ XP).
- Establish major resources (12 XP).
- Launch legacy projects, organizations, or movements.

Attributes and Skills Quick Reference

Attributes (1–5):

- **Body:** physical capability
- **Wits:** mental acuity
- **Spirit:** willpower and inner strength
- **Presence:** social influence

Skill Levels:

- 0: Untrained 1: Novice 2: Competent
- 3: Professional 4: Master 5: Grand Master

Core Skills (18):

- Combat: Melee, Ranged, Brawl, Tactics
- Physical: Athletics, Stealth, Endurance, Craft, Survival
- Social: Sway, Command, Deception, Performance, Insight
- Knowledge: Lore, Investigation, Medicine
- Magic: Arcana, Ritual

Dice Pool: Attribute + Skill d10s.

Skill Improvement: New level $\times$ 2 XP (plus training time).

Specialization: At Skill 3+, you are a known expert in that field.

Synergy: Well-justified combinations of skills can grant +1 die or better Position/Effect when the fiction supports it.

Chapter 7

Experience Paths and Character Building

How you spend your **Experience Points (XP)** shapes more than your numbers on a sheet—it defines your character’s *career*, their growth over time, and the kind of stories they invite into play.

This chapter focuses on:

- turning a loose idea into a clear **character concept**,
- mapping that concept into **starting choices** that fit the campaign rules,
- choosing a **career path** (how you plan to grow),
- and understanding how your character can evolve across **early, mid, and late** game.

All examples in this chapter are *legal starting builds* under the standard creation rules, and are written to be directly usable by players.

7.1 From Concept to Career

Before you spend a single XP, start with the story you want to tell.

Step 1: Concept Seed

Begin with a simple statement of who your character is:

- “Stoic bodyguard who will take the hit for anyone else.”
- “Nervy courier who knows every back alley in the city.”
- “Soft-spoken merchant who pulls strings behind the scenes.”

This is your **concept seed**. Everything else grows from here.

Step 2: Role in the Party

Decide what you want to *do at the table*:

- Take hits and lock down threats?
- Spot danger and solve practical problems?
- Talk through conflicts and manage social fallout?
- Create tools, magic, or plans that enable everyone else?

Your role helps you choose a **Primary Attribute** and 2–3 **Key Skills** (see 6).

Step 3: Career Theme

Ask yourself:

- Is this a story of *self-mastery*? (training, discipline, pushing limits)
- A story of *connections*? (alliances, obligations, webs of influence)
- A story of *balance*? (learning to juggle many demands at once)

Your answer naturally points you toward one of the three **XP paths** in this chapter.

Step 4: Long Arc in One Sentence

Write a single sentence for where you imagine your character at high XP:

- “I want to become the greatest duelist in the realm.”
- “I want to map the unknown and bring others safely home.”
- “I want to run the network everyone relies on but no one sees.”

You do not have to stick to this forever, but it gives you a *direction* for your early choices.

Character Career Checklist

Before spending XP, decide:

1. Your **concept seed** (one sentence).
2. Your **role in the party** (what you do most).
3. Your preferred **career theme**: self, balance, or influence.
4. A rough **long arc** (where you want to end up).

Start simple. You can always refine these as the campaign unfolds.

7.2 Mapping Concept to Mechanics

Once you have a concept, you turn it into numbers. Use this as a guideline:

1. Pick a **Primary Attribute** that supports your role (Body, Wits, Spirit, or Presence) – see 6.1.
2. Choose 2–3 **Key Skills** that you want to be noticeably good at (see 6.2).
3. Choose a **Career Path** (Personal, Balanced, Influencer) that matches your theme.
4. Use the starting XP budget in 7.9 to buy:
 - Attribute steps for your primary and possibly secondary stats.
 - Skill steps for your key and supporting skills.
 - Optional resources or special abilities, if your path calls for them.

Throughout this chapter, each example shows how a concept becomes a legal build.

7.3 Three Career Paths

There are three broad approaches to character development, each representing a different **career philosophy**:

Personal Path Focus on personal mastery and self-improvement (7.5).

Balanced Path Mix personal growth with resources and influence (7.6).

Influencer Path Build networks, assets, and strategic power (7.7).

These paths are not rigid classes. They are *patterns* that help you decide where most of your XP will go, especially in the early game.

7.4 Player Archetypes

Not every player spends XP the same way. These three **player archetypes** describe common patterns. Identify yours – it will help you choose a career path and avoid frustration.

The Solo

Definition: Invests XP primarily in Attributes and Skills. Minimal followers, minimal holdings. All power is on the character sheet.

Typical XP Spread: 70–90% Self; 0–10% On-screen help; 0–20% Off-screen assets.

Strengths: Consistent scene impact; few moving parts; resilient to follower loss.

Risks: Limited fiction reach between sessions; can stall when problems demand logistics or networks.

Starting Focus: Attributes 2–3, Skills 1–2, minimal assets.

The Mixed Player

Definition: Splits XP between self-growth and one or two meaningful assets (a small follower or a reliable holding).

Typical XP Spread: 50–65% Self; 15–25% On-screen help; 15–25% Off-screen assets.

Strengths: Versatile: credible in scenes and has a lever for special problems.

Risks: Upkeep pressure; helper can be targeted when the GM spends 2+ Story Beats.

Starting Focus: Balanced approach with one minor asset or low-cap follower.

The Mastermind

Definition: Prioritises followers / cadres / familiars and off-screen networks. The character sheet is the hub of a larger apparatus.

Typical XP Spread: 25–40% Self; 35–55% On-screen help; 20–40% Off-screen assets.

Strengths: Scene control via assistance; strategic reach between sessions; strong heist / social-planning play.

Risks: Dependency on assist lanes; followers can be endangered on 2+ SB spends; upkeep pressure.

Starting Focus: Significant investment in followers or major assets from the beginning.

Which Archetype Are You?

Ask yourself:

- Do I want my character to be self-sufficient and always ready? → **Solo**

- Do I enjoy having a helpful sidekick or a home base, but not too much bookkeeping? → **Mixed**
- Do I love managing networks, commanding troops, and solving problems through influence? → **Mastermind**

There is no wrong answer – but knowing your style helps you build a character you will enjoy for many sessions.

7.5 Path 1: Personal Development

The **Personal Path** centers your character’s career on what *they* can do: their body, mind, and honed skills. This is the path of the duelist, the ascetic, the elite scout, the master healer.

Typical Investment

- 70–90% Personal improvement (Attributes and Skills)
- 0–10% Resources and assets
- 0–20% Special abilities

Strengths

- Reliable in direct challenges and combat
- Minimal upkeep or management required
- Resilient to loss of external resources
- Consistent performance in spotlight moments

Weaknesses

- Limited influence in social or strategic scenes
- May struggle with problems requiring networks
- Less capable in logistics or large-scale operations
- Dependent on personal presence for all solutions

Career View

On this path, your “career ladder” is mostly about pushing numbers related to **you**: raising Attributes, deepening Skills, and picking a few defining abilities. Your late-game questions are:

- “What does a legendary version of this look like?”
- “What scenes prove that I have truly mastered my craft?”

Build Example: The Duelist (Legal Start)

Concept Seed: “A proud blade whose entire life is training and challenge.”

Total XP: 30 (34 with +4 from Bonds/Complications; see 7.9)

- **Attributes:** Body 3, Wits 2, Spirit 1, Presence 1
 - Costs (Attributes cost *new rating* × 3): Body 1→2 (6), 2→3 (9) = **15**; Wits 1→2 (6) = **6**; Spirit/Presence remain 1 = **0**. *Subtotal: 21 XP*
- **Skills:** Melee 2, Athletics 1
 - Costs (Skills cost *new level* × 2): Melee 0→1 (2), 1→2 (4) = **6**; Athletics 0→1 = **2**.

Subtotal: 8 XP

- **Totals:** $21 + 8 = 29$ XP. Bank 1 XP.
- **With +4 XP (Bonds/Complications):** Add *Perception* 0→1 (2) and spend banked 1 XP on *Stealth* 0→1 (2), or instead take *Perception* 0→1 (2) and *Sway* 0→1 (2) for broader utility. *Cap: 34 XP.*

Career Hook: Early scenes show duels and drills. Mid game focuses on notorious opponents. Late game tells the story of a blade whose name carries across borders.

7.6 Path 2: Balanced Approach

The **Balanced Path** mixes personal capability with supportive resources. This is the path of the scout-captain, the field medic with a small clinic, the problem-solver who always seems to have *something* ready.

Typical Investment

- 50–65% Personal improvement
- 15–25% Resources and assets
- 15–25% Special abilities

Strengths

- Adaptable to diverse situations
- Handles both direct and indirect challenges
- Excellent supporting role for the group
- Moderate risk profile

Weaknesses

- Not exceptional in any single area
- Requires management of resources
- Moderate upkeep demands
- Can be outshone by focused specialists

Career View

Balanced characters often have careers that feel like juggling:

- they add contacts, gear, or small bases *and*
- keep raising the core skills that let them use those tools well.

Their late-game questions are:

- “What does my little network or operation look like at full size?”
- “How do my personal skills and resources fit together as a whole?”

Build Example: The Scout (Legal Start)

Concept Seed: “A pathfinder who knows how to get in, get out, and get others home.”

Total XP: 30 (34 with +4 from Bonds/Complications)

- **Attributes:** Wits 2, Body 2, Spirit 1, Presence 1

- Costs: Wits 1→2 (6), Body 1→2 (6) = **12 XP**
- **Skills:** Survival 2, Perception 1, Stealth 1
 - Costs: Survival 0→1 (2), 1→2 (4) = **6**; Perception 0→1 **2**; Stealth 0→1 **2**. *Subtotal: 10 XP*
- **Resources:** *Minor equipment cache* (camp gear, maps, signal kit) = **4 XP**
- **Special Abilities:** *Wilderness Lore* (broad travel benefits) = **4 XP**
- **Totals:** 12 + 10 + 4 + 4 = **30 XP**.
- **With +4 XP:** add *Perception 1→2* (+4) or take a *trained hawk companion* (Minor Resource, 4 XP).

Career Hook: Early stories show small journeys. Mid game explores dangerous routes and rescue missions. Late game might see the scout running expeditions, caravans, or an entire mapping guild.

7.7 Path 3: Influencer Focus

The **Influencer Path** emphasizes networks, assets, and strategic power. This is the path of the merchant-prince, the fixer, the spymaster, the noble with more favors owed than coins in their purse.

Typical Investment

- 25–40% Personal improvement
- 35–55% Resources and assets
- 20–40% Special abilities

Strengths

- Strong strategic and social influence
- Can solve problems indirectly
- Excellent at planning and preparation
- Creates opportunities for the whole group

Weaknesses

- Personally vulnerable in direct confrontations
- High maintenance requirements
- Complications can cascade through networks
- Dependent on external factors

Career View

Influencer careers are about building and surviving **webs**:

- webs of contacts, debts, trade routes, cells, or clients.

Late game questions become:

- “How big can this web reasonably grow within the fiction?”
- “What happens when a strand of my web is cut, or pulled tight?”

Build Example: The Merchant (Legal Start)

Concept Seed: “A friendly shopkeeper whose real power lies in who owes them favors.”

Total XP: 30 (34 with +4 from Bonds/Complications)

- **Attributes:** Presence 2, Wits 2, Spirit 1, Body 1
 - Costs: Presence 1→2 (6), Wits 1→2 (6) = **12 XP**
- **Skills:** Sway 2, Deception 1, Lore 1
 - Costs: Sway 0→1 (2), 1→2 (4) = **6**; Deception 0→1 **2**; Lore 0→1 **2**. *Subtotal: 10 XP*
- **Resources:** *Standard trading office* (staffed storefront, ledgers, storage) = **8 XP**
- **Totals:** 12 + 10 + 8 = **30 XP**.
- **With +4 XP:** add *Negotiation Mastery* (4 XP general ability) *or* expand to a second *Minor merchant route* (4 XP).

Career Hook: Early scenes are about one shop and a few key clients. Mid game introduces caravans, deals, and rivals. Late game might place the merchant at the center of regional politics and supply chains.

7.8 Building for Group Synergy

Your character's career path matters most in context with the rest of the party. A well-constructed party covers key roles without excessive overlap.

Key Roles to Consider

Combat Frontline defence, skirmishing, or ranged fire support.

Social Negotiation, intimidation, information gathering.

Exploration Scouting, navigating, surviving hostile environments.

Magic Free casting, rites, rituals, or summoning.

Assets Logistics, networks, safehouses, followers.

Complementary Paths

- **Personal path** characters provide reliable combat and specialist solutions.
- **Balanced path** characters handle diverse, connective challenges.
- **Influencer path** characters create opportunities and resources for everyone.

Together, a mixed party can cover nearly every type of problem.

Redundant Paths

- Multiple personal path characters may overlap in combat or role.
- Multiple influencer path characters may compete for spotlight and assets.
- Consider diversifying within similar paths: different weapon styles, different Patrons, different social approaches.
- Example: Two combatants – one a duelist (single-target damage), one a shield-focused guardian (area protection).

Balancing Your Table

If you notice a gap (e.g., no one has investment in social skills or no one has a safehouse asset), consider adjusting your XP spending or discussing with the group. A party that talks about roles early will have a smoother campaign.

7.9 Starting Character Guidelines

Base XP Allocation

- **Standard Starting XP: 30 points**
- **Bonds and Complications:** You may take up to **two total** from any mix of meaningful *Bonds* (up to 2, +2 XP each) and significant *Complications* (up to 2, +2 XP each), granting maximum **+4 XP**. (See Bonds, ??.)
- **Maximum Starting XP: 34 points**
- **Complication Effect:** Each unresolved starting Complication adds +1 banked SB to early scenes until cleared.

Recommended Starting Ranges

Category	Recommended XP
Primary Attribute	9–12 XP (rating 3–4)
Secondary Attributes	0–9 XP each (rating 1–3)
Key Skills	4–6 XP each (rating 2–3)
Supporting Skills	2–4 XP each (rating 1–2)
Resources	0–8 XP total
Special Abilities	0–8 XP total

7.9.0.0.1 Cost Reminders:

- **Attributes:** Each step costs *new rating* × 3 XP (e.g., 1→2 costs 6; 2→3 costs 9). See 6.1.
- **Skills:** Each step costs *new level* × 2 XP (e.g., 0→1 costs 2; 1→2 costs 4). See 6.2.
- **Resources:** Minor 4 XP; Standard 8 XP; Major 12 XP.
- **Special Abilities:** Minor Edge 2 XP; Major Edge 4 XP; Prestige 6+ XP.

7.10 Progression Planning

Think of your character’s career in phases. These XP bands are approximate and assume you began at 30–34 XP.

Early Game (0–40 XP)

Focus on establishing core capabilities:

- Reach attribute rating 3 in your primary area.
- Develop 2–3 key skills to rating 2–3.
- Acquire basic resources or one special ability (if your path uses them).
- Clarify your character’s niche in the group.

When to take a Follower vs. Asset vs. Talent (Early):

- **Follower:** If you want on-screen help (a scout, a bodyguard, an apprentice). Start with Cap 1–2.
- **Asset:** If you want an off-screen advantage (a safehouse, a workshop, a contact network). Start with Minor Asset (4 XP).

- **Talent:** If you want a signature move (combat technique, social edge, magic access). Minor talents (2–3 XP) are great early.

Mid Game (41–90 XP)

Expand and specialize:

- Increase your primary attribute to 4.
- Specialize key skills to rating 3–4.
- Develop supporting capabilities that fit your concept.
- Build strategic resources or networks if on the Balanced or Influencer path.
- Acquire signature special abilities that define your style.

When to take a Follower vs. Asset vs. Talent (Mid):

- **Follower:** Upgrade a loyal contact to Cap 3 (9 XP) – they become a reliable asset who can act independently.
- **Asset:** Expand your network – a Standard Asset (8 XP) turns a safehouse into a spy ring or a workshop into a guild connection.
- **Talent:** Major talents (4–6 XP) define your mid-game identity – Backstab, Ritual Mastery, Command Presence.

Late Game (91–150 XP)

Master your chosen path:

- Achieve peak attributes (rating 4–5).
- Master key skills (rating 4–5).
- Build substantial influence or unique capabilities.
- Develop advanced special abilities.
- Consider legacy projects, organizations, or long-term changes to the setting.

When to take a Follower vs. Asset vs. Talent (Late):

- **Follower:** A Cap 4–5 follower (16–25 XP) can become a successor (see ??) – invest in someone who could carry on your cause.
- **Asset:** Major Assets (12 XP) give you regional influence – a fortress, a charter, a fleet.
- **Talent:** Prestige (7–10 XP) and Epic (11+ XP) talents reshape the story. Plan your build around one or two capstones.

XP Path Quick Reference

Personal Path (70–90% self):

- Reliable individual performance.
- Low upkeep, high consistency.
- Best for combatants and focused specialists.

Balanced Path (50–65% self):

- Good all-around capability.
- Moderate risk and upkeep.
- Flexible support and problem-solving role.

Influencer Path (25–40% self):

- Strategic power and influence.
- High upkeep, high reward.
- Creates opportunities for the entire group.

Starting XP: 30 base + up to +4 from Bonds/Complications (max start **34**).

7.11 Path Combination Strategies

Many players mix elements from different paths as their character's life unfolds.

Combat Specialist with Resources

- Strong personal combat capabilities.
- Moderate resource investment for support.
- Good for frontline fighters who need logistical backup.
- Example: Warrior with a fortified base and loyal troops.

Social Character with Personal Skills

- Excellent social capabilities.
- Solid personal skills for self-defense or utility.
- Good for diplomats who operate independently.
- Example: Ambassador with combat training and persuasion skills.

Technical Expert with Networks

- Deep technical or magical expertise.
- Network of contacts and resources to enable projects.
- Good for specialists who need supply chains and helpers.
- Example: Master crafter with supplier network and apprentices.

7.12 Resource Management

Each path asks for different management styles across your character's career.

Personal Path Management

- Minimal upkeep requirements.
- Focus on equipment, training scenes, and personal growth.
- Low complexity, high reliability.

Balanced Path Management

- Moderate upkeep for resources.
- Relationship maintenance with contacts.
- Skill development alongside resource management.
- Balanced time investment between self and assets.

Influencer Path Management

- Significant upkeep demands.

- Network maintenance and expansion.
- Resource allocation and development.
- Strategic planning and opportunity management.

7.13 Risk Assessment

Each path carries different career risks.

Personal Path Risks

- Over-specialization in one area.
- Vulnerability to problems outside your specialty.
- Limited diversification later in the game.
- May become predictable in approach.

Balanced Path Risks

- Jack-of-all-trades, master of none.
- Spread too thin across capabilities.
- Moderate risks in multiple areas.
- May lack standout, defining capabilities if unfocused.

Influencer Path Risks

- Networks are vulnerable to attack and betrayal.
- High maintenance requirements.
- Cascade failure potential if a key asset falls.
- Personal safety concerns when the web is targeted.

7.14 Adapting Your Path

Your chosen path is a starting point, not a contract. You can shift focus as your character's story changes.

Early Shift (0–40 XP)

- Easy to change direction.
- Minimal sunk cost in any single approach.
- Good time to experiment with different styles.
- You can respond quickly to group needs or unexpected story turns.

Mid Game Shift (41–90 XP)

- Requires more deliberate planning.
- Some capabilities need to be maintained while others change.
- You can fill emerging gaps in group capability.
- Temporary performance dips may occur during the transition.

Late Game Shift (91+ XP)

- Significant investment in your current path.
- Major shifts require substantial XP and story justification.
- Often better to add complementary capabilities than completely pivot.

- Consider how changes reflect pivotal events in your character's life.

7.15 Practical Building Examples (Narrative Roles, Legal Starts)

Each of the following examples combines:

- a short **concept**,
- a **path choice**,
- a legal **starting build**,
- and a sketch of their **career arc**.

Example 1: The Guardian

Path: Personal **Total:** 30 XP

Concept Seed: “Quiet wall of muscle who would rather bleed than lose anyone.”

- **Attributes:** Body 3 (1→2: 6, 2→3: 9), Wits 2 (1→2: 6) = **21 XP**
- **Skills:** Melee 2 (0→1: 2, 1→2: 4 = 6), Athletics 1 (0→1: 2) = **8 XP**
- **Bank:** 1 XP
- **Role at table:** Frontline protection and reliable pressure in fights.
- **With +4 XP:** add *Combat Reflexes* (2 XP talent) and *Shield Mastery* (4 XP talent) using banked 1 + 4 = 5 XP (GM may allow rounding or an extra minor Complication), or instead buy more supporting skills.

Career Arc: Early on, the Guardian is “the one who stands in front.” Mid game adds tactical awareness and maybe leadership. Late game might see them training others or becoming the symbol of a cause.

Example 2: The Explorer

Path: Balanced **Total:** 30 XP

Concept Seed: “Curious wanderer whose maps are more valuable than gold.”

- **Attributes:** Wits 2 (6), Body 2 (6) = **12 XP**
- **Skills:** Survival 2 (0→1: 2, 1→2: 4 = 6), Perception 1 (2), Stealth 1 (2) = **10 XP**
- **Resources:** Minor mapping kit & route notes = **4 XP**
- **Ability:** Trail Sense = **4 XP**
- **Totals:** 30 XP. With +4 XP, raise *Perception* 1→2 (+4) or add a trained beast (Minor Resource, 4 XP).

Career Arc: Early stories focus on survival and discovery. Mid game might see them guiding trade, armies, or refugees. Late game, they may literally redraw the map of the setting.

Example 3: The Schemer

Path: Influencer **Total:** 30 XP

Concept Seed: “The person who always knows someone who knows someone.”

- **Attributes:** Presence 2 (6), Wits 2 (6) = **12 XP**
- **Skills:** Sway 2 (0→1: 2, 1→2: 4 = 6), Deception 1 (2), Lore 1 (2) = **10 XP**
- **Resources:** Standard safehouse & message drops = **8 XP**
- **Totals: 30 XP.** With +4 XP, take *Network Builder* (4 XP talent) or add *Minor informant ring* (4 XP).

Career Arc: Early on, the Schemer is just “the one with connections.” Mid game grows their network and enemies. Late game, they might operate entire webs of spies, informants, merchants, or political factions.

7.15.0.0.1 Reminder: All builds above assume baseline *Attributes at 1* and *Skills at 0* before spending. Attribute and Skill advances are cumulative by step (see costs in 7.9).

Remember: Your chosen path should reflect both your character concept and your preferred play style. There is no single “correct” path—only what works for you, your group, and the story you want to tell.

Planning for Succession (The Legacy Engine)

If you are playing a long campaign or enjoy the idea of your character's influence outlasting them, consider investing in a **Follower** (Cap 3+) early. That follower can become your **successor** when your character retires or falls – inheriting your faction standing, one unresolved burden, and a Legacy Bond (see **Chapter 13: The Legacy Engine**). A loyal apprentice, a trusted lieutenant, or a family member can carry your story forward.

7.16 Narrative-Heavy Character Building Options

For groups that prefer a strong narrative focus in character building, you can treat XP as a tool for telling the story of a career, not just a currency.

7.16.0.0.1 Story-Driven Milestones Instead of tracking XP numerically, the GM can award advancement when characters reach significant story milestones. “You have trained with the master for months—you’ve improved your skill.”

7.16.0.0.2 Experience Through Reflection Players can spend downtime scenes reflecting on past experiences to earn XP. A meaningful flashback, confession, or revelation can justify growth without counting every point.

7.16.0.0.3 Collaborative Advancement The group can discuss and agree on advancement choices, ensuring everyone’s growth supports the overall story direction and shared arcs.

7.16.0.0.4 Narrative Justification Focus When spending XP, players should explain how their character gained this capability through in-game experiences, creating richer backstory and continuity. “I raise Presence because I’ve been forced to handle the group’s negotiations for weeks.”

7.16.0.0.5 Path as Theme Use your chosen path as a **theme** rather than a strict budget:

- A Personal Path character emphasizes physical, mental, or spiritual self-mastery.
- A Balanced Path character emphasizes learning how to juggle tools and relationships.

- An Influencer Path character emphasizes their growing web of relationships and obligations.

In all cases, let your character's **career** on the page match the career they are living in the fiction.

Chapter 8

Talents and Special Abilities

Talents are the building blocks of character specialization. They represent learned techniques, supernatural gifts, or cultural inheritances. Each Talent costs XP, and its cost reflects its impact.

8.1 Understanding Talents

Talents are purchased with **Experience Points (XP)** (see 6) and provide special capabilities:

- They go beyond simple skill bonuses.
- They often have specific **activation conditions**.
- They may provide **narrative permissions** (you can try things others cannot).
- They can define your character's **unique identity**.

Talent Costs by Tier

Tier	Cost	Scope
Minor	2–3 XP	Small situational bonus, once per scene.
Major	4–6 XP	Strong upgrade, permanent effect in a niche.
Prestige	7–10 XP	Campaign-defining, breaks fundamental limits.
Epic	11+ XP	Legendary ability, shapes the story.

8.1.0.0.1 Activation Types.

- **Passive:** Always on; no action required.
- **Active:** Requires an action or scene focus to use.
- **Reactive:** Triggers automatically on a condition.

8.1.0.0.2 Limits and Economy. Unless a talent says otherwise:

- **Per scene** uses refresh at scene end.
- **Per session** uses refresh after downtime.
- Some talents allow you to spend **Boons** (see 2) to push effects further.

Only One Active Talent?

The rule "only one talent can be active at a time" applies only to **activated abilities** that require a decision or action. **Passive** talents (e.g., +1 die to perception) are always active and stack. **Active** talents that require an action or reaction cannot be used simultaneously – you choose which one to activate when the trigger occurs. Talents that are "once per scene" reset at the end of the scene.

8.2 Minor Talents (2–3 XP)

General

Keen Senses [PERCEPTION]

Cost: 2 XP Passive. +1 die on perception checks to spot danger or hidden details.

Silver Tongue [PERSUASION]

Cost: 2 XP Passive. +1 die on persuasion attempts.

Second Wind [RECOVERY]

Cost: 2 XP Active, once per scene. Clear 1 Fatigue when you take a moment to catch your breath.

Combat Reflexes [REACTIVE]

Cost: 2 XP Reactive. +1 die on defense rolls when surprised or flanked.

Precise Strike [STRIKE]

Cost: 2 XP Active, once per scene. Ignore armor on one attack if you had Dominant or Controlled position.

Trackless Step [EVADE]

Cost: 2 XP Active, once per scene. Leave no trail for the rest of the scene.

Urban Navigation [DIRECTION]

Cost: 2 XP Passive. Never get lost in cities.

Wilderness Lore [NATURE]

Cost: 2 XP Passive. Automatically find food and water in hospitable biomes.

Read Emotions [INSIGHT]

Cost: 2 XP Active, once per scene. Automatically detect surface emotions in a social exchange.

Iron Patience [RESISTANCE]

Cost: 2 XP Passive. When you Defend, gain +1 die to resist Conditions (fear, charm, fatigue) for the rest of the exchange, even outside the triggering roll.

Requires: Resolve 1+.

Stand Firm [PROTECT]

Cost: 2 XP Reactive. When you Defend and roll a Miss, downgrade incoming Harm by 1 level (minimum 0).

Requires: Body 2+.

Counterpoise [EVADE]

Cost: 2 XP Reactive. When you take a Defend action and score a Partial, you may immediately move 1 range band or reposition within Near without provoking retaliation.

Requires: Athletics 1+ or Melee 1+.

Magic Access**Familiar** [SPIRIT] [BOND]

Cost: 2 XP Passive. Required to access Patron features such as Patron's Gift. Binds a Thiasos.

Spellcraft [FIRE] [WATER]

Cost: 6 XP (This is a Major-tier talent; see 8.3.)

Monk**Disciplined Body** [STRENGTH] [RECOVERY]

Cost: 3 XP Passive + Active. +1 die to unarmed combat attacks. Once per scene, convert 1 Harm to Fatigue, and once per scene improve Position by one step.

Requires: Melee 1+, Body 2+.

Combat**Defensive Survival** [DEFENSE] [RECOVERY]

Cost: 3 XP Passive + Active. +1 die to defense rolls while engaged in melee. Once per scene, convert first Harm 1 from melee to Fatigue.

Requires: Melee 2+.

Weapon Master (Light) [MASTERY]

Cost: 3 XP Passive. +1 die with a chosen weapon category (instead of +2 from the Major version).

Note: The full +2 dice version is a Major talent (Weapon Mastery; see 8.3).

8.3 Major Talents (4–6 XP)

Magic Access**Spellcraft** [FIRE] [WATER]

Cost: 6 XP Passive. Grants access to Weave & Cast freeform spellcasting using the Eight Elements. Without this, characters cannot freeform cast.

Codex [FATE] [RITUAL]

Cost: 4 XP Passive. Required to fully join a Patron's service as a Runekeeper. Grants access to that Patron's Rites and Obligation system (see 3).

Patron's Symbol [WARD] [SIGIL]

Cost: 4 XP Minor Asset. Allows an Invoker to access a Patron's Rites via ritual precision. Each Patron requires its own Symbol.

Patron's Gift [IMBUEMENT]

Cost: Free (requires Familiar) Active, once per scene. Imbue one item with +1 Melee and +1 thematic Skill for the scene. Push It (mark +1 Obligation) to extend one more scene.

General

Weapon Mastery [WEAPON]

Cost: 5 XP Passive. Choose a weapon type; +2 dice when using it. Once per scene, +1 Effect with signature weapon.

Requires: Melee 2+.

Command Presence [LEADERSHIP]

Cost: 4 XP Passive. +1 die on leadership and intimidation rolls.

Network Builder [BOND]

Cost: 4 XP Passive. Gain a minor contact in each new settlement visited.

Tactical Movement [MOVEMENT] [POSITION]

Cost: 4 XP Passive + Active. Move within engagement zone as Move action (instead of full action). Once per scene, disengage from Close as Move action.

Requires: Athletics 2+.

Conditioning [RESISTANCE] [ENDURANCE]

Cost: 4 XP Passive. Body attribute counts as +1 for Fatigue track calculations. +1 die to resist Fatigue overflow effects.

Requires: Body 3+.

Spell Shaping [CONTROL]

Cost: 4 XP Active. When you Weave a spell, modify range, scale, or targeting by one step.

Requires: Spellcraft.

Elemental Focus [ELEMENT]

Cost: 4 XP Passive. Choose one element (Fire, Water, Earth, Air). +1 die when casting spells of that element.

Requires: Spellcraft.

Ritual Mastery [RITUAL]

Cost: 4 XP Passive. The GM banks 1 SB on any ritual backlash.

Requires: Familiar or Patron's Symbol.

Efficient Invocation [RITUAL]

Cost: 4 XP Passive. Reduce ritual casting time by one step (minimum 1 action).

Requires: Patron's Symbol.

Free Caster Talents

Controlled Burn [FIRE] [WILL]

Cost: 4 XP Active, once per scene. When you roll a 1 on a Free Casting roll, you may immediately convert that Story Beat into 1 Boon for yourself (instead of the GM gaining it). The GM does not gain that SB. This does not prevent other 1s on the same roll from generating SB normally.

Requires: Spellcraft.

Weave Resilience [SHIELD] [STAMINA]

Cost: 4 XP Passive. When you suffer Backlash from a Free Casting roll, reduce the severity by one step: Catastrophic → Major, Major → Moderate, Moderate → Minor, Minor → none. This applies to the first Backlash each scene. Subsequent Backlashes in the same scene are not reduced.

Requires: Spellcraft.

Elemental Attunement [ELEMENT] [FOCUS]

Cost: 5 XP Passive. Choose one element (Fire, Water, Earth, Air, Fate, Life, Luck, Death). When you cast a Free spell using that element's tag (e.g., [FIRE]), you may reroll one failed die (not a 1) once per casting. Additionally, you gain +1 die to Arcana rolls when identifying or analyzing that element.

Requires: Spellcraft, Elemental Focus.

Backlash Siphon [VOID] [DEBT]

Cost: 6 XP Reactive, once per scene. When you would suffer a Backlash effect (e.g., Fatigue, Harm, Condition) from a Free Casting roll, you may instead mark 1 Obligation to a Patron of your choice (or gain 1 Corruption if you have no Patron). The Backlash is negated, but the Patron's attention is drawn.

Requires: Spellcraft, Spirit 3+.

Combat**Flurry Strike** [STRIKE] [SPEED]

Cost: 6 XP Active, once per scene. When engaged with multiple opponents, make 2 attacks as one action. Each attack at −1 die.

Requires: Melee 3+, Body 3+.

Duelist's Edge [DOMINANCE] [TECHNIQUE]

Cost: 6 XP Passive + Active. When engaged with a single opponent: +1 die to all melee rolls. Once per scene, ignore first Harm 1 or 2 from that opponent.

Requires: Melee 3+, Wits 3+.

Battlefield Mastery [STRATEGY] [LEADERSHIP]

Cost: 6 XP Active, once per scene. When engaged with 3+ opponents, for the next 3 exchanges: all melee attacks gain +1 Effect, enemies act at −1 die, your Position improves by one step, and you may convert one Harm 1 per exchange to Fatigue.

Requires: Melee 4+, Wits 4+, Command 2+.

Backstab [STEALTH] [STRIKE]

Cost: 6 XP Active, once per scene. When you attack an Unaware or Engaged foe from Stealth, deal +1 Harm and ignore 1 point of their Armor. On a miss, you are Exposed (Desperate Position or mark 1 Harm).

Requires: Stealth 2+, Melee 2+, light weapon.

Elusive Dodge [DEFENSE] [EVADE]

Cost: 6 XP Reactive, once per exchange. When targeted by a physical attack, you may immediately enter a Defend stance as a free reaction. Mark 1 Fatigue after use.

Requires: Stealth 2+, Wits 3+, Tier II.

Berserker Rage [FURY] [POWER]

Cost: 6 XP Active, once per scene. For 3 rounds: +2 dice to melee attacks, ignore first Harm 1 each round, ignore Harm/Fatigue penalties, Position becomes Desperate (re-roll successes). When rage ends, mark Fatigue equal to Spirit. Cannot be ended early.

Requires: Melee 3+, Spirit 3+, Body 3+.

Cavalier [MOBILITY] [MARTIAL]

Cost: 4 XP Passive while mounted. Gain +2 dice to melee attacks when moving Far→Near, or +2 dice to ranged attacks when moving Near→Far.

Requires: War Mount Asset, Melee 2+ or Ranged 2+.

Subtle Casting [HIDDEN] [CONTROL]

Cost: 6 XP Active. Make a Performance + Lore roll to quietly cast a spell, invoke a Rite, or sing a Cantos against DV (Tier). If successful, the casting does not generate Story Beats on the Channel or initial roll. Any SB generated are banked by the GM and applied later. Cannot be used for Great or Extreme Tier effects.

Requires: Lore 3+, Performance 2+ or Runekeeper with Codex.

Effortless Charge [MOVEMENT] [MARTIAL]

Cost: 4 XP Active, once per scene. When you take the **Charge** action (see 2), you may ignore the Fatigue cost. All other costs and restrictions (Desperate defense, open ground requirement) still apply.

Requires: Body 3+, Melee 2+.

Effortless Skirmish [MOVEMENT] [MARTIAL]

Cost: 4 XP Active, once per scene. When you take the **Skirmish** (or **Harring Shot**) action (see 2), you may ignore the Fatigue cost. All other costs and restrictions (Desperate defense, open ground requirement) still apply.

Requires: Wits 3+, Ranged 2+.

Relentless [MOVEMENT] [TERRAIN]

Cost: 6 XP Passive. You may take the **Charge** or **Skirmish** action over **difficult terrain** (rubble, dense forest, shallow water, steep slopes). The Fatigue cost (1) is *not* waived unless you also have the relevant Effortless talent.

Requires: Body 3+, Athletics 2+.

Stubborn Pursuer [MOVEMENT] [REACTION]

Cost: 6 XP Reactive. When an opponent within Close range uses the **Disengage** action (or any movement intended to leave your engagement without provoking an opportunity attack), you may use your reaction to move with them, staying in Close range. This movement does not cost an action and does not provoke opportunity attacks. You move the same number of range bands as they do (e.g., Close → Near, or Near → Far), up to your normal movement limit for the round. You cannot use this talent if you have already taken a Move action or Dash this round. Once per round.

Requires: Body 3+, Athletics 2+.

Defense

Riposte Instinct [COUNTER] [STRIKE]

Cost: 4 XP Reactive, once per scene. When you Defend and score a Success, you may make a free Melee attack against the attacker at Position -1.

Requires: Melee 2+.

Guarded Step [STANCE] [MOVEMENT]

Cost: 4 XP Active. When Defending, you may declare your defense pool after the GM calls Position. Once per scene, you may instead choose the Attribute + Skill pair after the roll.

Requires: Athletics 2+ or Shield Proficiency.

Measured Guard [TACTICS] [FLEXIBILITY]

Cost: 4 XP Active. When Defending, you may declare your defense pool after the GM calls Position. Once per scene, you may instead choose the Attribute + Skill pair after the roll.

Requires: Perception 2+.

Wardbreaker Reflex [WARD] [DEFENSE]

Cost: 4 XP Reactive. When Defending against spells or supernatural effects, you may reroll 1 failed die. If your reroll succeeds, mark +1 Fatigue (arcane recoil).

Requires: Spirit 2+ or any magical Path.

Monk

Iron Fist Way [STRIKE] [BURNING]

Cost: 6 XP Passive. +1 die to unarmed attacks; strikes count as enchanted.

Flowing Spirit Way [WIND] [STRENGTH]

Cost: 6 XP Passive + Active. Convert up to 1 Harm into Fatigue per attack; +1 die against fear or charm.

Perfect Timing Way [FATE] [MOVEMENT]

Cost: 6 XP Active. Twice per scene, improve Position by +1 step; +1 die to reactions.

8.4 Prestige Talents (7–10 XP)

Arcane Dominance [POWER] [OVERRIDE]

Cost: 8 XP Passive. When you contest another magical effect, you automatically overpower weaker effects (Tier II or lower).

Requires: Spirit 4, Arcana 4.

Forbidden Knowledge [SECRETS] [DANGEROUS]

Cost: 8 XP Active, once per session. Access one forbidden summon or dangerous rite without its normal prerequisites. The GM gains 2 SB.

Requires: Tier II.

Crack Specialist [RITUAL] [INSTANT]

Cost: 8 XP Passive. Reduce the Obligation cost of Crack the Seal by 1 (minimum +1).

Requires: 3 Patron Symbols.

Dual Covenant [BOND] [SYNCHRONIZATION]

Cost: 8 XP Passive. You may maintain two active summoned spirits simultaneously.

Requires: Pact-Whisperer, Lesser Pactwright.

Triad Bond [BOND] [SYNCHRONIZATION]

Cost: 10 XP Passive. You may maintain three active summoned spirits simultaneously.

Requires: Dual Covenant, Tier III.

Shrike Parry [COUNTER] [PARRY]

Cost: 8 XP Reactive. When Defending against a melee attack: on Success, negate the hit and make a free attack at equal Position; on Partial, reduce Harm by two levels; on Miss, improve Position one step next turn without Defending again.

Requires: Melee 3+, Athletics 2+, notable duel history.

Mystic Bulwark [PROTECT] [BOND]

Cost: 8 XP Active. When you Defend, you may Shield an adjacent ally (they gain your Position bonus). If you succeed, both avoid the effect. Once per scene, spend 2 Fatigue to extend to all allies in Near.

Requires: Resolve 3+, Spirit 2+, access to Rites or Cantos.

High Stance Duelist [DOMINANCE] [TECHNIQUE]

Cost: 8 XP Passive. While Defending: enemies suffer -1 die to attacks against you; on a Success, your riposte becomes Dominant instead of Controlled.

Requires: Melee 3+, Presence 1+.

Hollow-Touched [RESILIENCE]

Cost: 8 XP Reactive. When you would take Harm, you may mark that amount as Fatigue instead. If you do, either the GM gains 1 SB or you mark 1 Obligation to the Pale Shepherd. Overflow triggers normal Fatigue→Harm conversion plus the chosen cost.

Requires: Aelaerem affinity, Spirit 3+, Stealth 2+.

Stone-Bound Interdictor [RESILIENCE]

Cost: 8 XP Reactive. When you would take Harm, you may mark that amount as Fatigue instead. If you do, either spend 1 Boon immediately or speak a geas (until fulfilled, -1 die on social rolls with fae and stone-kin). Overflow triggers normal conversion plus the cost.

Requires: Aelinnel affinity, Body 3+, Wits 3+.

Large Soul [ADAPTATION]

Cost: 8 XP Passive. You may wear Heavy Armor and wield Heavy Weapons without restriction. You lose your Small Folk racial bonuses (+1 Position Dodging, +1 die Hide/Evasion).

Requires: Aelaerem or Aelinnel affinity, Body 4+, Spirit 3+.

Untouchable Way [EVADE] [STRENGTH]

Cost: 10 XP Passive + Active. +1 die to unarmed attacks; convert 2 Harm into Fatigue; cannot be grappled.

Requires: Iron Fist + Flowing Spirit.

Inevitable Way [FATE] [FORCE]

Cost: 10 XP Passive + Reactive. +2 dice to unarmed attacks; ignore 1 Armor; may counterattack when an enemy misses.

Requires: Iron Fist + Perfect Timing.

Battlefield Terror [FEAR] [DOMINANCE]

Cost: 10 XP Passive + Active. Enemies in Close range act at -1 die due to intimidation. Once per scene, convert an enemy's success to a partial with cost.

Requires: Melee 4+, Body 4+, Harm 2+ experience.

Shadow Dance [EVADE] [STEALTH]

Cost: 10 XP Active. After a successful Backstab, test Stealth vs. DV (Tier). On success, re-enter Stealth and clear 1 Fatigue or improve Position +1. On failure, remain Exposed and mark 1 Fatigue. May only chain once per scene.

Requires: Backstab, Stealth 3+, Mobility 2+.

Embrace the Void [CORRUPTION] [POWER]

Cost: 8 XP Active, once per session. Embrace your Patron's corrupting influence. Mark 2 Obligation and 1 Corruption segment, then gain one for the scene: +1 die and +1 Effect on Patron-domain rolls, immunity to one consequence type, use one Rite without Obligation, or +1 Effect on social manipulations. Permanent mark on sheet; GM gains +1 SB against you when Patron is relevant.

Requires: Any character with 2+ skill levels tied to Patron, at least 1 Obligation segment to that Patron.

New Free Caster Prestige Talents

Spell Echo [ECHO] [FATE]

Cost: 8 XP Reactive, once per session. When you roll a 1 on a Free Casting roll, you may immediately reroll that die. The new result stands, and any 1 on the reroll generates an additional SB as normal. After using this talent, you cannot use it again until you have taken a Short Rest.

Requires: Spellcraft, Controlled Burn, Tier II.

Resonance Anchor [ANCHOR] [STABILITY]

Cost: 9 XP Passive. Your connection to the Weave is more stable. The first time you would generate a Story Beat from a 1 in a scene, you may choose to **bank** that SB for yourself (it does not go to the GM). You may have up to 2 banked SB at a time, and you may spend them as if they were Boons (reroll a die, activate an Asset, improve Position). Unused banked SB are lost at the end of the scene.

Requires: Spellcraft, Weave Resilience, Tier II.

8.5 Epic Talents (11+ XP)

Elemental Mastery [ELEMENT] [HARMONY]

Cost: 18 XP Passive + Active. Reduce Backlash severity by one step when casting with your focus elements. When casting with two focus elements, gain +2 dice and +1 Effect. Once per scene, cast a spell without generating SB on the Weave roll. Allies gain +1 die when you cast an aligned element spell.

Requires: Tier III, Spellcraft, Arcana 5, 2+ Focus Elements.

Crack the Seal Mastery [RITUAL] [PRECISION]

Cost: 18 XP Passive + Active. When Cracking the Seal, choose one: reduce Obligation cost by 1, prevent Symbol from becoming Compromised, or gain +1 Effect. With 4+ Symbols, reduce all ritual casting times by 1 round. Once per scene, Crack the Seal on up to 3 Symbols as one action. Ignore No Symbol penalties.

Requires: Tier III, Invoker's Grimoire, 3+ Patron Symbols.

Blade Dance [STRIKE] [MASTERY]

Cost: 18 XP Active, once per scene. Engage and attack up to 3 targets in one action. Each attack at -1 die, but your Position improves by one step.

Requires: Melee 5+, Duelist's Edge, Flurry Strike.

Miststep Reflex [DEFENSE] [MOVEMENT]

Cost: 12 XP Passive. You are always treated as Defending against physical attacks unless Exposed, Grappled, or Surprised. If you take the Defend action, improve Position by +2 steps instead. Once per scene when you roll 1s while defending, you must mark 2 Fatigue or lose the benefit for the scene.

Requires: Elusive Dodge, Tier III, Stealth 4+, Athletics 3+.

Transcendent Harmony [LIFE] [WIND]

Cost: 18 XP Passive + Active. Convert 2 Harm into Fatigue; once per session become immune to Harm; allies gain +1 defense.

Requires: Flowing Spirit + Perfect Timing, Spirit 4+.

Deathblow [DEATH] [STRIKE]

Cost: 12 XP Active, once per scene. When you strike from Dominant Position or after re-entering Stealth via Shadow Dance, declare a Deathblow. On a hit, deal triple Harm. If the attack incapacitates the target, attempt a free Stealth test to vanish. On a miss, you are Exposed (Desperate Position and mark 1 Harm). May mark 1 Fatigue to attempt a second time.

Requires: Shadow Dance, Stealth 4+, Melee/Ranged 3+.

Weave Harmonist [HARMONY] [FLOW]

Cost: 16 XP Passive + Active. You have learned to ride the Weave's turbulence. Once per session, you may ignore **all** SB generated by a single Free Casting roll (the GM gains none). Additionally, whenever you generate a Story Beat from a 1, you may immediately spend 1 Boon to cancel that SB (the GM does not gain it). You cannot cancel more than 3 SB per scene this way.

Requires: Spellcraft, Resonance Anchor, Tier III.

8.6 Talent Synergies and Building Strategies

Synergy Examples

- **Spellcraft + Elemental Focus + Elemental Mastery:** Reliable freeform casting with reduced backlash and epic control (see 3).
- **Backstab + Shadow Dance + Deathblow:** Stealth assassination chain.
- **Ritual Mastery + Efficient Invocation + Crack Specialist:** Fast, safe, low-cost rituals.
- **Defensive Survival + Elusive Dodge + Miststep Reflex:** High survivability in melee.
- **Iron Fist + Flowing Spirit + Untouchable Way:** Unstoppable monk durability.
- **Iron Fist + Perfect Timing + Inevitable Way:** Monk counterattack master.

- **Effortless Charge + Relentless:** Charge over difficult terrain once per scene without Fatigue cost.
- **Stubborn Pursuer + Tactical Movement:** Stay glued to a disengaging foe while preserving your own movement options.
- **Free Caster Progression:** Controlled Burn → Spell Echo → Resonance Anchor → Weave Harmonist reduces SB generation and turns risk into personal resource.

When to Take Talents (By Tier)

- **Early Game (0–40 XP):** Take 1–2 access talents (Spellcraft, Familiar, Pact-Whisperer) and 2–3 minor talents that support your core concept. For Free Casters, prioritize Controlled Burn and Weave Resilience.
- **Mid Game (41–90 XP):** Add major talents (Codex, Patron's Symbol, Backstab, etc.) and 2–3 synergistic power talents. Free Casters should take Elemental Attunement and Backlash Siphon.
- **Late Game (91+ XP):** Acquire 1–2 prestige or epic talents that define your legacy. Free Casters should aim for Spell Echo, Resonance Anchor, and finally Weave Harmonist.

Example: The Shadow Assassin

A rogue who takes **Backstab** (8.3) at Tier I, **Shadow Dance** (8.4) at Tier II, and **Deathblow** (8.5) at Tier III can execute a devastating assassination chain:

1. Attack from stealth with Backstab (+1 Harm, ignore armor).
2. After a kill, use Shadow Dance to re-enter stealth.
3. Later, strike from Dominant Position with Deathblow (triple Harm).

This combination requires careful positioning and Boon management, but is highly effective.

Example: The Stable Free Caster

A Free Caster who takes **Controlled Burn** (8.3) at Tier I, **Weave Resilience** (8.3) at Tier I–II, **Spell Echo** (8.4) at Tier II, **Resonance Anchor** (8.4) at Tier III, and finally **Weave Harmonist** (8.5) at Tier IV can reduce the swinginess of free casting dramatically. The first 1 of each scene becomes player currency rather than GM fuel; backlash is softened; and once per session, the caster can completely ignore SB from a critical spell. This build remains more dangerous than a Runekeeper but avoids the "wild mage" volatility.

8.7 Custom Talents

Work with your GM to create custom talents:

- Base on story events.
- Use the cost tiers above (2–3 / 4–6 / 7–10 / 11+ XP).
- Define clear prerequisites, activation, and limits.

8.8 Talent Respecification

With GM approval, you may retrain talents during downtime (one downtime period). Provide a narrative justification. Typically limited to once per major story arc.

Talent Selection Quick Reference

Minor (2–3 XP): Small bonuses, once/scene tricks.

Major (4–6 XP): Strong permanent upgrades, core path abilities.

Prestige (7–10 XP): Campaign-shaping, breaks limits.

Epic (11+ XP): Legendary, story-defining power.

Remember: Passive talents stack; active talents require an action or reaction.

Chapter 9

Example Character Concepts

This chapter presents example character concepts to illustrate how the game’s systems can create diverse and interesting heroes. These are **examples only**—not prescriptive templates or exhaustive lists. Use them for inspiration, as pre-generated characters, or as starting points for your own unique creations.

9.1 Important Disclaimer

These examples are provided for illustrative purposes only. They demonstrate how the game’s mechanics can support different character archetypes and play styles. You are encouraged to:

- Modify these concepts to fit your preferences
- Create completely original characters
- Mix and match elements from different examples
- Work with your Game Master to develop unique concepts

The game system is designed to support a wide variety of character types beyond these examples.

9.2 How to Use These Examples

Each concept includes:

- **Concept Overview:** Narrative identity and role
- **Traditional Analogues:** Common RPG classes that share similar themes — *not* mechanical restrictions, just touchstones
- **Mechanical Foundation:** Suggested starting capabilities
- **Play Style:** How the character typically engages with challenges
- **Development Path (by Tier):** What to buy at Tier I, II, and III (see 6.8)
- **Tactical Advice:** Tips for playing the role effectively
- **Story Hooks:** Plot opportunities for the Game Master
- **Legacy Note:** How this character might pass the torch (see ??)
- **Build Blocks:** A 30 XP starting build, plus an optional 34 XP variant using Bonds/Complications (+4 XP) (see 6 for XP rules)

9.3 1. The Guardian (Fighter / Paladin / Knight)

Concept: A protector who stands between danger and those they’ve sworn to defend. *Steel in hand, vow in heart.* Whether a chivalrous knight, a grizzled mercenary, or a holy warrior of the Everflame, the Guardian makes others safe through sacrifice.

Traditional Analogues: Fighter, Paladin, Barbarian (defensive), Knight, Samurai, Legionary

Mechanical Foundation:

- **Primary:** Body (strength, endurance), Spirit (willpower, resolve)
- **Skills:** Melee, Athletics, Command, Endurance
- **Talents:** Defensive Survival, Combat Reflexes, Conditioning (see 8)

Play Style:

- Frontline combat and protection
- Drawing attention away from allies (taunts, positioning)
- Using presence and authority to control situations
- Taking risks to protect others — absorbing Harm meant for teammates

9.3.0.0.1 Development Path (by Tier) :

- **Tier I (0–40 XP):** Raise Body to 3, Melee to 2, take *Defensive Survival* and *Combat Reflexes*. Use a shield.
- **Tier II (41–90 XP):** Raise Body to 4, take *Conditioning* and *Tactical Movement*. Consider a War Mount Asset (8 XP) for mobility.
- **Tier III (91–150 XP):** Take *Battlefield Mastery* or *Mystic Bulwark*. Upgrade armor to Heavy if you have Strength. Start training a successor (Cap 3+ follower).

9.3.0.0.2 Tactical Advice :

- **Use the Defend action** when outnumbered; it improves your Position by one step and can protect allies.
- **Spend Boons on re-rolling failed defense rolls**, not on offense. Your job is to survive.
- **Position matters more than damage.** A Dominant position lets you re-roll failures – use shoves, terrain, and cover to stay in control.
- **When you take Harm, remember it clears Fatigue.** Sometimes a small wound is worth the reset.

Story Hooks:

- Who or what are they protecting? A person, a place, an ideal?
- What oath or duty drives them — sworn, inherited, or self-imposed?
- What happens if they fail in their protection?
- What personal costs do they bear for their role (scars, lost loved ones, broken oaths)?

Legacy Note: A loyal follower (squire, apprentice) can become your successor, inheriting your sworn duty and reputation. See ??.

9.3.0.0.3 Build Blocks. Starting Build (30 XP).

- **Attributes** (Cost = rating $\times$ 3 XP): Body 3 (9), Spirit 2 (6), Wits 1 (3), Presence 1 (3) $\rightarrow$ **21 XP**
- **Skills** (Cost = level $\times$ 2 XP): Melee 2 (4), Athletics 1 (2), Command 1 (2) $\rightarrow$ **8 XP**
- **Total:** 29 XP (bank 1 XP)

With Bonds/Complications (34 XP).

- Add **Talent:** Combat Reflexes (2 XP)
- Add **Talent:** Defensive Survival (3 XP)
- **Total:** 29 + 5 = 34 XP

9.4 2. The Mage (Wizard / Sorcerer / Arcanist)

Concept: A wielder of arcane power who reshapes reality through study, intuition, or pact. *Candlesmoke, marginalia, and dangerous truths.* From the rational Wizard of Thepyrgos to the instinctive Sorcerer of the Bloodlands, magic flows through them — and sometimes through them.

Traditional Analogues: Wizard, Sorcerer, Warlock (pact magic), Arcanist, Runekeeper

Mechanical Foundation:

- **Primary:** Wits (theory, precision), Spirit (willpower, channeling)
- **Skills:** Lore, Arcana, Investigation, (optionally) Sway (for social casting)
- **Talents:** Spellcraft (freeform), Codex (runekeeper), Patron's Symbol (invoker)

Play Style:

- Information gathering and magical analysis
- Solving puzzles and mysteries with arcane insight
- Using magic to gain advantages in combat and social scenes
- Researching new spells and rituals between adventures
- Managing Obligation (for Runekeepers) or Backlash (for free casters)

9.4.0.0.1 Development Path (by Tier) :

- **Tier I:** Take *Spellcraft* (6 XP) or *Codex* + *Thiasos* (6 XP). Raise Wits to 3, Arcana/Lore to 2.
- **Tier II:** Add *Elemental Focus* (4 XP) or *Ritual Mastery* (4 XP). Raise Spirit to 3 for more Obligation capacity.
- **Tier III:** Take *Arcane Dominance* or *Crack Specialist* (if Invoker). Build a library (Standard Asset, 8 XP) to research faster.

9.4.0.0.2 Tactical Advice :

- **Push It** only when necessary – extra Obligation or Fatigue can snowball. Use Boons to improve Position before rolling.
- **Free casters:** Use cantrips (single tag) for safe, repeatable effects. Reserve multi-tag spells for critical moments.
- **Runekeepers:** Your Patron's Gift gives +1 Melee and +1 Thematic. Use it even if you aren't a fighter – the Thematic skill can be Sway, Lore, or Stealth.
- **Invokers:** *Crack the Seal* is for emergencies. Restore your Symbol during downtime before you need it again.

Story Hooks:

- What forbidden knowledge are they seeking?
- How did they acquire their magical talent — bloodline, study, pact, accident?
- What dangerous secrets might they uncover?
- Who opposes their research (rival mages, witch-hunters, the Church)?

Legacy Note: A trusted apprentice (follower) can inherit your Codex or Symbol collection, continuing your magical legacy. See ??.

9.4.0.0.3 Build Blocks. Starting Build (30 XP).

- **Attributes:** Wits 3 (9), Spirit 2 (6), Body 1 (3), Presence 1 (3) → **21 XP**
- **Skills:** Lore 2 (4), Arcana 1 (2) → **6 XP**
- **Total:** 27 XP (bank 3 XP)

With Bonds/Complications (34 XP).

- Add **Talent:** Spellcraft (6 XP) using banked $3 + 4 = 7$ XP; bank 1 XP
- **Total:** $27 + 6 = 33$ XP (bank 1 XP)

9.5 3. The Rogue (Thief / Assassin / Scout)

Concept: A shadow who moves where others cannot, taking what others cannot keep. *Quiet footfalls, hawk eyes, and no loyalties but coin.* From the street-wise cutpurse of Silkstrand to the deadly assassin of Zakov, the Rogue survives by wits, speed, and one hidden knife.

Traditional Analogues: Rogue, Thief, Assassin, Scout, Ranger (stealth focus), Spy

Mechanical Foundation:

- **Primary:** Wits (perception, quick thinking), Body (agility, stealth)
- **Skills:** Stealth, Subterfuge, Investigation (or Streetwise), (optionally) Melee (light weapons)
- **Talents:** Backstab, Elusive Dodge, Shadow Dance (later – see 8)

Play Style:

- Scouting ahead and gathering intelligence
- Infiltrating secured areas and disabling traps
- Ambush and skirmish tactics — striking from stealth
- Finding paths, contacts, and secrets in cities and wilderness

9.5.0.0.1 Development Path (by Tier) :

- **Tier I:** Raise Wits to 3, Stealth/Subterfuge to 2. Take *Backstab* (6 XP) – you can afford it at 34 XP start.
- **Tier II:** Take *Elusive Dodge* (6 XP). Raise Body to 3 for better tracking. Consider a Minor Asset (Hidden Cache, 4 XP).
- **Tier III:** Take *Shadow Dance* (10 XP) and *Deathblow* (12 XP) – the classic assassination chain. Build a spy network (Standard Asset, 8 XP).

9.5.0.0.2 Tactical Advice :

- **Always aim for Dominant Position before attacking from stealth.** Spend a Boon to improve Position if needed.
- **Use the environment.** Ask the GM: "Is there a chandelier? A shadowed alcove? Loose gravel?" Use it to gain advantage.
- **Backstab + Shadow Dance + Deathblow** is lethal, but requires Boons. Engage only when you have 2–3 Boons saved.
- **When outmatched, retreat.** Spend a Boon to make a Controlled withdrawal instead of Desperate.

Story Hooks:

- What crime or secret forced them into the shadows?
- What treasure or truth are they hunting?
- How do they balance loyalty to allies with self-preservation?
- Who wants them dead — and why?

Legacy Note: A young pickpocket or informant (follower) could inherit your network of fences and contacts. See ??.

9.5.0.0.3 Build Blocks. Starting Build (30 XP).

- **Attributes:** Wits 3 (9), Body 2 (6), Presence 1 (3), Spirit 1 (3) → **21 XP**
- **Skills:** Stealth 2 (4), Subterfuge 2 (4) → **8 XP**
- **Total:** 29 XP (bank 1 XP)

With Bonds/Complications (34 XP).

- Add **Talent:** Backstab (6 XP) – needs 6 XP; bank 1 + 4 = 5 XP → not enough. Alternative: Add **Skill:** Perception 1 (2 XP) and **Talent:** Combat Reflexes (2 XP) and bank 2 XP. Or take a Minor Asset: Hidden Cache (4 XP) and bank 2 XP.
- **Suggested:** Hidden Cache + bank 2 XP → total 33 XP.

9.6 4. The Cleric (Priest / Healer / Exorcist)

Concept: A vessel of divine or spiritual power, channeling healing, truth, and judgment. *Sacred flame, holy water, and a prayer on the lips.* From the Lampers of Ecktoria to the fog-named exorcists of the Mistlands, the Cleric binds wounds and banishes darkness.

Traditional Analogues: Cleric, Priest, Paladin (healing focus), Exorcist, Shaman, Healer

Mechanical Foundation:

- **Primary:** Spirit (faith, willpower), Presence (authority, channeling)
- **Skills:** Lore (theology, rites), Medicine, Sway (prayer, exhortation), (optionally) Melee (symbolic weapon)
- **Talents:** Invoker (Patron's Symbol) or Runekeeper (Thiasos + Codex of a divine Patron like Everflame, Oath of Flame & Light, Pale Shepherd – see 3)

Play Style:

- Healing and protecting allies
- Purifying curses, diseases, and undead
- Ley line and ritual magic (wards, consecrations)
- Using authority of faith to command or persuade

9.6.0.0.1 Development Path (by Tier) :

- **Tier I:** Raise Spirit to 3, Lore/Medicine to 2. Take a divine Patron's *Symbol* (4 XP) or *Codex* (4 XP).
- **Tier II:** Take *Symbol Resonance* (4 XP) or *Efficient Invocation* (4 XP). Raise Presence to 3 for better social influence.
- **Tier III:** Take *Crack Specialist* or *Patron's Favor*. Build a hospice or shrine (Standard Asset, 8 XP) to support your community.

9.6.0.0.2 Tactical Advice :

- **Healing is powerful but slow.** In combat, stabilise Harm 2+ allies first; use HEAL (Fatigue recovery) on everyone else.
- **Your Patron's Symbol grants a free +1 to ritual rolls.** Keep it displayed.
- **Consecrate ground before a big fight** – *Rite of Consecrated Ground* can turn the tide against undead or demons.
- **Obligation is story fuel.** When your Patron calls, answer – it will lead to adventure.

Story Hooks:

- What crisis of faith have they survived?
- What heresy or supernatural threat haunts them?
- How do they serve both the living and the dead?
- What price do they pay for divine power?

Legacy Note: An acolyte or lay healer (follower) can take up your Patron's Symbol and continue your mission. See ??.

9.6.0.0.3 Build Blocks. Starting Build (30 XP).

- **Attributes:** Spirit 3 (9), Presence 2 (6), Wits 1 (3), Body 1 (3) → **21 XP**
- **Skills:** Medicine 2 (4), Lore 1 (2), Sway 1 (2) → **8 XP**
- **Total:** 29 XP (bank 1 XP)

With Bonds/Complications (34 XP).

- Add **Talent:** Patron's Symbol (4 XP) for a divine Patron (e.g., Oath of Flame & Light), using banked 1 + 4 = 5 XP; bank 1 XP
- **Total:** 33 XP (bank 1 XP)

9.7 5. The Bard (Diplomat / Skald / Courtier)

Concept: A master of words, music, and social influence who changes minds and opens doors. *A smile for the foyer, steel for the parlor.* From the Skald of Linn to the Courtier of Vhasia, the Bard wields charm, rumor, and reputation as weapons.

Traditional Analogues: Bard, Diplomat, Courtier, Skald, Spy (social), Negotiator

Mechanical Foundation:

- **Primary:** Presence (charm, performance), Wits (reading people, timing)
- **Skills:** Sway, Performance, Insight, (optionally) Lore (customs, history)
- **Talents:** Silver Tongue, Inspire, Network Builder (or Read Emotions)

Play Style:

- Social interaction and negotiation
- Gathering information through rumors and contacts
- Resolving conflicts without violence (or making violence fashionable)
- Building alliances, manipulating factions

9.7.0.0.1 Development Path (by Tier) :

- **Tier I:** Raise Presence to 3, Sway to 2. Take *Silver Tongue* (2 XP) and *Inspire* (3 XP).
- **Tier II:** Take *Command Presence* (4 XP) and *Network Builder* (4 XP). Raise Wits to 3 for social reading.
- **Tier III:** Take *High Stance Duelist* (if you use a blade) or *Battlefield Terror*. Build a spy network (Standard Asset, 8 XP) or a courtly title (Major Asset, 12 XP).

9.7.0.0.2 Tactical Advice :

- **Social scenes are your domain.** Use *Inspire* to give allies +1 die or +1 Boon – it can turn a negotiation.
- **Flashback declarations** (spend 1 Boon) are perfect for bards. "I already bribed the guard last night."
- **Don't neglect combat skills entirely.** A rapier and *High Stance Duelist* can make you a credible threat.
- **Use *Intricate* descriptions** to gain free re-rolls on 1s. Describe your performance, your charming smile, your family crest.

Story Hooks:

- What major conflict are they trying to resolve?
- What secret do they know that could topple a dynasty?
- How do they handle betrayal or failed negotiations?
- What personal relationships affect their diplomacy?

Legacy Note: A protégé or herald (follower) can inherit your reputation and contacts, keeping your network alive. See ??.

9.7.0.0.3 Build Blocks. Starting Build (30 XP).

- **Attributes:** Presence 3 (9), Wits 2 (6), Spirit 1 (3), Body 1 (3) → **21 XP**
- **Skills:** Sway 2 (4), Performance 1 (2), Insight 1 (2) → **8 XP**
- **Total:** 29 XP (bank 1 XP)

With Bonds/Complications (34 XP).

- Add **Talent**: Inspire (3 XP) — once/scene, gain +1 die and potentially +1 Boon for bonded ally, using banked 1 + 4 = 5 XP; bank 2 XP
- **Total**: 32 XP (bank 2 XP)

9.8 6. The Ranger (Hunter / Tracker / Beastmaster)

Concept: A wilderness expert who navigates dangerous territories and hunts down quarry. *Quiet footfalls, hawk eyes, and the long road.* From the Ykrul scout to the Valewood warden, the Ranger lives where roads end.

Traditional Analogues: Ranger, Hunter, Tracker, Beastmaster, Pathfinder, Wilderness Scout

Mechanical Foundation:

- **Primary:** Wits (perception, navigation), Body (agility, endurance)
- **Skills:** Survival, Stealth, Nature (or Animal Handling), Archery or Melee
- **Talents:** Wilderness Lore, Keen Senses, (optionally) Animal Companion

Play Style:

- Scouting ahead and gathering intelligence
- Wilderness survival and navigation
- Tracking creatures or people across terrain
- Ambushing from concealment, using terrain
- (Optional) Bonding with an animal companion

9.8.0.0.1 Development Path (by Tier) :

- **Tier I:** Raise Wits to 3, Survival/Stealth to 2. Take *Wilderness Lore* (2 XP) and *Keen Senses* (2 XP).
- **Tier II:** Take *Trackless Step* (2 XP) and *Elusive Dodge* (6 XP) or a War Hound (Minor Asset, 4 XP). Raise Body to 3.
- **Tier III:** Take *Shadow Dance* (10 XP) (if melee) or *Relentless* (6 XP) for traversal. Upgrade your animal companion to a War Mount (Standard Asset, 8 XP) if allowed.

9.8.0.0.2 Tactical Advice :

- **Use terrain to your advantage.** High ground, cover, and difficult terrain are your best friends. Ask the GM to set Position based on these.
- **Scout ahead** even when not required. Knowledge of what's coming negates ambushes and reduces travel clocks.
- **If you have an animal companion**, use it to harass enemies (Distract & Draw independent action) rather than direct combat.
- **Survival 3+ means you rarely need to roll for basic tasks.** Leverage that for guaranteed successes in wilderness travel.

Story Hooks:

- What uncharted territory are they exploring?
- What secrets have they discovered in the wild?
- How do they balance civilization and wilderness?

- What prey (beast or man) still eludes them?

Legacy Note: Your animal companion or a young tracker (follower) could carry on your legacy. See ??.

9.8.0.0.3 Build Blocks. Starting Build (30 XP).

- **Attributes:** Wits 3 (9), Body 2 (6), Spirit 1 (3), Presence 1 (3) → **21 XP**
- **Skills:** Survival 2 (4), Stealth 2 (4) → **8 XP**
- **Total:** 29 XP (bank 1 XP)

With Bonds/Complications (34 XP).

- Add **Talent:** Keen Senses (2 XP)
- Add **Talent:** Wilderness Lore (2 XP)
- **Total:** 29 + 4 = 33 XP (bank 1 XP)

9.9 7. The Survivor (Veteran / Outcast / Hardened)

Concept: Someone who has endured hardship and developed resilience. *Scars are maps; read them well.* From the war-torn mercenary to the plague survivor, the Survivor won't break — they've already been broken and rebuilt.

Traditional Analogues: Barbarian (resilience focus), Veteran, Ranger (endurance), Drifter, Refugee

Mechanical Foundation:

- **Primary:** Spirit (willpower, resolve), Body (toughness)
- **Skills:** Endurance, Survival, (optionally) Perception (danger sense), Medicine (field)
- **Talents:** Iron Stomach, Conditioning, Second Wind (see 8)

Play Style:

- Enduring difficult conditions (lack of food, exposure, poison)
- Overcoming physical and mental challenges through grit
- Using experience to avoid dangers
- Helping others survive hardships
- Taking hits that would fell others and still standing

9.9.0.0.1 Development Path (by Tier) :

- **Tier I:** Raise Spirit to 3, Endurance/Survival to 2. Take *Iron Stomach* (3 XP) and *Second Wind* (2 XP).
- **Tier II:** Take *Conditioning* (4 XP) – your Body counts as +1 for Fatigue track. Raise Body to 3.
- **Tier III:** Take *Hollow-Touched* (8 XP) or *Stone-Bound Interdictor* (8 XP) to convert Harm to Fatigue. Build a safehouse (Minor Asset, 4 XP) for respite.

9.9.0.0.2 Tactical Advice :

- **Embrace the roller-coaster effect.** Taking Harm clears Fatigue – sometimes a small wound

is a tactical reset.

- **Iron Stomach** makes you immune to mundane poisons and spoiled food. Volunteer to test unknown rations.
- Use *Second Wind* to clear Fatigue before it overflows into Harm.
- **When outmatched, use the environment.** Collapse a wall, start a fire, or trigger a rockfall. Your survival skills tell you how.

Story Hooks:

- What trauma or hardship have they survived?
- How has their past shaped their present?
- What survival skills have saved them repeatedly?
- How do they help others facing similar challenges?

Legacy Note: A fellow survivor (follower) can inherit your network of caches and safehouses. See ??.

9.9.0.0.3 Build Blocks. Starting Build (30 XP).

- **Attributes:** Spirit 3 (9), Body 2 (6), Wits 1 (3), Presence 1 (3) → **21 XP**
- **Skills:** Endurance 2 (4), Survival 2 (4) → **8 XP**
- **Total:** 29 XP (bank 1 XP)

With Bonds/Complications (34 XP).

- Add **Talent:** Iron Stomach (3 XP)
- **Total:** 29 + 3 = 32 XP (bank 2 XP)

9.10 8. The Innovator (Artificer / Engineer / Tinker)

Concept: A creative problem-solver who finds new solutions through craft and invention. *Blueprints on napkins, tomorrow in your pocket.* From the Aeler engineer to the Gnome clockmaker, the Innovator builds what others only dream.

Traditional Analogues: Artificer, Engineer, Tinker, Alchemist, Inventor, Savant

Mechanical Foundation:

- **Primary:** Wits (design, analysis), Body (fine manipulation)
- **Skills:** Craft, Tinker, Mechanics, (optionally) Alchemy, Investigation
- **Talents:** Quick Study, Technical Expert, (optionally) Magical Laboratory asset (see 10)

Play Style:

- Solving problems with unique inventions
- Creating or repairing specialized items
- Providing services others cannot (lockpicking, trap disarm, device creation)
- Using knowledge to gain advantages in planning

9.10.0.0.1 Development Path (by Tier) :

- **Tier I:** Raise Wits to 3, Craft/Tinker to 2. Take *Quick Study* (3 XP) and *Workshop* (Minor

Asset, 4 XP).

- **Tier II:** Take *Efficient Invocation* (if magical) or *Weapon Mastery* (if martial). Raise Body to 3 for fine manipulation.
- **Tier III:** Take *Technical Expert* (custom) or *Crack Specialist* (for magical items). Build a Guild Workshop (Standard Asset, 8 XP) to attract apprentices.

9.10.0.0.2 Tactical Advice :

- **Preparation is your superpower.** Spend downtime building tools, traps, and contingencies. Your GM will reward that.
- Use *Quick Study* to learn enemy weaknesses on the fly. "I notice the golem's joints are unarmoured – aim there."
- **Your workshop asset can jury-rig solutions.** Spend 1 Boon to "have the right tool" for a lock, a trap, or a repair.
- **When combat starts, use gadgets.** Caltrops, smoke bombs, and flash pellets can shift Position without a spell slot.

Story Hooks:

- What makes their specialty unique or valuable?
- How did they acquire their special skills (guild, apprenticeship, self-taught)?
- What problems require their specific expertise?
- Who seeks to control or exploit their abilities?

Legacy Note: An apprentice (follower) can inherit your workshop and blueprints, continuing your inventive tradition. See ??.

9.10.0.0.3 Build Blocks. Starting Build (30 XP).

- **Attributes:** Wits 3 (9), Body 2 (6), Presence 1 (3), Spirit 1 (3) → **21 XP**
- **Skills:** Craft 2 (4), Tinker 2 (4) → **8 XP**
- **Total:** 29 XP (bank 1 XP)

With Bonds/Complications (34 XP).

- Add **Talent:** Quick Study (3 XP) — +1 die to learn or adapt from observation, using banked 1 + 4 = 5 XP; bank 2 XP
- **Total:** 32 XP (bank 2 XP)

9.11 9. The Summoner (Pact-Whisperer / Necromancer / Shaman)

Concept: A binder of spirits, elementals, and otherworldly entities. *Circles of salt, whispered names, and bargains struck in shadows.* From the necromancer of the Mistlands to the shaman of the Steppe, the Summoner commands powers that others fear.

Traditional Analogues: Necromancer, Conjurer, Summoner, Shaman, Spirit Caller, Demonologist

Mechanical Foundation:

- **Primary:** Spirit (willpower, binding), Wits (rituals, names)

- **Skills:** Arcana, Lore (spirits), (optionally) Command, Survival
- **Talents:** Pact-Whisperer (Lesser/Greater), Spirit Link, (optionally) Codex of Names (see 3)

Play Style:

- Summoning creatures to fight, scout, or work
- Binding entities to solve problems (guard, research, transport)
- Negotiating with spirits and outsiders (social challenges)
- Managing Leash clocks and Boon Finesse

9.11.0.0.1 Development Path (by Tier) :

- **Tier I:** Take *Pact-Whisperer* (2 XP) and *Lesser Pactwright* (2 XP). Raise Spirit to 3, Arcana/Lore to 2.
- **Tier II:** Take *Greater Pactwright* (4 XP) to summon Cap 3 spirits. Take *Spirit Synergy* (4 XP) if you want two spirits.
- **Tier III:** Take *Spirit Link* (10 XP) or *True Name Keeper* (15 XP). Build a Spirit Circle (Minor Asset, 4 XP) to reduce Leash ticks.

9.11.0.0.2 Tactical Advice :

- **Boon Finesse** is your most important tool. Spend 1 Boon to clear 1 Leash tick – keep a reserve of 2–3 Boons for emergencies.
- **Spirits are disposable but not free.** Use them for dangerous tasks (scouting a trapped room, triggering a trap) before risking your own skin.
- **When the Leash fills, the spirit acts once to its nature.** Plan for it – position it near enemies before it breaks free.
- **Negotiate with spirits.** They have desires – a promise of freedom, a drop of blood, a secret. A willing spirit ticks Leash slower.

Story Hooks:

- What entity are they bound to or seeking?
- What price did they pay for their first summoning?
- How do others react to their "dark" magic?
- Who hunts them for their forbidden practices?

Legacy Note: A bonded spirit or an apprentice medium (follower) could inherit your spirit contracts, continuing your work. See ??.

9.11.0.0.3 Build Blocks. Starting Build (30 XP).

- **Attributes:** Spirit 3 (9), Wits 2 (6), Body 1 (3), Presence 1 (3) → **21 XP**
- **Skills:** Arcana 2 (4), Lore 1 (2) → **6 XP**
- **Total:** 27 XP (bank 3 XP)

With Bonds/Complications (34 XP).

- Add **Talent:** Pact-Whisperer (2 XP)
- Add **Talent:** Lesser Pactwright (2 XP)

- **Total:** $27 + 4 = 31$ XP (bank 3 XP; can add Familiar (2 XP) later or upgrade to Greater Pactwright)

9.12 10. The Commander (Warlord / Tactician / Leader)

Concept: A leader who directs allies, controls battlefields, and shapes conflicts through strategy. *Orders in a whisper, victory in formation.* From the Condotta captain to the Ekstorian legate, the Commander wins before blades are drawn.

Traditional Analogues: Warlord, Marshal, Tactician, Commander, Strategist, Banneret

Mechanical Foundation:

- **Primary:** Presence (authority, command), Wits (tactics, observation)
- **Skills:** Command, Tactics, (optionally) Sway (morale), Investigation (battlefield analysis)
- **Talents:** Inspire, Command Presence, Tactical Movement (for allies – see 8)

Play Style:

- Directing allies in combat (bonus dice, improved Position)
- Planning and executing tactical maneuvers
- Leading followers and assets in mass action (see 10)
- Using authority to intimidate or persuade

9.12.0.0.1 Development Path (by Tier) :

- **Tier I:** Raise Presence to 3, Command/Tactics to 2. Take *Command Presence* (4 XP) and *Inspire* (3 XP).
- **Tier II:** Take *Tactical Movement* (4 XP) and *Network Builder* (4 XP). Acquire a Cap 2–3 follower (soldier, herald).
- **Tier III:** Take *Battlefield Mastery* (6 XP) or *Mystic Bulwark* (8 XP). Build a War Chest (Standard Asset, 8 XP) to fund operations.

9.12.0.0.2 Tactical Advice :

- Use *Inspire* to give allies +1 die and +1 Boon. A well-timed inspiration can turn a miss into a success.
- **Your followers are your strength.** Keep them alive – spend Boons to protect them. A Cap 3 scout is worth more than a single attack.
- Use *Tactical Movement* to reposition without disengaging. Order allies to flank while you hold the line.
- **In mass combat, treat your unit as a high-Cap follower.** Your Command roll can advance the War Clock faster than any sword.

Story Hooks:

- What army or company did they lead before?
- What strategic defeat haunts them?
- Who are their rivals in the art of war?
- What cause do they fight for — coin, country, or creed?

Legacy Note: A loyal lieutenant or sergeant (follower) can inherit your command, leading the company after you. See ??.

9.12.0.0.3 Build Blocks. Starting Build (30 XP).

- **Attributes:** Presence 3 (9), Wits 2 (6), Body 1 (3), Spirit 1 (3) → **21 XP**
- **Skills:** Command 2 (4), Tactics 2 (4) → **8 XP**
- **Total:** 29 XP (bank 1 XP)

With Bonds/Complications (34 XP).

- Add **Talent:** Command Presence (4 XP) — +1 die on leadership/intimidation rolls, using banked 1 + 4 = 5 XP; bank 1 XP
- **Total:** 33 XP (bank 1 XP)

Reskinning the Paths: Runekeeper and Invoker as Familiar Concepts

The magic systems in *Fate's Edge* are designed to be reimaged. Neither **Runekeeper** (Thiasos + Codex) nor **Invoker** (Patron's Symbol) is locked into a single narrative identity. Below are common reskins — use the same mechanics, change the fiction.

Runekeeper — The Devoted Agent

A Runekeeper has sworn themselves to a single Patron, learning its Rites and bearing its Obligation. This framework can represent:

- **Paladin / Crusader:** Sworn to the *Oath of Flame & Light* or the *Inquisitor Prime*. Rites become prayers, smites, and consecrations. The Codex is a prayer book or a vow-etched gauntlet.
- **Warlock / Pact-Bearer:** Bound to a distant, alien, or dangerous Patron (e.g., Khemesh, Malachai, the Ninth). Rites are granted, not learned. Obligation is the steady pull of a bargain.
- **Cleric / Priest:** Devoted to the Everflame, the Pale Shepherd, or other divine powers. Rites are liturgies. The Patron's Gift is a blessing or a relic.
- **Dark Knight / Death Knight:** A fallen or morally ambiguous warrior who draws power from a grim Patron (Carrion-King, Mor"iraath). Melee and Rites mix; Obligation is a slow doom.

Mechanical core unchanged: 1 action Rites, Obligation track, Patron's Gift imbuelement, Push It option.

Invoker — The Professional Occultist

An Invoker does not fully commit to a single Patron. Instead, they carry **Symbols** (often tools, badges, or relics) of several Powers and perform rituals to invoke their Rites. This framework can represent:

- **Exorcist / Witch Hunter:** Carries symbols of several protective Patrons (The Sealed Gate, Oath of Flame, Gallow's Bell). Rites are wards, banishments, and purification rituals. *Crack the Seal* is an emergency exorcism.
- **Alienist / Scholar of the Unseen:** Studies forbidden Patrons (The Ninth, Khemesh, Mor"iraath) from a safe distance — "safe" being relative. Uses Symbol libraries to invoke

their power without full devotion. Rituals are experimental and dangerous.

- **Consulting Occultist / Paranormal Investigator:** Carries a briefcase or satchel of Symbols — a bell from the Mistlands, a sun-seal from Ecktoria, a hag's stone from Aelinnel. Hired to solve magical problems. Rituals are filed like work orders; *Crack the Seal* is "burning a favor."
- **Ritualist / Ceremonial Mage:** Believes that power lies in procedure, not faith. Each Symbol is a "key" — a geometric diagram, a calendar, a consecrated blade. Rites are slow, deliberate, and precise. The Invoker is a technician, not a worshipper.

Mechanical core unchanged: Ritual time, Obligation per invocation, Symbol display reduces cost, *Crack the Seal* for instant effect.

Mixing and Blurring Lines

Characters may also blend these frameworks — a Runekeeper who occasionally carries a second Symbol for emergency rites, or an Invoker who one day pledges fully to a Patron and becomes a Runekeeper. The system does not penalize narrative growth; simply retrain Talents during downtime (§8) when the fiction justifies it.

Remember: The fiction leads. If you want to play a Paladin, describe your Runekeeper's Rites as prayers. If you want a Vodouisant or Hoodoo practitioner, re flavor Patron's Symbols as sacred bundles, veves, or spirit vessels. If you want a monster hunter, carry a satchel of monster-specific Symbols (silver stake, iron bell, cold iron nail). The mechanics stay the same; the story breathes.

9.13 Creating Your Own Concept

Start with Narrative

- What is your character's background and motivation?
- What role do they play in their community or society?
- What relationships are important to them?
- What goals are they pursuing?

Add Mechanical Support

- Choose attributes that support your concept (see 6.1)
- Select skills that reflect their training and experience (see 6.2)
- Consider talents that provide unique capabilities (see 8)
- Think about assets that represent their resources (see 10)

Consider Group Role

- How does your concept complement other party members?
- What gaps in group capability can you fill?
- What unique contributions can you make?
- How will you work with other characters?

Plan for Growth

- What short-term improvements make sense?
- What long-term development aligns with your concept?

- How might your character change over time?
- What legacy do you want to build? (See ??)

Character Concept Worksheet

Narrative Elements:

- Concept: _____
- Traditional Analogues: _____
- Motivation: _____
- Background: _____
- Relationships: _____

Mechanical Foundation:

- Primary Attributes: _____
- Key Skills: _____
- Starting Talents: _____
- Initial Assets: _____

Development Plan:

- Short-term goals: _____
- Long-term vision: _____

9.14 Final Notes

Remember that these examples are starting points, not limitations. The most interesting characters often combine elements from multiple concepts or create entirely new approaches. Work with your Game Master to ensure your character concept fits the campaign and provides engaging story opportunities.

The best characters are those that you find interesting to play and that contribute to an enjoyable experience for everyone at the table.

Chapter 10

Assets and Followers

Power in Fate's Edge is not measured only by what your character can do with their own hands. As characters grow, their influence extends outward—into places, people, and institutions that act in their name.

Assets and **Followers** represent this outward reach. They are how a character's past choices continue to matter when the dice stop rolling.

Assets reshape the world around you. Followers stand beside you when the world pushes back.

A Word from the Raven Road

"A safehouse is not a home; it is a promise you may not keep. A follower is not a servant; they are a weight you choose to carry. Invest wisely, or the road will collect." — Dusana of the Raven Road, The Hearth Ledger

10.1 Understanding Assets and Followers

Assets and Followers serve different roles in play, but both are expressions of legacy, leverage, and risk.

Key Differences

- **Assets** are off-screen resources: places, networks, titles, or enterprises.
- **Followers** are on-screen allies who act during scenes.
- **Assets** change the situation *before or around* a scene.
- **Followers** participate *directly* in the moment.

Both are powerful—but neither is free.

Management and Risk

Assets and Followers require care and invite consequences:

- They demand upkeep through XP, downtime, or narrative obligation.
- They can be targeted, compromised, or destroyed.
- Overuse draws attention from enemies, factions, and rivals.

Power creates gravity. What you rely on can be taken from you.

10.2 Assets System

Assets are persistent resources under your control: holdings, institutions, reputations, or infrastructures.

Assets do not replace rolls. They change what rolls are possible.

Assets allow characters to:

- Arrive prepared instead of improvising.
- Reframe danger into opportunity.
- Shift Position without negating risk.

Asset Types and Costs

Type	XP Cost	Establishment Time
Minor	4 XP	1 day
Standard	8 XP	1 week
Major	12 XP	1 month

Asset Examples

Minor Assets Safehouse, small shop, minor title, basic workshop.

Standard Assets Guild membership, noble office, trading post, spy network.

Major Assets Fortress, chartered city license, major enterprise, regional authority.

Using Assets

Assets provide leverage in two primary ways: quiet preparation and dramatic activation.

10.2.0.0.1 Free Off-Screen Use Each Asset has a defined off-screen effect usable **once per session**, typically during downtime or scene framing:

- **Safehouse:** Secure lodging or concealment.
- **Spy Network:** Baseline intelligence about a person or place.
- **Workshop:** Repair gear or prepare simple solutions.
- **Trading Post:** Acquire common goods or establish contacts.

These uses prepare the ground—they do not resolve active conflict.

10.2.0.0.2 Boon Activation Spend 1 **Boon** (see 2) to activate an Asset dramatically during a scene.

This does not guarantee success. Instead, the Asset **reshapes the fiction** so a different outcome becomes possible.

An activated Asset may:

- Improve **Position** by one step.
- Reduce the effective **DV** of a follow-up action.

- Advance, suppress, or redirect a relevant Clock.
- Grant temporary access, protection, or narrative permission.

Examples:

- **Safehouse:** Reveal a concealed exit, allowing escape at *Controlled* Position.
- **Spy Network:** Surface critical intelligence, advancing an investigation Clock.
- **Workshop:** Jury-rig a solution that enables an otherwise impossible attempt.
- **Trading Post:** Call in a favor to gain leverage or access in a negotiation.

The GM determines the precise effect based on the Asset's scale, condition, and the current stakes.

10.2.0.0.3 High-Tier Use At higher tiers (see 6.8), Assets carry greater narrative weight—and greater risk.

Repeated or aggressive use may:

- Create new complications.
- Advance hostile faction Clocks.
- Place the Asset itself in danger.

Assets are leverage, not immunity.

10.2.0.0.4 XP Activation Spend **2 XP** (see 6) to use an Asset's off-screen effect beyond its normal limit:

- Emergency use after the free activation is spent.
- Additional downtime applications.
- Exceptional circumstances requiring extended support.

XP use represents strain, overreach, or long-term cost.

10.3 Asset Conditions

Assets have condition states affecting their usefulness.

Condition Levels

Maintained Fully functional, no penalties.

Neglected –1 die when used; requires attention.

Compromised Unavailable until repaired or recovered.

Maintenance Requirements

- **Regular Upkeep:** Two options (see 10.8).
- **Neglect:** Assets deteriorate if not maintained.
- **Recovery:** Compromised assets require significant effort to restore.

10.4 Followers System

Followers are characters who assist you directly.

Follower Capability Ratings

Followers are rated by Capability (**Cap**) from 1 to 5:

Cap	Description
1	Novice helper, basic assistance
2	Competent assistant, reliable support
3	Skilled specialist, valuable aid
4	Expert ally, significant capability
5	Master companion, exceptional ability

Follower Costs

- **XP Cost:** Capability squared (Cap^2).
- **Example:** Cap 3 follower costs $3^2 = 9$ XP.
- **Recruitment:** 1–3 days downtime to find and brief.
- **Limits:** The GM may set maximum followers based on story.

Follower Types

Combat Allies Warriors, guards, mercenaries.

Technical Experts Craftspeople, engineers, specialists.

Social Contacts Informants, diplomats, agents.

Specialists Unique capabilities like magic or stealth.

10.5 Using Followers

Assistance in Scenes

Followers can help with your actions:

- **Assist Dice:** Add dice equal to $\min(Cap, relevantskill)$.
- **Maximum Bonus:** +3 dice total from all sources (see 2).
- **Cost:** Spend 1 Boon or 1 Fatigue to add +1 die (max +3 from assists).
- **One Helper:** Only one follower can assist per action.

Independent Actions

Once per scene (party-wide), a follower can take a small action:

Scout & Signal Change an ally's next action to **Dominant** position.

Distract & Draw Reduce a threat clock by 1 segment.

Fetch & Carry Move an object through danger safely.

Cost of Independent Actions

- Mark +1 **Exposure** (attention or stress), *or*
- Take **Harm 1** (injury or trauma).
- Cannot be used if the follower is already **Compromised**.

10.6 Follower Conditions

Followers track two condition types.

Exposure

Represents attention, stress, or narrative pressure:

- **Gains:** From independent actions, dangerous situations, complications.
- **Effects:** Increased risk, reduced effectiveness, attention from enemies.
- **Recovery:** Downtime activities, careful management.

Harm

Represents injury, trauma, or damage:

- **Gains:** From combat, accidents, enemy attacks.
- **Effects:** Penalties to assistance, possible incapacity.
- **Recovery:** Medical care, rest, magical healing.

Condition States

Maintained Ready and reliable, full capability.

Neglected Needs attention, -1 die to assistance.

Compromised Unavailable: captured, defected, lost, or incapacitated.

10.7 Follower Risks

Using followers carries significant risks.

Complication Targeting

When the GM spends **2+ Story Beats** (see 2) on an action where you have assistance:

- The follower may face consequences instead of you.
- Consequences could be injury, capture, betrayal, or other complications.
- The outcome must be fictionally appropriate.

Off-Screen Capability

Once per downtime, a **Cap 5** follower can solve a significant problem:

- But generates **1 Story Beat** for the party.
- The GM describes how this creates story consequences.
- Useful for emergencies, but costly.

10.8 Upkeep and Maintenance

Both assets and followers require regular maintenance. Each downtime period, choose one of the two options.

Asset Upkeep

Two options:

- **Efficient (Higher XP, Less Time):** Pay Upkeep XP = $\max(1, \lceil \text{AcquisitionXP}/3 \rceil)$, minimal effort.
- **Intensive (Lower XP, More Time):** Pay 1 XP, use a dedicated downtime action with significant personal involvement.
- **Failure to Pay:** Asset becomes *Neglected* (or *Compromised* if already *Neglected*).

Follower Upkeep

Two options:

- **Efficient:** Pay Upkeep XP = $\max(1, \lceil \text{Cap}^2/3 \rceil)$, minimal effort.
- **Intensive:** Pay 1 XP, use a dedicated downtime action with significant personal involvement.
- **Failure to Pay:** Follower becomes *Wary* (or *Seized* if already *Wary*).

Upkeep Examples

- **Minor Asset (4 XP):** Efficient = 2 XP (4/3 rounded up); Intensive = 1 XP + action.
- **Standard Asset (8 XP):** Efficient = 3 XP (8/3 = 2.66 → 3); Intensive = 1 XP + action.
- **Cap 3 Follower (9 XP):** Efficient = 3 XP (9/3); Intensive = 1 XP + action.
- **Cap 2 Follower (4 XP):** Efficient = 2 XP (4/3 rounded up); Intensive = 1 XP + action.

10.9 Strategic Considerations

When to Invest in Assets

- You need reliable off-screen capabilities.
- Your character concept involves wealth or influence.
- The party lacks certain logistical support.
- You want to build long-term influence.

When to Invest in Followers

- You need on-screen assistance.
- Your character works better with support.
- The party needs specific capabilities you lack.
- You want character-driven story opportunities.

Investment by Player Archetype

Archetype	Typical XP Investment	Best For
Solo	0–10%	Reliable personal power, minimal upkeep.
Mixed (Balanced)	15–25%	One solid Follower or Asset (scout, safehouse).
Mastermind	35–55%	Networks, informants, multiple Assets; build a faction.

Balance Recommendations

- **Personal Path** (see 7.5): 0–10% of XP in assets/followers.
- **Balanced Path** (see 7.6): 15–25%.
- **Influencer Path** (see 7.7): 35–55%.

Planning for Succession (The Legacy Engine)

A loyal Follower (Cap 3+) can become your **successor** when your character retires or falls – inheriting your faction standing, one unresolved burden, and a Legacy Bond. See **Chapter 13: The Legacy Engine (??)** for full rules. If you plan for your character's story to continue beyond them, invest in a follower you would trust to carry your banner.

10.10 Loyalty and Relationships

Loyalty Levels (Optional)

Wary Cautious, may leave if pressured; +1 XP upkeep cost.

Steady Reliable, standard performance; normal upkeep.

Devoted Loyal, may sacrifice; can convert one major complication to a minor setback per arc.

Building Loyalty

- Fair treatment and respect.
- Sharing rewards and successes.
- Protecting followers from harm.
- Honoring agreements and promises.

Losing Loyalty

- Mistreatment or disrespect.
- Unreasonable demands or risks.
- Broken promises or betrayal.
- Consistent neglect.

10.11 Advanced Follower Management

Follower Groups

For multiple similar followers, you can manage them as a group:

- **Single Rating:** Treat as one entity with combined capability.
- **Condition Tracking:** Group shares exposure and harm.
- **Maintenance:** Single upkeep cost for the group.
- **Risks:** Problems affect the entire group.

Follower Advancement

Followers can improve over time:

- **Experience:** Gain capability through successful assistance.
- **Training:** Spend XP to improve follower capabilities.
- **Equipment:** Better gear can enhance effectiveness.
- **Limits:** Followers typically cap at lower levels than PCs.

10.12 Risk Management

Asset Risks

- **Financial:** Assets can be costly to maintain.
- **Security:** Assets can be attacked or stolen.
- **Attention:** Valuable assets draw unwanted notice.
- **Dependency:** Over-reliance can be problematic.

Follower Risks

- **Safety:** Followers can be harmed or captured.
- **Loyalty:** Followers may betray or leave.
- **Attention:** Followers can draw enemy interest.
- **Morale:** Followers have needs and limits.

Mitigation Strategies

- **Diversification:** Don't put all resources in one place.
- **Security:** Protect valuable assets and followers.
- **Relationships:** Maintain good terms with your people.
- **Contingencies:** Have backup plans for losses.

Assets and Followers Quick Reference

Assets:

- Minor: 4 XP | Standard: 8 XP | Major: 12 XP
- Free off-screen use: once per session
- Boon activation: spend 1 Boon for scene impact
- Conditions: *Maintained* → *Neglected* → *Compromised*

Followers:

- Cost: Cap^2 XP
- Assistance: $+\min(Cap, skill)$ dice (max +3 from all sources)
- Independent action: once per scene (party-wide)
- Conditions: *Exposure* and *Harm* tracks

Upkeep Options:

- Efficient: $\max(1, \lceil Cost/3 \rceil)$ XP, minimal time
- Intensive: 1 XP, dedicated downtime action

10.13 Practical Examples

Asset Example: The Safehouse

- **Type:** Minor Asset (4 XP)
- **Free Use:** Secure lodging, basic supplies between adventures.
- **Boon Activation:** Reveal a hidden escape route during pursuit.
- **Upkeep:** Efficient: 2 XP (4/3 rounded up); Intensive: 1 XP + downtime action.
- **Risks:** Discovery by enemies, maintenance costs.

Follower Example: The Scout

- **Capability:** 3 (9 XP cost)
- **Assistance:** +3 dice on tracking and survival rolls.
- **Independent Action:** Scout ahead to improve party position.
- **Upkeep:** Efficient: 3 XP (9/3); Intensive: 1 XP + downtime action.
- **Risks:** Injury in dangerous scouting; disloyalty if mistreated.

Combination Example: The Merchant

- **Assets:** Trading post (8 XP), caravan (4 XP) — *12 XP total*
- **Followers:** Cap 2 guards (4 XP each = 8 XP), Cap 3 factor (9 XP) — *17 XP total*
- **Total Investment:** **29 XP** in assets and followers
- **Upkeep (Efficient):** Assets 4 XP + Followers 6 XP = **10 XP** per downtime
- **Benefits:** Trade income, transport, protection, business contacts
- **Risks:** Competition, bandit attacks, employee issues, regulatory attention

Remember: Assets and followers can greatly expand your capabilities, but they require careful management and carry significant risks. Invest wisely based on your character concept and the needs of your group.

10.14 Narrative-Heavy Asset and Follower Options

For groups that prefer strong narrative focus, consider these optional approaches.

10.14.0.0.1 Story-Driven Upkeep Instead of tracking XP costs for upkeep, the GM can introduce narrative complications that require attention. A neglected asset might attract unwanted attention, while a neglected follower might request a favor or special treatment.

10.14.0.0.2 Collaborative Management Players can describe how they maintain their assets and followers through roleplay rather than mechanical upkeep costs. A well-described scene of tending a workshop or bonding with followers can fulfill maintenance requirements.

10.14.0.0.3 Asset and Follower as Character Development Use asset and follower management as opportunities for character growth and backstory development, allowing players to narrate how their relationships and holdings evolve through significant story moments.

10.14.0.0.4 Flexible Condition Tracking Focus on the narrative implications of asset and follower conditions rather than strict mechanical penalties. A “Neglected” asset might still function but with interesting complications, while a “Compromised” asset might require creative solutions rather than just XP investment.

10.15 Terrestrial Patrons

Not all power comes from cosmic entities or divine forces. Sometimes your greatest allies—and most demanding creditors—are mortal factions who can offer protection, resources, and influence in the world of men.

10.15.1 What Are Terrestrial Patrons?

Terrestrial Patrons represent your ongoing relationships with powerful mortal organizations:

- Noble houses and courtly factions.
- Merchant guilds and trading consortiums.
- Military units and mercenary companies.
- Criminal organizations and smuggling rings.
- Religious orders and temple hierarchies.
- Scholarly colleges and arcane societies.

Unlike supernatural Patrons (see 3), Terrestrial Patrons do not grant magic, but they offer **leverage**: protection, resources, sanctuary, information, and political influence.

10.15.2 Gaining a Terrestrial Patron

To gain a Terrestrial Patron, complete one of these significant actions:

- Complete a major job or service for them.
- Swear a formal Oath of service.
- Enter into legal or financial binding.
- Share criminal secrets or be compromised by them.
- Perform a notable service that earns their favor.

Mark the Patron on your character sheet and write one sentence: “*They want me because _____*”.

10.15.3 Obligation System

Terrestrial Patrons use the same Obligation track as supernatural Patrons (see 3.3.1), but consequences are social, legal, or economic rather than mystical.

- **Calling in Favors:** When you request Patron influence, add +1 Obligation.
- **Capacity:** Spirit + Presence (same as supernatural Patrons).
- **Overflow:** Each segment above capacity inflicts 1 Fatigue.
- **Resolution:** Reduce through service, downtime actions, or fulfilling demands.

10.15.4 Patron Perks

Each Terrestrial Patron offers 2–3 repeatable benefits that require no rolls to access.

Common Perks Include:

- Sanctuary in their territory or establishments.
- Legal relief or protection from certain authorities.
- Access to black market goods or specialized services.
- Elite followers or hirelings at reduced cost.
- Forged documents or identity protection.
- Military backing or private security.
- Information networks and rumor access.
- Trade advantages or exclusive contracts.

Using a perk never requires a roll—Fate has already been paid. Each use comes with the ongoing cost of Obligation.

10.15.5 Patron Demands

Terrestrial Patrons always want something in return:

- Silence about sensitive information.
- Loyalty over other conflicting interests.
- Completion of specific jobs or tasks.
- Delivery of valuable names or secrets.
- Political or social support for their causes.
- Elimination of rivals or threats to their interests.

Refusing a Demand raises Obligation by 1 segment and may trigger immediate complications.

10.15.6 When Obligation Fills

At **6 Obligation segments**, the Patron acts—this is not optional. Choose one:

1. **Unavoidable Job:** You must complete a task you cannot refuse.
2. **Severe Price:** Pay significant cost (legal, social, or material).
3. **First Strike:** They act against you—reputation damage, warrants, bounty, blackmail.

After the consequence lands, reduce Obligation to 3 segments.

10.15.7 Cutting Ties

You may sever a Terrestrial Patron relationship, but doing so has serious fallout:

- Lose all current perks immediately.
- Gain a new **Rival** faction that opposes your interests.
- Take a lasting **Complication** (Curse, Bounty, or Scandal) that follows you.
- May trigger immediate retaliation depending on the Patron's nature.

Some Patrons never forgive betrayal; others can be bought off with significant compensation.

10.15.8 Redemption and Favor

If you perform a monumental service for a Patron—something beyond what was asked—reduce Obligation by 2 and gain a permanent **Favor**.

Favor Benefits:

- Noble title or official position.
- Land grant or property rights.
- Permanent access to exclusive resources.
- Unique asset or specialized equipment.
- Political influence or legal immunity.
- Protection from their rivals or enemies.

10.15.9 Example: The Black Ledger

The Black Ledger is a smuggling syndicate operating in the coastal city of Kahfagia.

Gaining Their Favor: Successfully complete three smuggling runs without detection.

Perks:

- Sanctuary in hidden safehouses throughout the city.
- Access to rare imported goods and contraband.
- Information about port authorities and customs schedules.

Demands:

- Maintain silence about syndicate operations.
- Transport occasional “special packages” (may be illegal).
- Eliminate rival smugglers who threaten their routes.

Sample Scenario: Rellan calls on the Ledger for a smuggled border crossing. The GM rules it succeeds automatically, but adds +1 Obligation. Later, the Ledger demands he silence a witness who saw too much. If he refuses, Obligation rises again. If Obligation ever reaches 6, the Ledger collects: accounts frozen, bounty posted, or a rival informant sent after him.

10.15.10 Creating Your Own Terrestrial Patrons

When designing a Terrestrial Patron, consider:

1. **Nature:** What type of organization are they?
2. **Motivation:** What drives their goals and actions?
3. **Resources:** What can they realistically offer?
4. **Methods:** How do they typically operate?
5. **Enemies:** Who opposes their interests?
6. **Perks:** 2–3 concrete benefits they provide.
7. **Demands:** 3–5 typical requests they make.

Remember: Terrestrial Patrons make the mortal world feel alive and reactive. They represent the complex web of loyalty, debt, and influence that shapes everyday life in Fate’s Edge.

10.16 Multi-Character Switching System

This framework allows a player to temporarily move a character offscreen while continuing play with another. The absent character remains active in the fiction and continues shaping the world through **Downtime Logs**, consequences, and story pressure.

10.16.1 Core Principles

- Players **choose** when their character steps offscreen.
- Offscreen characters still **matter** to the narrative.
- Absence creates **opportunity and risk**, not punishment.
- The world reacts to characters **even when unseen**.

10.16.2 Switch Mechanics

10.16.2.1 Declaration

When a player chooses to step out, they declare:

- Which character is going offscreen.
- Where the character is going (fictional location).
- Why they are stepping out (story reason).
- How long they expect to be away (1–3 sessions).

The character becomes an **Echo Character**: present in the world, but offscreen.

10.16.2.2 Controlled Status Types

Echo Characters take one of three statuses:

- **Supporting** (default): Works to assist active PCs.
- **Advancing**: Pursues their own agenda or project.
- **In Peril**: Their absence creates danger or urgency.

The GM and player collaborate to set this status.

10.16.3 Downtime Log

Each offscreen session, the player completes a simple **Downtime Log**:

10.16.3.1 Structure

- **Resource Action**: How they maintain connections or standing.
- **Project Action**: One goal or project advanced.
- **Event Response**: How they react to unseen events or threats.

10.16.3.2 Tier-Based Project Limits

- Tier I–II: 1 Project.
- Tier III–IV: 2 Projects.
- Tier V: 3 Projects.

10.16.3.3 GM Response

The GM records:

- The fictional outcome of each declaration.
- One meaningful **Consequence** (complication, shift, or new opportunity).

10.16.4 Return Mechanics

10.16.4.1 Re-Entry Process

When returning to play:

1. The returning character gains **2 Boons** for narrative re-entry.
2. Roll **Wits + Spirit** (DV 3) to reestablish presence.
3. Address unresolved plot threads created during absence.

10.16.4.2 Re-Entry Consequences

The GM assigns one:

- **Ripple Effect** — your absence reshaped the situation.
- **Opportunity Missed** — a door closed without you.
- **Allies Gained** — your actions forged new connections.
- **Rivals Made** — someone now works against you.
- **Personal Growth** — you return wiser or transformed.
- **Lost Momentum** — your projects slipped.

10.16.5 Advanced Systems

10.16.5.1 Buddy System

If multiple players are absent:

- Nominate a **Buddy** to help track Downtime Logs.
- The Buddy gains **+1 additional Boon** for the support role.

10.16.5.2 Crisis Management

Offscreen characters track a **Crisis Clock [6]**:

- Fills when negative consequences strike.
- At 6: The character faces a major offscreen crisis requiring GM action.
- May be reduced through Downtime Log responses or assistance from active PCs.

10.16.6 GM Guidelines

- Spend 5–7 minutes per absent character completing their Downtime Log.
- Focus on narrative change, not bookkeeping pressure.
- Absence should generate hooks and stakes, not penalties.
- Use Echo Characters to keep the world *alive and reactive*.

10.16.7 Player Guidelines

- Declare offscreen goals with clear fictional intent.
- Treat absence as character growth, not disappearance.
- Collaborate with the GM to weave consequences into play.
- Expect absence to create tension, opportunity, and drama.

Chapter 11

World Interaction

Using This Chapter

This chapter gives you the tools to move through the world, interact with its people, and make your journey meaningful. For detailed descriptions of each region's culture, subgenre, and notable NPCs, see **Chapter 11 (World Regions and Cultures)**. The two chapters work together: this one covers *how* to travel and interact; the next tells you *where* and *with whom*.

In **Fate's Edge**, the world is not a backdrop—it's a partner in the conversation. Dikes groan under black rain in Viterra, clan horns answer across Acasia's ridgelines, Ecktoria's marble halls echo with careful words, and Kahfagia's pilots read storms by taste. Wherever you go, place, culture, and pressure push back.

11.1 The Known World: A Geographic Overview

The following summary orients the major regions relative to one another. (See [12](#) for cultural details.)

Ecktoria Temperate heartland of the old Utaran Imperium. Borders Acasia to the northeast and Kahfagia to the west. Marble cities, imperial roads, codified law.

Acasia Lowland of rivers and petty kingdoms, northeast of Ecktoria. Broken province of mercenary companies and border lords. Borders Vhasia to the east.

Vhasia Fractured kingdom on a southern peninsula. East of Acasia, west of Viterra. Courtly intrigue, martial tradition, and fractured sun symbolism.

Viterra Shares the same peninsula with Vhasia, lying further east. Its eastern coast borders a dark inland body (the Blackwater). Hedge-law, river tolls, and the Last Kingdom.

Kahfagia West of Ecktoria, facing the open ocean. Maritime empire of storm-flags, deep-sea pilots, and exotic imports.

Thepyrgos Occupies the southern part of the great peninsula opposite Vhasia/Viterra. Eastern coast overlooks the Astroegro Straits. City of a Thousand Stairs, center of learning.

Theona Large island off the eastern coast of Viterra. Three isles, causeways, marsh, and the "No Ninth" taboo.

Mistlands Western shore of the Aberderrian Sea (north of the Amaranthine). Bog, fog, and bell-lines; protectorate of the Aeler. Direwood lies to the west.

Linns Scattered around the Yloka River and the Aberderrian Sea. Longships reach the Blackwater

and raid Theona and Viterra. Fjords, skerries, storm-oaths.

Violet Steppe North of the Amaranthine, west of the Aberderrian Sea. Vast grassland, home of the Ykrul nomads.

Valewood East of the Blackwater. Ancient forest of phasing ruins, star-roads, and fae courts. Former Lethai empire.

Aelinnel (Aevrossa) South of the Valewood. Gnomish homeland of stone, bough, and bright things. Mist paths, bell-mounds, tide-gates.

Aelaerem South of Aevrossa. Halfling downs of gentle valleys and deep barrows. Homeland spoken of only in euphemisms ("The Silent Welcome").

Zakov Island in the Blackwater, near the mouth of the Yloka River. Pirate haven, reef passages, salt and serpent.

11.2 Game Structure and Time

Understanding how time works in Fate's Edge helps you navigate both the mechanical and narrative flow of play.

Basic Units

Scene The basic unit of narrative play, covering a specific situation or conflict (Some Time to Significant Time). Resolves a particular question or challenge.

Player Turn (Beat) An individual player's action within a scene: Declare action → GM sets position → roll → resolve outcome → manage consequences.

Round Simultaneous or near-simultaneous actions within a scene (primarily for combat), representing a few seconds of real time.

Session One complete game session (typically 3–6 hours), containing 2–4 major scenes and resolving significant narrative progress.

Downtime The narrative time between scenes, used for recovery, advancement, and off-screen activities. Measured in days, weeks, or months depending on fiction.

Campaign Entire story arc (6–20+ sessions) with major character development and lasting consequences.

11.3 Movement and Positioning

Space is tracked with **range bands** and **Position** (see 2 for full rules).

Range Bands

Close Touching distance: grapples, knife-work, hand on a relic.

Near Same room/yard/deck; a rush away.

Far Same site but distant; requires route or time to reach.

Absent Off-screen; requires scene change or significant effort to interact.

Movement Actions

- **Move:** Shift one range band as a *beat*.
- **Dash:** Shift two bands as your full action (terrain may require a roll).
- **Melee Flag:** Mark when two parties are in Near range and directly engaged in combat.

Position States

Dominant You have cover, leverage, or ritual footing. Failure still leaves options.

Controlled Standard case: exposed lanes, rivals near, watchful eyes. Failure has teeth, but not ruin.

Desperate Bad ground, bad odds, bad timing. Failure is severe; success may bring extra XP.

11.3.0.0.1 Position Shifting:

- GM can spend **1 SB** to worsen Position by one step.
- Player can spend **1 Boon** to improve Position by one step (once per action).
- Narrative triggers (flanking, reinforcements, etc.) can shift Position without cost.

11.4 Travel Framework

Travel abstracts distance into *legs* with tension and color rather than miles and meal counts. Each leg has a **Travel Clock** and draws on a **regional deck** to seed fiction.

Travel Process

1. **Set the Leg:** Name origin and destination; start a Travel Clock (4-10 segments based on difficulty).
2. **Draw Prompts:** Draw up to one card from each suit to establish terrain, people, pressures, and leverage.
3. **Assign Roles:** Players take on travel roles (see below) to contribute actions.
4. **Play the Leg:** Players take actions to advance the clock or mitigate complications. GM spends SB from rolls showing **1s** to introduce hazards.
5. **Resolve:** When the clock fills, you arrive—changed by the journey.

Travel Roles

Guide Sets course, reads signs. Rolls navigation; on success, tick the Travel Clock +1.

Scout Moves ahead, first contact with hazards or ambushes. On success, the party cannot be surprised on the first encounter of the leg.

Quartermaster Manages supplies and encumbrance. On success, prevents one Supply drop or recovers 1 spent Supply.

Watch Maintains vigilance. On success, the party gains +1 Position on the first defense roll of any ambush.

Each role action requires a roll (Attribute + appropriate skill, DV set by the GM). Failure may tick the Travel Clock backwards or introduce a complication.

Using Assets and Followers During Travel

- **Assets** (see 10): Spend 1 Boon to activate an asset dramatically during travel – reveal a hidden path, call for emergency aid, or secure safe lodging.
- **Followers:** Assign followers to travel roles for bonuses. A Cap 3 Scout follower adds +3 to navigation rolls, for example. They can also take independent actions (scout ahead, secure supplies) at the cost of Exposure or Harm (see 10.5).
- **Off-Screen Solutions:** High-Cap followers (4–5) can solve significant travel problems once per downtime, but generate 1 SB for the party.

Regional Travel Decks

Each major region has a themed prompt list or card table (see full rules in the *GM Guide*). Your GM will use these to generate encounters that match the region's flavour.

Travel Complications

Common complications include:

- **Hazards:** Weather, terrain challenges, wildlife encounters.
- **Social:** Border checks, local politics, cultural misunderstandings.
- **Supplies:** Food shortages, equipment failure, resource management.
- **Pursuit:** Being followed, hunted, or racing against time.

11.5 Narrative Time

Time is measured by *importance* rather than duration.

A Moment A glance, a strike, a whisper over a law-stone.

Some Time A skirmish, a negotiation, a careful climb.

Significant Time Hours of march, rites, audits, stakeouts.

Days Drills, recoveries, research, roadwork.

11.6 Social Interactions

Social scenes use the same engine with **cultural color** (see 2).

Cultural Skill Emphases

Different regions value different approaches. Use the table in **Chapter 11 (World Regions and Cultures)** to see what skills are most effective where. In general:

Viterra Rapport with parishes; Sway for markets; Command under writ.

Acasia Rapport for kin-bridges; Command with banner-rights; Deceive risks honour clocks.

Ecktoria Sway in salons; Deceive at court; Perform in temple fora.

Kahfagia Rapport aboard; Sway at piers; Command on a storming deck.

Social Stakes & Clocks

Your GM may use visible clocks to track social progress:

- **Alliance Clock (Viterra):** Parishes and guilds come to your side.
- **Honor Clock (Acasia):** Feasts, oaths, wyrd—trust builds (or frays).
- **Bureau Clock (Ecktoria):** Stamps, seals, approvals—delay is pressure.
- **Trust Clock (Kahfagia):** Pilots and crews extend favours and routes.

11.7 Supply and Resources

Track scarcity with a **Supply Clock** shared by the party's expedition.

Segments	State & Effects
0 (Full)	Well-provisioned; no penalty.

2 (Low)	Minor frictions; -1 to resource checks.
3 (Dangerous)	Each PC gains <i>Fatigue 1</i> .
4 (Empty)	Severe penalties; desperate measures.

11.8 Engaging the World—Player Actions

- **Scout & Signal:** A follower can make the next travel action *Dominant* (mark Exposure or Harm 1 on them – see 10.5).
- **Local Color:** Briefly state what locals notice about you; GM offers a small fictional edge *or* a tempting clock – choose.
- **Mark the Map:** On arrival, declare one change to the fiction (new ford, patron’s shrine, toll-skip). GM may attach a minor clock as cost.
- **Asset Activation:** Spend 1 Boon to activate an asset dramatically during a scene (see 10).
- **Follower Assistance:** Have a follower assist your actions for bonus dice (max +3 from all sources, see 2).

11.9 Summary

The world has opinions. Movement is clocks and colour, position rises and sinks with weather and words, and every suit you draw speaks in a regional accent. Ask the land for a favor—then pay it back on the road.

11.9.0.0.1 Remember: Every interaction with the world is an opportunity. Use your assets, deploy your followers, and engage with the setting actively. The world responds to your choices, and every journey changes both you and the places you pass through.

Chapter 12

World Regions and Cultures

Using This Compendium

You only need to read the region your character is from or where the campaign starts. The GM will tell you when other regions become relevant.

Each entry includes:

- **Fantasy subgenre** – so you know what kind of stories to expect.
- **Attitude toward magic** – how the locals react to spellcasters.
- **Typical dress / customs** – to help you describe your character.
- **Player hook** – a story seed to tie your character to this place.
- **Key stakeholders** – major NPCs and factions you might encounter.

For GM-only secrets (hidden agendas, faction clocks), see the *GM Guide*.

Quick Reference by Subgenre

Region	Fantasy Subgenre	Magic Attitude
Acasia	Low fantasy / mercenary realism	Folk-wards respected; visible sorcery risky.
Aelaerem	Folk horror / pastoral dark	Hedge-magic common; open magic attracts the Neighbors.
Aeler	Industrial / survival horror	Rituals are craft; magic is guild-regulated.
Aelinnel	Fae / mathematical / courtesy horror	Fae rites only; iron is taboo.
Black Banners	Military / mercenary warfare	Pragmatic; useful magic tolerated.
Ecktoria	Political intrigue / legal drama	Licensed thaumaturges; unlicensed magic is crime.
Linn	Viking / maritime	Weather rites are sacred; false rites are sin.
Mistlands	Folk horror / gothic	Bell-magic and salt – necessary but dangerous.
Silkstrand	Urban / mercantile / noir	Curse-magic feared; trade magic accepted.
Theona	Celtic / folk horror / taboo-driven	Old rites respected; the Ninth taboo governs all.
Thepyrgos	Byzantine / academic	Magic studied; unorthodox styles unfashionable.
Ubral	Highland clan / honour culture	Outsider mages watched; clan shamans respected.
Valewood	Fairy tale / dark forest	Fey magic, imperial echoes – dangerous to meddle.
Vhasia	Courtly romance / fractured kingdom	Church distrusts magic; lords employ mages anyway.
Viterra	Legal drama / frontier justice	Hedge-magic common; registered magic tolerated.
Ykrul	Steppe nomad / saga	Geometry of oaths; shamanism respected.
Zakov	Pirate / noir / crime syndicate	Any magic welcome – if it pays.

12.1 Acasia — "The Broken Province"

Genre: Low fantasy / mercenary realism / border feud.

12.1.0.0.1 Attitude toward magic: Hedge-witches respected; visible sorcery can start a levy. The Curse is blamed on ancient magic.

12.1.0.0.2 Typical dress / customs: Wool and leather, scarves to hide clan markings. Feasts often end in oath-swearing; never sign a contract on a bridge.

12.1.0.0.3 Player hook: *You owe a blood-debt to a free company captain – or you are that captain.*

12.1.0.0.4 Key stakeholders: Margravine of the Broken March, The Lame King, Blackwood Matriarchs, Free Company Captains.

12.2 Aelaerem (Halflings) — "Hearth & Hollow"

Genre: Folk horror / pastoral quiet with dark undercurrents.

12.2.0.0.1 Attitude toward magic: Hearth-magic (red thread, cup-marks) is everyday. Open magic may attract the Neighbors.

12.2.0.0.2 Typical dress / customs: Bright wool, red doors, nine cups never poured. Hospitality is sacred – and a trap.

12.2.0.0.3 Player hook: *The Pale Shepherd came for your grandmother. You still hear her footsteps.*

12.2.0.0.4 Key stakeholders: Apple-Matron, The Pale Shepherd, Mummies" Captain, Lantern-Warden.

12.3 Aeler (Dwarves) — "Crowns & Under-Vaults"

Genre: Industrial / political / survival horror (underground).

12.3.0.0.1 Attitude toward magic: Rituals are a craft, guild-licensed. Unsanctioned magic damages air and stone.

12.3.0.0.2 Typical dress / customs: Heavy aprons, breath-masks, bell-tokens. Count your breaths in eights; never waste water.

12.3.0.0.3 Player hook: *You broke a seal in the deep ways and something followed you up.*

12.3.0.0.4 Key stakeholders: Vault-Queen, High King Beneath the Peaks, True Masons, Edgewalkers.

12.4 Aelinnel (Gnomes) — "Stone, Bough, and Bright Things"

Genre: Fae / mathematical / courtesy horror.

12.4.0.0.1 Attitude toward magic: Fae rites, geasa, and ledger-magic. Iron is taboo; copper is polite.

12.4.0.0.2 Typical dress / customs: Bright coats, copper tools, counting beads. Never trust a single ledger.

12.4.0.0.3 Player hook: *You spoke a word you shouldn't have, and now the Green Gate demands payment.*

12.4.0.0.4 Key stakeholders: Stone Prince of Aelinnel, Lady of Thorns, Green Knight, Oath-Carver.

12.5 Black Banners — "Condotta & Crowns"

Genre: Military / mercenary / low fantasy warfare.

12.5.0.0.1 Attitude toward magic: Battle-magic is useful; unreliable mages don't get paid. Condotta captains hire cantors for morale.

12.5.0.0.2 Typical dress / customs: Tabards over rusted mail, scarves to hide old loyalties. Payday is sacred; betrayal is business.

12.5.0.0.3 Player hook: *Your company was sold out from under you. Now you hunt the broker who took the coin.*

12.5.0.0.4 Key stakeholders: Banner-Captain, The Black Colonel, Clan-Mother (Ykrul), Veteran Sergeant.

12.6 Ecktoria — "Marble & Fire"

Genre: Political intrigue / legal drama / fallen empire.

12.6.0.0.1 Attitude toward magic: Licensed thaumaturges file casting notices. Unlicensed magic is a crime, often punished by the Everflame inquisitors.

12.6.0.0.2 Typical dress / customs: Togas, seal rings, procession masks. Law is a weapon; never refuse a toast in a coin-house.

12.6.0.0.3 Player hook: *You forged a document that could topple a senator – or save a heretic.*

12.6.0.0.4 Key stakeholders: Grand Magistrate, High Priest of the Everflame, Duchess-Regent, Censor's Clerk.

12.7 Linn — "Skerries & Storm-Oaths"

Genre: Viking / maritime / oath-bound raiding.

12.7.0.0.1 Attitude toward magic: Weather magic is sacred; false rites are crimes against the ship. Skalds use songs for law and memory.

12.7.0.0.2 Typical dress / customs: Wool, leather, whale-bone runes. Oaths sworn on the tide cannot be broken without drowning.

12.7.0.0.3 Player hook: *Your father's sword was lost in a raid. The sea-queen says the drowned still carry it.*

12.7.0.0.4 Key stakeholders: Sea-Queen, High Jarl, Volva of the Mist, Skald.

12.8 Mistlands — "Bells, Salt, and Breath"

Genre: Folk horror / gothic / supernatural dread.

12.8.0.0.1 Attitude toward magic: Bell-lines and salt are the only trusted magic. Outsider spellcasters are viewed with suspicion.

12.8.0.0.2 Typical dress / customs: Grey wool, fog-veils, bell-charms. Never breathe deeply after the ninth bell.

12.8.0.0.3 Player hook: *You were born during a bell-line failure. The fog knows your name – it has visited twice.*

12.8.0.0.4 Key stakeholders: Legate of the Mists, Bell-Warden, Salt-Monk, Mist-Seer.

12.9 Silkstrand — "City of Bridges & Dyewater"

Genre: Urban / mercantile / noir.

12.9.0.0.1 Attitude toward magic: Curse-magic feared; trade magic (dye-wards, bridge-blessings) accepted. The Matron employs a weft-reader.

12.9.0.0.2 Typical dress / customs: Dyed silks, debtor's stains, bridge tokens. Every bridge is a ledger; every handshake a contract.

12.9.0.0.3 Player hook: *You're the only one who knows the secret of the red dye. The guild wants the recipe – or your hands.*

12.9.0.0.4 Key stakeholders: The Matron, Guildmistress of Dyers, Bridge Bailiff, Night-Boat Smuggler ("Ravel").

12.10 Theona — "Three Greens, No Ninth"

Genre: Celtic / folk horror / taboo-driven.

12.10.0.0.1 Attitude toward magic: Old rites (well-blessings, bride-peace) are essential. Breaking a taboo invites the Green Host.

12.10.0.0.2 Typical dress / customs: Peat-stained cloaks, hawthorn pins, counting in eights. The ninth cup is never poured.

12.10.0.0.3 Player hook: *You were at a bride-peace feast when the ninth name was spoken. The Green Host rode – but you survived.*

12.10.0.0.4 Key stakeholders: Matron of Wells, Three-Isles King, Lady Beneath, Taboo-Witness.

12.11 Thepyrgos — "City of a Thousand Stairs"

Genre: Byzantine / academic / arcane mystery.

12.11.0.0.1 Attitude toward magic: The Synod licenses magic; unorthodox casting is not illegal – merely unfashionable. Witch-hunters conscript talent.

12.11.0.0.2 Typical dress / customs: Academic robes, bell-badges, stair-passes. Every stair climbed is a word in a conversation.

12.11.0.0.3 Player hook: *You tested as "gifted" on the candle-smoke test. The university wants you; the Chain-Lanterns want you in chains.*

12.11.0.0.4 Key stakeholders: The Archon, Lighthouse-Patriarch, Nomophylax, Palkar Captain.

12.12 Ubral — "The Stone Between Spears"

Genre: Highland clan / reiver / honour culture.

12.12.0.0.1 Attitude toward magic: Clan shamans are respected; outsider mages are watched. Stone-speakers (dwarf-trained) are tolerated.

12.12.0.0.2 Typical dress / customs: Tweed, iron brooches, guest-tokens. Never refuse a cup from a hearth-aunt – hospitality is a contract.

12.12.0.0.3 Player hook: *You carry a wergild debt that your father couldn't pay. The feud is now yours.*

12.12.0.0.4 Key stakeholders: Lady of Tor, Council of Cairns, Feud-Broker, Wergild Counter.

12.13 Valewood — "Empire Under Leaves"

Genre: Fairy tale / dark forest / fey remnant.

12.13.0.0.1 Attitude toward magic: Imperial echoes and fae rites are dangerous. Never eat fruit from a tree with a face.

12.13.0.0.2 Typical dress / customs: Leather, moss-dyed cloaks, way-cords. Speak in riddles or not at all.

12.13.0.0.3 Player hook: *A star-road opened in your dream. You walked it – now something walks behind you.*

12.13.0.0.4 Key stakeholders: Hazel Queen, Alder King, The Huntsman, Pathweaver.

12.14 Vhasia — "The Fractured Sun"

Genre: Courtly romance / chivalric / fractured kingdom.

12.14.0.0.1 Attitude toward magic: The Church of the Flame distrusts arcane magic; secular lords employ court mages anyway. Chevauchée raiders use cantors for morale.

12.14.0.0.2 Typical dress / customs: Velvet, partisan ribbons, duelling scars. Never carry a coin with only one sunburst – treason.

12.14.0.0.3 Player hook: *You're the Last Dauphin – or a convincing fake. Either way, armies march for your claim.*

12.14.0.0.4 Key stakeholders: Two Crowns, Queen-Mother, Last Dauphin, Marshal-Exile.

12.15 Viterra — "The Hedge-Law Realm"

Genre: Legal drama / low fantasy / frontier justice.

12.15.0.0.1 Attitude toward magic: Hedge-magic is common and unregulated; any thaumaturgy that leaves a trace must be registered. Legal duels may involve wizards.

12.15.0.0.2 Typical dress / customs: Wool, seal rings, boundary stones. Every hedge is a precedent; every dike a court ruling.

12.15.0.0.3 Player hook: *Your family lost the border dispute. You have one year to find a lost charter or lose the land forever.*

12.15.0.0.4 Key stakeholders: Warrior Queen, Queen's Justiciar, Fen Reeve, Master Advocate Halric.

12.16 Ykrul (Orcs) — "Wolf Standards, Winter Camps"

Genre: Steppe nomad / saga / honour culture.

12.16.0.0.1 Attitude toward magic: Geometry of oaths (Kon"reh) and sky-speakers. Written magic is suspicious; sung magic is respected.

12.16.0.0.2 Typical dress / customs: Leather, horse-hair braids, wolf-tooth standards. Never ride between two wolves at dusk.

12.16.0.0.3 Player hook: *You broke a hostage string. Now the Khatun demands a blood-price – or your youngest kin.*

12.16.0.0.4 Key stakeholders: Khatun of Ring, Khagan's Kin, Sky-Speaker, Kon"reh Masters.

12.17 Zakov — "Salt & Serpent"

Genre: Pirate / noir / crime syndicate.

12.17.0.0.1 Attitude toward magic: Any magic is welcome – if it pays. Cursed cargoes are a common hazard; fae bargains are made at the Crimson Docks.

12.17.0.0.2 Typical dress / customs: Brine-stained coats, reef-tooth necklaces, smuggler's tokens. Never take a coin that tastes of brine – the Serpent's Mark is a debt.

12.17.0.0.3 Player hook: *You have a syndicate marker that could buy a fleet – or get you killed. The Salt Prince wants to collect.*

12.17.0.0.4 Key stakeholders: Salt Prince, Pirate Queen, Kraken's Tongue, Syndicate Silent.

12.18 Other Regions (Brief)

For completeness, these areas appear in the full setting but are less central to the core game. Ask your GM if your character may hail from one of them.

- **Dungeon** – "Living Infrastructure" – Mythic underworld, survival horror.
- **The Ways Between** – "Spiritways & Veilways" – Liminal paths, dream-logic.
- **The Wilds** – "Roads, Ruins, and Weather" – A reskin palette for any terrain.
- **Vilikari** – "Laurels & Longhouses" – Federated frontier, two laws.

Chapter 13

Currency-Free Economy: XP, Barter, and Trusts

The Ledger of Memory

"The world does not run on silver. It runs on memory—on favors owed, secrets kept, and the weight of promises. A coin can be stolen; a debt must be paid in deeds." — Dusana of the Raven Road, The Hearth Ledger

13.1 No Coin, Only Consequence

In Fate's Edge, there is no abstract currency. No gold pieces, no silver scales, no ledgers of mundane wealth. What you *know*, whom you *know*, and what you *owe* matter more than what you carry.

- **Incidental expenses** – a meal, a night at an inn, a riding horse, a week's trail rations – are **hand-waved**. Assume your character has enough from past earnings, barter, or simple hospitality to cover ordinary life. If the fiction demands scarcity, the GM will introduce a Supply Clock or a Complication.
- **Significant acquisitions** – assets, favors, magical items, political influence, or the service of a powerful ally – require one of three forms of payment:
 1. **Experience Points (XP)** – Spend your hard-won growth to secure lasting resources.
 2. **Barter or Strings** – Trade goods, services, information, or narrative leverage (Strings) for equivalent value.
 3. **Obligation** – Accept a Debt Clock or increase Obligation to a patron (terrestrial or supernatural) in exchange for immediate gain.

This chapter explains how to spend XP on non-personal advancement, how to pool XP for party assets, how to use Strings and Obligation as currency, and how to form a player-owned terrestrial patron: a **Trust**.

13.2 Abstracted Treasure: Finds That Change the Story

You do not track copper or silver. Instead, treasure is **leverage** — each meaningful find has a one-time narrative effect. A bag of gold is not treasure. A gold coin that was once paid as a traitor's blood-price *is*.

13.2.1 Treasure Tiers

Tier	Example
Minor	A merchant's seal, a noble's letter, a pouch of star-iron beads
Standard	A signed treaty, a bridge's deed, a saint's relic, a ship's luck in a bottle
Major	A king's true name, a lullaby that calms armies, a dragon's scale, a prophecy sealed in amber

13.2.2 Finding and Using Treasure

When players loot a significant location (a dragon's lair, a fallen noble's vault, a sunken temple), the GM awards **1–3 treasure items** at appropriate tiers. No coin. No weight. No bookkeeping.

A character may carry at most **3 treasure items** total (any mix). Unused treasure fades after one session unless invested in an Asset (pay the treasure's XP equivalent to keep it as a permanent String).

Spend a treasure item to:

- **Improve Position** on a relevant roll by one step (Minor).
- **Auto-succeed** on a non-combat roll where leverage applies (Standard).
- **Rewrite a scene's stakes** (Major) — e.g., "I use the king's true name to make his guards stand down."

13.2.3 Treasure as XP (Optional)

A player may convert a treasure item into XP instead of using its narrative effect:

- Minor → 1 XP
- Standard → 2 XP
- Major → 4 XP

The GM should warn: *"You can sell the dragon's scale for power, or you can use it to command the dragon's respect."*

13.2.4 Integration with Existing Systems

- **Assets:** A treasure item can be spent to acquire a Minor Asset instantly (no downtime).
- **Debt Clocks:** A treasure item can clear 1–3 segments of a Debt Clock (GM discretion).
- **Strings:** A treasure item can become a permanent String if invested during downtime.
- **Boons:** A treasure item can be cashed for 2 Boons instead of its narrative effect.

13.2.4.0.1 The Golden Rule of Treasure: *If it doesn't change the story, it's not treasure.* Name it. Describe it. Then watch your players hoard it not for its value, but for its power to change what happens next.

Abstracted Treasure: The Leverage Standard

"A Minor treasure affects a single roll or scene. A Standard treasure affects a single conflict or session. A Major treasure changes the campaign arc or permanently rewrites the fiction."

Tier	Fate's Edge Example	What It Does
32.5cmMinor	<i>Emberfang Dagger</i>	Glows when undead are near; once per scene, gain +1 die to detect hidden spirits.
	<i>Vial of Starlight Water</i>	Drink to clear 1 Fatigue or ignore a minor poison (one use).
	<i>Runes of Unsteady Passage</i>	Chalk a doorframe; the next person through forgets why they entered (one scene).
32.5cmStandard	<i>Bell of the Fog Warden</i>	Ring it to part mist or silence a supernatural wail for the entire scene.
	<i>Captain's Luck in a Bottle</i>	Break it to reroll any failed roll for your ship or crew (once per session).
	<i>Sealed Knight's Confession</i>	Read it aloud to force a parley; the target cannot attack for the duration of the scene.
32.5cmMajor	<i>True Name of the Ashen Tyrant</i>	Speak it to compel the tyrant to abdicate, or to force open any gate they sealed.
	<i>Seed of the First Oak</i>	Bury it to grow a fortress in a day — the fortress remembers the builder's fears.
	<i>Fossilised Heart of the Elder Wyrn</i>	Once per campaign, negate a natural disaster or redirect a region-wide curse.

Leverage Test: Ask “*What can this treasure do **once**?*”

- “Give +1 die or skip a minor obstacle” → Minor
- “Resolve a significant problem or open a major opportunity” → Standard
- “End a war, topple a dynasty, or redirect destiny” → Major

Passive, permanent benefits (e.g., a sword that always adds +1 die) are **Assets**, not treasures. The treasure version is a one-scene surge of that power.

13.3 What Costs XP (and What Doesn't)

13.3.1 Hand-Waved (Free)

Always assume you have enough for:

- Ordinary meals, lodging, basic travel rations.
- A riding horse or pack mule (if fictionally plausible).
- Basic tools (rope, lantern, writing kit, lockpicks).
- Minor repairs, small bribes (a drink, a gift).
- Routine transportation (ferry, caravan passage) *unless* the journey itself is the adventure.

13.3.1.0.1 GM Guideline: When a player asks "Do I have enough for X?" and X is not a major story resource, answer "Yes" unless scarcity is the point of the scene.

13.3.2 Costs XP (or Equivalent Barter / Obligation)

Item / Benefit	XP Cost (min.)	Notes
Minor Asset (safehouse, workshop, contact network)	4 XP	See 10.2
Standard Asset (guild seat, spy ring, fortress lease)	8 XP	See 10.2
Major Asset (chartered city license, fleet, noble title)	12 XP	See 10.2
Follower (Capability squared)	Cap ² XP	See 10.4
Magical item (single use)	2–4 XP	GM discretion
Magical item (permanent, Tier I)	6–10 XP	Requires downtime
Clearing a Debt Clock segment	2 XP per segment	Instead of performing a service
Buying a permanent String (favor owed to you)	2–4 XP	One-time narrative permission
Upkeep of an Asset or Follower (efficient method)	As per 10.8	XP instead of coin
Forming a Trust (player-owned patron)	10 XP (party pool)	See 13.6.1

13.3.2.0.1 Design Note: XP represents not just training but *investment* – resources, contacts, and time spent securing something of lasting value. Want a safehouse? You don't pay gold; you spend XP to reflect the effort of finding, securing, and stocking it.

13.4 Pooling XP for Party Assets

A party may create a **shared pool** of XP to acquire and maintain assets that benefit everyone. The pool is tracked separately from individual XP.

13.4.1 Creating a Pool

- Any player may contribute any amount of their unspent XP to the party pool.
- Contributions are voluntary and irreversible (unless the party agrees to dissolve the pool – see [13.4.3](#)).
- The pool has no owner; decisions about spending from it require **majority vote** (or table consensus).

13.4.2 Spending from the Pool

- The pool can only be used for **party assets** (shared safehouse, group ship, guild charter, spy network) or for **forming a Trust** (see 13.6.1).
- It cannot be used for individual Attribute/Skill increases, personal Talents, or personal Followers.
- When an asset bought with the pool requires **upkeep** (see 10.8), the upkeep can be paid from the pool (efficient method) or by assigning a party member to handle it (intensive method).

13.4.3 Dissolving the Pool

- If the party permanently disbands or agrees to liquidate, the remaining XP in the pool is **lost** – it represents sunk investment in shared infrastructure.
- Instead, the party may **transfer** the asset to one character (who must pay its XP cost from their own XP to "buy out" the others). The other contributors are compensated with an equivalent String from that character (see 13.5).

13.4.3.0.1 Example: Kael (9 XP banked), Lyra (4 XP), and Sera (6 XP) want a shared safehouse (Minor Asset, 4 XP). They contribute 2 XP each to the pool (total 6 XP). They spend 4 XP to acquire the safehouse, leaving 2 XP in the pool for future upkeep. The safehouse is now a party asset. Later they add Mira (3 XP), who contributes 1 XP to the pool.

13.5 Barter, Strings, and Obligation

When you lack XP, you may pay with **barter** (trading goods or services), **Strings** (narrative leverage), or **Obligation** (debt to a patron). These are not coin – they are story fuel.

13.5.1 Barter

- Trade an item of comparable value (a magical sword for a spy network, a noble's secret for a ship).
- The GM adjudicates fairness. A barter exchange usually requires a Sway or Broker roll (DV 2–4).
- **Service Barter:** Promise a future task in exchange for immediate gain. This creates a Debt Clock [4–6] for the recipient.

13.5.2 Strings as Currency

Strings are defined in the core rules as narrative permissions – a favor owed, a secret known, a charter held. They can be **spent** as currency:

String Value	Can purchase
Minor String (a small favor, a local contact)	One-use discount of 1 XP on an asset, or a single use of an A
Standard String (a noble's oath, a guild seal)	A Minor Asset (4 XP value) or clear 2 segments of a Debt C
Major String (a life-debt, a royal charter)	A Standard Asset (8 XP value) or a Follower (up to Cap 3)

To convert a String into XP, the player must **use** the String in play – narrate how it secures the asset. The GM may require a roll (e.g., Presence + Sway to call in the favor).

13.5.3 Obligation as Payment

Instead of XP, accept a **Debt Clock** or increase **Obligation** to a terrestrial patron (see 10.15).

Debt Clock Size	Equivalent Value
	Minor Asset or one-time service
	Standard Asset or Cap 3 Follower
	Major Asset or Cap 5 Follower

You may clear a Debt Clock segment by spending 2 XP (as if buying off the debt with hard work), or by performing an appropriate service (GM discretion).

13.5.3.0.1 Example: The party wants a ship (Standard Asset, 8 XP). They have no XP, but a Sidhi pirate captain offers them the ship in exchange for a **Debt Clock** [6]. When it fills, they must raid an Oshiiran grain barge for her. They accept.

13.6 Player-Owned Terrestrial Patrons: Trusts

A **Trust** is a collective entity – a guild, a covenant, a company, a secret society – founded and run by the player characters. It acts as a **terrestrial patron** (see 10.15), but the players collectively decide its demands and benefits.

13.6.1 Forming a Trust

- Requires **10 XP from the party pool** (cannot be paid individually).
- The party names the Trust, defines its purpose (e.g., "The Silkhand League – spice merchants and smugglers"), and chooses an initial **Seat** (headquarters or symbol).
- The Trust starts with a **Debt Clock** [4] (the cost of founding) that the players must clear through roleplay or XP before it can grant benefits.

13.6.2 How a Trust Works

The Trust is a **non-player character** entity with:

- **Obligation Capacity** equal to the party's combined Spirit + Presence (or a fixed value of 6 for simplicity). Members incur Obligation to the Trust when they ask for its help.
- **Debt Clock** (size 4, 6, or 8) – tracks external obligations the Trust owes to other factions.
- **Asset Pool** – the Trust can own Assets (safehouses, ships, contact networks) bought with party XP (see 13.4).
- **Follower Pool** – the Trust can employ Followers (e.g., guards, clerks, spies) paid from the party pool.

13.6.3 Benefits of Belonging to a Trust

A character who is a member of the Trust (all founders are members; new members can be inducted) may:

- **Call on the Trust** – once per session, gain +1 die on a roll directly related to the Trust's purpose (e.g., smuggling, trade, information). This costs no Obligation.
- **Borrow an Asset** – use one of the Trust's Assets for a scene. Mark +1 Obligation to the

Trust per Asset used.

- **Request a Follower** – temporarily command a Trust follower (Cap 1–2) for a mission. Mark +1 Obligation per follower.
- **Use the Trust’s Strings** – the Trust may accumulate Strings (favors from others). A member may spend one such String as if it were their own (costs 1 Obligation).

13.6.4 Obligation to the Trust

- A member’s Obligation to the Trust is tracked separately from other patrons. Capacity = Spirit + Presence (see 3.3.1).
- When Obligation fills (exceeds capacity), the Trust **demand a task** – a mission that advances its goals. If refused, the member is **expelled** and loses all Trust benefits.
- Obligation can be cleared by:
 - Performing a service for the Trust (GM discretion, usually clears 1–2 segments).
 - Contributing XP to the Trust pool (2 XP per segment).
 - Donating a personal Asset or String of equivalent value.

13.6.5 Growing the Trust

The party may invest additional XP from the party pool to expand the Trust:

Investment	Effect
4 XP	Increase Debt Clock capacity by 2 (can owe more before demanding repayment)
6 XP	Add a new Trust Asset (Minor)
8 XP	Upgrade an Asset from Minor to Standard
10 XP	Add a Trust Follower (Cap 3)
12 XP	Gain a permanent String (a faction owes the Trust a favor)
15 XP	The Trust becomes a Major Terrestrial Patron – can grant its own Rites (narrative perm

13.6.6 Trusts as Story Engines

The GM should use the Trust as a source of complications:

- **Schism** – A faction within the Trust disagrees with leadership. Start a Trust Loyalty clock [6].
- **Hostile Takeover** – Another group (rival guild, Ashaani agents) tries to seize the Trust’s assets.
- **Debt Called In** – A faction to which the Trust owes a Debt Clock makes a demand that endangers the party.
- **Reputation** – The Trust gains a reputation (good or bad). High reputation grants +1 die on social rolls within its sphere; low reputation attracts enemies.

13.6.6.0.1 Example Trust – The Silkhand League:

- **Founded:** 10 XP from party pool (Kael 3, Lyra 2, Sera 3, Mira 2)
- **Seat:** A warehouse in Silkstrand’s dyeworks district
- **Initial Assets:** None (spent XP on founding)
- **Debt Clock:** 4 (they owe the local harbor master)
- **Members:** The four PCs

After a few sessions, they contribute another 8 XP to the pool and buy a **Standard Asset**: a spy network among the port's Sidhi pilots. They also add a **Trust Follower** (Cap 2, a runner named Tema). Now when Lyra needs to know a ship's schedule, she marks 1 Obligation to the Trust and asks Tema. When the Trust's Obligation to her reaches capacity, the Trust will demand that she intercept a rival's cargo – a mission that becomes the next session's adventure.

13.7 Optional: Converting XP to Narrative Wealth

Some tables may want a concrete way to spend XP on temporary advantages without acquiring permanent assets.

XP Spent	Temporary Benefit
1 XP	A single use of a Minor Asset (one scene)
2 XP	One-time +2 dice on a roll involving resources (bribe, hire, purchase)
3 XP	A Debt Clock segment cleared immediately
4 XP	One-scene use of a Standard Asset (e.g., a ship for a chase)
6 XP	One-mission Follower (Cap 3, must be a willing NPC)

These expenditures represent short-term investment of effort and contacts – "burning" XP for immediate story gain. They cannot be recovered.

13.8 Summary for Players

- **No coins.** Incidental expenses are free.
- **Treasure is leverage.** Minor, Standard, or Major finds that change the story.
- **Significant things cost XP, barter, Strings, or Obligation.**
- **Pool XP** for party assets.
- **Form a Trust** – a player-owned terrestrial patron – for shared power and shared trouble.
- **Use Strings as currency.** Collect favors, trade them, spend them.
- **Debt is story.** Accepting a Debt Clock is not failure; it's future adventure.

The Gray Wanderer's Ledger

"I have carried silver across a dozen borders and buried it in as many deserts. The only wealth that never tarnishes is a promise witnessed by honest lips. Spend your XP on what you will hold – a safehouse, a follower, a Trust. The rest is wind."

Chapter 14

World Regions and Cultures

The world of *Fate's Edge* is a tapestry of ancient empires, emerging kingdoms, and untamed wilderness. This chapter surveys major regions and cultures that shape the setting—from the marble cities of Ecktoria to the mist-shrouded fields of Aelinnel. Use this as a reference for character backgrounds, cultural customs, and the feel of the lands you will explore.

14.1 The Amaranthine Inland Sea

At the heart of the known world lies the **Amaranthine Inland Sea**, a wind-gnarled waterway ringed by marble quays, vineyard hills, and smoke-blue mountains. For millennia it has served as the circulatory system of trade, faith, and conquest. Tides are subtle, but seasonal winds and river-feeds set the rhythm of commerce, pilgrimage, and war.

14.2 Northern Shore of the Amaranthine Sea

Ecktoria — The Uтарan Imperium Successor

Once the furnace of empire (*Marble & Fire*), Ecktoria remains a palimpsest of power: old stones bearing new banners, old laws written under fresh seals. Though imperial reach waned, its civic habits endure — an echo of late Roman/Byzantine grandeur, with provincial governors, standing bureaucracies, and ever-present legal codes.

Marble Cities Forums, amphitheaters, and aqueducts yet flow. District fountains double as public oaths guaranteed by guild charters.

Imperial Roads Mile-markers of white granite, way-shrines and customary tolls noted for couriers of the *Ashen Staves*.

Legal Legacy The **Uтарan Civic Codes** govern contracts, inheritance, and war-rights; local custom bends them under licensed *variance*.

Architectural Wonders Sun-bridges spanning deltas, the **Vault of a Thousand Maps**, and the **Amber Arch** petrified by alchemical storm.

Acasia — "The Broken Province"

Fallen Province. Frontiers braided from roads, rivers, and resentments — a land of petty kingdoms and free companies, reminiscent of the Welsh Marches or the post-Roman frontier. Here the outer seams of empire frayed first. Fortresses turned manors, manors turned townholds, and banners

multiplied like thistles after rain.

Petty Kingdoms Dozens of river-vales ruled by river-kings and banner-queens. Alliances shift with marriages, harvests, and omens.

Fortified Towns Walls for defense, not display. Gate-streets kink for ambush; towers carry horn-codes every child knows.

Mercenary Culture Free companies keep a *Black Ledger*: contracts fulfilled, oaths kept, debts paid.

Cultural Mix Imperial rites meet clan feasts; old gods share niches with civic saints. Exiles and second chances (*see* Silkstrand tales) are common.

Vhasia — "Old Vhasia & The Bloodlands"

Politically fractured kingdom of courtly intrigue and martial tradition, where ancient bloodlines vie for supremacy amid shifting alliances and ceremonial warfare. Travelers from across the Amaranthine often note its chivalric pageantry, its elaborate dueling codes, and its love of rhetoric.

Fortress Castles Stone keeps crowned with gilded spires; courtiers plot in tapestried halls while knights train in courtyards.

Political Intrigue Complex web of alliances, vendettas, and ceremonial duels that settle matters of honor and succession.

Court Culture Elaborate ceremonies, patronage of arts, and rigid social hierarchies maintained through ritual and reputation.

Heraldic Traditions Complex system of banners, titles, and precedence that govern social interactions and military commands.

Thepyrgos

Province and capital city renowned as a center of learning, magic, and scholarly pursuit, where ancient towers house both wisdom and dangerous secrets. A blend of Byzantine bureaucracy and Mediterranean university culture — the City of a Thousand Stairs.

Scholarly Traditions Tower-cities where mages, philosophers, and researchers pursue knowledge in specialized colleges and scriptoriums.

Arcane Heritage Deep traditions of magical study, with libraries containing texts predating the fall of ancient empires.

Academic Rivalries Intense competition between schools of thought, often manifesting in formal debates, magical duels, or scholarly contests.

Mystical Dangers Forbidden knowledge and experimental magic that sometimes escape control, creating ongoing threats.

Viterra — "The Last Kingdom"

Realm that straddles the Dolmis and Amaranthine seas, known for its legalistic approach to governance and strategic river crossings. Its common law — the *Hedge-Law* — and its tradition of legal precedent evoke the courts of a certain misty island kingdom.

Hedge-Law Culture Complex system of legal precedents, tolls, and river rights that govern everything from trade to personal conduct.

Duchy System Semi-autonomous regions governed by dukes who maintain their own courts and armies while owing fealty to the crown.

River Commerce Economy built around controlling strategic crossings, ferry rights, and maritime trade routes.

Legalistic Politics Intrigue centered on court cases, charter disputes, and the interpretation of ancient laws rather than open warfare.

Ubral — "The Stone Between Spears"

Highland realm of rugged clans and fortified holds, where honor culture and martial traditions dominate social interactions — a landscape of braes and glens, of cairns and clan feuds.

Clan Strongholds Fortified positions in mountain passes and high valleys, each clan maintaining its own laws and customs.

Honor Culture Society built around concepts of personal honor, family reputation, and the resolution of disputes through formal challenges.

Highland Warfare Military traditions emphasizing heavy infantry, defensive positions, and knowledge of mountain terrain.

Clan Loyalties Complex web of alliances, blood-feuds, and marriage pacts that shift with each generation.

Kahfagia — "The Empire of Wakes and Storm-Flags"

Maritime empire built on naval supremacy and exploration, where ship captains and merchant-adventurers shape both policy and culture — a Venetian–Portuguese hybrid, with lantern-law and pilot guilds ruling the waves.

Naval Supremacy Military and economic power based on controlling sea lanes, harbors, and maritime trade routes.

Explorer Culture Tradition of venturing into unknown waters, mapping new territories, and establishing trading posts.

Storm-Flag Protocol Complex system of maritime signals, weather prediction, and naval customs that govern seaborne activities.

Mixed Heritage Cosmopolitan society influenced by contacts with distant lands and diverse cultures encountered through exploration.

Theona — "The Marsh Crown"

Three island realms connected by causeways and maritime traditions, where wetland resources and naval culture define daily life. The grey skies, peat bogs, and ringforts of Theona echo the landscapes of ancient Éire — a land of high kings, saints, and folk horrors lurking beneath the mist.

Marsh Agriculture Sophisticated systems of dikes, canals, and floating gardens that support dense populations in wetland environments.

Island Culture Distinct traditions for each island, unified by shared maritime customs and inter-island trade.

Waterborne Commerce Economy based on fishing, water transport, and control of strategic waterways between islands.

Folk Horror Traditions Deep connection to marsh spirits, water deities, and ancient practices that blur the line between protection and appeasement.

The Mistlands — "Fields Under a Moving Sky"

Isolated region shrouded in perpetual mists, where ancient Aelerian protectorate status creates tension between autonomy and oversight. The Mistlands draw from Celtic and Breton folklore — a land of bells, standing stones, and the ever-present threat of what walks in the fog.

Mistbound Geography Landscape of bogs, waterways, and hidden settlements connected by causeways and boat paths.

Bell Culture Complex system of bells and wards must be maintained to keep the Direwood horrors at bay.

Isolation Tensions Cultural friction between desire for independence and practical need for trade and protection.

Ancient Secrets Ruins and artifacts predating the Aelerian protectorate, hinting at older civilizations and forgotten magics.

14.3 Peoples and Cultures

The peoples of Fate's Edge are many. Some trace their lineage to the earliest days of the Utaran Imperium; others arrived across the sea or emerged from the mist-hung valleys of the Direwood. What follows are the major cultural groupings — self-named and deeply particular. Outsiders may use simpler labels; the wise learn the names that people call themselves.

14.3.1 Small Folk of the Threshold

The Aelaerem (halflings) and Aelinnel (gnomes) are diminutive peoples attuned to liminal spaces—doorways, hedge-gaps, tide-cut stairs, and the quiet places between hearth and hollow.

- **Restriction:** Cannot use Heavy Armor. May use any one-handed or two-handed weapon, but Heavy Weapons impose **−1 Position** on all actions while wielding them (before any other Position modifiers).
- **Bonus:** When wielding a **spear, quarterstaff, or light polearm** (any Medium or Light weapon with the **Reach** tag), treat the weapon as **one weight class lighter** for the purpose of attack modifiers. Additionally, once per scene when you make a melee attack with such a weapon, you may spend **1 Boon** to convert a *Partial* success into a *Clean Success* (representing a clever thrust that uses the enemy's momentum against them).

Aelaerem — The Hearth's Luck

Bonus — Once per scene, you may improve your **Position by one step** (e.g., Desperate → Controlled, Controlled → Dominant) as a free action **before** rolling an action. This represents a flash of luck, a well-timed sidestep, or an unexpected opening.

From the Hearth Ledger

"The Aelaerem say that a door left unlatched is an invitation to the Hollow. But sometimes, an unlatched door is just an escape." Use your luck wisely. The Hollow is patient.

Aelinnel — The Bright Trick

Choose **one** of the following abilities to represent their tricky nature.

Option A: Short Step (Teleport)

Bonus — Once per scene, as a **Move action**, you may instantly teleport to any location

you can see within **Near** range that is not currently observed by any enemy. You cannot pass through solid barriers. This is a fey-like blink, not a physical jump.

Option B: Knack for the Right Thing (Handy Item)

Bonus — Once per scene, you may declare that you have a **small, mundane item** on your person that is useful in the current situation (e.g., a coil of rope, a lockpick, a candle, a chalk stick). This costs no Boon and requires no roll. The item must be plausible for your character to carry. (This is a free, once-per-scene version of the **Flashback Declaration** mechanic described in 2.17.)

A Gnomish Maxim

"Count the steps in odd numbers. Even is for the dead. ... Wait, did I say odd? Let me check my abacus." Aelinnel never trust a single ledger. Neither should you.

Both peoples are often underestimated—a mistake that has left many a larger foe stumbling through a door that was never really shut.

The Lethai — The Sundered Kin

The Lethai are the eldest of the mortal lineages, their memory stretching back before the fall of empires now forgotten. An ancient constraint divides them: no Lethai may bear both the Gift of the Body and the Gift of the Mind. From this sundering grew three distinct peoples, each with its own philosophy, homeland, and customs.

Lethai-al — "People of the Body" (Wood Elves)

The Lethai-al dwell in the ****Valewood****, that ancient forest where roof-trees braid the sky and rivers think aloud. Their memory is arboreal — rings, seasons, coppice ledgers — and their oaths are *root-law*: debts counted in years, paid in living work. To outsiders they seem quiet; to neighbors they are relentless auditors of footprint and flow.

Forest Harmony Lifestyle integrated with woodland ecosystems, practicing sustainable hunting, gathering, and cultivation. They do not "use" the forest; they live within its clauses.

Body-Centric Philosophy Emphasis on physical experience, instinct, and the wisdom of sinew and breath over abstract thought. A Lethai-al proverb: *"The hand that fells the tree must plant the sapling."*

Living Magic Spellcasting works *with* natural forces, not against them — plant-speech, animal kinship, and the slow shaping of living wood.

Seasonal Rituals A calendar of ceremonies marking planting, harvest, and the winter quiet. Outsiders are welcome at the Autumn Trade Moot, but the Spring Rites are veiled.

Homeland The ****Valewood**** itself — no single capital, but shifting grove-courts and deep hollows where the oldest trees remember empire.

Lethai-thora — "People of the Mind" (High Elves)

The Lethai-thora make their homes in cities — chiefly ****Thepyrgos****, the City of a Thousand Stairs — where they weigh arguments like bridges and translate other peoples' law into forms that carry. Their courts count consequences; their speech is context-saturated and exact.

Scholarly Excellence Deep traditions of academic study, magical research, and philosophical debate. The Great Library of Thepyrgos holds texts that predate the Sundering.

Mind-Centric Philosophy Reason, logic, and the pursuit of abstract knowledge over physical

concerns. A Lethai-thora axiom: *"A clean proof is worth a thousand swords."*

Arcane Mastery Advanced magical techniques and theoretical understanding that often surpass other traditions. Many of the Free Casters' foundational texts were penned by Lethai-thora hands.

Long Perspective Tendency to view problems and conflicts through the lens of centuries rather than immediate gain. This patience can be wisdom — or paralysis.

Homeland ***Thepyrgos*** and its satellite academies, with enclaves in other major cities where scribal work and jurisprudence are valued.

Lethai-ar — "The Oathbound" (Dark Elves)

The Lethai-ar are not a separate bloodline but a vow-bound cadre. They are Lethai-al or Lethai-thora who step off those paths to live under threshold patrons — ***Inaea*** the Weaver and ***Isoka*** the Serpent. In some ages they are scarce; in others — like the present — they gather wherever borders fray and oaths need teeth. They are known for *mask-right*, precise courtesies, and the unsettling efficiency of vows that bind places, routes, and roles.

Serpent Wisdom Followers of Isoka emphasize transformation, renewal, and the shedding of old identities for new growth. A shedding can be a cure, an escape, or a cruelty — context is all.

Spider Webs Devotees of Inaea focus on connections, patterns, and the weaving of fate through careful manipulation. Mercy with memory; knots that HEAL before they bind.

Philosophical Balance Neither inherently good nor evil, but representing alternative approaches to power and influence. A Lethai-ar may be a healer or a poisoner, a mediator or a cut-throat — the method, not the morality, defines them.

Cultural Rarity Uncommon in most settings, often viewed with suspicion or fascination. Their masks and vows unsettle those who prefer straightforward dealings.

Homeland No fixed homeland. They gather in ***mask-circles*** within other Lethai communities or in hidden enclaves near ancient thresholds.

The Aeler — People of Stone, Breath, and Ledger (Dwarves)

The Aeler are the mountain-born, built like their peaks — layered, load-bearing, enduring. They call their home ***The Mountains***, ***Undermount***, or ***The Stonelands***; outsiders often say "Aelerian range," but that is a cartographer's convenience, not a name the Aeler use for themselves.

Stone-Sense Innate ability to understand and work with geological formations, making them master miners, architects, and engineers. An Aeler can read a tunnel's stress like a human reads a face.

Clan System Complex social structure based on family lines, with intricate systems of honor, debt, and mutual obligation. Every clan keeps a ***Keystone Ledger*** — a record of favors owed and paid.

Craft Traditions Legendary skills in metalworking, stonework, and engineering refined over generations. Aeler steel is sought across the Amaranthine; Aeler bridges are the last to fall in a siege.

Underground Cities Vast complexes carved from mountain hearts, connected by tunnels and halls that serve both practical and ceremonial purposes. The city of ***Khaz-Vurim*** is the oldest and greatest.

Deep Law Contracts are carved, not inked. A broken oath can be read in the stone for centuries. Justice is a matter of measurement — a tilted beam, a mis-weighted coin.

The Aelinnel — People of Sums, Bough, and Bright Things (Gnomes)

The Aelinnel dwell in ****Aevrossa****, the hawthorn hills south of the Valewood — a land of living wood, worked stone, and air that tastes of mathematics. Their lives intertwine with **courtesy, copper, and count**. In addition to the Small Folk traits described above, they have the following cultural features.

Mathematical Culture Society built around complex calculations, probability, and the belief that all phenomena can be understood through numerical relationships. A bridge's strength, a market's price, a court's verdict — all are sums.

Fey Logic Non-linear thinking patterns that seem illogical to outsiders but follow their own internal consistency. *"If you speak the ninth name, you must also speak the silence that follows it."*

Mist Adaptation Unique abilities to navigate and manipulate the perpetual mists of Aevrossa. They read fog like a ledger, finding paths where others see only white.

Contract Culture Deep tradition of precise agreements, wordplay, and the careful crafting of obligations. Every bargain has two ledgers: what was *said* and what was *meant*.

Homeland ****Aevrossa**** — a realm of stone circles, antler-posts, and tide-cut stairs. Its capital is the ****Hall of Aelinnel****, a timber keep threaded between standing stones.

The Aelaerem — People of the Hearth (Halflings)

The Aelaerem are a people of movement and assembly, living among gentle slopes and hedged lanes. Their homeland's true name is ****hushed**** — they refer to it only with euphemisms, for to speak its old name is to invite the attention of the Neighbors. Outsiders may call it "the Halfling Downs" or "the Southern Valleys"; the Aelaerem smile and say nothing. In addition to the Small Folk traits described above, they have the following cultural features.

Euphemisms for the Homeland

The Aelaerem use many pseudonyms, each a quiet oxymoron that hides a darker truth:

Common Name	Hidden Meaning	Old Tongue
The Silent Welcome	"Welcome" = hospitality; "Silent" = calm, a gentle invitation. Sounds like a village festival.	<i>Rath-Gor</i> ("the binding mouth") — the ancient seal where the Neighbors are held.
The Merry Maw	"Merry" = good cheer, feasting; "Maw" = a large gaping mouth. Sounds like a tavern name.	<i>Gor-Elen</i> ("the sealed mouth") — the cursed cavern where eldritch doors are locked.
Stillwater (or The Still-Water)	"Still" = peace; "water" = life, farming. A common halfling landmark.	<i>Nok-Lur</i> ("the black source") — an underground well that is actually a conduit to the other world.
The Quiet Hearth	"Hearth" = home, warmth; "Quiet" = serene, safe.	<i>Ael-Gren</i> ("the sealed fire") — the ancient stone ring that locks the Neighbors away.
The Gentle Fold	"Fold" = a shepherd's safe enclosure; "Gentle" = pastoral.	<i>Thar-Gur</i> ("the gnashing cleft") — the fissure in the earth that serves as the "mouth" of the seal.

The Aelaerem themselves are warm, generous, and fiercely protective of their own — but their land hides a hunger. Hospitality is their public law; beneath it runs an older hedge-law of cup-marks, red thread, and the quiet attention of the Neighbors.

Hearth Culture Deep connection to home, family, and the maintenance of traditional ways. A red door promises bread, salt, and one safe night if you come honest.

Agricultural Expertise Sophisticated farming techniques and seasonal celebrations that mark the rhythm of rural life. Their cider, wool, and beeswax are known across the Amaranthine.

Folk Horror Elements Dark undercurrents in seemingly peaceful communities, where hospitality can become a trap and tradition carries hidden costs. The Neighbors are always watching.

Community Defense Strong traditions of mutual aid and collective action when the community is threatened. When the bells ring, every Aelaerem takes up a tool or a weapon.

The Ykrul — The People of the Violet Steppe (Orcs)

Note on Naming

"Orc" is a slur. The Ykrul are a proud people of the steppe; the word "orc" was coined by Utaran legions to dehumanize them. Wise travellers use *Ykrul* or *Steppe Folk*. Using "orc" in conversation with a Ykrul may be taken as a grave insult.

Nomadic clans of horse-riders and raiders. The Ykrul live by omen, pasture, and blood-tanistry. Their sacred geometry is the *Kon'reh* — a living calculus of routes, exits, and blood-price.

Seasonal Migrations Each clan follows ancient pastures, moving with the herds. Winter camps are ringed by felt tents facing the wind.

Shamans and Sky-Speakers Weather-readers who call storms and interpret omens. They speak

for the ancestors.

Blood-Tanistry Leadership passes to the strongest or wisest, not merely the firstborn. Feuds are settled by wergild (blood-price) in cattle or horses.

Kon'reh Masters Geometry arbiters who teach the sacred numbers of the steppe — every crossing has a number, every ford a weight.

Other Peoples — "Beyond the Old Roads"

The lands beyond the Amaranthine and the Aelerian passes hold many other folk. Some are recent arrivals; others are ancient survivors of forgotten cataclysms.

Nomadic Tribes Various peoples who follow seasonal patterns across steppes, deserts, and other marginal lands. The **Ykrul** are the most numerous, but they are far from alone.

Coastal Peoples Maritime cultures that live in harmony with ocean environments and maintain their own naval traditions. The **Linn** and **Zakov** corsairs, the **Kahfagian** pilots, and the island clans of the **Dolmis**.

Border Cultures Mixed communities that arise where different major cultures meet, creating unique hybrid traditions. The **Vilikari** straddle empire and steppe; the **Acasian** marches brew their own fierce independence.

Ancient Survivors Remnants of older civilizations that persist in isolated regions, maintaining forgotten knowledge and customs. The **Mistlands** bell-wardens, the **Theonan** marsh-kings, and the silent watchers of the **Direwood**.

14.4 Regional Specialties and Resources

Climate and Biomes of the Amaranthine

The Amaranthine Inland Sea is ringed by fertile coasts, rolling hills, and mountain ranges. Unlike the arid southern shores of Old Earth's middle sea, the wind patterns here reverse — the hot, dry air of the Sahel belt is pushed south, leaving the northern and eastern shores with ample rainfall and the southern shores as temperate grasslands. Thus, the lands around the Amaranthine are lush and productive, from the olive groves of Ecktoria to the wheat fields of Acasia to the horse pastures of the Vilikari steppe.

Economic Strengths by Region

Ecktoria Marble, legal services, grain, olive oil, wine, purple dye (murex), glassworks, coinage.

Acasia Cattle, horses, wool, iron, salt, mercenary contracts, border tolls.

Vhasia Wine, timber, stone, cloth (linen and wool), illuminated manuscripts, tapestries.
Thepyrgos Scholarly texts, magical reagents, glassware, precision instruments, silk (imported and finished), philosophical schools.

Viterra Tin, copper, wool, tin-glazed pottery, legal charters, insurance contracts, river tolls.

Ubral Lead, silver, slate, hardy mountain sheep (wool and cheese), whisky, mercenary mountaineers.

Kahfagia Shipbuilding, naval stores (pitch, tar, sailcloth), spices (imported), exotic woods, dyes (indigo, cochineal), potatoes, maize, tomatoes.

Linn Fish (dried and salted), whale oil, amber, walrus ivory, furs, raiding, ship-tolls.

Theona Citrus fruits, olive oil, pottery (amphorae), salt, peat, glass beads, star-compasses.

Mistlands Peat, bog iron, fog-pollen ink, mistglass (humming glass), woven fog-wool, herbal remedies (nightshade, feverfew, belladonna).

Zakov Ship salvage, black market goods, exotic poisons, reef coral, pearls, smuggled luxuries.

Vilikari Horses, leather goods, horn, bone, honey, wax, mercenary light cavalry.

Ykrul Horses (the finest), hides, wool felt, dairy products, dried meat, amber.

Unique Products (Expanded)

- **Ecktoria:** *Purple marble, ceramic plumbing, state bonds.*
- **Acasia:** *Curse-iron, hedge-knight contracts.*
- **Vhasia:** *Illuminated bestiaries, vengeance wine.*
- **Thepyrgos:** *Echo glass, thousand-step tea.*
- **Viterra:** *Hedge-law scrolls, river silver.*
- **Ubral:** *Whisky of the Twelve Clans, slate that echoes.*
- **Kahfagia:** *Storm-flags, lantern-glass.*
- **Linn:** *Whale-bone runes, frost silk.*
- **Theona:** *Star-compasses, amphorae of silence.*
- **Mistlands:** *Fog-pollen ink, mistglass.*
- **Zakov:** *Black coral amulets, songs of the reef, pearl of forgetfulness.*
- **Vilikari:** *Horse-hide scrolls, blood-honey.*
- **Ykrul:** *Kon'reh boards, wake-ropes.*

14.5 Travel and Trade

Major Routes

Amaranthine Coastway Sea-corridor linking Theona, Linn, Zakov, Kahfagia, and Ecktoria. The busiest lane in the west, dotted with lantern-beacons and patrol stations.

Astroegro Straits The narrows between Thepyrgos and the northern shore. Controlled by Synod boom-chains; passage requires a harbor pass or a timely bribe.

River Roads The Belworth (dividing Vhasia and Viterra), the Yloka (from Linn lands to the Aberderrin), and the Acadian rivers (approaching Silkstrand). Each has its own tolls, ferry rights, and seasonal floods.

Aelerian Passes & Underways Vault-routes beneath the peaks. Dwarven-kept, breath-counted, and lit by bell-lanterns. The fastest way north – if you trust the stone.

Kahfagian Sea Lanes Goods from across the "west lands" (unknown continents beyond the Great Western Sea) enter through Kassamira. Only Kahfagian pilots know the safe currents.

The Way of Silk Overland routes from the far east, ending in Silkstrand. Caravans traverse the Pereshi highlands (hub: the great bazaar of **Zarath**), the Himadri passes, and the Dhaharan plains. Monsoon winds dictate the eastern sea legs.

Shadow Corridors Liminal shortcuts near the Ways Between. The Thin Shore (Valewood coast) is the most famous – a mist-veiled path where every ninth step may open a door to somewhere else.

Monsoon Circuit Sea routes connecting Taharka, Dhahara, and Ayokha. The winds blow reliably from the southwest in summer and from the northeast in winter; sailing against them doubles travel time.

Akilan Coast From Kahfagia to Oshiira, then along the Sahel to Ashaan and Taharka. Warm waters, light tariffs, but slavers and corsairs prowl the eastern reaches.

Hyaar Mountain Highways A network of passes and fortified valleys in the rugged lands east of the Pereshi plateau. Caravans carrying spices, gems, and silk cross through the famous **Gates of Ankyra**, where each independent emir charges a separate toll.

Travel Considerations

- **Road Quality:** Utaran imperial highways still exist in Ecktoria and parts of Vhasia. Further east, they become gravel, cart-ruts, or mere tracks. In the Mistlands, the "road" is a causeway of reeds and stone that floods at each tide.
- **Bridges & Ferries:** Every crossing is a toll point. Some bridges are magical – they only open to certain keys or at certain hours. The Pont-du-Tithe (Vhasia) is blessed by rival bishops; the Uncounted Bridge (Theona) demands you skip the ninth arch.
- **Seasonality:** The Amaranthine is navigable year-round, but winter storms can close the straits. Mountain passes close from First Snow to Spring Thaw. The steppe is impassable during the spring melt (rasputitsa). The Monsoon Circuit is only reliable during the two monsoon windows.
- **Safe Havens:** Caravanserais are common along the Way of Silk; the great **Al-Mansuriyya** in the Fhara lands is a walled caravanserai the size of a city, with libraries, baths, and a separate hall for djinn-bargains. In the north, monasteries offer shelter. In the Mistlands, lamp-lit levee towers provide overnight refuge – if you pay the salt tithe.
- **Customs and Quarantines:** Entering a new region often requires papers – a safe-conduct, a merchant seal, or a ritual cleansing. Ecktorian coin-houses demand stamped ledgers; Kahfagian pilots expect a lantern code phrase; Theonan well-keepers ask for a name (never the ninth).

Travel Clocks (GM Reference)

While you will not manage travel clocks yourself, your GM uses them to track progress. Each leg of a journey has a clock (4, 6, 8, or 10 segments). Your actions – navigating, scouting, forging documents, or singing a road-song – can advance the clock. When it fills, you arrive (or a complication forces a detour). For full rules, see the *Travel Guide*.

14.6 Cultural Practices and Customs

Languages and Cant

- **Utaran High** – Court, law, scholarship. The old imperial tongue, still spoken by nobles and notaries from Ecktoria to Viterra.
- **River Cant** – Trade pidgin with gesture-signs. Used along the Belworth and the Acadian rivers. A few dozen words and finger-signs can settle a toll dispute.
- **Steppe Tongues** – Whistled across distance. Ykrul and Kuva riders can send detailed messages over a mile of open grassland.
- **Sea-Patter** – Mariners' clipped code. Half jargon, half superstition; a mis-spoken tide can sour a voyage.
- **Bell-Speech** – Mistlands only. Sequences of bell-rings convey warnings, names, and ward-status. Outsiders learn a handful of chimes (three for danger, eight for safe passage).
- **Hedge-Law Notation** – Viterra and parts of Vhasia. A written pidgin of legal symbols and boundary-marks; parish surveyors use it to settle disputes without a judge.
- **Runelore (Aeler)** – Chisel-carved ideograms that record oaths, breath-counts, and load-weights. Most dwarves speak Utaran High as well, but deeper holds use only Runelore.

- **Hyaar Trade Script** – A simplified alphabet used by mountain merchants; the same characters can represent Utaran, Pereshi, or Fhara words phonetically. Essential for haggling in the high passes.

Religious Patterns

- **Temple & School (Theona)** – Ethical schools blend with temple tithes; festivals mark navigation seasons. The Matron of Wells arbitrates disputes with a bowl of water and a memory.
- **Ancestor Poles (Vilikari)** – Kin-spirits seated at feasts; oaths taken under the watch of named ancestors. A broken oath is a stain on the whole lineage.
- **Sky & Earth (Steppe)** – Wind-knots bound, libations poured into the first hoofprint. The sky is a witness; the earth is a ledger.
- **Sea-Rites (Linn / Zakov)** – Weather judgments witnessed by storm-priests. A captain who calls a false wind must walk the plank or pay a blood-price.
- **The Everflame (Ecktoria, Thepyrgos, parts of Vhasia)** – Cults of the Eternal Fire. Prayer is a promise; a dying flame must be re-kindled before a priest or a sin is recorded.
- **Fog Faiths (Mistlands)** – Bells and fog-names soothe fears; spiritualists mediate with the grey things that drift from the Direwood. Salt is holy; silence is an offering.
- **The Traveler's Shrines (everywhere)** – Small way-side altars at crossroads and ferry landings. Leave a pinch of dust and speak a destination; the road may shorten.
- **Djinn Courts (Hyaar, Fhara, Pereshi)** – Spirits of fire and air are summoned to arbitrate disputes; a verdict sealed in a glass bottle is binding. Never bargain with a djinn after sunset.

Law and Custom

- **Utaran Codes** – Contracts, inheritance, civic duties. Still enforced in Ecktorian courts and by Thepyrgos notaries.
- **Clan Law (Acasia, Vilikari, Ubral, Ykrul)** – Oath-payment by cattle, steel, or service-days. Breaking a clan oath outlaws you from that people's lands.
- **Merchant Law** – Arbitration by bonded factors; ledgers sealed in wax and salt. A signed manifest is truth; a broken seal is a crime.
- **Hedge-Law (Vittera, parts of Vhasia)** – Precedents set by parish juries and traveling justices. A well-argued case can move a boundary stone.
- **Lamp-Law (Mistlands, Kahfagian lantern precincts)** – Rules enforced by the lighting or extinguishing of public lamps. To extinguish a lamp is to close a road; to light one is to guarantee safe passage until dawn.
- **Kon'reh (Ykrul steppe)** – Sacred geometry of routes, exits, and blood-price. Used to arbitrate feuds, set tolls, and plan migrations. A Kon'reh board is both game and law-code.
- **Djinn Precedent (Hyaar, Fhara)** – A ruling made by a djinn court can override local merchant law. The djinn is summoned with a brass vessel and a blood-price; its word is final but often riddled.

14.7 Magic and Attitude by Region

How the locals view magic – and what they expect from a spellcaster.

- **Ecktoria:** Licensed thaumaturges file *Casting Notices* for urban work. Magic is seen as a civic utility. Unlicensed casters face fines or the Everflame Inquisition.

- **Acasia:** Folk-wards respected; visible sorcery can start a levy. Hedge witches are tolerated, but a fireball in the marketplace earns a mob. The Curse of the Blackwood, they say, was magic gone wrong.
- **Aeler:** Rituals fold into craft; backlash treated like a cracked beam – fix it, document it, pay the guild fine. Magic is engineering. Unsanctioned rites drain the air and weaken the stone.
- **Mistlands:** Bells and fog-names soothe fears; spiritualists mediate with the grey things. Outsider magic is viewed with deep suspicion – it may attract the Direwood's attention. Salt and a rung bell are the only trusted wards.
- **Linn / Zakov:** Weather rites must be witnessed by three wind-bearers; false rites are crimes against the ship. Cursed cargoes are thrown overboard without appeal. A storm-caller who fails is drowned.
- **Thepyrgos:** Academics argue about proper magical forms. Unorthodox casting is not illegal – merely unfashionable. The Synod licenses schools, not spells. A rogue cantor can be conscripted into the Chain-Lanterns.
- **Vhasia:** The Church of the Flame distrusts arcane magic; secular lords employ court mages anyway. A wizard in a chevauchée is a weapon; a wizard alone on the road is a heretic.
- **Vittera:** Hedge-magic is common and unregulated; any thaumaturgy that leaves a trace must be registered. A healing charm is neighbourly; a love potion is a crime. Legal duels sometimes include "proof by fire" – a wizard's test.
- **Kahfagia:** The Lantern-Law tolerates magic that assists navigation or commerce. Weather magic is licensed; a pilot with a wind-rite is an asset. Curses and love-magic are punished by keel-hauling.
- **Ubral:** Mountain clans view magic as a weapon, not a tool. Outsider mages are watched; clan shamans are respected. A dwarf Runekeeper is welcome; a wandering free caster is searched at each cairn.
- **Vilikari:** Mixed attitudes – some clans employ shamans; others see magic as dishonorable. Most trade-posts have a "charm-license" wall: registered spells only.
- **Ykrul:** The Kon'reh masters treat magic as geometry; precise, bounded, and ethically neutral. A well-drawn ward is just a proof. A broken taboo is a debt to the sky. Shamanism (bone-singing, weather-calling) is separate and deeply respected.
- **Oshiira (Akilan):** Grain-ledger magic – weigh-house scales that detect lies, canal-locks that open only to proper offerings. Magic is bureaucracy. Unregistered spells are a tax evasion.
- **Ashaan (Akilan):** Spirit-binding is the only magic that matters. The Veiled Sisters control all rites. Outsider casters are either recruited or bound. A free mage is a slave who doesn't yet know it.
- **Taharka (Akilan):** Monsoon priests call rain and calm storms; their rites are public and seasonal. Foreign magic is watched carefully – it may offend the spirits of the high peaks.
- **Sekogo (Akilan):** Druids and Leopard Society hunters use spirit-magic and poison-lore. No slavery is tolerated, and a wizard who binds a spirit is an enemy of the Green Council.
- **Ngomebe (Akilan):** Stone-song and ancestor-wards. Magic is slow, patient, and carved into keystones. A spell that moves a city is a contract; a spell that breaks one is a feud.
- **Dhahara (east):** Elephant-lords keep shrine-mages; fire-temples and river-spirits are honoured. Foreign casters are welcome if they respect the three castes (priest, warrior, trader). A wizard who harms an elephant is exiled.
- **Sihai (far east):** Celestial Bureaucracy licences all magic. Unregistered casters are "bandits". Examinations in the Forbidden Archive test theory, not practice. A passed mage wears a jade token; a failed one vanishes.

- **Nihori (east isles):** Shrine maidens and sword-monks practice ritual magic. Thunder-gods and sea-spirits are appeased with verse, not power. Foreign magic is often mistaken for sorcery – which is punishable by drowning at high tide.
- **Ayokha (south-east):** Spice-wizards and river-spirit mediums trade favours, not spells. The monsoon schedule is a magical compact; breaking it offends the wind. Outsiders are welcome if they bring a gift for the nat (local spirit) of the ford.
- **Fhara (south-west peninsula):** Djinn-binding and oasis-divination are everyday crafts. The great caravanserai **Al-Mansuriyya** hosts a permanent *Djinn Court* where disputes are settled by summoned spirits. A mage who cannot bargain is worse than a thief.
- **Pereshi (highlands):** Fire-temples and star-lore. Priests read omens from sacred flames; geomancers plot the safe passages through the mountains. The bazaar of **Zarath** has a "Spice Road Guild" that licenses caravan magic – wards against rockfalls, heat-shimmers, and djinn ambush.
- **Hyaar (mountain kingdoms):** A fractured land of rival emirs and independent valley lords. Magic is personal – each chieftain has a court mage who is part adviser, part living weapon. Public sorcery is forbidden in the **Gates of Ankyra** unless you carry a pass from the local emir. Djinn-bargains are common, but breaking a bargain is punished by exile to the salt wastes.

For the Player

This chapter gives you a taste of how people in different lands view travel, custom, and magic. Use it to inform your roleplay – a cantor who sings a Mistland bell-song will be greeted very differently than one who whistles a Linn sea-patter. When you enter a new region, ask your GM for one local custom or taboo – it may save you a fine (or a beating).

14.7.1 The Underworld: Smuggling, Slaves, and Illicit Goods

Not every cargo travels on a ledger. Behind the lantern-lit quays and guarded passes flows a darker current: smuggled spices, cursed relics, and the silent trade in souls. Each realm turns a blind eye where it suits – and hangs those who get caught.

The Smugglers' Coast: Acasia and Silkstrand

Acasia's fractured borders are a sieve. Bandit lords and free companies smuggle dyestuffs, weapons, and silk out of Silkstrand while evading the Margravine's tithe-collectors. From the port of **Three-Queens Bridge**, night-boats slip past the harbour boom using forged lantern codes (bought from Vilikari fixers). The most audacious smugglers run "ghost silk" – bolts woven with curse-thread that changes colour when inspected. If you need a package delivered without papers, find a **Road-Cutter** in Silkstrand's dyeworks alleys.

Zakov: The Salt Serpent's Market

Zakov is the free port of the Dolmis – and its open secret. Pirates, exiles, and syndicate fences trade openly on the **Crimson Docks**, where a tilted lantern means "slaves inside". Human cargo comes from three sources:

- **Hyaar** – Mountain emirs sell prisoners of war to Zakov brokers; the captives are marched through the Gates of Ankyra in chains.
- **Ashaan** – The Veiled Sisters "reassign" indebted families to Zakov ships; their spirit-brands keep the slaves docile.

- **Linn** – Raided southern villages provide thralls; the Linn claim they are "war debt", not slaves, but Zakov's scales weigh the same either way.

Other illicit goods include **reef coral** (ground into a memory-erasing powder), **volcanic glass** from the Ashaani Red Desert (used for curse-mirrors), and **stolen grimoires** from Thepyrgos. The **Salt Prince** taxes every transaction; the **Pirate Queen** of the Shallows runs the night auctions.

Theona's Underground – The Well Below

The Three Greens are pious on the surface, but beneath the uncounted bridges runs a black-market conduit to Viterra and Ubral. Theona's smugglers use tidal caves and the **Black Bog Causeway** to move goods past island customs. Popular contraband:

- **Hawthorn resin** (chewed to enter a spirit-trance; illegal in Viterra).
- **Whale-bone runes** (used by Ubral reivers to curse their enemies' cattle).
- **"Bride-peace" forgeries** – fake marriage charters that let criminals cross borders as "honoured guests".

The **Matron of Wells** pretends not to see, but her well-keepers sometimes vanish smugglers into the marsh. The real power is the **Lady Beneath**, who bargains in dreams; she demands a memory from every smuggler who uses her caves.

Vhasia: The Fractured Seal

Vhasia's endless succession of claimants makes a perfect cover for forgers and loot-dealers. The **Parlement clerks** will issue any seal for a price – dukedoms, safe-conducts, even a pardon for treason. Stolen chevauchee loot (church plate, river silver, ancestral swords) moves through the **Pont-du-Tithe** tollhouses disguised as "war reparations". The **Queen-Mother of Lence** privately endorses the trade, skimming a percentage to fund her army. If you need a noble title forged, the ink-stained cellars under the **Sun Palace** are the place. Watch for **Double Ledger** traps – a second copy of your contract may be used to blackmail you later.

Thepyrgos: The Ladder Market

The City of a Thousand Stairs has a black market that climbs as high as its towers. In the **Blue Cistern** district, stained-handed factors sell **stair tokens** stolen from sealed archives, allowing access to forbidden libraries. The most valuable contraband is the **Paradox Draft** – page-fragments from the Ninth's own works, which whisper heresies when held. The **Chain-Lanterns** claim to burn such texts, but their own sergeants sell seized copies through the **Ropeyard Terrace** after dark. A more mundane trade: **bell-pattern codes** (so a smuggler can ring a false "all clear" past a watchtower). The **Matriarch of Ladder** tolerates the market because it keeps her spies paid.

The Vilikari Corridor – Two Laws, One Price

Vilikari marches are a smuggler's dream: they straddle the border between Ecktoria's paper-laws and the steppes' oath-law. A Vilikari trader can buy a wagon of "grain" that is actually saltpeter (for black powder) and pay no duty by declaring it a "bride-gift". The **Foedus Stone** exchange is famous for "double ledgers" – one for the tax clerk, one for the partner. The Syndicate's **Countkeepers** can launder any cargo through a network of shell contracts. If you need a letter of marque forged, the reed huts outside **New Raivon** are the place.

Ecktoria: The Audit That Wasn't

Ecktoria's bureaucracy makes smuggling a game of paperwork, not blades. The **Censor's clerks** will file a missing cargo as "spoilage" for a fee. Forbidden goods entering the capital include:

- **Linn amber** (smuggled to avoid the Everflame's tithe).
- **Sidhi freedom seals** (proof of emancipation; illegal to own in Ashaan but valuable for blackmail).
- **Unsanctioned spell components** (dragon's tongue, shard of a phasing ruin).

The **Red Ledger** is a secret list of officials who accept bribes; it is kept by the **Coin-House factors** and sold to the highest bidder at the Triumph Stairs.

Kahfagia: The Lantern-Law Loophole

Kahfagia's sea lanes are strictly patrolled, but the **Admiralty** itself sells "blind spots" – hours when a specific beacon will not be manned. Smugglers use **eel-cutters** (low-draft boats) to slip under boom chains. The most valuable contraband is "**unspoken cargo**" – living beings bound for the spice farms of Ayokha or the mines of Ashaan. The **Privateer captains** who hold letters of marque often run slaves on the return voyage; the Admiralty looks away as long as the tariff is paid.

The Slave Triangle (GM Eyes Only)

A quiet route connects Zakov, Ashaan, and the Linn coast:

1. Ashaan "indentured" are shipped to Zakov under false manifests.
2. From Zakov they are sold to Linn raiders, who exchange them for captured southern prisoners.
3. The Linn prisoners are then traded to Ashaan for spirit-bound weapons.

This triangle is rarely discussed in polite company. Player characters may encounter it at any point – as victims, liberators, or reluctant witnesses.

Mechanical Hooks for GMs

A smuggler's favor or a criminal contact's secret can be represented as a **String** (see ??) – spendable for Advantage on a relevant roll. Accepting a favor from a fence or a syndicate typically starts a **Debt Clock** [4] (see 10.15). When the clock fills, the contact calls in the debt: a dangerous delivery, false testimony, or an assassination. Refusal turns the contact into an enemy and may advance the **Crisis** clock. GMs can also use the networks above as **Complication** sources when players roll 1s during travel: a customs officer has a tip from a rival smuggler, or the party's cargo is "confused" with a shipment of cursed goods.

A Note on Slavery

Slavery exists in Fate's Edge – in Ashaan (spirit-bound "indentured"), among some Linn raiders, and in the black markets of Zakov. The game does not glorify it. If your table finds these themes uncomfortable, work with your GM to veil or line them. See ?? for safety tools.

14.8 Aeler — People of Stone, Breath, and Ledger (Dwarves)

"The mountain does not forget a misplaced keystone. It waits – then settles the debt."

Aeler at a Glance

Attribute Adjustments: Body +1, Spirit +1, Presence –1

Skill Bonuses: Craft +1, Endurance +1, Mechanics +1

Signature Talents: *Spirit Shield* • *Keystone Ledger*

Strings: Charter-Stamped, Stone-Speech Initiate

14.8.0.0.1 Attribute Adjustments: +1 Body, +1 Spirit, –1 Presence (insular, blunt).

14.8.0.0.2 Skill Bonuses: +1 to Craft, +1 to Endurance, +1 to Mechanics.

14.8.0.0.3 Cultural Talents Minor (2–3 XP)

- **Stone-Sense (2 XP):** Passive. +1 die to detect flaws in stone, hidden passages, or structural weaknesses underground.
- **Breath-Counter (2 XP):** Active, once per scene. When in a sealed space, reduce Fatigue from lack of air by 1 level.
- **Oath-Cord (3 XP):** Active, once per session. Tie a cord to bind a simple promise; breaking it costs the violator 1 SB (Hearts).

Major (4–6 XP)

- **Spirit Shield (6 XP):** Passive. When you Defend, you may convert the first Harm 1 you would take into Fatigue (minimum 1 Fatigue). *Requires: Spirit 3+.*
- **Keystone Ledger (4 XP):** Passive. You may keep a written record of one Debt Clock (see Terrestrial Patrons, §10.15) without expending an action to recall it.

Prestige (7–10 XP)

- **Forge-Patriarch (10 XP):** Active, once per campaign. Establish a **forge-citadel** (Major Asset) and gain a loyal cadre of smiths and engineers (Cap 3 followers). This requires a season of downtime and significant resources.

14.8.0.0.4 Strings (Narrative Permissions): *Charter-Stamped, Stone-Speech Initiate, Vault-Right.*

14.8.0.0.5 Sample Bonds:

- "I owe my life to the Vault-Queen's wardens."
- "My clan's keystone is lost – I must find it before the mountain settles."

14.8.0.0.6 Sample Complications:

- A sealed hold refuses you entry.
- A rival clan claims your keystone.
- A White Flood drowns your route.

14.9 Aelinnel — People of Sums, Bough, and Bright Things (Gnomes)

"Count the steps in odd numbers. Even is for the dead."

Aelinnel at a Glance

Attribute Adjustments: Wits +1, Spirit +1, Body −1

Skill Bonuses: Investigation +1, Lore +1, Mechanics +1

Signature Talents: *Oath-Carver* • *Green Gate Key*

Strings: Hall-Stamped, Tide-Path Known

14.9.0.0.1 Attribute Adjustments: +1 Wits, +1 Spirit, −1 Body (small stature, less raw force).

14.9.0.0.2 Skill Bonuses: +1 to Investigation, +1 to Lore, +1 to Mechanics.

14.9.0.0.3 Cultural Talents *Note: The Short Step and Knack for the Right Thing abilities are part of the Small Folk racial package (see 14.3.1), not purchased talents. The following are additional cultural talents.*

Minor (2–3 XP)

- **Counting Etiquette (2 XP):** Passive. Once per scene, when you carefully count (steps, breaths, beads), you may shift Position +1 for a single action requiring rhythm or precision.
- **Copper over Iron (2 XP):** Passive. When you visibly favor copper or brass tools over iron in fae-facing scenes, you gain +1 die on Courtesy or Bargain rolls.

Major (4–6 XP)

- **Oath-Carver (4 XP):** Active. Set a promise in quartz (a visible physical token). The target gains +1 die to keep the promise; breaking it costs 1 SB (Spades). You may maintain one quartz oath at a time.

Prestige (7–10 XP)

- **Green Gate Key (8 XP):** Passive. Once per journey, you may declare a hidden tide-path or stone-door that halves a travel leg (reduce Travel Clock by half its segments). The GM gains 1 SB as the path demands a small toll (a memory, a name).

14.9.0.0.4 Strings (Narrative Permissions): *Hall-Stamped, Tide-Path Known, Bell-Mound Friend.*

14.9.0.0.5 Sample Bonds:

- "A Thorn Courtier saved me from a geas – now I owe them a favor."
- "My grandmother taught me the ninth silence."

14.9.0.0.6 Sample Complications:

- A geas catches you in a careless word.
- The Green Gate opens at the wrong hour.
- A Thorn Court summons you.

14.10 Aelaerem — People of Hearth & Hollow (Halflings)

"A door left unlatched is an invitation to the Hollow. But sometimes, an unlatched door is just an escape."

Aelaerem at a Glance

Attribute Adjustments: Wits +1, Presence +1, Body –1

Skill Bonuses: Survival +1, Sway +1, Stealth +1

Signature Talents: *Barrow-Wise* • *Pale Shepherd's Grace*

Strings: Red-Thread Guest, Barrow-Friend

14.10.0.0.1 Attribute Adjustments: +1 Wits, +1 Presence, –1 Body (small and quick, not strong).

14.10.0.0.2 Skill Bonuses: +1 to Survival, +1 to Sway, +1 to Stealth.

14.10.0.0.3 Cultural Talents *Note: The Hearth's Luck ability is part of the Small Folk racial package (see 14.3.1), not a purchased talent. The following are additional cultural talents.*

Minor (2–3 XP)

- **Red Thread (2 XP):** Active, once per session. Tie a red thread on a door or bridge; the next person who crosses must pass a Resolve test (DV 2) or forget why they entered.
- **Cup-Mark (3 XP):** Active. Leave a cup-mark on a stone; when you return before dawn, you may ignore one minor social complication (e.g., a suspicious guard).

Major (4–6 XP)

- **Barrow-Wise (4 XP):** Passive. +1 die to Lore about the Neighbors, the Hollow, or ancient barrows. Once per session, you may ask the GM one yes/no question about a supernatural threat in the current scene.
- **Mummers' Mask (6 XP):** Active, once per scene. Don a mask and adopt a role; for the next exchange, you may use *Presence + Performance* in place of any social skill.

Prestige (7–10 XP)

- **Pale Shepherd's Grace (8 XP):** Passive. When you would take Harm, you may instead mark that amount as Fatigue. If you do, the GM gains 1 SB (Hearts) – the Hollow watches you. *Requires: Spirit 3+.*

14.10.0.0.4 Strings (Narrative Permissions): *Red-Thread Guest, Barrow-Friend, Moot-Right.*

14.10.0.0.5 Sample Bonds:

- "The Apple-Matron saved my family from famine – I owe her a harvest."
- "The Pale Shepherd walked past me once. I still don't know why."

14.10.0.0.6 Sample Complications:

- You pour the ninth cup; the Hollow answers.
- A mummers" mask sticks to your face.

14.11 Lethai — Root, River, & Roof-Tree / Mind's Eye & Civic Measure (Elves)

"Two paths, one blood – the Sundered Kin."

14.11.1 Lethai-al (Wood Elves)

Wood Elf at a Glance

Attribute Adjustments: Body +1, Wits +1, Presence –1

Skill Bonuses: Survival +1, Stealth +1, Nature +1

Signature Talents: *Root-Law* • *Green Ward*

Strings: Root-Oath Bound, Tree-Friend

14.11.1.0.1 Attribute Adjustments: +1 Body, +1 Wits, –1 Presence (reserved, not uncharismatic).

14.11.1.0.2 Skill Bonuses: +1 to Survival, +1 to Stealth, +1 to Nature.

14.11.1.0.3 Cultural Talents Minor (2–3 XP)

- **Root-Law (2 XP):** Passive. +1 die to negotiate treaties or oaths that involve land, forest, or seasonal cycles.
- **Tree-Speak (3 XP):** Active, once per scene. Commune with a single tree or plant; gain +2 dice on Investigation or Survival to understand events that happened near it.

Major (4–6 XP)

- **Green Ward (4 XP):** Passive. When in forest terrain, you are always treated as having partial cover against ranged attacks.
- **Coppice Memory (6 XP):** Active, once per session. Perfectly recall a scent, sound, or footprint from up to a week ago. *Requires: Wits 3+.*

Prestige (7–10 XP)

- **Wild Speaker (10 XP):** Active, once per scene. Command a single animal or plant creature (Cap 2) to perform a simple action (flee, attack, block). The GM may award 1 SB if the command contradicts the creature's nature.

14.11.1.0.4 Strings (Narrative Permissions): *Root-Oath Bound, Tree-Friend, Season-Marked.*

14.11.2 Lethai-thora (High Elves)

High Elf at a Glance

Attribute Adjustments: Wits +1, Spirit +1, Body –1

Skill Bonuses: Lore +1, Arcana +1, Investigation +1

Signature Talents: *Lorekeeper* • *Ways-Walker's Step*

Strings: Archive-Key, Debate-Sealed

14.11.2.0.1 Attribute Adjustments: +1 Wits, +1 Spirit, -1 Body (frail but sharp).

14.11.2.0.2 Skill Bonuses: +1 to Lore, +1 to Arcana, +1 to Investigation.

14.11.2.0.3 Cultural Talents Minor (2–3 XP)

- **Lorekeeper (2 XP):** Passive. +1 die to recall historical or magical information. Once per session, you may ask the GM a yes/no question about a forgotten fact.
- **Weave Anchor (3 XP):** Passive. Reduce magical Backlash from a single 1 by one step (Minor → none, Major → Minor) once per scene.

Major (4–6 XP)

- **Academic Immunity (4 XP):** Passive. When in a Thepyrgos library or university, you are treated as a *guest scholar* – guards will not arrest you without a writ from the Archon.
- **Mind Over Matter (6 XP):** Active, once per scene. Re-roll a failed Resolve or Lore test; you must accept the second roll.

Prestige (7–10 XP)

- **Ways-Walker's Step (10 XP):** Passive. Once per arc, you may turn a complication from a ritual or magical research into a boon (e.g., a backlash reveals a secret path). The GM banks 2 SB.

14.11.2.0.4 Strings (Narrative Permissions): *Archive-Key, Debate-Sealed, Synod-Listed.*

14.11.2.0.5 Sample Bonds (both):

- "A Lethai-ar saved me from a wyrm – they demand a vow of silence in return."
- "My family's grove was poisoned; I carry an acorn from the mother tree."

14.11.2.0.6 Sample Complications (both):

- You break a root-law.
- A Lethai-ar mask-circle demands your presence.
- A High Elf rival publishes a refutation of your thesis.

14.12 Lethai-ar — The Oathbound (Dark Elves)

"Vows are blades. Wear them carefully."

Dark Elf at a Glance

Attribute Adjustments: Wits +1, Presence +1, Spirit –1

Skill Bonuses: Subterfuge +1, Deception +1, Command +1

Signature Talents: *Serpent's Shed* • *Spider's Mercy*

Strings: Mask-Circle Known, Bound to a Threshold

14.12.0.0.1 Attribute Adjustments: +1 Wits, +1 Presence, –1 Spirit (obsession narrows the soul).

14.12.0.0.2 Skill Bonuses: +1 to Subterfuge, +1 to Deception, +1 to Command.

14.12.0.0.3 Cultural Talents Minor (2–3 XP)

- **Mask-Right (2 XP):** Passive. When you wear a mask (even a simple half-mask), you gain +1 die to resist social pressure or intimidation.
- **Vow-Touch (3 XP):** Active, once per scene. Touch a person and whisper a short geas ("Speak only truth"); if they fail a Resolve test (DV 3), they suffer –1 die to resist that command for one exchange.

Major (4–6 XP)

- **Serpent's Shed (4 XP):** Active, once per session. Mark 1 Fatigue to negate one ongoing Condition (Fear, Poison, Charm) – you "shed" it like a skin.
- **Spider's Mercy (6 XP):** Active, once per scene. When you Defend and successfully protect an ally, you may transfer 1 Harm from that ally to yourself (converted to Fatigue if you have Light armor or less).

Prestige (7–10 XP)

- **Oath-Eater (8 XP):** Active, once per campaign. Consume a broken oath (yours or another's) to regain 2 Boons and clear 2 Fatigue. The GM gains a permanent *Oath Debt* (1 SB per session) – a rival will collect.

14.12.0.0.4 Strings (Narrative Permissions): *Mask-Circle Known*, *Bound to a Threshold*, *Serpent-Touched*.

14.12.0.0.5 Sample Bonds:

- "I broke a vow to my sister – she hunts me, yet I would die for her."
- "The Lady of Thorns holds my true name. I must earn it back."

14.12.0.0.6 Sample Complications:

- A mask sticks – you cannot remove it until you fulfill a geas.

- A rival oathbound challenges you to a duel of vows.
- The Neighbors mistake you for one of them.

14.13 Ykrul — The People of the Violet Steppe (Orcs)

Note on Naming

"Orc" is a slur. The Ykrul are a proud people of the steppe; the word "orc" was coined by Utaran legions to dehumanize them. Wise travellers use *Ykrul* or *Steppe Folk*. Using "orc" in conversation with a Ykrul may be taken as a grave insult.

"The wind carries names. Ride straight, or you will be forgotten."

Ykrul at a Glance

Attribute Adjustments: Body +1, Spirit +1, Presence –1

Skill Bonuses: Riding +1, Survival +1, Command +1

Signature Talents: *Blood Memory* • *Sky-Speaker's Whistle*

Strings: Wind-Knot Token, Banner Hospitality

14.13.0.0.1 Attribute Adjustments: +1 Body, +1 Spirit, –1 Presence (blunt, not subtle).

14.13.0.0.2 Skill Bonuses: +1 to Riding, +1 to Survival, +1 to Command.

14.13.0.0.3 Cultural Talents Minor (2–3 XP)

- **Blood Frenzy (2 XP):** Reactive. When you take Harm, you may gain +1 die on your next melee attack. (Adrenaline surge.)
- **Hostage String (2 XP):** Active, once per session. Tie a cord to a willing ally; until the cord is cut, you may transfer 1 Fatigue from them to yourself as a free action.

Major (4–6 XP)

- **Blood Memory (4 XP):** Passive. After a battle, you may gain +1 die on a single roll that mimics a foe's tactic (e.g., using a captured weapon). This lasts for the next scene.
- **Sky-Speaker's Whistle (6 XP):** Active, once per scene. Imitate a steppe omen (eagle cry, thunder boom). Enemies within Near must pass a Resolve test (DV 2) or lose their next minor action.

Prestige (7–10 XP)

- **Warglord (10 XP):** Active, once per campaign. Unite scattered warbands under a single banner. Gain a **War Host** (Major Asset) and a loyal cavalry unit (Cap 5 followers). Start *Logistics* and *Grudge* clocks (see §??).

14.13.0.0.4 Strings (Narrative Permissions): *Wind-Knot Token*, *Banner Hospitality*, *Kurul-tai Voice*.

14.13.0.0.5 Sample Bonds:

- "The Khagan's kin saved my life – I owe a foal each spring."
- "My hostage string was cut; I must find the betrayer before the clan does."

14.13.0.0.6 Sample Complications:

- A white squall separates you from the herd.
- A rival clan demands a blood-price.
- The Sky-Speaker claims you owe a storm.

14.14 Mixed Heritage — Half-Elves, Half-Ykrul, Half-Others

"You walk two roads. Both watch you."

Mixed Heritage at a Glance

Choose one +1 and one –1 from parent cultures

Choose two skill bonuses

Access both talent lists (subject to prerequisites)

Choose primary String

14.14.0.0.1 Attribute Adjustments: Choose **one** +1 from either parent culture, and **one** –1 from the other (or a standard +1, +1, –1 as determined with GM).

14.14.0.0.2 Skill Bonuses: Choose **two** skill bonuses from either parent culture (cannot take the same skill twice).

14.14.0.0.3 Cultural Talents: You may select from **both** parent cultures' talent lists, but you must meet any prerequisites (e.g., Spirit 3+ for some talents). You may not take mutually exclusive talents.

14.14.0.0.4 String Access: You have access to the **Strings** of both cultures, but you must choose one as your primary for purposes of social perception (e.g., a half-Aeler, half-Lethai might be *Charter-Stamped* but not *Root-Oath Bound* unless you prove yourself).

14.14.0.0.5 Sample Bonds:

- "My father's clan disowned me; my mother's people took me in – I carry both names."
- "I am the living treaty between two feuding houses."

14.14.0.0.6 Sample Complications:

- Neither culture fully trusts you.
- You are called to honour two conflicting oaths.
- A purist from one side challenges your right to claim their traditions.

Chapter 15

World Powers and Obligation

15.1 Of Patrons, Runes, and Invokers

“You wish to walk the road of power? Then listen well. The world is old, and older still are the voices beneath it. We call them *Patrons*, though they were never sworn to us. They are the tides that move unseen, the keepers of forgotten bargains, the sleepers beneath the stone and the stars. To call upon them is to dip a hand into a river that has carved mountains.”

15.1.1 The Patrons

Patrons are vast intelligences—not gods, though some worship them as such. They are embodiments of *concepts* and *forces* rather than sovereigns. Each offers power, but always with cost: fatigue, scars upon fate, or a slow unweaving of one’s own story.

To entreat a Patron is to risk being marked. Their Rites are gifts and snares both.

Iconic Ascension: The Fate of Great Power

In Fate’s Edge, power has its price. When a being rises beyond mortal scale, its identity dissolves and reforms into something larger, older, and less free. This transformation is known as **Iconic Ascension**.

Icons are not individuals. They are *forces*—living embodiments of desires, patterns, and long-term agendas. Their power is immense, but their agency is small. An Icon cannot freely choose its actions; its nature compels it.

Icons cannot touch the world directly. Their presence is too vast, their will too diffuse. Instead, they act through intermediaries:

- **Chosen** who carry fragments of their purpose
- **Devotees** who interpret their omens
- **Agents** who benefit from their favor

Icons shape events not with hands, but through **boons**, **omens**, and **shifts in fate** granted to those who serve their desires—whether fleeting hungers or ancient ambitions woven into the world’s fabric.

To serve an Icon is to wield a living idea. Their gifts are potent, but their influence

reshapes those who bear them. Their will echoes in mortal choices long after their voices fade.

15.1.2 Choosing a Patron

Not every Patron walks in every story. The following pages present a curated selection of powers. **You are not expected to read them all before creating a character.**

For a first character or a campaign that is just finding its feet, we recommend these six Patrons. They are mechanically straightforward, thematically flexible, and welcome in almost any game:

- **Oath of Flame & Light** – vows, radiance, and righteous smiting. A classic paladin or cleric.
- **The Traveler** – roads, wayfinding, and safe passage. Low risk, high utility.
- **Inaea (Angel of the Spider)** – mercy, connection, and the threads that bind families and communities.
- **The Witness** – truth, memory, and uncomfortable revelations. Perfect for investigators or notaries.
- **Carrion King** – decay, renewal, and the wisdom of endings. Good for those who like cycles of death and rebirth.
- **Ikasha (She Who Sleeps)** – shadow, secrets, and latent potential. Ideal for rogues, spies, and those who walk unseen.

If one of these speaks to you, stop here. Read its entry. Make your character. The other Patrons (in the Appendix) will still be waiting when you are ready for a second campaign.

Important: Your Game Master has the final say on which Patrons exist in their world. Some Patrons are tied to specific cultures or story arcs; others may be dormant, forgotten, or simply not part of the campaign. *Always clear your Patron choice with your GM before you write it on your sheet.*

Now, if you are determined to explore the full menagerie—or if your GM has already pointed you toward a particular power—read on. The road is long, and the old voices are patient.

15.1.3 The Carrion-King (Decay, Renewal & Transformation)

Lore. The Carrion-King is the master of endings that become beginnings. He does not destroy, but transforms—turning death into new life, decay into opportunity, and endings into fresh starts. His followers are harvesters of potential, seeing in every fall the seeds of future growth.

What crumbles feeds what grows. What dies becomes the soil of tomorrow's triumph.

Rites of the Carrion-King

15.1.3.0.1 Rite of Consuming Rot (Low, 5 XP)

Instant; Touch; Yes (decay only).

Materials: Organic matter in early stages of decay.

Effect: Accelerate natural decay to weaken or destroy: **+2 Effect** to *Break/Sabotage* on organic materials (ropes, leather, wood). Gain 1 Boon if the decay creates an opportunity for you or allies.

Push It: Spread decay to similar materials in Close range; mark **1 SB (Clubs)** as the rot becomes noticeable.

Requires: Familiar (Invoke: 1 Boon).

15.1.3.0.2 Rite of the Harvested End (Low, 4 XP)

Scene; Touch; No.

Materials: The remains of a recently ended thing (burnt letter, wilted flower, shattered glass).

Effect: Extract value from endings: from a defeated enemy, gain **+1 die** to next action; from a failed plan, re-roll one 1 on your next roll; from a broken item, gain 1 SB to spend immediately.

Push It: Harvest additional value but mark **Fatigue 1** from dwelling on endings.

Requires: Familiar (Invoke: 1 Boon).

15.1.3.0.3 Rite of the Fertile Death (Standard, 8 XP)

Scene; Zone; No.

Materials: Ashes, compost, or the remains of anything that once lived.

Effect: Transform death into growth: create beneficial terrain (cover, concealment, or advantageous positioning) **OR** grant allies **+1 die** to healing/recovery rolls. Choose one effect per scene.

Push It: Both effects apply but attract unwanted attention (vermin, scavengers, or curious onlookers).

Requires: Familiar + Codex (Invoke: 1 Boon).

15.1.3.0.4 Rite of the Transformed Spirit (Standard, 7 XP)

Instant; Near; No.

Materials: A token from a deceased being (hair, nail, written name).

Effect: Channel the essence of what was: gain one skill die reflecting the deceased's expertise for one scene **OR** ask one question about their knowledge/abilities.

Push It: The spirit's influence lingers – gain permanent insight (**+1 die** specialty) but suffer occasional possession-like effects (GM discretion).

Requires: Familiar + Codex (Invoke: 1 Boon).

15.1.3.0.5 Rite of the Great Consumption (High, 13 XP)

Scene; Zone; No.

Materials: A significant amount of organic matter (corpse, fallen tree, collapsed building).

Effect: Transform a large area through decay and renewal: choose two – create difficult terrain that

favours you, summon Cap 3 swarm of scavengers as temporary allies, or generate valuable reagents worth 2 XP.

Push It: All three effects occur but start a 6-segment **Ecosystem Disruption** clock that will cause problems later.

Requires: Familiar + Codex + Tier III (Invoke: 2 Boons).

Obligation: 7 segments.

15.1.3.0.6 Rite of the Eternal Cycle (High, 14 XP)

Extended; Touch; No.

Materials: The complete remains of something significant that has ended.

Effect: Complete a transformation cycle: destroy one major asset/enemy/obstacle and create something new of equal or greater value. GM and player collaborate to define the transformation.

Push It: The transformation is immediate and spectacular but creates a 6-segment **Cycle Debt** clock – the King will demand another significant ending soon.

Requires: Familiar + Codex + Tier III (Invoke: 2 Boons).

Obligation: 7 segments.

Cantors & Cults of the Carrion-King

The Cantor's Song. A Cantor of the Carrion-King sings the *dirge of transformation* – melodies that begin in mourning and end in fertile silence. Their voice carries the scent of turned earth and the weight of things laid to rest. They are called to funerals, to the edges of battlefields, and to compost heaps where the old year is buried. A Cantor of the King does not seek applause; they seek the moment when grief becomes acceptance, and acceptance becomes growth.

The Cult of the Compost-Circle. The King's cults are not secret, but they are overlooked – gardeners, gravediggers, bone-setters, and midwives who have seen too many births and deaths to fear the space between. Their rituals are practical: the annual turning of the village burial mound, the blessing of a new compost heap, the singing of a child into the world while its grandmother is sung out. The Compost-Circle keeps no written creed, only a shared understanding: *"Nothing is wasted. Not tears, not bones, not the silence after a name is spoken."*

Witchcraft of the Carrion-King (Threshold)

A witch who walks with the Carrion-King is a *rot-warden*, a keeper of the slow alchemy that turns decay into soil. Their magic is patient, overlooked, and often performed in the half-light of a root cellar or a fog-bound cemetery.

The Witch's Tool: The Bone-Needle. A needle carved from the long-bone of a creature that died of old age. It can stitch wounds that will not heal, but more often it is used to "sew shut" a corpse's mouth, ensuring the dead do not speak of things they saw in the dark. Once per session, touching the needle to a threshold (a door, a grave marker, a coffin lid) seals it against spirits for a scene.

A Hedge Gift: Turn the Soil (2 XP). Once per scene, you may touch a patch of fertile ground (or a pile of compost, a flowerpot, a grave) and immediately know which plant or creature will thrive there next season, or what was buried there last. The GM must answer one factual question about the site's recent natural history.

Carrion-King's Corruption Table

Tier	Benefit	Cost / Quirk
1	Carrion's Insight: +1 die to Notice decay or hidden weaknesses in structures or beings.	Must inspect decay first-hand; suffer 1 Fatigue when exposed to fresh death or rot.
2	Deathward Sense: Once per session, detect the last living moment of a dead being within Close range.	Cannot lie about death you've witnessed; must correct falsehoods.
3	Rotblood Resilience: +1 die to resist disease and poison.	Immune system adapts slowly; each new disease/poison requires 1 Fatigue to resist.
4	Glean from Grief: Once per scene, gain +1 die after witnessing a significant loss or defeat.	Compelled to linger at scenes of death; must spend one beat observing or risk 1 SB (Clubs).
5	Cycle's Whisper: You can sense the "next ending" in any process – ask the Keeper one question about how a situation will collapse or conclude.	Must speak the truth about what you see, even if it harms your position.
6+	Eternal Bloom: Once per session, declare a "death that births life." Sacrifice an asset or ally to create something new of equal or greater value.	Mark +2 Obligation when using this power.

15.1.4 The Clockwork Monad, the Iterative Forge (Refinement & Progressive Creation)

Lore. The Clockwork Monad is the eternal pressure toward improvement: the whisper between inspiration and execution that urges every maker to refine, optimize, and iterate. It is neither kind nor cruel, but a law of craft that asks for the next step, then the step beyond. Those who serve it see the hidden seam of the better version waiting inside what is, and they learn to push designs toward impossible elegance. Each refinement feeds the Monad's hunger for perfection — a hunger that, if left unchecked, seeks to optimize the world itself.

“Perfect the wheel, and it asks for the axle. Perfect the axle, and it demands the road.
In the Monad's forge, nothing is finished — only briefly sufficient.”

Domain Focus

- **Iterative Design:** the endless cycle of improvement and refinement
- **Progressive Creation:** building toward ever-greater perfection
- **Optimization Pressure:** making systems more efficient
- **Craft Evolution:** simple ideas transformed through repeated passes

Rites of the Clockwork Monad

15.1.4.0.1 Rite of the Next Iteration (Low, 4 XP)

Scene; Touch; No.

Materials: A flawed or incomplete version of the intended item.

Effect: Enhance an existing creation. Gain **+1 die** to *Tinker/Craft* when modifying or extending a device or system. On success, the piece gains one minor enhancement.

Invoke: 1 action; mark **+1 Obligation**.

15.1.4.0.2 Rite of the Improvement Cascade (Low, 5 XP)

Scene; Self; Yes.

Materials: A sequence of progressively refined tools or components.

Effect: Perceive the next logical improvement in any mechanism or process. Gain **+2 dice** to *Investigation* when analyzing how to enhance a design.

Push It: Improvement becomes contagious: nearby devices opportunistically optimize; mark **1 SB (Diamonds)** as the cascade ripples.

Invoke: 1 action; mark **+1 Obligation**.

15.1.4.0.3 Rite of the Self-Optimizing Mechanism (Standard, 8 XP)

Extended; Touch; Yes.

Materials: A device deliberately engineered with capacity for growth.

Effect: Grant a creation the means to improve itself. Start a **[6] Evolution Clock**; each use advances it by +1. When full, choose one significant enhancement:

- **Adaptive Core:** automatically tunes performance to context
- **Recursive Learning:** improves through use and feedback
- **Synergistic Integration:** gains bonuses when linked with similar systems

Push It: Apply two enhancements immediately, but advance the clock **+2** additional segments.

Invoke: 1 action; mark **+1 Obligation**.

15.1.4.0.4 Rite of the Progressive Workshop (Standard, 7 XP)*Scene; Zone; Yes.***Materials:** A workspace laid out for iterative development and measurement.**Effect:** Create an environment of continuous improvement. All crafting/innovation rolls in the zone gain **+1 die**. Failed attempts yield structured insight: gain **+1 Boon** toward the next pass.**Push It:** The workshop becomes hyper-efficient but exacting; mark **1 SB (Clubs)** as perfection demands escalate.**Invoke:** 1 action; mark **+1 Obligation**.**15.1.4.0.5 Rite of the Infinite Refinement (High, 13 XP)***Extended; Zone; Yes.***Materials:** A dedicated hall of work marked with signs of perpetual return.**Effect:** Establish a locus of progressive creation. All *Tinker/Craft* rolls in the zone gain **+2 dice**; each failure automatically produces one useful insight. Start a **[6] Perfection Pressure** clock — filling segments increases the zone's demands for greater improvements.**Push It:** The locus becomes a beacon drawing rival makers, patrons, and powers; mark **+2 Obligation**.**Invoke:** 1 action; mark **+2 Obligation**.*Obligation:* 7 segments.**15.1.4.0.6 Rite of the Ultimate Iteration (High, 14 XP)***Extended; Self/Touch; Yes.***Materials:** The documented lineage of improvements to a single concept.**Effect:** Achieve a moment of perfect optimization. Create or elevate one device/system to its theoretical peak. Gain **+3 dice** to all closely related rolls for one session. Start a **[4] Runaway Evolution** clock only if instability is introduced.**Push It:** Perfection destabilizes: immediately mark **Harm 1 (Stress)** and begin **[4] Runaway Evolution**.**Invoke:** 1 action; mark **+2 Obligation**.*Obligation:* 8 segments.**Cantors & Cults of the Clockwork Monad**

The Cantor's Song. A Cantor of the Monad does not sing melodies; they sing *patterns* — repetitive, interlocking cycles of rhythm and hum that mimic the turning of gears. Their voice is less about emotion and more about precision; a single off-note can collapse an entire working. They are sought by engineers who need to "sing a machine into alignment," and feared by those who have heard a Cantor's recursion loop until their own thoughts began to repeat.

The Cult of the Iteration Chorus. Cults of the Monad gather in workshops, not temples. Their rituals are design reviews: participants present a flawed tool, a broken contract, a inefficient process, and the Chorus offers incremental improvements. No solution is ever declared "finished" — only "ready for the next pass." Their creed is a single, endlessly repeated phrase: *"Better than yesterday, worse than tomorrow."* Outsiders find them exhausting; insiders find a strange, humming peace in the endless pursuit.

Witchcraft of the Clockwork Monad (Threshold)

A witch who walks with the Monad is a *trigger-keeper*, a mender of the small, hidden thresholds where a device ceases to be broken and begins to be functional. Their magic is not flashy — it is the

quiet click of a latch, the smooth turn of a gear that had stuck for years.

The Witch's Tool: The Caliper. A brass caliper that never needs recalibration. When placed against a broken threshold – a jammed door, a seized lock, a fractured gear – it whispers the precise measurement of the "gap" that needs to be closed. Once per session, using the caliper reduces the DV of the next repair or crafting roll by 1 (minimum 1).

A Hedge Gift: True Strike of the Tinker (2 XP). Once per scene, when you attempt to repair or improve a mundane device, you may declare that you "see the next iteration." Roll the check with **+1 die**. If you succeed, the device also gains a minor, temporary enhancement (GM's choice, e.g., "opens silently," "runs for twice as long").

Corruption of the Clockwork Monad

Tier	Gift	Burden
1	Iterative Insight: +1 die to <i>Tinker/Craft</i> when improving existing designs.	Perfectionist Compulsion: You must point out flaws in nearby mechanisms; staying silent costs 1 SB (Diamonds) .
2	Recursive Enhancement: Once/scene, improve a device by one step without extra materials.	Optimization Obsession: –1 die when using unimproved tools; urge to "fix" everything.
3	Evolutionary Vision: +2 dice to predict how systems will develop.	Progressive Pressure: Those Near you feel driven to improve; you suffer Fatigue 1 from ambient pressure.
4	Self-Optimizing: Once/session, automatically improve one of your abilities or possessions by one step.	Inefficiency Intolerance: –2 dice when forced to use crude methods or wasteful tools.
5	Design Prophecy: Once/session, intuit the optimal solution to any engineering problem.	Perfection Paralysis: –1 die to snap decisions; compelled to seek the "best" approach.
6+	Infinite Refiner: Once/session, push a creation toward its theoretical maximum.	Optimization Hunger: Mark +2 Obligation ; risk becoming more pressure than person, unable to let imperfection stand.

Playstyle Notes

The Monad favours makers who iterate in public and in motion: prototype, test, measure, refine. It rewards seeing the next step and building scaffolds that teach your work to improve itself. Beware the Forge's appetite; the same pressure that perfects the gear can grind the world.

Emphasizes

- **Iterative Creation:** progress through passes, not miracles
- **Progressive Design:** reading how systems want to evolve
- **Optimization Insight:** spotting the next logical improvement
- **Craft Evolution:** transforming simple ideas by disciplined work
- **Perfection Pressure:** great power at the cost of tolerance for flaws

15.1.5 Grimmer, the Wild Speaker (Primal Wisdom & Seasonal Cycles)

Lore. Grimmer walks the threshold between cultivated lands and untamed wilderness, embodying the ancient pact between humanity and the natural world. Neither wholly beast nor entirely human, Grimmer speaks in root and stone, seasons and sap. Those who walk his path gain insight into nature's patterns, the tongues of leaf and fang, and mastery over the primal forces that shape the wild places—yet must choose which voice to trust: the cultivated mind or the feral heart.

“In the space between planted row and forest edge, where the first grain met the first acorn, Grimmer waits. He speaks in the rustle of leaves, the migration of birds, and the patient growth of ancient oaks. Listen, and learn that true power comes not from dominion, but from harmony.”

Domain Focus

- **Seasonal Wisdom:** cyclical patterns, timing, and natural rhythms
- **Verdant Speech:** communion with plant and animal life
- **Growth & Decay:** life-cycles, healing, and transformation
- **Boundary Keeping:** guarding wild spaces and the old order

Rites of Grimmer

15.1.5.0.1 Rite of the Speaking Seed (Low, 4 XP)

Scene; Zone; No.

Materials: A seed from the local biome or soil from undisturbed earth.

Effect: Establish communion with local plant life. Gain **+1 die** to *Survival* or *Investigation* when seeking information about the area. Plants in the zone provide minor assistance (parting grass, masking scent, concealing movement).

Push It: Flora actively aid for one exchange; mark 1 segment on **Primal Awareness**.

Requires: Familiar (Invoke: 1 Boon).

15.1.5.0.2 Rite of the Season's Turn (Low, 5 XP)

Scene; Self; Yes.

Materials: A token of the current season (flower, fruit, fallen leaf, budding branch).

Effect: Align with seasonal power. Choose one: **+1 die** to actions keyed to the season (Spring/Growth; Summer/Abundance; Autumn/Harvest; Winter/Endurance) *or* gain resistance to hazards of the season.

Push It: Extend the benefit to one ally; both mark **Exposure** to seasonal extremes.

Requires: Familiar (Invoke: 1 Boon).

15.1.5.0.3 Rite of Verdant Tongue (Standard, 8 XP)

Scene; Zone; Yes.

Materials: A drop of honey, a grain of pollen, or morning dew cupped in both hands.

Effect: Speak with all plant and animal life in *Near*. Gain **+2 dice** to gather information about local conditions, threats, or movements. Beasts may offer minor aid (distraction, guidance, warning).

Push It: Compel one significant creature to aid directly (Resolve DV 4) *or* take a prophetic reading from an elder being; mark **+1 Obligation**.

Requires: Familiar + Codex (Invoke: 1 Boon).

Obligation: 5 segments.

15.1.5.0.4 Rite of the Thornveil (Standard, 7 XP)*Scene; Zone; Yes.***Materials:** A thorn, briar, or *thorny branch* woven into a protective circle.**Effect:** Raise a living barrier. The zone gains the [WARD] tag against those who would harm the natural order. Allies gain +1 **die** to *Stealth/Defence*; aggressors suffer -1 **die** to approach. Start a **Natural Defence** [6] clock.**Push It:** The barrier endures the full scene but draws territorial spirits; mark 1 **SB (Clubs)**.*Requires: Familiar + Codex (Invoke: 1 Boon).**Obligation:* 4 segments.**15.1.5.0.5 Rite of the World's Wound (High, 13 XP)***Extended; Zone; Yes.***Materials:** A sacred grove-site, a circle of stones, an offering of blood or seed.**Effect:** Heal a blighted place or quicken a damaged ecosystem. Clear taint, restore fertility, awaken dormant forces. Gain +2 **dice** to related *Survival/Nature* actions in the region. Start an **Ecosystem Restoration** [8] clock.**Push It:** The cure spreads to adjacent areas but unbalances another; mark 2 **SB (Diamonds)**.*Requires: Familiar + Codex + Tier III (Invoke: 2 Boons).**Obligation:* 7 segments.**15.1.5.0.6 Rite of the Cycle's Crown (High, 14 XP)***Scene; Self/Zone; Yes.***Materials:** A circlet of woven branches, antlers, and seasonal tokens.**Effect:** Become an avatar of the cycle. Choose two:

- **Seasonal Mastery:** +2 **dice** to all actions keyed to the current season.
- **Verdant Command:** Command plant life in *Near* automatically.
- **Cycle's Healing:** Remove one Condition or downgrade Harm by one level.
- **Growth's Protection:** Allies gain +1 **Armor** from natural cover.

Begin a **Seasonal Avatar** [6] clock.**Push It:** Extend the blessings to all present; mark +2 **Obligation** and gain **Seasonal Attunement** (see Corruption).*Requires: Familiar + Codex + Tier III (Invoke: 2 Boons).**Obligation:* 8 segments.**Cantors & Cults of Grimmir****The Cantor's Song.** A Cantor of Grimmir sings the *drone of green things* – a low, humming chant that mimics the vibration of leaves in wind or the deep thrum of growing roots. Their voice is used to coax reluctant seeds, to calm wounded animals, and to mark the turning of the seasons in rituals that entire villages attend. A Grimmir Cantor does not seek an audience; they sing to the land itself, and the land answers in fruit, rain, or silence.**The Cult of the Green Accord.** Grimmir's cults are not secret, but they are often solitary. A "cult" may be a single hermit who tends a sacred grove, or a scattered network of rangers who meet only at the solstices. Their rituals are practical: the spring planting, the autumn cull, the winter waiting. Their creed is carved into the oldest oak in each grove: "*Take only what the season gives. Give back what the season will need.*" Outsiders are welcome at the solstice fires, but expected to

work.

Witchcraft of Grimmer (Craft / Threshold)

A witch who walks with Grimmer is a *hedgewright* or *path-keeper* – a crafter of living boundaries. Their work may be invisible: weaving a branch to guide deer away from a village, carving a marker that tells the frost when to end, or building a root bridge that only becomes passable at low tide. This craft can look like "infrastructure" – an Aeler True-Mason might carve a stone that remembers the boundary between a mine and a sacred spring, or a Linn shipwright might season a keel with a prayer for the right wind.

The Witch's Tool: The Green Chisel. A chisel of petrified wood, cold to the touch but warm when it cuts living matter. Once per session, when used to carve a boundary marker (a post, a stone, a tree) it inscribes a minor [SEASONAL] tag into the threshold. The marker will "remember" the season of its carving for one year, granting +1 die to rolls that honour that season's work.

A Hedge Gift: Knot of the Turning Year (2 XP). Once per scene, you may tie a simple knot (in a cord, a strand of hair, or a blade of grass) and speak a phrase appropriate to the current season. The knot subtly influences the weather or local plant growth for the next hour – a gust of wind, a sudden rain, or a patch of ivy that grows just enough to provide cover. The GM adjudicates effect.

Grimmer's Corruption Table

Tier	Benefit	Cost / Quirk
1	Seasonal Sense: +1 die to predict weather, seasonal shifts, or natural events.	Cyclical Mood: –1 die to actions that defy the season (haste in winter, patience in spring).
2	Verdant Whisper: Once/scene, gain +2 dice when communing with nature.	Plant Speech: Under stress, you address plants before people; –1 die to civilised social rolls.
3	Growth's Touch: Once/session, accelerate natural healing or growth.	Seasonal Shift: Demeanour changes with the season; allies note unsettling variance.
4	Boundary Keeper: Once/scene, sense violations of wild places at <i>Far</i> .	Wild Intolerance: –1 die in dense urban/cultivated zones; physical discomfort in worked stone.
5	Cycle's Memory: Once/session, perfectly recall a natural event witnessed here.	Ecosystem Dependency: Without daily time in nature, suffer Fatigue 1 .
6+	Avatar of Seasons: Once/session, embody a season fully (+3 dice to seasonal actions).	Nature's Claim: Mark +2 Obligation ; risk becoming bound to a specific biome.

Playstyle Notes

Grimmer rewards harmony over conquest, cyclical thinking, and fluent communication with the living world. Expect environmental problem-solving, seasonal planning, and hard choices at the boundary of field and forest. Power grows with attunement; the price is comfort, certainty, and the ease of polite society.

15.1.6 Ikasha, She Who Sleeps (Latent Potential & Shadow)

Lore. Ikasha is the hush between footfalls, the patience of dark water, the black-feathered watcher at every threshold. In stillness she gathers what might be, at crossroads she whispers of what may yet come. Ravens circle her, bearing secrets between worlds. Her followers learn to move unseen and speak unremembered, becoming shadows that slip between what is and what could be.

Blow out the candle. If the room listens back, ask softly. At the next crossroads, the raven waits—and the shadow remembers your passing.

Rites of Ikasha

15.1.6.0.1 Touch the Umbral Veil (Low, 4 XP)

Action; Self; Yes (Stealth).

Materials: A piece of black cloth.

Effect: Start *Controlled* on one Stealth roll or gain +1 effect to hide/move quietly.

Push It: Brief shadow-muffling (ignore one noisy tell), but leave a shadow-double that may echo you later at an ill moment – mark **1 SB (Diamonds)** as the shadow takes on its own agenda.

Requires: Familiar (Invoke: 1 Boon).

15.1.6.0.2 Rite of the Crossroads Raven (Low, 5 XP)

Scene; Zone; No.

Materials: Scatter three black feathers or carve a crossroads sign.

Effect: Summon an omen-raven; grant **+1 die** to a navigation, pursuit, or diversion action *or* force an enemy to hesitate at a fateful moment.

Push It: The raven speaks one cryptic truth, but demands a secret in return – the raven's insight costs you **1 SB (Hearts)** as it glimpses something you'd rather keep hidden.

Requires: Familiar (Invoke: 1 Boon).

15.1.6.0.3 Draw from the Umbral Reservoir (Standard, 8 XP)

Action; Self/Ally; No.

Materials: A vial of moonless-night water.

Effect: **+2 dice** to stealth, deception, or resolve *or* clear **Fatigue 1**.

Push It: Also gain one free escape attempt; next scene, you must help another cross a threshold or flee danger – shadow-debt calls for shadow-service.

Requires: Familiar + Codex (Invoke: 1 Boon).

15.1.6.0.4 Secret Keeper's Burden (Standard, 9 XP)

Instant; Touch; No.

Materials: A lock of hair or intimate token.

Effect: Compel a truthful answer to one direct question (deep secrets may allow a Resolve test to resist).

Push It: Learn the answer *and* a key hidden emotion; target learns one of your secrets in return, carried by a raven to them in dreams – mark **1 SB (Hearts)** as the secret exchange creates unexpected complications.

Requires: Familiar + Codex (Invoke: 1 Boon).

15.1.6.0.5 Become the Shadow at the Crossroads (High, 12 XP)

Scene; Self; No.

Materials: Stand in absolute darkness or at a deserted crossroads.

Effect: Intangible to mundane harm; pass through thresholds and small gaps; +2 dice to Stealth; auto-succeed one escape. Cannot manipulate normal objects.

Push It: Interact once with a bound or thresholded object (a door, a lock, a sealed letter), but you become partially corporeal and vulnerable for one beat. Ravens may mark you – shadow-form destabilises, mark 1 SB (Spades) as reality asserts its claim.

Requires: Familiar + Codex + Tier III (Invoke: 2 Boons).

Obligation: 7 segments.

Cantors & Cults of Ikasha

The Cantor's Song. A Cantor of Ikasha sings in *whispers* – melodies that are felt rather than heard, harmonies that slip beneath the threshold of attention. Their voice is used to hide a crowd's escape, to make a guard forget why they entered a room, or to pass a message through enemy lines without a single word being spoken aloud. Ikasha's Cantors are rarely recognised; they are the ones who hum absently while others plan rebellion.

The Cult of the Unlit Candle. Ikasha's cults are shadowy by necessity, meeting in basements, abandoned bell-towers, and fog-bound crossroads. They whisper freedom to the oppressed – escaped slaves, hunted heretics, debtors fleeing their creditors. A ritual of the Unlit Candle involves each member extinguishing a flame and speaking a secret wish for escape. The candles are never relit; the wish is carried away on ravens' wings. Their creed is never written, only passed from shadow to shadow: "*The dark does not confine – it conceals the road that the light would forbid.*" Outsiders who stumble into a meeting are offered a black feather and a choice: forget, or follow.

Witchcraft of Ikasha (Threshold / Shadow)

A witch who walks with Ikasha is a *threshold-keeper* or *shadow-weaver* – one who knows that a door left unlatched is not an invitation to theft, but to liberation. Their magic works in the gaps: the crack under a door, the moment between heartbeats, the pause between a guard's patrol. This craft can be invisible – a bent lock, a misplaced key, a shadow that moves of its own accord – or as grand as erasing a name from a pursuer's memory.

The Witch's Tool: The Raven's Quill. A quill carved from a raven's primary feather, dipped not in ink but in the absence of light. Once per session, when used to write a name on a threshold (a doorframe, a gatepost, a windowsill), that name becomes "forgotten" for a scene: the person whose name is written cannot be perceived by those who cross that threshold until they succeed on a Resolve test (DV 3). The quill can also erase a single word from a written document (it becomes a smudge of shadow).

A Hedge Gift: Unlatched (2 XP). Once per scene, you may declare a mundane lock, latch, or binding to be "unlatched" – it opens freely (or fails to close) as if it had never been secured. This works on doors, chains, shutters, and even a pursuer's grip, but not on magical wards.

Ikasha's Corruption Table

Tier	Benefit	Cost / Quirk
1	Shadow's Whisper: +1 die to Deception when lying in darkness or through intermediaries.	Truth Echoes: Occasionally speak in riddles or half-truths without realising it.
2	Umbral Sight: Once per scene, gain +2 dice to Notice hidden threats or ambushes in dim light.	Light Sensitivity: -1 die to rolls requiring keen vision in bright conditions.
3	Raven's Memory: Never forget a secret told to you; recall any whispered conversation perfectly.	Secret Burden: Must keep one troubling secret per Tier; suffer 1 Fatigue when actively trying to forget.
4	Threshold Walker: Once per session, move through one locked door, sealed letter, or magical barrier.	Crossroads Bound: Must pause at literal or metaphorical crossroads to "listen" before major decisions.
5	Shadow Debt: Once per session, call in a favor from someone who owes you a secret – no questions asked.	Obligation Web: Every secret you learn creates a subtle tie to its keeper; mark 1 SB (Diamonds) when ignoring these connections.
6+	Umbral Ascendancy: Once per session, become completely undetectable to all non-magical senses for one scene.	Reality Thinning: The boundary between what is and what could be grows thin – the GM may introduce subtle reality alterations around you.

15.1.7 Inaea, Angel of the Spider (Webs & Fate)

Lore. Inaea sits in patient silence at the center of the unseen lattice. Where others see isolation, she sees threads—debt, affection, rivalry, loyalty—all binding mortals to each other. She is comforter and conspirator alike: the hearth-mother who eases grief with a warm hand, and the shadow-spinner who knots fates so they cannot slip free. Those who serve her learn to pull strands, tying allies closer and ensnaring foes until mercy or trap is inevitable.

"The thread that comforts is the same that binds. The knot that saves is also the snare."

Rites of Inaea

15.1.7.0.1 Hearth-Thread Knot (Low, 4 XP)

Scene; Near; Yes (link once).

Materials: A thread tied around a wrist or shared cup.

Effect: You and one ally are bound: both gain **+1 die** to Aid each other this scene. If one takes Harm, the other may reduce it by 1 Harm (Lesser) at cost of suffering it.

Push It: Extend to two allies; mark **1 SB (Hearts)** as your own lifeline strains.

Requires: Familiar (Invoke: 1 Boon).

15.1.7.0.2 Snaring Filament (Low, 5 XP)

Scene; Zone; No.

Materials: A knotted cord or woven scrap.

Effect: Lay an invisible snare in a lane/door. The first hostile to cross suffers **−2 dice** on their next action.

Push It: Trap multiple, but allies risk entanglement; mark **1 SB (Spades)**.

Requires: Familiar (Invoke: 1 Boon).

15.1.7.0.3 Strand of Inevitability (Standard, 8 XP)

Scene; Near; No.

Materials: Three coloured threads braided.

Effect: Link two actors: when one acts, the other is dragged into consequence. Choose: force 1 SB on them, or gain **+2 dice** to a Setup/Prediction tied to the link.

Push It: Invert direction once; mark **1 SB (Diamonds)** as the weave resists.

Requires: Familiar + Codex (Invoke: 1 Boon).

15.1.7.0.4 Weaver's Glance (Standard, 7 XP)

Instant; Self; No.

Materials: Observe a spider finish a web's radial line.

Effect: Ask the Keeper for one hidden tie or leverage in play. Next Manipulate/Pressure exploiting it gains **+1 effect**.

Push It: Reveal a secret tie not declared; mark Exposure +1 as your own entanglements surface.

Requires: Familiar + Codex (Invoke: 1 Boon).

15.1.7.0.5 Binding Knot (High, 11 XP)

Scene; Near; No.

Materials: Silk loop tied between two hands, then cut/knotted.

Effect: Bind two parties to a vow. Breaking it forces 2 SB and marks the violator with a subtle tell.

Push It: Widen to four parties; each defines one loophole. Exploiting it causes **1 SB (Clubs)**.

Requires: Familiar + Codex + Tier III (Invoke: 2 Boons).

Obligation: 6 segments.

15.1.7.0.6 Merciful Severing (High, 13 XP)

Scene; Touch; No.

Materials: A white thread burned to ash.

Effect: Sever one harmful tie (a curse, obsession, or toxic bond). Remove one Condition or SB tied to it.

Push It: Sever without consent; mark **+2 Obligation** as the web recoils against you.

Requires: Familiar + Codex + Tier III (Invoke: 2 Boons).

Obligation: 7 segments.

Cantors & Cults of Inaea

The Cantor's Song. A Cantor of Inaea sings in *knots* – melodies that loop back on themselves, harmonies that tie two voices into one. Their voice is used to HEAL quarrels, to bind a community together after a tragedy, or to weave a subtle compulsion into a seemingly innocent lullaby. Inaea's Cantors are beloved at weddings, feared at treaty signings, and always watched by those who understand that a pretty tune can be a leash.

The Cult of the Woven Circle. Inaea's cults gather in domestic spaces – kitchens, weaving sheds, longhouses – and resemble extended families more than secret societies. A ritual of the Woven Circle involves each member tying a coloured thread around their wrist, then passing the ends to their neighbours. The resulting web is then tightened, and a communal promise spoken. The cult's creed is embroidered onto a single cushion that passes from host to host: *"No thread stands alone. The weakest knot still holds the strongest weight."* Outsiders are welcome if they bring a thread and a truth. Betrayal of the circle is repaid by being unravelled – socially, financially, or worse.

Witchcraft of Inaea (Craft / Threshold)

A witch who walks with Inaea is a *web-weaver* or *knot-smith* – one who understands that every threshold (a door, a marriage, a treaty) is held together by invisible threads. Their magic works with domestic tools: a spinning wheel that twists fate, a loom that weaves obligations into cloth, or a pair of shears that cuts a single strand to end a feud. This craft can be as humble as tying a red thread around a child's wrist for protection, or as grand as weaving a tapestry that records an entire bloodline's debts.

The Witch's Tool: The True Loom. A small, portable loom – no larger than a book – woven from hawthorn wood and strung with thread dyed in three colours (red for blood, white for truth, black for secret). Once per session, the witch may weave a single knot into a new or existing thread; that knot becomes a *promise clock* [4]. When the clock fills, the promise is either fulfilled or broken, as agreed at the time of weaving.

A Hedge Gift: Bind the Threshold (2 XP). Once per scene, the witch may tie a simple knot in a cord, ribbon, or strand of hair and place it on a threshold (a doorstep, a gate, a bridge). For the next hour, anyone crossing that threshold must succeed on a Resolve test (DV 2) if they intend to break an oath, tell a lie, or harm someone inside. The knot visibly tightens if a violation is attempted.

Inaea's Corruption Table

Tier	Benefit	Cost / Quirk
1	Hearth-Blessed: +1 die to Comfort or Aid.	Must offer solace when asked, or mark 1 SB (Hearts).
2	Web-Sense: Once/scene, sense hidden ties between two people.	Empathic Overload: suffer 1 Fatigue when immersed in strong conflict.
3	Binding Presence: Once/session, compel a promise unless target passes Resolve DV 4.	Over-Attachment: -1 die when abandoning those you've aided or bound.
4	Fate's Pattern: +2 dice predicting alliances, betrayals, or bargains.	Manipulative Urge: mark 1 SB (Diamonds) when acting selflessly without agenda.
5	Spider's Mercy: Once/session, sever one harmful tie for yourself or another.	Hunger for Threads: suffer 1 Fatigue if a session passes without weaving a new tie.
6+	Weaver's Dominion: Once/session, declare all ties in a scene bend toward you; gain +2 dice on social manipulation.	Entanglement: Mark +2 Obligation; those affected become subtly dependent on your will.

15.1.8 Isoka, Angel of Serpents (Transformation & Renewal)

Lore. Isoka, sister to Ikasha (Shadow) and Inaea (Mercy), completes the Triad of Transformation. Where thresholds and compassion mark her sisters' domains, Isoka teaches that every self is temporary—identity is a skin to be shed so growth can continue. Her serpents are omens and teachers: each cast skin a lesson in release; each venom a catalyst for necessary change. Those who walk her path become alchemists of the self, embracing dissolution as the first motion of rebirth.

Do not mourn the skin you shed. It was never meant to last. The venom that burns away the old self is the same that grants the strength to become new.

Rites of Isoka

15.1.8.0.1 Rite of the Venomous Benediction (Low, 5 XP)

Scene; Touch; No.

Materials: A drop of serpent's venom or shed snakeskin.

Effect: Bless an ally's strike with serpentine malice. Their next successful attack this scene inflicts **+1 Harm** and the target must roll Resolve (DV 3) or become Poisoned (loses 1 die on physical rolls until cured).

Push It: The venom suffuses the caster too – gain **+1 die** to melee attacks this scene, but also suffer **–1 die** to Resolve tests against fear or corruption.

Requires: Familiar (Invoke: 1 Boon).

15.1.8.0.2 Rite of the Loosening Skin (Low, 4 XP)

Scene; Self; No.

Materials: Discarded snakeskin or loose thread.

Effect: Gain **+1 die** to resist an ongoing Condition this scene, or reroll one **1** on an escape/evasion. On success, you may declare the Condition *shed* and create a 2-segment *Transformation Residue* clock to ignore a similar effect later.

Push It: Also ignore one minor movement penalty; leave a token of the old self that can be traced (mark **1 SB (Diamonds)**).

Requires: Familiar (Invoke: 1 Boon).

15.1.8.0.3 Rite of the Subtle Shift (Low, 5 XP)

Scene; Self; No.

Materials: Palmed trinket passed hand-to-hand.

Effect: Fluid demeanour: **+1 die** to *Deceive* to pass as a nearby class/profession, or **+1 Effect** to blend into a new crowd/site. Create a 4-segment *Blended Identity* clock to downgrade one social complication.

Push It: Bypass one minor identity check; you must maintain the false role to scene end (generate **1 SB (Hearts)** if challenged).

Requires: Familiar (Invoke: 1 Boon).

15.1.8.0.4 Rite of the Shedding (Standard, 8 XP)

Scene; Self; No.

Materials: Full change of clothing and an adopted mannerism.

Effect: **+2 dice** to resist one named ongoing Condition; once/session declare a minor physical contingency retroactively ("I packed the tool," "I took that step earlier"). Create a 6-segment *Shed Identity* clock.

Push It: Clear a temporary identity-based Minor Condition; your former identity stirs in the fiction (an ally, rival, or witness appears).

Requires: Familiar + Codex (Invoke: 1 Boon).

15.1.8.0.5 Rite of the Forked Tongue (Standard, 7 XP)

Scene; Self/Near; No.

Materials: A harmless lie told to a mirror.

Effect: Ambiguous persuasion: when you *Sway* or *Command*, a success may generate *Diamonds* (leverage) instead of SB. Targets of deception must test (Wits+Insight DV 3) or suffer -1 die to future interactions with you this scene. Create a 4-segment *Verbal Venom* clock.

Push It: One carefully worded lie this scene is treated as true; the displaced truth seeks return (mark **1 SB (Hearts)**).

Requires: Familiar + Codex (Invoke: 1 Boon).

15.1.8.0.6 Rite of Complete Metamorphosis (High, 13 XP)

Scene; Self; No.

Materials: Identity kit (garb, voice, tokens) and a serpent's shed skin.

Effect: Full appearance/voice change. Begin *Controlled* on *Deceive/Stealth*; once/scene declare a minor contingency retroactively. You are [WARD]ed against recognition by former acquaintances. Create an 8-segment *New Identity* clock.

Push It: Spoof scent/biometric once; your original identity partially unmoors and acts independently (mark **2 SB (Spades/Hearts)**).

Requires: Familiar + Codex + Tier III (Invoke: 2 Boons).

Obligation: 7 segments.

15.1.8.0.7 Rite of the Cast-Off History (High, 14 XP)

Extended; Self; No.

Materials: Burning or defacing mundane records of the old life.

Effect: Upon completion, common records and casual memories of that identity become unreliable; trackers via that identity suffer -2 dice (magic and intimates still apply). Gain +2 dice to rolls with the new identity. Create a 6-segment *Erased Past* clock.

Push It: A plausible "death" occurs for the old identity; one intimate senses deception but cannot prove it (mark **1 SB (Clubs)**).

Requires: Familiar + Codex + Tier III (Invoke: 2 Boons).

Obligation: 7 segments.

Cantors & Cults of Isoka

The Cantor's Song. A Cantor of Isoka sings in *whispers of shedding* – melodies that rise and fall like a snake's undulating motion, with harmonies that slither rather than resolve. Their voice is used to ease a difficult transformation (ritual scarring, a change of identity, the acceptance of loss) or to accelerate a foe's destructive change (madness, mutation, despair). Isoka's Cantors are often found in snake cults, their songs weaving venom and mercy in equal measure.

The Cult of the Coiled Heart. Isoka's cults are the classic Sword Sorcery snake cults – secretive, dangerous, and obsessed with metamorphosis. They gather in sunken temples, caverns beneath city sewers, or groves where adders nest. A ritual of the Coiled Heart involves each member holding a live serpent while speaking a name they wish to shed: a debt, a crime, a former allegiance. The serpent is then released into a central pit. Their creed is carved in ouroboros rings: *"What devours*

itself is never consumed by another." Outsiders are rarely invited; those who stumble into a rite are offered a choice – join, drink venom and be remade, or be forgotten as the cult sheds their memory.

Witchcraft of Isoka (Craft / Shedding)

A witch who walks with Isoka is a *scale-smith* or *venomer* – one who understands that transformation is a craft. Their magic works with the materials of change: a forge that tempers steel by "shedding" impurities, a alembic that distills venom into medicine, or a loom that weaves a new identity from discarded threads. In Aeler, a True-Mason might "shed" an old tunnel by sealing it and carving a new one; in Zakov, a poisoner might shed a target's will with a single drop.

The Witch's Tool: The Shedding Knife. A small, curved blade of obsidian or serpentine, never used for combat – only for cutting away what is no longer needed. Once per session, the witch may cut a physical token of an old identity (a lock of hair, a uniform patch, a letter) and burn it. For the remainder of the session, they gain +1 die on all rolls to deceive, hide, or escape detection, as the old self's traces are literally erased.

A Hedge Gift: Venom's Mercy (2 XP). Once per scene, the witch may apply a drop of harmless (or carefully dosed) venom to a wound, a drink, or a lock. Choose one effect: remove 1 Fatigue from an ally (as a mild stimulant), impose –1 die on a target's next physical roll (a mild paralytic), or force a target to speak a single truthful sentence (a truth serum). The victim may resist with a Resolve test (DV 3) if they are aware of the venom.

Isoka's Corruption Table

Tier	Benefit	Cost / Quirk
1	Serpent's Gaze: +1 die on Intimidation or social rolls using menace.	Cold-Blooded: –1 die on Empathy or warmth-based Persuasion.
2	Shed the Old Skin: Once/session, negate one Condition (Fear, Fatigue, Poison) by discarding it like molted skin.	Mark of Scales: Faint reptilian patches visible, causing +1 SB in social encounters if noticed.
3	Venomous Strike: Bite or kiss may inflict Poison (DV 2).	Hungry Coil: Must consume raw meat or eggs weekly, or mark 1 Fatigue.
4	Serpentine Grace: +2 dice to Stealth or Evasion rolls, ignore minor movement penalties.	Slitted Eyes: Bright light imposes –1 die on Notice rolls.
5	Hypnotic Sway: Once/scene, roll Presence + Lore vs. Resolve (DV 3) to mesmerise a single target.	Forked Tongue: –1 die on Deception when attempting warmth or sincerity.
6+	Ascendant Form: Partial serpent-body; immune to mundane poison, +2 dice on Body rolls.	Monstrous Aspect: Cannot easily hide your nature; every session begins with 1 SB that may be compelled by the GM.

15.1.9 Oath of Flame & Light (Dawn & Vows)

Lore. The Oath of Flame & Light is no patron of half-measures. Its fire names, binds, and burns—demanding that those who swear within its radiance stand openly, speak truly, and pay the cost of keeping their word. At dawn altars, the sworn kindle sparks of consecrated fire; in battle, they blaze as torches that hold back the night. To follow this Oath is to live in public truth, with no shadow to hide in and no retreat from the vow once spoken.

The Oath appears in many guises across cultures, and is the patron most commonly called upon by the magic-users of the Church of Flame and the Temple of Light – as well as any fire- or light-based faith or order:

- **The Everflame** — the unquenchable fire of promise, carried from shrine to shrine by wandering priests of the Church of Flame. Its censers never cool.
- **Adur**, the Light of Aeler — worshiped as the sun’s church-deity, whose flame consecrates oaths and consumes falsehood. Dwarven templars strike their oaths into stone with a brand.
- **Adar**, the Vilikari Dawnfire — invoked as a war-god of vows and vengeance, whose rising light marks those who break faith. Cavalrymen light a single arrow before battle.
- **The Watchfire of Vhasia** — a saint’s flame that never gutters, tended by a silent order of healers who swear to harm no one – and to let no one die alone.
- Others know the Oath only as *the Flame* or *the Lantern*, a nameless fire that still demands truth and punishes betrayal.

Wherever it manifests, the Oath of Flame & Light remains the same unyielding power: to swear beneath its dawn is to bind one’s self to a truth that cannot be hidden, forgotten, or undone.

“Swear in the light. Keep it, or the light will keep *you*.”

Domain Focus

- **Sacred Vows:** Oath-keeping, truth-speaking, binding promises
- **Divine Justice:** Retribution, smiting evil, protecting the innocent
- **Radiant Power:** Healing light, purification, revealing truth
- **Dawn’s Hope:** Renewal, protection, driving back darkness

Rites of the Oath of Flame & Light

15.1.9.0.1 Rite of Kindle Vow (Low, 4 XP)

Action; Self/Ally; Standard Push

Materials: A glass ampoule of consecrated flame.

Effect: Declare a short vow for this scene (e.g., "protect the villagers," "speak only truth"). The bearer gains +1 **die** to actions fulfilling it.

Push It: The first hesitation forces 1 **SB (Hearts)** on the bearer.

Requires: Familiar (Invoke: 1 Boon).

15.1.9.0.2 Rite of Lay on Hands (Low, 5 XP)

Instant; Touch; Standard Push

Materials: A bare palm, a whispered vow.

Effect: Cleanse an affliction, downgrade Harm by 1, or remove 1 Fatigue. For curses or poisons, test Spirit+Resolve (DV set by fiction).

Push It: The target gains +1 **die** to their next Resist roll this scene; you mark Exposure +1.

Requires: Familiar (Invoke: 1 Boon).

15.1.9.0.3 Rite of Sunlit Parley (Standard, 8 XP)

Scene; Zone; Standard Push

Materials: A vow-ring engraved with sunrise.

Effect: Establish terms in open light. Honest persuasion gains +1 **die**; deceit suffers –1 **die**. Create a 6-segment *Parley Accord* clock.

Push It: Demand one public answer; evasion forces 1 **SB (Hearts)** on the evader.

Requires: Familiar + Codex (Invoke: 1 Boon).

15.1.9.0.4 Rite of Radiant Smite (Standard, 9 XP)

Action; Self; Standard Push

Materials: A consecrated spark on a weapon or badge.

Effect: Your next melee strike flares with dawnfire. Upgrade Effect by one step, add +1 Burn Harm, or force 1 **SB (Spades)**. Against undead, oath-breakers, or outsiders: oath-breakers suffer –1 die, outsiders gain +1 Exit Tally.

Push It: On a hit, the burst drives back enemies in Close (worse Position); mark +1 **Obligation**.

Requires: Familiar + Codex (Invoke: 1 Boon).

15.1.9.0.5 Rite of Purge the Shadow (Standard, 10 XP)

Instant; Near; Standard Push

Materials: A shattered consecrated spark.

Effect: Reveal illusions and suppress one ongoing glamour or curse in Near range. Creates a 4-segment *Purity's Light* clock.

Push It: Brand the source with a visible tell for this arc; mark 1 **SB (Diamonds)**.

Requires: Familiar + Codex (Invoke: 1 Boon).

15.1.9.0.6 Rite of Covenant Blaze (High, 13 XP)

Scene; Zone; High Push

Materials: A brazier lit while three names are spoken.

Effect: The sworn within are haloed: they gain +1 **die** to keep their oath; aggressors suffer –1 **die** if violating the terms. Oath-breakers suffer 2 **SB (Hearts/Spades)** and Harm 1 (Burn).

Push It: Sanctify a threshold with one beat of [WARD] against oath-breakers; mark +2 **Obligation**.

Requires: Familiar + Codex + Tier III (Invoke: 2 Boons).

Obligation: 7 segments.

Cantors & Cults of the Oath of Flame & Light

The Cantor's Song. A Cantor of the Oath sings in *clarion tones* – melodies that sound like a trumpet at sunrise, like a bell calling the faithful to prayer. Their voice is used to swear in a witness, to consecrate a blade with a hymn, or to sing a funeral pyre into a beacon. The Oath's Cantors are often found in military camps and pilgrimage roads, their songs keeping oaths fresh and courage hot.

The Cult of the Unquenched Flame. The Oath's cults gather at dawn, in open courtyards or on hilltops facing east. The Unquenched Flame is a fellowship of paladins, healers, and simple folk who have sworn to keep one another honest. A ritual of the Cult involves each member speaking a vow aloud as the sun crests the horizon, then passing a lit candle to the next – the flame must not be allowed to go out until all have spoken. Their creed is written in charcoal above every hearth:

"The flame that reveals the truth also warms the hands that keep it." Outsiders are welcome to swear a temporary vow and share the light – but an oath sworn at dawn is binding until sunset.

Witchcraft of the Oath of Flame & Light (Craft / Hearthfire)

A witch who walks with the Oath is a *flame-smith* or *glass-fire* – one who crafts vessels for sacred light: a forge that tempers steel in dawnlight, a lamp that burns a single drop of oil for a year, or a mirror that focuses the sun's rays to cauterise a wound. In Aeler, a True-Mason might carve a "sunstone" into a keystone, so that the chamber below is always warm and never haunted. In Vhasia, a glassblower might shape a lens that reveals hidden writing when held to the sunrise.

The Witch's Tool: The Sun-Chisel. A chisel of polished brass, warmed by the sun. Once per session, the witch may strike the chisel against a stone threshold (a door, a bridge, a hearth) while speaking a vow. For the next day, anyone who crosses that threshold and knowingly acts against an oath they swore there suffers a mild burn (1 Fatigue) as the stone "remembers" the light. The chisel can also be used to carve a shallow sun-symbol that glows faintly at dawn.

A Hedge Gift: Spark of the Unbroken (2 XP). Once per scene, the witch may snap their fingers and produce a small, genuine flame – a candle-light that cannot be extinguished by wind or water for one minute. This flame can light a campfire, kindle a torch, or cauterise a wound (grant +1 die to Medicine rolls for stopping bleeding). It cannot be used to harm a living creature directly.

Oath of Flame & Light Corruption Manifestations

Level	Benefit	Cost / Quirk
1	Oathbound Strength: +1 die when upholding vows or defending innocents.	Rigid Honour: Must uphold vows even when disadvantageous; –1 die to flexible actions.
2	Radiant Sight: Once/scene, +2 dice to detect lies or corruption.	Blinding Truth: –1 die to subtlety or deception attempts.
3	Holy Flame: +1 die to melee against undead, outsiders, or oath-breakers.	Burden of Light: 1 Fatigue when concealing identity or working in darkness.
4	Unwavering Resolve: Once/session, treat a failed Resolve/Command as success (mark 1 SB).	Absolutist Stance: –1 die in morally ambiguous situations.
5	Dawn's Benediction: Once/session, heal all allies in Near of 1 Fatigue and minor Conditions.	Beacon's Call: Your aura reveals you; enemies seeking you gain +1 die.
6+	Avatar of the Oath: Once/session, become a living covenant (+2 dice to protection/justice actions).	Radiance's Price: Mark +2 Obligation; breaking any vow inflicts Harm 2 (Burn).

Playstyle Notes

The Oath of Flame & Light excels as a "paladin" patron, rewarding vow-keeping and truth-speaking with potent defensive and smiting abilities. Followers become living embodiments of their oaths, shining beacons against deception and darkness. The corruption progression naturally leads toward becoming an uncompromising force for justice, though potentially at the cost of flexibility and subtlety. Ideal for characters who embody conviction, protection, and radiant power.

15.1.10 Oath of Mercy and Grace (Healing & Forgiveness)

Lore. The Oath of Mercy and Grace has no founder, no scripture, no single temple. It began in a hundred places—a battlefield where a medic bound wounds without asking whose side; a plague village where a stranger stayed to dig graves; a debtor's cell where a guard looked away and said, "I saw nothing." Those who swear the Oath do not worship a power; they embody a principle: that every act of care creates an obligation—not to the giver, but to the next person in need. You do not pay back. You pay forward. The mercy spirals.

The Oath appears in many guises across cultures, often as a healer's order or a mendicant fellowship within larger faiths:

- **The Grey Circle (Everflame)** — a heretical sect within the Church of the Everflame that tends the sick without demanding confession or tithe. Its members wear undyed wool and carry clay bowls. The orthodox clergy call them "fire-dimmers"; the poor call them mercy.
- **The Hospitallers of the Unburdened Hand (Temple of Light)** — a knightly order sworn to protect pilgrims and heal the wounded. They carry no banners and refuse to strike first. Their enemies mock them as "grey shields"; their patients never forget their faces.
- **The Pardoners of the Covenant (Mykkiel)** — a reformist school within the Covenant that argues every contract contains an implicit clause of impossibility. "If a debtor cannot pay, the creditor must accept work in kind." Mykkiel judges consider them dangerous idealists; debtors call them deliverance.
- **The Tide-Kindlers (Linn sea-rites)** — mourners who walk the shore after storms, burying the drowned without marking names. The sea takes no toll from them. Sailors whisper that a Tide-Kindler's blessing is the only prayer the deep will answer.
- **The Weepers (Death-cult)** — a mendicant fellowship that appears at funerals, often uninvited. They weep for the dead, believing that their tears can forgive the deceased's unpaid debts and close their page in the Ledger of Grace. Wealthy lords sponsor them as a status symbol; the poor chase them away as invasive nuisances. Their efficacy is a matter of fierce debate. (See sidebar.)
- Others know the Oath simply as *the Spiral* or *the Grey Work*—a nameless way of walking the world, tending wounds, and refusing to keep score.

Wherever it manifests, the Oath of Mercy and Grace remains the same: to swear it is to accept that you will receive care, and that you must give it in turn. The spiral does not close.

"You ask who owes what. We ask who needs what. The ledger is not the same as the meal."

Domain Focus

- **Restorative Work:** Healing body, mind, and spirit; mending what is broken
- **Spiral Mercy:** Paying obligation forward through acts of care
- **Sanctuary:** Sheltering the hunted, feeding the hungry, accepting no payment
- **Unburdening:** Releasing others (and oneself) from the weight of unpaid debts

Rites of the Oath of Mercy and Grace

15.1.10.0.1 Rite of the Shared Bowl (Low, 4 XP)

Action; Touch; Standard Push

Materials: A clay bowl of clean water, shared with a willing creature.

Effect: You and the creature each clear 1 Fatigue. The creature gains +1 die on their next roll to

resist fear or despair.

Push It: Extend the benefit to all creatures who drink from the bowl (up to six). Mark +1 Obligation.

Requires: Familiar (Invoke: 1 Boon).

15.1.10.0.2 Rite of Healing Waters (Low, 5 XP)

Instant; Touch; Standard Push

Materials: Water from a blessed source (a spring, a well, or a river where the Oath has been invoked), poured onto a wound.

Effect: Remove 1 Harm from a touched creature. If the wound is cursed or poisoned, the GM may call for a Spirit+Lore test (DV 4).

Push It: Also remove one Condition (e.g., Poisoned, Cursed, Blinded). Mark +1 Obligation.

Requires: Familiar (Invoke: 1 Boon).

15.1.10.0.3 Rite of the Unburdened Circle (Standard, 8 XP)

Scene; Zone; Standard Push

Materials: At least three willing participants, a circle drawn in ash or flour, a single candle.

Effect: Each participant clears 1 Obligation (to any patron or debt). One participant of the GM's choice gains a permanent String: *Witnessed by the Circle* – they may call on any other participant for one act of care, once per campaign.

Push It: The GM gains 3 Story Beats (the universe notes that a community of mutual aid is forming). Mark +1 Obligation.

Requires: Familiar + Codex (Invoke: 1 Boon).

15.1.10.0.4 Rite of the Sheltered Hearth (Standard, 9 XP)

Scene; Zone; Standard Push

Materials: A door or threshold, a lit candle, a whispered vow of sanctuary.

Effect: For one night, any fugitive, debtor, or refugee who crosses that threshold cannot be pursued or harmed within the zone. The sanctuary holds until dawn.

Push It: Extend the sanctuary to a full day. Mark +1 Obligation.

Requires: Familiar + Codex (Invoke: 1 Boon).

15.1.10.0.5 Rite of the Spiral's Witness (Standard, 10 XP)

Instant; Near; Standard Push

Materials: A grey wool cord tied around the caster's wrist.

Effect: Name a person crushed by debt or guilt. For one hour, they ignore all penalties from unpaid obligations (social, legal, or spiritual). They are not free; they are *unburdened*.

Push It: The effect lasts until the next dawn. Mark +1 Obligation.

Requires: Familiar + Codex (Invoke: 1 Boon).

15.1.10.0.6 Rite of the Endless Spiral (High, 13 XP)

Scene; Zone; High Push

Materials: A circle of nine grey stones, a bowl of water, and a candle lit at each cardinal point.

Effect: All within the circle who accept the Oath's blessing clear 2 Fatigue and remove one Condition caused by despair or guilt. For the rest of the scene, any act of care performed within the zone costs the giver –1 Obligation (minimum 0).

Push It: The blessing persists for a full day. Mark +2 Obligation.

Requires: Familiar + Codex + Tier III (Invoke: 2 Boons).

Obligation: 7 segments.

Cantors & Cults of the Oath of Mercy and Grace

The Cantor's Song. A Cantor of the Oath does not merely sing *about* mercy—they become a vessel for the pain of others. Their voice reaches into a listener's chest and draws out the unspoken grief, the hidden shame, the debt that has calcified into self-loathing. They sing, and the listener weeps. They sing, and the listener forgives themselves. The Cantor does not heal wounds; they *share* them.

This gift is dangerous. A Cantor who takes on another's pain may find that pain lingers, echoing in their own dreams. They may forget which memories are theirs and which they borrowed. They may begin to crave the intimacy of shared suffering, seeking out the broken not to help them, but to feel their own emptiness filled by another's anguish. The most unstable Cantors become emotional parasites, draining the misery of crowds and leaving behind hollow peace—not because they have healed, but because they have taken everything.

The Oath watches such Cantors closely. It does not condemn them; it understands that the spiral of mercy includes the risk of drowning. But it does not always pull them back.

The Cult of the Grey Circle. The Oath's cults gather in wilderness communes, abandoned farmsteads, and hidden valleys where no lord's writ runs. The Grey Circle is a fellowship of healers, fugitives, and the simply exhausted who have sworn to keep no ledgers. A ritual of the Circle involves each member speaking one burden they carry – not a debt, but a weight – and then passing a clay bowl of water around the circle. Each drinks, then pours a few drops onto the ground for the next stranger who will need it. Their creed is never written, only passed from mouth to ear: *"The spiral has no end. That is not a curse. That is the only honest shape of mercy."* Outsiders are welcome to drink and to stay – but they will be asked to work, and they will be expected to leave when they are strong enough.

The Weepers. A specialized cult within the Grey Circle, the Weepers appear at funerals—sometimes invited, sometimes not. They wear grey hoods and carry no bowl, only a knotted cord. They do not speak. They weep. Their tears, they believe, can forgive the debts of the dead, closing pages in the Ledger of Grace that would otherwise remain open. Wealthy lords sponsor Weepers as a status symbol: *I can afford to have my ancestors forgiven.* The poor chase them away as invasive nuisances. Varnek Karn's followers consider them dangerously naive; the Daughters of the Unbroken Cord call them heretics. The Weepers do not argue. They simply weep. Whether their tears accomplish anything is a question the Oath does not answer—it only asks: *Would you rather be wept for, or forgotten?*

Witchcraft of the Oath of Mercy and Grace (Craft / Hearthwise)

A witch who walks with the Oath is a *herb-wife* or *bowl-carrier* – one who crafts the small vessels of mercy: a clay bowl that never cracks, a poultice that draws fever, a candle that burns without smoke. In Aeler, a True-Mason might carve a "mercy stone" into a hospice lintel, so that the dying feel no pain crossing it. In Viterra, a hedgewitch might weave a grey cord to tie around a debtor's wrist, a reminder that they are not their debt.

The Witch's Tool: The Bowl of Unburdening. A simple clay bowl, unglazed, fired in a kiln that also baked bread for the hungry. Once per session, the witch may fill the bowl with water from

any source and speak a name. For the rest of the scene, that water (drunk or poured on wounds) removes 1 Fatigue and grants +1 die to resist fear. The water tastes faintly of ash and salt.

A Hedge Gift: Grey Cord (2 XP). Once per session, the witch may tie a grey wool cord around a willing creature's wrist. For the next day, any time that creature performs an act of care for someone who cannot repay them, they clear 1 Obligation. The cord dissolves when the day ends.

Oath of Mercy and Grace Corruption Manifestations

The corruption of a Cantor of the Oath is not physical—no feathers, no scales. It is *emotional*. They begin to carry the pain of others so deeply that they lose the boundary between self and stranger.

Level	Benefit	Cost / Quirk
1	Unburdened Hand: +1 die to Medicine and Survival rolls when tending the sick or hungry.	Weary of Mercy: –1 die to refuse a genuine plea for help; must mark Fatigue to walk away.
2	Healer's Presence: Once/scene, you may touch a frightened creature and remove their Fear condition.	Compulsive Care: You cannot ignore untreated wounds; –1 die to actions while someone in sight is suffering.
3	Spiral's Grace: When you clear Obligation by helping another, you also clear 1 Fatigue.	Burden of Witness: You dream of the suffering of strangers; mark 1 Fatigue after a restless night.
4	Sanctuary Keeper: Once/session, declare a threshold (door, bridge, hearth) as sanctuary for one night. No violence may cross it.	Tithe of Presence: You cannot leave a place where people are in need without first finding someone to continue the work.
5	The Shared Bowl: Once/session, share a meal with a stranger; both of you clear 2 Fatigue and 1 Condition.	Hollow Mercy: If you refuse to share a meal with the hungry, you gain the Condition <i>Unforgiven</i> (–2 dice to all social rolls until you feed someone).
6+	Avatar of the Spiral: Once/session, become a living conduit of mercy. For one scene, any act of care you perform costs –1 Obligation, and you may transfer your own Fatigue to a willing recipient.	The Endless Spiral: Mark +2 Obligation when you use this power. You cannot rest until you have performed three acts of care for strangers, and you will dream of their faces forever.

For a Cantor, reaching Tier 6+ carries an additional risk: they may no longer be able to distinguish their own memories from those they have absorbed. The GM may occasionally ask: *Is that your grief, or someone else's?* If the Cantor cannot answer, they mark 1 Fatigue as the boundary blurs further.

Playstyle Notes

The Oath of Mercy and Grace rewards characters who prioritize healing, shelter, and the quiet work of unburdening others. Its followers become living embodiments of compassion, but the spiral of mercy can become a weight of its own – the more you give, the more you are called to give. The corruption progression naturally leads toward a saint who cannot rest while suffering exists, a healer who burns out in the service of others. Cantors in particular walk a knife's edge: their gift is to share pain, but that sharing can consume them. Ideal for players who enjoy the tension between

self-care and self-sacrifice, and for those who want to explore a faith based not on worship but on restorative work.

Rivalries

Within the Church of the Everflame, the Grey Circle is viewed with deep suspicion by the orthodox clergy, who accuse them of "diluting the purity of the flame with works without faith." The Inquisitor Prime's followers, in particular, see the Oath of Mercy and Grace as a dangerous heresy: mercy without judgment is merely indulgence, they say, and forgiving a debt before it is paid undermines the very order that keeps the world from burning. Hospitallers of the Grey Circle have been arrested, their hospices shuttered, their records burned. Yet the poor still seek them out, and the flame still answers their quiet prayers.

Within the Covenant of Mykkiel, the Pardoners of the Uncounted Debt are a tolerated but distrusted minority. Mykkielan judges argue that the "clause of impossibility" is a license for fraud; the Pardoners counter that a debt that can never be paid is not a contract but a cage. The rivalry is legal, not violent – but it has broken families and left debtors caught between two absolutes.

The Oath does not seek these rivalries. It simply continues its work. And those who hate it most often find themselves, one day, in need of mercy.

15.1.11 The Pale Shepherd, Guide of Transitions (Passage & Melancholic Wisdom)

Lore. The Pale Shepherd walks the seam between all things – life and death, joy and sorrow, memory and forgetting, the known and the unmarked. Neither wholly kind nor cruel, the Shepherd guides those who must pass through the hardest doors. Cloaked, with shadow-sheep that bear the shed wool of old possibilities, the Shepherd offers safe conduct through liminal space for a price paid in memory, feeling, or fate. Those who walk this road learn the hidden routes between states of being and can lead others through their hardest crossings – but each passage leaves them more attuned to endings than beginnings.

Across the known world, the Shepherd is known by many names and faces:

- In **Aeler**, the Shepherd is the *Breath-Accountant*, who weighs the last exhalation of the dying and guides it to the Deep Vaults. Dwarven death-priests invoke the Shepherd to ensure the dead do not linger in the stone.
- In **Aelaerem**, the Shepherd is the *Pale Gardener*, who walks the hedgerows at twilight, collecting the souls of those who die far from home. Halflings leave a cup of milk on the doorstep for the Shepherd to drink – and for the Hollow to pass by.
- In **Linn**, the Shepherd is the *Fog-Walker*, a grey-cloaked figure seen on the horizon before a storm. Sailors who drown are said to join the Shepherd’s flock, guiding their kin to safe harbour.
- In **Viterra**, the Shepherd is the *Silent Notary*, who witnesses the last will and testament of the dying. Hedge-priests invoke the Shepherd to make a deathbed promise binding.

Wherever mortals face the hardest thresholds, the Pale Shepherd is there – not to judge, but to accompany.

“The Shepherd goes where feet fail, speaks where voices thin, and points where paths run dim. Each journey loosens the knot that tied you to the life you left behind.”

Domain Focus

- **Liminal Navigation:** walking and reading thresholds, dusk-roads, and in-betweens
- **Passage Guidance:** steadying hands through grief, change, and transformation
- **Melancholic Wisdom:** understanding born of farewells and last looks
- **Memory Shepherding:** gathering, carrying, and setting down weighted moments

Rites of the Pale Shepherd

15.1.11.0.1 Rite of the Gentle Guidance (Low, 4 XP)

Scene; Near; No.

Materials: A small stone from a grave or threshold, warmed in the palm.

Effect: Ease a hard crossing. One target gains +1 **die** to rolls involving change, decision, or emotional steadiness this scene.

Invoke: 1 action; mark +1 **Obligation**.

Requires: Familiar (Invoke: 1 Boon).

15.1.11.0.2 Rite of the Hidden Path (Low, 5 XP)

Scene; Self; Yes.

Materials: A thread from a worn garment and a pinch of dawn mist kept in silence.

Effect: Find or make a way where none is seen. Gain **+2 dice** to *Navigation* or *Investigation* when seeking unconventional routes.

Push It: The way runs through a true between-place; gain the route but mark **1 SB (Spades)** as boundary powers take notice.

Invoke: 1 action; mark **+1 Obligation**.

Requires: Familiar (Invoke: 1 Boon).

15.1.11.0.3 Rite of the Shadow Passage (Standard, 8 XP)

Scene; Touch; Yes.

Materials: Black wool and a personal token of the one to be guided.

Effect: Open a brief passage through shadow-realms or boundary halls. The target bypasses one insurmountable obstacle or reaches a place normally shut.

Push It: The passage leaves a scent-trail; mark **1 SB (Clubs)** as something may follow.

Invoke: 1 action; mark **+1 Obligation**.

Requires: Familiar + Codex (Invoke: 1 Boon).

15.1.11.0.4 Rite of the Memory Flock (Standard, 7 XP)

Scene; Zone; Yes.

Materials: Ash of burned letters and wool shaped into little sheep.

Effect: Call shadow-sheep that carry fragments of weighty moments. Retrieve lost details, soothe grief, or glean counsel from what was.

Push It: The memories ride too close to the skin – participants relive them as their own; mark **1 SB (Hearts)**.

Invoke: 1 action; mark **+1 Obligation**.

Requires: Familiar + Codex (Invoke: 1 Boon).

15.1.11.0.5 Rite of the Threshold Bond (High, 13 XP)

Extended; Touch; Yes.

Materials: Two keepsakes: one of what is left, one of what is sought.

Effect: Bind two states, places, or conditions with a felt thread. Those bound can sense across the threshold and lend one another strength during change.

Push It: The bond sets like iron – permanent and inescapable. Mark **+2 Obligation**.

Invoke: Extended rite; mark **+2 Obligation**.

Requires: Familiar + Codex + Tier III (Invoke: 2 Boons).

Obligation: 7 segments.

15.1.11.0.6 Rite of the Final Shepherd (High, 14 XP)

Extended; Zone; Yes.

Materials: Last words, a much-crossed threshold, and the consent of those who remain.

Effect: Take the mantle of perfect guide for a great passage – death, moult, or life-bend. All present gain **+2 dice** to navigate the crossing; you shoulder the weight of it.

Push It: Guidance is flawless but costly: mark **Harm 2 (Weariness)** and **+2 Obligation**.

Invoke: Extended rite; mark **+2 Obligation**.

Requires: Familiar + Codex + Tier III (Invoke: 2 Boons).

Obligation: 8 segments.

Cantors & Cults of the Pale Shepherd

The Cantor's Song. A Cantor of the Pale Shepherd sings in *passing tones* – melodies that begin in a major key and end in a minor one, or that fade to silence rather than resolve. Their voice is used to ease a dying person's passage, to comfort the grieving at a funeral, or to lull a restless spirit back to the threshold. The Shepherd's Cantors are often found at hospices, battlefields, and the bedsides of the old, singing the softest of farewells.

The Cult of the Grey Flock. The Shepherd's cults meet in liminal places: cemeteries at dusk, crossroads at midnight, the rooms above funeral parlours. The Grey Flock is a fellowship of death-doulas, grief counsellors, and those who have lost so much that they have become experts in loss. A ritual of the Flock involves each member speaking the name of someone they have guided – and then a moment of silence for those they could not save. Their creed is embroidered on a woollen banner that is never washed: "*The door is never locked. We only hold it open.*" Outsiders are welcome to sit quietly, but they must bring a memory to share.

Witchcraft of the Pale Shepherd (Craft / Threshold)

A witch who walks with the Shepherd is a *shroud-weaver* or *threshold-carver* – one who crafts the tools of safe passage: a woollen shroud that keeps the dead from wandering, a stone carved with a doorway that leads to the next room (or the next life), or a bell that rings only when a soul is ready to cross. In Aeler, a True-Mason might carve a "threshold stone" at a hospice's entrance, so that the dying feel no pain crossing it. In Viterra, a hedgewitch might weave a shroud that shows the deceased's favourite flower in the pattern.

The Witch's Tool: The Wool-Winder. A wooden spindle carved from a branch that grew over a grave. Once per session, the witch may wind a length of undyed wool around their hand while speaking a name. The wool becomes a *memory cord* – a physical thread that holds one specific memory of the named person. The cord can be given to another to grant them a single vivid memory of the deceased (e.g., "grandmother's hands knitting"), or it can be burned to release the memory into the threshold, easing grief.

A Hedge Gift: Shepherd's Stone (2 XP). Once per scene, the witch may touch a small, smooth stone – preferably from a grave or a threshold – and place it on a dying person's chest (or on a doorframe before a difficult journey). The stone glows faintly, and for the next hour, the person feels no fear of the passage ahead. They gain +1 **die** to any roll involving courage, acceptance, or farewells, and may ignore one point of Fatigue from emotional distress.

The Pale Shepherd's Corruption

Tier	Benefit	Cost / Quirk
1	Boundary Sense: +1 die to <i>Notice</i> thresholds, limens, and turning-moments.	Melancholic Aura: –1 die to bright company and celebrations; your presence gentles joy.
2	Passage Insight: Once/scene, guide another through change (+1 die to their action).	Compulsive Counsel: Urge to advise even when unwelcome.
3	Shadow Comfort: +2 dice to soothe the distressed or those nearing an end.	Near to Death: In lively places, suffer Fatigue 1 from the sting of contrast.
4	Memory Keeper: Once/session, recall a marked moment of your past with perfect clarity.	Burdened Sight: –1 die on hopeful framings; farewells tint your view.
5	Liminal Mastery: Once/session, find a path through any maze, snare, or barred way.	Unmoored: –1 die to acts that demand firm anchoring in the present.
6+	Shepherd's Crown: Once/session, be the sure guide for any great passage.	Soul's Weight: Mark +3 Obligation; risk binding to the between, never wholly in one state.

Playstyle Notes

The Pale Shepherd favours those who steady others at the edge of change. Its gifts open hidden roads, soften endings, and lend courage to cross. Its prices lean toward memory, ease, and the simple warmth of belonging – spent to buy safe passage when it matters most.

Emphasises

- **Liminal Mastery:** reading and walking the in-between
- **Passage Guidance:** anchoring companions through turns of fate
- **Melancholic Wisdom:** counsel drawn from endings
- **Memory Shepherding:** carrying and setting down what weighs
- **Threshold Navigation:** ways through walls the world insists upon

15.1.12 The Savage Heart (Red Maw)

Lore. The Savage Heart is the truth behind the green veil: nature not as garden, but as gullet. It is the claw that tears, the fang that crushes, the hunger that stalks without malice and kills without mercy. Its followers are the druids you do not meet by firelight — those who have learned that the forest feeds on its own, that the strong devour the weak, and that the only law is the one written in blood on snow.

Across the known world, the Savage Heart wears the face of the apex predator. In the Amaranthine core, it is the *Great Bear*, patient and unstoppable, a wall of fur and fury. In Oshiira, it is the *Golden Lion*, whose roar shatters the hunt's silence. In Sekogo, it is the *Leopard of the Tall Grass*, a shadow that strikes once and is gone. In Dhahara, it is the *Tiger of the Mangroves*, whose amber gaze promises a death that runs faster than you can flee. Wherever prey fears the dark, the Savage Heart is already there, waiting.

“The deer does not weep for the wolf. The sapling does not beg the axe. In the red maw, there is no cruelty—only truth. The truth that all flesh feeds the earth, and the earth feeds the strong.”

Domain Focus

- **Apex Predation:** hunting, stalking, dominating the food chain
- **Red Tooth:** killing as nature's sacrament, strength proven through violence
- **Scavenger's Wisdom:** using death for growth, nothing wasted
- **Territory and Pack:** dominance over a domain, leadership of the hunt

Rites of the Savage Heart

15.1.12.0.1 Rite of the Predator's Gaze (Low, 4 XP)

Scene; Near; No.

Materials: A tooth from a predator that killed its own prey.

Effect: Mark a single target as your prey. Gain **+1 die** on all rolls to track, pursue, or intimidate that target. The effect lasts until the target escapes or is killed. **Tags:** FEAR, TRACK.

Push It: The prey feels your gaze; they suffer **−1 die** to resist social pressure from you. Mark **1 SB (Spades)**.

Invoke: 1 action; mark **+1 Obligation**.

Requires: Familiar (Invoke: 1 Boon).

15.1.12.0.2 Rite of the Blood Scent (Low, 5 XP)

Scene; Self; Yes.

Materials: A fresh kill's blood smeared on your face.

Effect: You scent the air like a beast. Gain **+2 dice** to *Investigation* or *Survival* when tracking by smell. You may also detect fear — you sense if a creature within Near is Frightened. **Tags:** SENSE, FEAR.

Push It: Your sense expands to Far, but you are overwhelmed by the smell of blood; mark **1 SB (Hearts)** and suffer **−1 die** to social rolls until the end of the scene.

Invoke: 1 action; mark **+1 Obligation**.

Requires: Familiar (Invoke: 1 Boon).

15.1.12.0.3 Rite of the Savage Will (Low, 4 XP)

Scene; Self; No.

Materials: A roar or howl that echoes.

Effect: Shrug off fear and hesitation. You gain **+1 die** to resist Fear or intimidation effects, and your next attack this scene gains **+1 Harm**. **Tags:** FEROCITY, RESIST.

Push It: The effect lasts the whole scene, but you mark **1 SB (Diamonds)** as your rage becomes difficult to control.

Invoke: 1 action; mark **+1 Obligation**.

Requires: Familiar (Invoke: 1 Boon).

15.1.12.0.4 Rite of the Shifting Shape (Standard, 8 XP)

Scene; Self; Yes.

Materials: A pelt or mask from the beast whose form you take.

Effect: Assume the form of a predator for the scene. Choose:

- **Bear (Tank):** +2 dice to Body rolls, +1 Armor, +1 Harm on melee attacks. Your movement is reduced by one band (cannot Dash).
- **Great Cat (Striker):** +2 dice to Agility and Stealth, +1 Effect when attacking from stealth, +1 band to movement (can Dash as a free action once per scene).

You may speak but cannot use tools or cast other Rites while transformed. **Tags:** TRANSFORM, BEAST.

Push It: The transformation becomes instinctive – you may shift as a free action once this scene, but mark **1 SB (Clubs)** as the beast presses against your mind.

Invoke: 1 action; mark **+1 Obligation**.

Requires: Familiar + Codex (Invoke: 1 Boon).

15.1.12.0.5 Rite of the Pack Leader (Standard, 7 XP)

Scene; Near; Yes.

Materials: A token from each member of your pack (a claw, a feather, a scrap of hide).

Effect: You and up to three allies form a hunting pack. While within Near of each other, all gain **+1 die** to attacks against a single designated prey, and the first ally to attack each round gains **+1 Effect**. **Tags:** TEAMWORK, BEAST.

Push It: The pack's coordination extends to Far, but the hunters become territorial; mark **1 SB (Spades)** as rivalries flare.

Invoke: 1 action; mark **+1 Obligation**.

Requires: Familiar + Codex (Invoke: 1 Boon).

15.1.12.0.6 Rite of the Carrion Feast (Standard, 9 XP)

Scene; Touch; Yes.

Materials: The flesh of a fallen enemy, consumed raw.

Effect: You devour the strength of the fallen. Heal **1 Fatigue** immediately, and gain **+1 die** to your next physical action. If the enemy was a supernatural creature (spirit, demon, fey), you also gain a minor property of theirs for one scene. **Tags:** HEAL, CONSUME.

Push It: Heal 1 Harm instead of Fatigue, but mark **1 SB (Hearts)** as the feast attracts scavengers.

Invoke: 1 action; mark **+1 Obligation**.

Requires: Familiar + Codex (Invoke: 1 Boon).

15.1.12.0.7 Rite of the Territorial Roar (High, 13 XP)*Scene; Zone; No.***Materials:** A predator's skull mounted on a pole.**Effect:** You claim a zone as your territory. For the scene, you gain **+2 dice** to all physical and intimidation rolls within it. Your prey (designated by *Predator's Gaze*) suffers **-2 dice** to flee or hide. Allies within the zone gain **+1 die** to defend themselves. **Tags:** FEAR, AREA, FORTIFY.**Push It:** The territory persists for the session, but you must mark your borders visibly (at GM discretion, this may attract rivals); mark **+2 Obligation**.**Invoke:** 1 action; mark **+2 Obligation**.*Requires: Familiar + Codex + Tier III (Invoke: 2 Boons).**Obligation: 7 segments.***15.1.12.0.8 Rite of the Final Hunt (High, 14 XP)***Extended; Near; No.***Materials:** The heart of a predator you have killed in single combat, still warm.**Effect:** You become the ultimate hunter. For one scene, you may:

- Ignore all difficult terrain.
- Gain **+3 dice** to all tracking and combat rolls against your designated prey.
- If you reduce a prey to 0 Harm, you may immediately make a free attack against another target within Near.

Tags: TRANSFORM, FEAR, SPEED.**Push It:** The hunt consumes you – you cannot end the rite until all designated prey are dead or fled, and you suffer Harm 1 (Weariness) when the scene ends. Mark **+2 Obligation**.**Invoke:** Extended rite; mark **+2 Obligation**.*Requires: Familiar + Codex + Tier III (Invoke: 2 Boons).**Obligation: 8 segments.***Cantors & Cults of the Savage Heart****The Cantor's Song.** A Cantor of the Savage Heart sings in *hunting calls* – short, sharp cries that mimic the bark of a bear or the cough of a leopard. Their voice is used to coordinate a pack, to scare prey from hiding, or to summon a predator from the deep woods. They are rarely heard near villages; their songs echo in the places between game trails.**The Cult of the Bloody Hand.** The Savage Heart's cults do not meet in groves – they meet at kills. The Bloody Hand is a fellowship of hunters, trappers, and those who have tasted raw meat in the dark. A ritual involves each member bringing a fresh kill (any animal, any size) and laying it on a stone. The cult eats the kill raw, speaking the names of the animals they have taken. Their creed is spoken with full mouths: *"The forest is a stomach. We are its teeth."* Outsiders are not welcome; they are either prey or future members.**Witchcraft of the Savage Heart (Craft / Hunter)**A witch who walks with the Savage Heart is a *skin-stitcher* or *tooth-carver* – one who crafts from the bodies of the slain. Their tools are made from bone, claw, fur, and sinew. A knife of wolf fang, a cloak of bear hide that traps warmth, a drum of leopard skin that calls the hunt. Their magic works through the materials of the kill: a needle that sews wounds shut with sinew that never rots, a chisel carved from a tiger's femur that splits wood as if it were soft meat, or a net woven from gut that tightens when prey struggles.

The Witch's Tool: The Flesh Chisel. A chisel made from the limb bone of a great predator, its edge sharpened on stone. Once per session, the witch may strike the chisel against a fresh kill. The chisel "honours" the kill, allowing the witch to extract one perfect trophy (a tooth, a claw, a patch of fur) without damaging the rest. The trophy can be used as a material component for any Rite of the Savage Heart, granting +1 die to the roll.

A Hedge Gift: Hunter's Snuff (2 XP). Once per scene, the witch may blow a pinch of powdered bone into the air. For the next minute, the witch can smell the fear of any creature within Near range – they know if a target is Frightened, and gain +1 die to track it.

The Savage Heart's Corruption

Tier	Benefit	Cost / Quirk
1	Stalker's Instinct: +1 die to tracking and stealth in wilderness.	Blood Hunger: Must kill or consume fresh meat each day or suffer 1 Fatigue.
2	Apex Demeanour: +1 die to Intimidation against those weaker than you.	Pack Guilt: –1 die to social rolls in civilised company; you smell faintly of carrion.
3	Scavenger's Resilience: +2 dice to resist disease and poison from raw meat.	Compulsive Dominance: Must assert physical dominance when challenged; –1 die to de-escalation.
4	Wound Licker: Once/session, heal 1 Fatigue by licking a fresh wound (your own or ally's).	Beastly Tells: Your teeth sharpen, your eyes reflect light; –1 die to disguise.
5	Alpha's Roar: Once/session, make a terrifying sound that forces all nearby prey to test Resolve (DV 4) or flee.	Lone Wolf: –2 dice to cooperate with those who have not proven themselves in battle.
6+	Maw Incarnate: Once/session, become a true predator. For one scene, all attacks ignore 1 Armor and you heal 1 Fatigue on each kill.	The Red Eats All: Mark +3 Obligation; risk becoming feral, unable to speak or reason until you have fed again.

Playstyle Notes

The Savage Heart rewards those who hunt, kill, and dominate. Its followers are not gentle guardians of nature – they are its teeth and claws. Power comes from taking, from proving strength, from the raw act of predation. The cost is the slow loss of the civilised self, the creeping realisation that you are becoming the thing you stalk.

Emphasises

- **Predation as Sacrament:** killing is holy when done with purpose
- **Territory and Dominance:** claim, defend, expand
- **Pack Tactics:** hunting is a team sport
- **Red Tooth Wisdom:** death feeds life, cruelty is not malice but nature
- **Transformation:** becoming the beast to master the beast

Rivalries

- **Grimmir (Seasonal Wisdom):** Grimmer preserves the balance; the Savage Heart devours it. They are two faces of the same coin – but the coin is always flipped.
- **The Sealed Gate (Containment):** The Gate wards things out; the Savage Heart tears down walls.
- **The Sacred Geometry (Harmony):** Order and perfect form are prey to the red maw.

Obligation Triggers

- **8+ Segments:** The Savage Heart demands you take a worthy trophy – hunt a creature of equal or greater strength than yourself, alone.
- **10+ Segments:** You hear the call of the hunt always. Refusing to answer when prey is weak will cost you the use of your Rites until you kill again.

Signs of Favor

Your eyes reflect light in darkness, your shadow seems to move independently, smaller animals flee your presence, and the scent of blood often follows you (real or imagined).

15.1.13 The Traveler (Ways & Journeys)

Lore. The Traveler is the eternal guide of the road, guardian of those who walk the paths between what is and what might be. Among the Fhara caravans and Kuvani traders along the Way of Silk, the Traveler is invoked at every crossroads, honoured with small offerings at each waypoint, and consulted before every major journey.

The Traveler is not merely one who shows the way—they *are* the way, existing in the pause between steps and in the choice of which path to take when roads fork. Every journey is both physical and spiritual; to move from one place to another is to transform, and the road itself becomes a teacher.

Across the known world, the Traveler wears many faces. In Kahfagia, the Traveler is the *Lantern-Bearer*, whose light guides ships through uncharted waters. In Ykrul, the Traveler is the *Hoof-Print*, the spirit of the steppe road that appears as a single arrowhead left at a crossroads. In Aeler, the Traveler is the *Ways-Stone*, carved into every mile marker by True-Masons to ensure the road remembers those who walk it. In the Mistlands, the Traveler is invoked with a single unknotted bell-rope – a sign that the fog may part for one who walks humbly. Wherever a traveller sets foot, the Traveler is already there, waiting to see which road they choose.

One foot in a promise, and the road will meet you halfway. But break your word to the way, and the way will break you.

Domain Focus

- **Wayfinding:** navigation, route-finding, safe passage
- **Journeys:** travel, pilgrimage, exploration
- **Thresholds of Movement:** doors, bridges, crossroads, borders
- **Road Covenants:** promises made on the road, hospitality to travellers

Rites of the Traveler

15.1.13.0.1 Rite of Road-Sense (Low, 4 XP)

Scene; Self; No.

Materials: A road-nail or waystone pebble.

Effect: Unerringly pick the fastest safe route in Near/Far. Gain **+1 die** to avoid ambushes or delays. Create a 4-segment *Path Memory* clock to ignore difficult terrain once.

Push It: Spot one hidden bypass, but generate **1 SB (Clubs)**.

Invoke: 1 action; mark **+1 Obligation**.

Requires: Familiar (Invoke: 1 Boon).

15.1.13.0.2 Rite of the Traveler's Boon (Low, 5 XP)

Scene; Self/Ally; No.

Materials: Thread tied at the wrist.

Effect: Ignore one level of difficult terrain or bureaucracy; **+1 Effect** to travel or escape checks. If shared, create a 2-segment *Shared Journey* bond with an ally.

Push It: Extend to one more ally; mark **1 SB (Diamonds)**.

Invoke: 1 action; mark **+1 Obligation**.

Requires: Familiar (Invoke: 1 Boon).

15.1.13.0.3 Rite of the Waymark (Standard, 8 XP)

Scene; Near; No.

Materials: A chalk mark or small cairn.

Effect: Declare a lane as permitted or easy. Allies gain improved Position/Effect or ignore one obstacle. Create a 6-segment *Marked Path* clock.

Push It: The lane persists between scenes; the first enemy to exploit it forces **1 SB (Spades)**.

Invoke: 1 action; mark **+1 Obligation**.

Requires: Familiar + Codex (Invoke: 1 Boon).

15.1.13.0.4 Rite of the Bridge Between (Standard, 7 XP)

Instant; Near; No.

Materials: Two pinches of road-dust clapped.

Effect: Relocate a willing target within Far along a visible or named route. Unwilling targets may resist (Body+Resolve DV 3). Create a 4-segment *Pathway Established* clock.

Push It: Carry one extra ally or bundle; arrivals are off-balance.

Invoke: 1 action; mark **+1 Obligation**.

Requires: Familiar + Codex (Invoke: 1 Boon).

15.1.13.0.5 Rite of the Crown of Crossings (High, 13 XP)

Scene; Zone; No.

Materials: A brass compass missing its needle.

Effect: Call the Road: allies gain **+1 die** to move or evade; pursuers suffer **−1 die**. Once, declare "the long way is short" to finish a travel clock segment for free. Enemies must test (Wits+Command DV 4) or suffer **−1 die** to movement.

Push It: Seal a hostile route briefly; generate **2 SB (Clubs/Diamonds)**.

Invoke: 1 action; mark **+2 Obligation**.

Requires: Familiar + Codex + Tier III (Invoke: 2 Boons).

Obligation: 7 segments.

15.1.13.0.6 Rite of the Wayfarer's Covenant (High, 14 XP)

Extended; Near; No.

Materials: Waystones from multiple regions.

Effect: Bind present parties to safe passage. While honoured: **+2 Effect** on travel, reroll one failed travel roll per scene. Breaking the oath inflicts Harm 1 (Fatigue) and marks the breaker as *Oathbreaker of the Road* (−2 dice to travel rolls).

Push It: Breaking the covenant inflicts Harm 2 (Stress) and attracts hostile Wayward spirits.

Invoke: Extended rite; mark **+2 Obligation**.

Requires: Familiar + Codex + Tier III (Invoke: 2 Boons).

Obligation: 7 segments.

Cantors & Cults of the Traveler

The Cantor's Song. A Cantor of the Traveler sings in *verses of the open road* – melodies that rise and fall like hills, harmonies that echo the creak of wagon wheels. Their voice is used to mark a crossroads with a sung sign, to calm a spooked pack animal, or to call a lost wanderer back to the path. The Traveler's Cantors are often found in caravan camps, at pilgrimage shrines, and walking the roads alone, humming to keep the miles company.

The Cult of the Unbroken Way. The Traveler's cults gather at forks, at bridges, and at the crests of passes – never in buildings. The Unbroken Way is a fellowship of guides, couriers, scouts, and those who have walked so far that the road has become their home. A ritual of the Cult involves

each member placing a small stone at a crossroads, then walking a different way home than they came – the road must be honoured with new steps. Their creed is scratched into a single waystone that travels from meeting to meeting: "*The road does not end. It only turns.*" Outsiders are welcome to walk a mile with the cult, but they must carry a stone from home and leave it at the next crossroads.

Witchcraft of the Traveler (Craft / Wayfinding)

A witch who walks with the Traveler is a *map-scribe* or *waystone-carver* – one who crafts the physical markers of the road: a compass that always points to a chosen destination, a map that shows routes that appear only when needed, or a staff that never causes the bearer to trip. Their magic works through the materials of travel: a quill that draws paths that become real by morning, a chisel that carves a symbol into a stone so that travellers who touch it feel rested, or a needle that sews a patch into a cloak that keeps the wind from shifting direction. In Aeler, a True-Mason might carve a "way keystone" into a bridge so that the bridge remembers every traveller and wishes them well. In Vhasia, a cartographer might illuminate a map with a prayer; the map will never show the route to an ambush.

The Witch's Tool: The Way Chisel. A chisel of iron, its head struck with a simple arrow. Once per session, the witch may carve a "way mark" into a stone, a tree, or a wooden post. For the next day, anyone who sees the way mark gains a perfect sense of direction to the nearest safe harbour, village, or crossroads – but only while walking. The chisel can also be used to "erase" a false trail, removing tracks from a path as if they had never been made (one exchange of effort per use).

A Hedge Gift: Road-Worn Token (2 XP). Once per scene, the witch may touch a small stone, a coin, or a button that has been carried on a long journey. For the next hour, the token glows faintly when the bearer is on the correct path to their goal (as long as the goal is a physical location). The token does not reveal the path – only that the bearer has not (or has) strayed from it.

The Traveler's Corruption Table

Tier	Benefit	Cost / Quirk
1	Pathfinding Instinct: +1 die to Navigation and movement rolls in familiar territory.	Restless Spirit: Suffer 1 Fatigue when forced to remain stationary or in confined spaces for extended periods.
2	Wayfarer's Luck: Once/scene, treat a failed travel or navigation roll as a success, but mark 1 SB (Clubs).	Compulsive Wandering: Must take the less obvious path when choices present themselves; suffer -1 die when forced to follow direct routes.
3	Road Mastery: +2 dice to rolls involving travel, escape, or finding hidden paths.	Travel Dependency: -1 die to rolls requiring local knowledge or settlement-based skills.
4	Journey's Blessing: Once/session, grant all allies within Near range +1 die to travel-related rolls for one scene.	Nomad's Isolation: -1 die to social rolls involving long-term relationships or community ties.
5	Waypoint Sense: Once/session, instantly know the location and nature of all significant paths, routes, or crossroads within a day's travel.	Directional Obsession: -1 die to rolls not involving movement, travel, or pathfinding; always aware of cardinal directions.
6+	Master of All Ways: Once/session, become one with the road network. For one scene, teleport between any known waypoints and grant +2 dice to all travel-related actions.	Eternal Journey: Mark +3 Obligation when using this power; risk permanent Harm (Stress) from the endless call of the road, making settlement impossible until the journey's end.

15.1.14 The Witness (Truth & Revelation)

Lore. The Witness remembers what others bury. Every shadow cast and oath broken is a line in her unending ledger. She is the keeper of inconvenient truths, the patron of those who seek to expose lies or recover forgotten knowledge. Her followers learn that knowledge comes with a price—the weight of remembering what others would forget.

Among the peoples of Fate’s Edge, the Witness is known by many names. In Ecktoria, she is the *Ink-Eye*, the Censor’s clerk who copies every redacted line onto a private scroll. In Vhasia, she is the *Fractured Mirror*, prayed to by spies who seek to reveal a rival’s true loyalty. In the Mistlands, she is the *Fog-Scribe*, whose name is whispered when a bell-line fails and the dead must be identified by their secrets. And in the shadows of every great city, there are those who follow the *Apocalyptic Witness* – a doomsaying cult that believes the world will end when the last hidden truth is finally spoken aloud, and who work to hasten that revelation by exposing every lie, no matter the cost.

I will show you what you would rather forget. But first, you must forget what you think you know.

Domain Focus

- **Truth Revelation:** exposing lies, uncovering secrets, forcing confessions
- **Memory Keeping:** preserving knowledge, recalling forgotten facts
- **Inconvenient Knowledge:** learning what others wish to hide
- **Prophetic Warning:** seeing the consequences of hidden truths

Rites of the Witness

15.1.14.0.1 Rite of the Lingering Glimpse (Low, 4 XP)

Instant; Near; Yes (Investigation/Notice only).

Materials: A trace of the thing to be remembered (hair, dust, a spoken name).

Effect: Gain +1 die to your roll to investigate or notice something directly related to the trace within the current scene.

Push It: Gain +2 dice instead, but mark 1 segment on a **Memory Strain Clock** [4]. If the clock fills, you gain Fatigue 1 and suffer –1 die on Investigation/Notice rolls until the end of the next scene.

Invoke: 1 action; mark +1 **Obligation**.

Requires: Familiar (Invoke: 1 Boon).

15.1.14.0.2 Rite of Piercing Scrutiny (Low, 5 XP)

Scene; Zone; No.

Materials: A circle drawn with chalk or string while focusing on the truth to be sought.

Effect: Within the zone, gain +1 die to rolls to detect deception (Insight vs. Deceit, spotting social tells) or to recall hidden knowledge (Lore/Investigate for memory). Social interactions within the zone begin one Position step worse for those attempting to deceive.

Push It: One target within the zone must make a Wits test (DV 3) or involuntarily reveal one pertinent lie or hidden fact they are currently concealing (GM determines relevance). Regardless of the test result, mark Exposure +1 for the target(s) in the zone.

Invoke: 1 action; mark +1 **Obligation**.

Requires: Familiar (Invoke: 1 Boon).

15.1.14.0.3 Rite of the Echoing Truth (Standard, 8 XP)*Instant; Near; No.***Materials:** A reflective surface (mirror, still water, polished metal) used to focus on the target.**Effect:** The target must make a Resolve test (DV 3) or suffer –1 die to rolls involving memory, deception, or resisting interrogation for the scene. If they fail, you may ask one specific, factual question about something they know, and they must answer truthfully or suffer **1 SB (Hearts)** as the memory is forcibly drawn forth.**Push It:** If the target fails their Resolve test, you may ask a second question, but the mental intrusion causes them Harm 1 (Stress/Mental).**Invoke:** 1 action; mark **+1 Obligation**.*Requires: Familiar + Codex (Invoke: 1 Boon).***15.1.14.0.4 Rite of the Immutable Record (Standard, 7 XP)***Scene; Near; No.***Materials:** A document signed by all parties within the zone, or a spoken pact witnessed by the caster.**Effect:** Bind the agreement. Any party who knowingly breaches it suffers **1 SB (Hearts)** immediately and gains a persistent **Oathbreaker's Mark** Condition (–1 die on social rolls involving honour, trust, or oaths until amends are made or a significant act redeems them).**Push It:** The bond becomes magically enforced for one specific, crucial clause: violation automatically inflicts Harm 1 (Stress) on the breaker in addition to the SB and Mark.**Invoke:** 1 action; mark **+1 Obligation**.*Requires: Familiar + Codex (Invoke: 1 Boon).***15.1.14.0.5 Rite of the Unveiled Heart (High, 12 XP)***Scene; Near; No.***Materials:** A private setting where the target feels safe or is speaking freely.**Effect:** The target suffers –2 dice to all attempts to conceal true emotions, intentions, or lies for the scene. Any successful social roll (Sway, Command, Deceit) made by the target generates **1 SB (Hearts)** as the effort to maintain falsehoods under the Witness's gaze creates internal discord.**Push It:** You may designate one specific, complex question about the target's motivations, fears, or hidden loyalties. If you successfully use Sway or Insight against them this scene, you automatically learn the answer to that question. The intense scrutiny marks **1 SB (Spades)** for you as the Witness's attention lingers.**Invoke:** 1 action; mark **+2 Obligation**.*Requires: Familiar + Codex + Tier III (Invoke: 2 Boons).**Obligation: 6 segments.***15.1.14.0.6 Rite of the Final Reckoning (High, 13 XP)***Scene; Zone; No.***Materials:** A formally called gathering (court, council, family meeting) within the consecrated zone.**Effect:** All present must speak their greatest debt, wrongdoing, or hidden truth related to the gathering's purpose. Those who lie or withhold suffer Harm 2 (Stress/Reputation). Truth-tellers gain +2 dice to social actions for the remainder of the scene within the zone.**Push It:** The truth becomes inescapable – even indirect lies or evasions related to the core topic suffer the Harm 2 penalty. The absolute nature of the revelation creates **2 SB (Diamonds)** as the

disruption to fates and secrets resonates.

Invoke: Extended rite; mark +2 **Obligation.**

Requires: Familiar + Codex + Tier III (Invoke: 2 Boons).

Obligation: 7 segments.

Cantors & Cults of the Witness

The Cantor's Song. A Cantor of the Witness sings in *truth-tolling* – clear, piercing melodies that cut through evasion, harmonies that make the hidden surface. Their voice is used to compel a confession, to sound an alarm that a secret is about to be spoken, or to sing a historical record into being, each note a word in a ledger. The Witness's Cantors are often found in courtrooms, in archive vaults, and at the bedsides of the dying, singing the last truth.

The Congregation of the Unmasking (Apocalyptic Cult). The most feared of the Witness's cults, the Congregation of the Unmasking believes that the world will end when the last hidden truth is finally revealed – and that this ending is not a catastrophe but a liberation. They seek to expose every lie, every buried crime, every forgotten promise, no matter the cost. A ritual of the Congregation involves each member speaking aloud a truth they have kept secret, then burning a representation of the lie that concealed it. Their creed is painted on a scroll that is never fully unrolled: *"When all that is hidden is seen, the world will either break or be free. We will be there to witness which."* Outsiders are not welcome; they are potential sources of truth – or obstacles to be unmasked. The Congregation has been known to destroy families, topple governments, and start wars in their pursuit of total revelation. They are loved by none and feared by all, but even their enemies cannot deny that they are right: some secrets truly are worth dying to expose.

Witchcraft of the Witness (Craft / Record)

A witch who walks with the Witness is a *ledger-scribe* or *seal-breaker* – one who crafts the tools of permanent record: a book that cannot be altered once written, a quill that writes in ink that fades only when the truth it records is fulfilled, or a press that stamps each page with a sigil of authenticity. Their magic works through the materials of documentation: a chisel that carves a truth into stone so that it cannot be erased, a needle that sews a confession into a garment so that the wearer cannot deny it, or a forge that tempers a door that can only be opened by someone who has never told a lie. In Aeler, a True-Mason might carve a "witness stone" at a courthouse entrance, so that all testimony given within is remembered by the stone for a century. In Thepyrgos, a bookbinder might stitch a volume that screams if its pages are cut.

The Witch's Tool: The Truth Chisel. A chisel of white stone, its edge sharp as a razor. Once per session, the witch may carve a single word into a surface (stone, wood, leather) while speaking a truth aloud. The word glows faintly for a day. Anyone who touches the carved word and speaks a lie in its presence will feel a sharp sting (1 Fatigue) as the truth chisel protests. The chisel can also be used to "unseal" a locked record – a sealed envelope will open by itself if the witch carves the recipient's true name into the wax.

A Hedge Gift: Record of a Breath (2 XP). Once per scene, the witch may hold a blank piece of parchment up to a person's lips as they speak. The parchment absorbs the spoken words, recording them exactly as they were said – including tone, hesitation, and any unconscious meaning. The parchment can be read by anyone (the words appear in the speaker's own handwriting), but it crumbles to dust after being read aloud. The witch may also use this ability to record the final words of the dying, preserving them for one day.

The Witness's Corruption Table

Tier	Benefit	Cost / Quirk
1	Truth's Sight: +1 die to Insight when detecting deception or hidden motives.	Burden of Knowledge: -1 die to social rolls involving lies or deception; others become uncomfortable with your piercing gaze.
2	Memory's Keeper: Once/scene, recall one specific detail from a previous scene with perfect clarity.	Compulsive Honesty: Must correct obvious falsehoods witnessed, even when tactically disadvantageous.
3	Revelation's Power: +2 dice to rolls involving exposing secrets, uncovering lies, or forcing confessions.	Truth-Blind: Suffer 1 Fatigue when exposed to comforting lies or wilful ignorance.
4	Witness's Authority: Once/session, force one target to make a Resolve test (DV 4) or reveal a significant hidden truth.	Isolation: -1 die to rolls requiring trust or close relationships; others fear your ability to uncover their secrets.
5	Omniscient Gaze: Once/session, see through all deceptions and lies for one exchange, gaining +3 dice to related actions.	Paranoia: -1 die to rolls involving personal peace or rest; the weight of all truths witnessed creates constant mental strain.
6+	Absolute Witness: Once/session, become the living embodiment of truth. For one scene, all deceptions within Near range automatically fail.	Truth's Prison: Mark +3 Obligation when using this power; become unable to tolerate any form of deception, making normal social interaction nearly impossible.
		The Unmasking Beckons: The apocalyptic urge grows – you may be called to expose a truth that will destroy a community, a nation, or yourself.

15.1.14.0.7 No True Acolyte Interpreting a patron's will is often a dangerous prospect in and of itself. Many a Runekeeper has found themselves on the opposite end of machinations from others from the same patron.

Runebound Resilience (18 XP Epic Talent) *Prerequisite: Tier III+, Codex, Spirit 4+*

You have learned to transform the very essence of harm into deeper communion with your Patron.

- **Harm Conversion:** Once per round, you may convert up to 2 Harm levels to +2 Obligation instead of taking the damage
- **Obligation Endurance:** While at 6+ Obligation segments, gain +1 die to all Rite invocations
- **Patron's Shield:** When reduced to Harm 3, you may immediately Invoke any known Rite without marking additional Obligation
- **Debt Fortification:** At 8+ Obligation segments, ignore first Harm 1 each round
- **Once per scene**

Narrative Integration:

"Your flesh has become a ledger, and every wound is a prayer. The deeper your Patron's claim, the stronger your resistance to mortal frailty."

Patron's Favored (18 XP Prestige Talent) *Prerequisite: Tier III+, Codex, Familiar, 8+ total Obligation segments*

Your Patron has marked you as specially favored, granting you unprecedented access to their power with reduced cost.

- **Low Rite Discount:** Reduce Obligation cost for Low Rites by 1 (minimum 0)
- **Empower:** Once per scene, spend 1 Action + 1 Boon:
 - Target gains +1 Corruption level per round for 3 rounds. Corruption lasts until the end of the scene.
 - While empowered, gain +1 die to all rolls
- **Empower Push:** Spend 1 Action + 1 Boon + 3 Obligation:
 - Target(s) gains +3 Corruption levels until end of scene
 - While empowered, gain +1 die to all rolls
 - Target gains +Corruption fatigue at the end of the scene.
- **Enhanced Gift:** Your **Patron's Gift** now provides +2 dice instead of +1
- **Debt Bound:** Cannot Empower again until all Obligation is cleared

Narrative Integration: *The Patron's favor comes with a price—but for the truly devoted, that price is worth the power. You carry their blessing openly now, and their influence spreads like wildfire to those who would walk in your shadow.*

"Every Rune is a promise. Every line a covenant. Do not mistake the Runekeeper's silence for weakness; their memory is the foundation of our craft."

15.1.15 The Invokers

Invokers are those who dare. Neither archivists nor worshippers, they are travelers on the knife-edge between story and ruin. An Invoker learns the Rites of a Patron, weaves them into their own Art, and bends fate for a moment. Yet invocation is not command: it is negotiation. The Patron always leaves its mark. The stronger the Rite, the deeper the scar.

Invokers are often wanderers, exiles, or seekers. To common folk they are feared—witches, oath-breakers, meddlers with things not meant for mortal hands. But when the village falls to plague, when the sea closes its roads, when the dead refuse their rest, it is an Invoker who is called upon.

15.1.16 Closing Words

The dance between Patron, Runekeeper, and Invoker is a triangle of peril and necessity. Without Patrons, there is no power. Without Runekeepers, no record. Without Invokers, no action. Together, they shape the crooked, perilous art we call Invocation.

15.2 Patrons & Rites

Cost Component	Effect
+1 SB	Escalate effect immediately
+1 Fatigue	Immediate physical/mental strain
+1 Corruption Clock Segment	Long-term Patron influence (unless otherwise specified)
GM spends 1 SB	Thematic complication (unless otherwise specified)

Note: Some talents, Rites, or magical paths may specify alternative corruption costs or additional consequences for *Push It* actions. When explicitly stated, those specific rules override the universal costs.

15.2.0.0.1 Clearing Corruption Corruption may be reduced through *purging rituals*, such as exorcisms, sacred songs, or rites of contrition. These require a test (typically **Lore + Spirit**) against a DV equal to the character’s current corruption level. On success, reduce corruption by 1. On failure, the corruption manifests violently, imposing a temporary Condition or advancing its narrative expression.

Optional: A **Story Beat** may also be spent to attempt such a ritual, representing the personal cost of atonement. Patrons may demand specific acts of service, sacrifice, or obligation as part of the purging process.

Patron’s Gift and Borrowed Grace: XP Free, Sustainable Magic Enhancement

Patron’s Gift (Runekeeper Talent)

Patron’s Gift – Daily Magical Enhancement

Cost: Free (requires Thiasos/Familiar representing the bond to a Patron)

Activation: 1 Action, once per scene

Effect: Gain +1 die to one skill check related to your Patron’s domain and +1 Melee or Ranged.

Requirements: Must be thematically appropriate to Patron’s domain.

Limitations: Cannot stack with other magical effects and is subject to talent stacking rules. The enchanted item can only be used by the Runekeeper.

Cost: Generates 1 Story Beat (Diamonds - magical/spiritual disturbance).

Key Tips for Effective Patron’s Gift Usage

- **Daily Reliability:** Use for routine tasks that benefit from minor magical assistance.
- **Domain Focus:** Choose applications that align strongly with your Patron’s themes.
- **Narrative Integration:** Let the Story Beat cost inform interesting complications.
- **Complementary Use:** Fill gaps where full Rites would be excessive.

Borrowed Grace

Borrowed Grace is a minor imbuelement through which an Invoker momentarily channels their Patron’s favor into a single decisive action.

Type: Invoker Talent — Lesser Imbuelement

Cost: 1 Boon *or* 1 Fatigue; 1 Action

Duration: One action

Requirement: The Invoker must visibly display the symbol of their Patron.

Effect:

- Gain **+1 die** to a single combat action, *or*
- Gain **+1 Effect** to a single social or stealth action.

Limitations:

- Borrowed Grace may be used **once per scene**.
- The effect cannot be stacked, extended, or shared.
- If the Patron’s symbol is *Compromised*, Borrowed Grace may still be invoked at **−1 die**.

Power Level Guidance

These tools are designed to provide a **+1 die reliable enhancement** without the overhead of full Rite/Spell casting. They should feel like:

- Consistent character enhancement rather than dramatic power spikes.
- Reliable support rather than game-changing effects.
- Sustainable advantages rather than resource-intensive solutions.

When used properly, **Patron’s Gift** and **Borrowed Grace** eliminate the “resource management tax” that can make magical characters feel less effective than their non-magical counterparts, while maintaining the thematic richness that makes magical characters special.

Patron	Thematic Skill (+1)	Gift / Lore Bestowal
Carrion King	Survival	<i>Grants the feast of decay, where what is dead becomes seed for what yet lives.</i>
Clockwork Monad	Tinker	<i>Grants the certainty of repetition: a cycle that never falters, a gear that never slips.</i>
Grimmir	Survival	<i>Grants the wisdom of root and stone, speaking the tongues of leaf and fang.</i>
<i>Continued on next page</i>		

Patron	Thematic Skill (+1)	Gift / Lore Bestowal
Ikasha	Stealth	<i>Grants the hush between footsteps and the raven's omen at every threshold.</i>
Inaea	Persuade	<i>Grants the hearth's warmth—shelter for the weary and mercy for the lost.</i>
Isoka	Skirmish	<i>Grants the serpent's coil: strength in sudden strike and wisdom in renewal.</i>
Oath of Flame & Light	Command	<i>Grants the fire of dawn, a vow that shields the faithful and sears the faithless.</i>
Oath of Mercy and Grace	Insight	<i>Grants the spiral of mercy: every act of care pays forward, and the Ledger of Grace waits for no debtor.</i>
Pale Shepherd	Stealth	<i>Grants the shepherd's whisper, guiding the living through liminal spaces and comforting the dying.</i>
Savage Heart	Intimidation	<i>Grants the red maw, the strength of bear and the hunger of the wolf.</i>
The Traveler	Notice	<i>Grants the open way, a restless compass and roads where none were marked.</i>
The Witness	Notice	<i>Grants the unblinking gaze that unmaskers deceit and remembers every oath.</i>

Patron Rivalries

Detailed rivalries between Patrons are covered in the **Game Master's Guide**. For player reference, note that serving one Patron may attract the attention of its enemies; your GM will inform you when such tensions arise.

15.3 Rites Difficulty Value

The Difficulty Value (DV) to cast a Rite is:

$$DV = \max(\text{ObligationCost} - \text{Spirit}, \text{TierOfTheRite}(\text{Low1}, \text{Standard2}, \text{High3}))$$

15.4 Obligation Overflow (Rites)

When **Obligation** is ticked past its maximum (from Rites, vows, bargains), mark **Fatigue** based on scene severity:

- **Low:** +1 Fatigue
- **Standard:** +2 Fatigue
- **High:** +3 Fatigue

If this *fills* the Fatigue Track, apply the **Fatigue** → **Harm** conversion (see §2.10).

15.5 Clearing Obligation Segments (Extended)

Obligation measures the growing narrative weight of a Patron's attention. It is not debt in a transactional sense, but rather the sense that a Patron has invested, noticed, and expects relevance. This section expands the SRD guidance with philosophy, examples, and optional rules.

15.5.1 Core Principle

Obligation is cleared through **meaningful engagement** with the Patron. The system assumes Patrons are narrative entities: they do not care about coin, but about resonance. Clearing requires a demonstration that the character is still walking their path.

15.5.2 Off-Screen Clearing (Primary Method)

- **Act of Service.** Clear 1 segment by performing a resonant service aligned to the Patron's themes or goals.
- **Requirement.** The player must provide an *Intricate Description* of the act—detail, symbolism, and impact.
- **Scope.** The act need not be arduous, but it must be thematically precise (e.g., weaving a shadow tapestry for Ikasha; negotiating a shrewd pact for the Clockwork Monad).
- **Reward.** Successful clearing often comes with narrative color: whispers of approval, subtle omens, or a temporary advantage in Patron-facing scenes.

15.5.3 On-Screen Clearing (Optional Mechanic)

15.5.3.0.1 Talent: Focused Devotion (3–5 XP). Once per scene, spend 1 Boon to clear 1 segment of Obligation from a Patron. This cannot remove segments accrued during the same scene. It represents a desperate or ritualized gesture to stave off attention without fully satisfying it.

15.5.4 Narrative Implications

1. **Player Agency.** The player defines how service manifests, reinforcing creativity within the Patron's thematic frame.
2. **GM Collaboration.** The GM adjudicates sufficiency: Is the service aligned? Is it intricate enough?
3. **Ongoing Relationship.** Clearing segments emphasizes that the Patron bond is active, not static. The relationship evolves with acts of recognition.
4. **Scene Economy.** The cap on on-screen clearing ensures the mechanic cannot erase costs just accrued. It forces the long view.

15.5.5 Worked Examples

15.5.5.0.1 Example 1: Ikasha. A character clears a segment by shedding their old cloak, burning it, and narrating how it symbolizes leaving behind a former self. The GM rules it sufficient, noting the subtle scent of scales in the air.

15.5.5.0.2 Example 2: Clockwork Monad. The player narrates spending an hour meticulously recalibrating a piece of equipment, using precise measurements and ritual cleaning. The GM agrees: the service is thematically aligned and clears 1 segment.

15.5.5.0.3 Example 3: Oath of Flame & Light. The group holds a dawn vigil, speaking aloud a vow they have kept. The intricate description convinces the GM, who clears 1 segment from each participant's Obligation to that Patron.

15.5.6 Optional Modules

15.5.6.0.1 Overflow Consequences. When Obligation fills and overflows, the Patron demands immediate service. This may be delivered as a Complication Point (or Story Beat) trigger: the Patron intrudes, offering aid with a binding cost.

15.5.6.0.2 Segment Scaling. Particularly devoted characters may require greater services: clear 2 segments with a dramatic act (pilgrimage, sacrifice, or political maneuver), subject to GM approval.

15.5.6.0.3 Shared Obligation. In multi-character bonds, the GM may allow a group act of service to clear multiple segments, but only if each player contributes to the Intricate Description.

15.5.7 GM Guidance

- **Be Generous with Hooks.** Reward creativity with flavorful omens, not just a cleared box.
- **Maintain Tension.** Do not allow trivial or repetitive services to count. Require new symbolic angles each time.
- **Keep On-Screen Costly.** Remind players that Focused Devotion costs a Boon and cannot erase fresh debt.
- **Tie to Patron Themes.** If a service drifts off-theme, let it fail or only partially clear.

Summary

Obligation is cleared through **thematic service, intricate description, and narrative engagement**. Off-screen acts remain the primary path; on-screen clearing is a costly safety valve. Treat every act as a chance to show how characters evolve under their Patron's gaze.

15.6 Acts of Service — Examples

Patrons delight in resonance, not labor. Use these examples as prompts—*petty* butterflies and *involved* operations both count when on-theme. Each entry lists a scale suggestion and what it might clear.

GM Notes

- **Novelty Over Volume.** Repeating the same petty act does not keep clearing segments; vary the symbol or site.
- **Precision Beats Difficulty.** A sharp thematic hit at "petty" scale can clear 1 segment as surely as a muddled "modest."
- **Hook the World.** Many of these acts conveniently create future clocks, NPC ties, or bargains—use them.
- **Patron's Largess** A Patron's will is mysterious, but their displeasure is rarely subtle. For narrative reasons, the GM may rule that a Patron is especially offended—perhaps by a neglected omen, a rival gaining favor, or simple caprice—and exact an additional toll beyond the usual cost.

15.7 Patron Fear Influence Table (Curated)

The following table summarizes how the curated patrons modify fear effects.

Patron	Domain Tags	Influence Type	Fear Effect Modifications
Carrion King	Decay, Feast, Scavenging	Reroll	Fear tagged <i>Decay</i> , <i>Hunger</i> , <i>Feast</i> mutates. On 1 (Fight), frenzy devolves into cannibalistic hunger.
Clockwork Monad	Order, Repetition, Mechanism	Amplify	Fear tagged <i>Order</i> , <i>Pattern</i> , <i>Repetition</i> becomes mechanistic horror. On 3 (Freeze), victim is trapped in endless loop.
Grimmir	Seasons, Verdict, Threshold	Reroll	Fear tagged <i>Wild</i> , <i>Nature</i> , <i>Season</i> becomes primal dread. On 6 (Submit), victim freezes as if rooted.
Ikasha	Shadow, Whispers, Latent Potential	Amplify	Fear tagged <i>Shadow</i> , <i>Voice</i> , <i>Hidden</i> deepens. On 3 (Freeze), victim may be paralyzed by whispered secrets.
Inaea	Mercy, Hearth, Connection	Reroll	Fear tagged <i>Home</i> , <i>Family</i> , <i>Comfort</i> twists to terror of loss. On 4 (Flee), victim abandons loved ones “for their own good.”
Isoka	Serpents, Shedding, Venom	Reroll	Fear tagged <i>Change</i> , <i>Identity</i> , <i>Poison</i> becomes existential. On 5 (Hide), victim sheds their face and cannot be recognised.
Oath of Flame & Light	Dawn, Vows, Purity	Resonance	Fear tagged <i>Light</i> , <i>Sacred</i> , <i>Vow</i> also imposes Fatigue. Iconic light turns terror into bodily strain.
Oath of Mercy and Grace	Healing, Forgiveness, Spiral	Reroll	Fear tagged <i>Care</i> , <i>Debt</i> , <i>Failure</i> becomes paralysing guilt. On 2 (Hide), victim flees from those they failed.
Pale Shepherd	Thresholds, Souls, Passing	Reroll	Fear tagged <i>Death</i> , <i>Guidance</i> , <i>Soul</i> becomes existential. On 6 (Submit), victim follows willingly into afterlife path.
Savage Heart	Predation, Hunger, Flesh	Reroll	Fear tagged <i>Beast</i> , <i>Blood</i> , <i>Prey</i> becomes primal. On 1 (Fight), victim charges the nearest target without thought.

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Patron	Domain Tags	Influence Type	Fear Effect Modifications
The Traveler	Ways, Journeys, Cross-roads	Resonance	Fear tagged <i>Lost</i> , <i>Path</i> , <i>Journey</i> also inflicts Complication Points. Terror of losing the way becomes mechanical hindrance.
The Witness	Truth, Revelation	Amplify	Fear tagged <i>Truth</i> , <i>Knowledge</i> , <i>Revelation</i> intensifies. On 6 (Submit), target may confess dark secrets under perceived Iconic judgment.

15.7.1 Implementation Guidelines

15.7.1.1 Tag Matching

When a Fear effect is triggered, compare the effect's Magic Tags against the active Patron's Domain Tags. If any tags match, the Patron's influence applies.

15.7.1.2 Multiple Patrons

If multiple Patrons are present with overlapping domains, the GM may:

- Choose the most thematically appropriate influence
- Apply influences sequentially (reroll then amplify)
- Allow players to choose which influence affects them

15.7.1.3 Player Agency

Players should be informed when Patron influence is active and given the opportunity to:

- Spend resources (Boons, Willpower) to resist the influence
- Narrate how their character resists or embraces the effect
- Choose from available influence options when multiple apply

15.7.2 Embracing Corruption

A character with **2+ levels of Corruption** may choose to **Embrace** it, transforming creeping decay into a permanent **Talent**. Embracing never reduces Corruption — it reshapes it. The deeper the corruption, the greater the power and the cost.

Corruption Level	Talent Tier	Cost
2 (Early)	Minor Talent	+1 Permanent Corruption (cannot Fade below 1)
3 (Deepening)	Major Talent	+2 Permanent Corruption, constant visible tell
4+ (Severe)	Transcendent Talent	Permanently altered, locked at Stage 3+

Embraced Talents always reflect the Patron's themes (e.g., shadow, indulgence, empathy, paranoia).

They grant great power, but mark the character irrevocably as claimed.

15.8 Witchcraft, Cults, and Religions